

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART ONE OF THIRTEEN

The Land Before the Name

From the first villages to about 500 BCE

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Who is writing this, and why

You are about to read thirteen parts of history. Before you give me that much of your time, you are owed a straight account of who I am, what I am not, and what I am trying to do.

What I am not

I am not a historian by training. I hold no degree in history. I have never taught it, never excavated anything, and never read a Persian chronicle in Persian. If you are looking for credentials of that kind, I do not have them, and I would rather say so on the first page than have you discover it on the four hundredth.

I am also Punjabi. I am writing about my own people, my own land, and in Parts 9 and 10, about events that shaped the world my family lived in. That is a conflict of interest and I am declaring it, because a researcher who pretends to have no stake in his subject is either lying or has not understood the subject.

What I am

I am a researcher and writer. I run **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio, and I am Founder and Managing Director of **Five Rivers Inc.** I have studied at Panjab University and Chandigarh University, and I am in the second year of an MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis. I am a **Certified Ethical Hacker**, and I taught myself to write software. I am now working toward doctoral research.

None of that qualifies me to write about the Battle of the Ten Kings. I know that. But three habits from that work turned out to matter more than I expected, and they are the only credentials I am actually claiming.

From security work, I learned to attack my own conclusions. When you test a system, you do not go looking for proof that it is sound. You go looking for the one input that breaks it, and you assume it exists until you have failed to find it. That instinct is the exact opposite of how most people write about Punjab — and it is the instinct behind Rule 3 of this work, where I state every opposing argument in its strongest form before I answer it. An argument that has only ever beaten a weak opponent has not won anything.

From strategy and analysis, I learned to ask what the numbers actually support. Not what they can be made to suggest. In Part 12 I run a feasibility audit on Khalistan the way I would run one on a business plan: water, land, capital, revenue, supply lines, exit routes. Emotion is not admissible in that chapter. Neither is sentiment on the other side.

From teaching myself to code, I learned that you can understand almost anything if you are honest about what you do not yet know. The failure mode is never ignorance. It is pretending.

Why I started this

Because everybody in Punjab has an opinion about Punjab, and almost nobody arguing has read anything.

I do not say that to insult anyone. I include myself in it. I grew up hearing confident claims from every direction — that Bhindranwale was a saint, that he was a terrorist, that 1984 was a massacre, that it was an operation against militants, that Khalistan is freedom, that Khalistan is a foreign intelligence project. I could not have defended any of those positions with a source. Neither, when I asked, could the people making them.

So I decided to find out. Not to prove a point I already held — to find out. That distinction is the entire reason this exists.

What I promise, and what I refuse

I promise to show you the range. Where the sources conflict — and on the most important questions in this story they conflict violently — I will give you both figures, name who published each, and explain why they differ. Hiding uncertainty is not confidence. It is dishonesty with better posture.

I promise to include what damages my own case. There are facts in Part 10 that are painful for Sikhs to read, and facts in the same part that are painful for the Indian state to read. Both are going in.

I refuse to insult a people. Not out of politeness — because it does not work. "Punjabis are fools" cannot explain anything, since it cannot explain change, and Punjab has changed enormously. Every time I was tempted by that kind of sentence, it turned out I had simply not yet found the actual cause. The insult is what you write when you have run out of explanation.

I refuse to write propaganda in either direction. Including my own.

Where this is going

These thirteen parts are the first major work of **The Living Archive**, a long-form research project I am building on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — written from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing. This is also groundwork. I am working toward doctoral research, and Punjab is where I intend to do it.

Which means I need this to be right more than I need it to be popular. If you find an error, I want to hear about it. My sources are listed at the end of every part precisely so that you can check me.

One last thing, about the language. I have written all thirteen parts so that a student in Class 6 can follow every sentence. That is deliberate, and it is not a compromise. Most writing on this subject is difficult on purpose — complexity is how people hide that they are not sure what they are saying. If I cannot explain the Anandpur Sahib Resolution to a fifteen-year-old, I do not understand it well enough to have an opinion about it. Simple language is not simple thinking. It is what is left after the thinking is finished.

— Lovepreet Singh
The Living Archive

BEFORE WE BEGIN

How to read this book

This is Part 1 of 13. Together they try to answer one enormous question: what actually happened to Punjab, and why does everyone argue about it so violently?

You are going to read a lot of pages about Punjab. Before you do, you should know exactly what kind of book this is, and what rules it follows. If you skip this section, you may misunderstand everything that comes after it.

What this book is trying to do

Punjab is one of the most argued-about places on earth. Say the word and people immediately reach for a story. One person says Punjab is the sword-arm of India, the land that fed the country and guarded its border. Another says Punjab is a colony that India bled dry. One says Bhindranwale was a saint. Another says he was a terrorist. One says Khalistan is a freedom movement. Another says it is a Pakistani intelligence project run by lawyers in New Jersey.

All of these people can produce facts. That is the problem. Almost every claim in the Punjab argument has *some* evidence behind it. What people do is pick the facts that suit them and hide the rest.

I try to do the opposite. I put all of it on the table — the glory and the shame, what Punjab did to others and what was done to Punjab — and then asks what the full picture actually supports.

THE SIMPLEST WAY TO SAY IT

Most writing about Punjab is a lawyer's argument: pick a side, then hunt for evidence. This book tries to be a doctor's report: look at everything, then say what you found — even if nobody likes it.

My five rules

Rule 1 — Plain English, always. If a school student in Class 6 cannot follow a sentence, that sentence is badly written. Every specialist word — *doab*, *Miri-Piri*, *riparian rights*, *Anandpur Sahib Resolution* — gets explained in ordinary words the first time it appears. Simple language is not the same as simple thinking. A senior civil servant reading this should find the analysis sharp; a fifteen-year-old should find the words easy. Those two goals do not conflict. They only look like they conflict because most people write badly.

Rule 2 — When the numbers are disputed, you see the dispute. Some of the most important facts in this story have no agreed figure. How many people died in Operation Blue Star in 1984? The Government of India's White Paper said 493 civilians and militants.

Independent estimates run to several thousand. I will not quietly pick one. I will show you both, tell you who said what, and explain why they disagree. You are then free to think for yourself. A book that hides its uncertainty is not being confident. It is being dishonest.

Rule 3 — Every side gets its best case, not its worst. It is easy to defeat a stupid version of an argument. It proves nothing. So when I examine the case for Khalistan, I will state that case the way its cleverest supporter would state it — and then answer it. When I examine the Indian state's conduct, I will state the state's justification at full strength — and then test it. An argument that can only beat a weak opponent has not won anything.

Rule 4 — Groups of people are never the explanation. "Punjabis are fools." "Sikhs are hot-headed." "Hindus are cowards." These are not analysis; they are insults wearing a lab coat. They also happen to be useless, because they cannot explain change. If Punjabis were simply "like that," Punjab would have looked the same in 2500 BCE, in 1799, in 1965 and in 1988. It did not. It changed enormously, and it changed for reasons — geography, money, water, politics, war, specific decisions by specific named people. Those reasons are what I am hunting for. Blaming a people's character is what you do when you have run out of actual explanations.

Rule 5 — Nobody in this story is only a hero or only a villain. The Indian state defeated a genuinely murderous insurgency and also killed innocent people and covered it up. Punjab produced extraordinary courage and also produced men who machine-gunned bus passengers for their religion. Both halves are true. A history that gives you only the flattering half of anybody is a history you should not trust, including mine.

A WARNING ABOUT THIS SUBJECT

Punjab's history is used as a weapon almost every day, by many different people, in several countries. Some of what you will read online about Bhindranwale, about 1984, about Khalistan, is fabricated — invented quotes, doctored photographs, casualty figures multiplied by ten, real atrocities denied outright. This happens on *every* side of the argument. So I flag what is documented, what is disputed, and what is simply made up. When we get to Part 9 and Part 10, that flagging becomes the most important thing in the book.

What Part 1 covers, and why we start so far back

You may be impatient. You want Bhindranwale, 1984, Khalistan, Pannun, the drug crisis. Those are Parts 9 to 13, and they are the longest parts of this work.

But if you start there you will not understand any of it. Here is why.

Every serious argument about modern Punjab eventually comes down to four things: **water, land, who counts as a Punjabi, and who has the right to rule.** The Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal fight is about water. The Chandigarh dispute is about land. The Punjabi Suba movement was about who counts as a Punjabi. Khalistan is about who has the right to rule.

All four of those questions are older than 1984. They are older than 1947. Two of them are older than writing. They are set into the ground Punjab sits on. Part 1 is where I dig them up, so that when they explode later you already know what they are.

If you do not understand Punjab's rivers, you cannot understand a single day of Punjab's politics — not in 1500 BCE, not in 1947, not this morning.

What is in Part 1

CHAPTER 1 Where is Punjab, actually? Four different places share one name.

CHAPTER 2 The five rivers — the machine that made Punjab, and the trap inside it.

CHAPTER 3 What Punjab was called before it was called Punjab.

CHAPTER 4 The first Punjabis: Harappa, and the awkward fact hidden inside it.

CHAPTER 5 The Rigveda: Punjab's first book, and India's first named battle.

CHAPTER 6 Why geography is destiny here — four permanent facts.

CHAPTER 7 Scorecard: what Part 1 proves, and what it does not.

CHAPTER ONE

Where is Punjab, actually?

Before we can discuss Punjab's history, we have to solve a problem most people never notice: the word "Punjab" means at least four different places, and arguments about Punjab usually involve people quietly using different ones.

Four Punjabs

Say "Punjab" to five people and you may get five maps.

THE FOUR THINGS PEOPLE MEAN BY "PUNJAB"

Which Punjab	Rough size	What it includes
1. Indian Punjab The state, today	50,362 sq km ~3 crore people	Amritsar, Ludhiana, Jalandhar, Patiala, Bathinda. Shares its capital, Chandigarh, with Haryana. About 1.5% of India's land.
2. Pakistani Punjab The province, today	205,344 sq km ~12–13 crore people	Lahore, Faisalabad, Rawalpindi, Multan, Gujranwala. Pakistan's largest province by population — over half the country.
3. Historical Punjab Before 1947	~350,000 sq km	Both of the above, plus today's Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Chandigarh and Islamabad, plus parts of Delhi's surroundings. This is the Punjab of Ranjit Singh and of the British province.
4. Cultural Punjab	No fixed border	Wherever Punjabi is spoken and Punjabi life is lived — including Delhi, Southall in London, Surrey in Canada, Fresno in California. Roughly 15 crore Punjabi speakers worldwide.

Notice something uncomfortable. Indian Punjab — the one most people mean when they argue about "Punjab" in India — is **less than one-seventh** of historical Punjab. It is a fragment of a fragment. Lahore, the great capital of Punjab for a thousand years, is not in it. Neither is Ranjit Singh's tomb. Neither is Nankana Sahib, where Guru Nanak was born. Neither is Harappa, the city that named an entire civilisation.

PUT SIMPLY

Modern Indian Punjab is to historical Punjab roughly what a single slice is to a whole cake. When someone says "Punjab has been reduced to nothing," this is what they are pointing at — and on that narrow point, they are factually correct.

Why this matters more than it looks

This is not pedantry. Watch how the four definitions get swapped in real arguments:

- Someone says "*Punjab was once a great empire, so it can be a country again.*" The empire they mean is historical Punjab (Definition 3), which is mostly in Pakistan today. The country they propose is Indian Punjab (Definition 1). These are not the same place, and the argument silently jumps between them.
- Someone says "*Punjab is a Sikh-majority land.*" True of Indian Punjab today (Sikhs are roughly 57–58%). Not true of historical Punjab at any point in its history — Sikhs were never a majority of undivided Punjab. In 1941, undivided Punjab was about 53% Muslim, 30% Hindu and 15% Sikh.
- Someone says "*Punjab gave India its army.*" True of British Punjab (Definition 3), which supplied enormous numbers of recruits from areas that are now in Pakistan. Punjabi Muslims from Rawalpindi and Jhelum were a huge share of that army. After 1947 they went to Pakistan's army.

Every one of those slippages is common. Some are honest confusion; some are deliberate. Once you can spot them, half the noise in the Punjab debate falls away.

REMEMBER THIS FOR PART 12

The single hardest question for any proposal to make Punjab a separate country is: **which Punjab?** The 50,000 sq km one with no port, no capital of its own, and no control of its rivers — or the 350,000 sq km one that would require taking half of Pakistan? Supporters almost never answer this. We will make them answer it.

The definition this book will use

To avoid confusion, I will be explicit every time. When I say "Punjab" without qualification in the ancient and medieval chapters, I mean **the historical region** — the land of the five rivers, roughly Definition 3. From Part 7 onwards, when partition splits it, I will always say "Indian Punjab" or "Pakistani Punjab." Where a number could apply to either, I will tell you which.

CHAPTER TWO

The five rivers: the machine that made Punjab

Punjab is not a nation, a religion, or a language first. It is a river system. Everything else grew on top of that.

Meet the five

The name says five waters. Here they are, running from west to east — which is also the order an invader coming from Afghanistan would cross them.

THE FIVE RIVERS OF PUNJAB, WEST TO EAST

River	Old name	Where it is born	Notes
Jhelum	Vitasta (Hydaspes to the Greeks)	Verinag, Kashmir	Where Alexander fought Porus in 326 BCE. Entirely in Pakistan and J&K today.
Chenab	Asikni (Acesines)	Lahaul, Himachal	The largest of the five by volume. Chenab means "moon river." The river of Heer-Ranjha and Sohni-Mahiwal.
Ravi	Parushni, later Iravati (Hydraotes)	Bara Bhangal, Himachal	Lahore and Harappa both sit on it. India's first great recorded battle was fought on its banks.
Beas	Vipas (Hyphasis)	Rohtang, Himachal	The only one of the five that begins and ends inside India. Where Alexander's army mutinied and turned back.
Sutlej	Shutudri (Hesidros)	Lake Rakshastal, Tibet	The longest of the five. Rises outside India entirely. Ranjit Singh's empire was defined by it.

All five eventually pour into a sixth and much larger river, the **Indus**, which carries their combined water down through Sindh and into the Arabian Sea. Strictly speaking Punjab is five rivers feeding one, and the Indus is the trunk of the tree.

The doabs: the real map of Punjab

Now the single most useful idea in this whole part. When five rivers run roughly parallel across a flat plain, they cut the land into long strips. Each strip is a piece of land with a river on either side.

The Persian word for such a strip is **doab** — *do* means two, *ab* means water. Land between two waters.

Punjab has five of them, and if you learn these five names you will understand more about Punjabi history than most people who have read three books about it.

THE FIVE DOABS — PUNJAB'S TRUE INTERNAL GEOGRAPHY

Doab	Between which rivers	Main cities, then and now
Sindh Sagar	Indus and Jhelum	Rawalpindi, Islamabad. Dry, rugged, the classic army-recruiting country. In Pakistan.
Chaj	Jhelum and Chenab	Gujrat, Sargodha. In Pakistan.
Rechna	Chenab and Ravi	Faisalabad (old Lyallpur), Gujranwala — Ranjit Singh's birthplace. In Pakistan.
Bari	Ravi and Beas	Lahore and Amritsar. The cultural heart of Punjab. Cut in half by the border in 1947.
Bist Jalandhar	Beas and Sutlej	Jalandhar, Hoshiarpur, Kapurthala. In India.

Look hard at the Bari Doab row. Lahore and Amritsar are about 50 kilometres apart. They sat in the same strip of land, watered by the same two rivers, for their entire history. They were one economic unit — one market, one canal system, one road. In 1947 a line was drawn between them by a British lawyer who had never been to India before, working from maps and census tables in six weeks.

We will return to that in Part 7. For now, just hold on to the fact that partition did not merely divide a province. It cut a doab down the middle, which is like cutting a body down the middle rather than separating two people.

PUT SIMPLY

Imagine five long ribbons of land laid side by side, each with a river on its left and a river on its right. Those are the doabs. Armies marched along them. Canals were dug across them. Cities grew where two of them met a crossing point. Punjab's map is not one blob — it is five ribbons.

Why the soil here is extraordinary

Here is the process, in one paragraph. The Himalaya is the youngest and highest mountain range on earth, and it is still rising. Rain, ice and frost grind its rock into fine particles. The rivers pick up those particles and carry them downhill. When the rivers hit the flat plain, they slow down, and slow water cannot carry heavy loads, so it drops what it is carrying. Every year, for millions of years, the rivers have been laying down a fresh coat of ground-up mountain across Punjab.

The result is **alluvial soil** — soil made of river deposits — and in Punjab it is not a thin layer. In places the alluvium is hundreds of metres deep. If you dug straight down in central Punjab you would go through the height of a skyscraper before you hit rock.

This soil is flat, deep, soft, easy to plough with simple tools, and naturally fertile. It is one of the best agricultural surfaces on the planet. This is not a small detail. It is the reason there were cities here in 2600 BCE, the reason every empire wanted the place, and the reason Punjab could feed India in the 1970s.

The trap: Punjab does not get much rain

Now the part almost everybody misses, and it is the most important sentence in this chapter.

Punjab is semi-arid. That means it is a dry place. Most of Punjab receives somewhere between 300 and 700 millimetres of rain a year, and the south-west — Bathinda, Ferozepur, Muktsar, and across the border into Cholistan — gets far less than that and shades into genuine desert. For comparison, Kerala gets around 3,000 mm and Assam's wettest districts get far more.

So Punjab has magnificent soil and not enough rain to use it.

Which leads to the defining fact of Punjabi history:

Punjab has never been rich because of rain falling on it. Punjab has been rich because it could move water sideways — out of rivers, into fields.

Every prosperous period in Punjab's history is a period when somebody was good at moving water. The Harappans dug channels and wells. Medieval rulers cut inundation canals that filled when rivers flooded. The British built the largest canal network in the world in the late 1800s and turned dry western Punjab into the "canal colonies." Independent India built dams — Bhakra, Pong, Ranjit Sagar — and then, from the 1970s, drilled millions of tubewells and pumped water up from underground.

Every poor or desperate period is a period when the water stopped moving, or moved to somebody else.

REMEMBER THIS FOR PARTS 8, 12 AND 13

Three of the biggest fights in modern Punjab are all the same fight in different clothes: the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 (which gave Pakistan the Indus, Jhelum and Chenab, and India the Ravi, Beas and Sutlej); the Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal dispute with Haryana; and the collapsing groundwater table under Punjab today. All three are arguments about moving water sideways. A Punjab that loses those arguments does not become slightly poorer. It stops working.

One more thing the rivers did: they made Punjab open

A river is a barrier. But a river on a flat plain is a weak barrier. In the dry season, before the monsoon, the five rivers of Punjab can be forded — walked across — in many places. There is no gorge, no cliff, no jungle, no swamp.

Compare this with other Indian regions. The Western Ghats protect the Konkan coast. The Vindhya and Satpura ranges and the Narmada shield the Deccan. Bengal has its delta and its forests. Kashmir has a wall of mountains around it. Nepal has the Himalaya itself.

Punjab has none of that. Punjab is a smooth, rich, flat table set immediately behind the only easy land entrance to the subcontinent. It is, in military terms, indefensible — unless you defend it with an army standing in the open.

Hold that thought. It becomes the explanation for almost everything in Chapter 6.

CHAPTER THREE

What Punjab was called before it was called Punjab

The land is roughly five thousand years old as a settled civilisation. The name "Punjab" is roughly seven hundred years old. That gap contains a lesson.

The names, in order

WHAT THIS REGION HAS BEEN CALLED

Name	Language / source	Rough period	Meaning and note
Sapta Sindhu	Sanskrit, Rigveda	c. 1500–1000 BCE	"Seven rivers." The oldest name we have for the region, from India's oldest surviving text.
Hapta Hindu	Old Iranian, Avesta	Similar period	The Persian version of the same phrase. Sanskrit <i>s</i> becomes Iranian <i>h</i> . Same words, cousin language.
Panchanada	Sanskrit, Mahabharata and later texts	c. 400 BCE onward	"Five rivers." <i>Pancha</i> = five, <i>nada</i> = river. This is the direct ancestor, in meaning, of "Punjab."
Pentapotamia	Greek	c. 300 BCE	"Five rivers" again, in Greek. Used by writers describing Alexander's campaign.
Punjab / Panjab	Persian	c. 1300 CE onward	<i>Panj</i> = five, <i>ab</i> = water. Appears in Ibn Battuta's travels, in Wassaf's history, and in Ayn al-Mulk Mahru's <i>Insha-i-Mahru</i> , which calls it the <i>wilayat</i> (province) of Punjab. Becomes standard under the Mughals; Emperor Jahangir uses it in his memoirs, the <i>Tuzk-i-Jahangiri</i> .

"It's a Persian name" — what that does and doesn't mean

People sometimes use the Persian origin of "Punjab" as a debating point: either to say the name is foreign and therefore the identity is fake, or to say the region was named by Muslim conquerors. Both are sloppy.

Here is the accurate position. Persian and Sanskrit are not unrelated languages. They are close cousins, both descended from a common ancestor language spoken thousands of years ago. Look at the actual words:

Concept	Sanskrit	Persian
five	<i>pañca</i>	<i>panj</i>
water	<i>áp</i>	<i>āb</i>

These are not translations. They are the same words, worn down differently by two thousand years in two different mouths. "Panchanada" and "Panj-ab" mean the same thing in two branches of one family. The name did not arrive from outer space with an invading army. It drifted in from next door and slotted into a slot that was already there.

Also worth knowing: the word **India** comes from exactly the same process, applied to one of these rivers. Sanskrit *Sindhu* (the river we call the Indus) became Iranian *Hindu*, which became Greek *Indos*, which became Latin *India*. The word "Hindu" and the word "India" are both, originally, the name of a Punjabi-Sindhi river with a Persian accent.

PUT SIMPLY

"Punjab" is a Persian phrase, but Persian and Sanskrit are cousins, and the Sanskrit version — *Panchanada*, five rivers — meant exactly the same thing more than a thousand years earlier. Arguing that the name is foreign is like arguing that "father" is foreign because Latin says *pater*.

The lesson hidden in the naming

Notice that every single name for this region, across five languages and three thousand years, is a description of its rivers. Not its kings. Not its gods. Not its people. Its rivers.

No other major Indian region is named this way. Bengal, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan — these are named after peoples, dynasties or directions. Punjab alone is named after its plumbing.

Outsiders and insiders alike, for three thousand years, looked at this land and said: *this is the place where the water is*. That is what it was for. That is what it still is for.

Every name Punjab has ever had is a description of its water. Nobody ever named it after a king.

And one honest correction

Because the name is only about seven centuries old, be suspicious of any sentence that begins "Punjab has always...". Punjab as a *named* thing is younger than the Delhi Sultanate. Punjab as a *political* unit — a single government ruling the whole five-river country — is younger still, and has existed for only short stretches.

The land is ancient. The soil is ancient. The people have been there continuously for at least five millennia. But "Punjab" as an idea people identify with is a much more recent invention than the arguments about it usually assume. That does not make the identity less real. Identities that are recent can be as strong as any other — Italian and German national identity are younger than the United States. But it does mean that anyone claiming a five-thousand-year-old Punjabi nation is describing something that did not exist.

CHAPTER FOUR

The first Punjabis: Harappa

Around 2600 BCE, while the Egyptians were building pyramids, the people of Punjab were building something the Egyptians never thought of: a sewer.

The timeline in one table

THE INDUS VALLEY (HARAPPAN) CIVILISATION

Phase	Dates	What was happening
Mehrgarh / earliest farming	c. 7000–3300 BCE	Farming and herding begin in the region (Mehrgarh itself is in Balochistan, but it belongs to the same developing world). Wheat, barley, cattle, cotton.
Early Harappan	c. 3300–2600 BCE	Villages grow into towns. Pottery styles spread. Trade networks form.
Mature Harappan	c. 2600–1900 BCE	The famous phase. Planned cities, standard bricks, drains, weights, seals, long-distance trade with Mesopotamia.
Late Harappan / decline	c. 1900–1300 BCE	Cities shrink and are abandoned. Populations move east and south. Village life continues; urban life stops.

How big was it?

Bigger than people assume. Archaeologists have identified **more than a thousand settlements** belonging to this civilisation. Population estimates for its peak run to around **five million people** — an enormous number for the Bronze Age.

In area, the Indus Valley Civilisation covered roughly 1.2 to 1.3 million square kilometres, stretching from north-east Afghanistan through Pakistan and into north-west India. That is larger than ancient Egypt and Mesopotamia put together. It was, on the evidence we have, the largest civilisation in the world at the time.

And its heartland was Punjab and Sindh.

The cities that matter for our story

KEY HARAPPAN SITES IN OR NEAR THE PUNJAB REGION

Site	Where it is today	Why it matters
Harappa	Sahiwal district, Pakistani Punjab, on the Ravi	Excavated first, so the entire civilisation is named after it. Around 150 hectares at its peak; population estimates around 23,500. This is a Punjabi city, on a Punjabi river, that gave its name to a civilisation spanning three modern countries.
Mohenjo-daro	Larkana district, Sindh	The best-preserved city. About 300 hectares. Home of the Great Bath and the "Priest-King" statue. Not in Punjab, but the same civilisation.
Rakhigarhi	Hisar district, Haryana — part of historical Punjab	Possibly the largest site of all. One measurement puts it at around 350 hectares across its mounds, which would exceed Mohenjo-daro. Source of the famous 2019 DNA study.
Ganweriwala	Cholistan desert, Pakistani Punjab	Ranked around the fifth largest city of the civilisation. Largely unexcavated. Sits on the dried-up bed of the Ghaggar-Hakra river system.
Rupar (Ropar)	Rupnagar district, Indian Punjab, on the Sutlej	The first Harappan site excavated in independent India, in 1953. Proof that the civilisation reached well into today's Indian Punjab.
Kalibangan	Hanumangarh, Rajasthan	Famous for the world's earliest known ploughed field.

What these people had

The list is genuinely astonishing for 2600 BCE:

- **Grid-planned streets.** Main roads running north-south and east-west, crossing at right angles. Cities laid out on paper before they were built in mud.
- **Standardised bricks.** Baked bricks made to a ratio of roughly 1 : 2 : 4 — thickness to width to length — used at sites more than a thousand kilometres apart. Somebody was enforcing a standard across an area the size of Western Europe.
- **Covered drains and household bathrooms.** Waste water ran from houses into brick-lined sewers under the street, with inspection covers. No other civilisation of that era did sanitation on this scale. Many Indian and Pakistani towns did not match it until the twentieth century.
- **Standard weights.** Cubes of chert in a fixed binary sequence, accurate enough that traders a thousand kilometres apart could deal honestly.
- **Long-distance trade.** Harappan seals have been found in Mesopotamia. Mesopotamian records mention a trading land called Meluhha, which most scholars identify as the Indus

region.

- **Granaries, docks and water tanks**, including the Great Bath at Mohenjo-daro and the great reservoirs of Dholavira.
- **A script** — about 400 to 600 distinct signs, found on thousands of seals — that **nobody has been able to read**. Every claimed decipherment is disputed. Until it is read, we do not know their language, their gods' names, their kings' names, or their own name for themselves.

And now the awkward part

Here is what the Harappans did *not* have, and it is the most important paragraph in this chapter.

Archaeologists have dug at Harappan sites for over a hundred years. They have found no palaces. No royal tombs stuffed with gold. No monuments to kings. No carved scenes of a ruler crushing his enemies — the standard artwork of every other Bronze Age state. Almost no swords. Very few weapons of any kind beyond hunting tools. No evidence of a large standing army. Very little sign of city walls built for war, as opposed to embankments built against floods.

Compare this with Egypt, where the pharaoh's face is on everything, or Mesopotamia, whose art is full of bound prisoners and marching soldiers, or later Assyria, which decorated its palaces with flayings.

The first great civilisation of the Punjab plain appears to have been, by the standards of its time, remarkably peaceful and remarkably unhierarchical.

The oldest Punjabi civilisation we can dig up is the least warlike ancient civilisation on earth. Whatever made Punjabis fighters, it was not something in the soil.

Be careful here, in both directions. "Absence of evidence" is not proof. Wooden weapons rot. Cloth armour rots. Some scholars think Harappan society may have been more stratified and more violent than the romantic picture allows, and there is real skeletal evidence of injury at some sites. The honest statement is this: *compared with every contemporary civilisation we can compare it to, Harappan society left behind strikingly little evidence of organised warfare and glorified kingship*. That is a real finding, and it is inconvenient for a very popular story.

CONTESTED: HOW EQUAL WERE THEY?

The traditional reading — no palaces, no kings, standardised everything — suggests something like a merchant republic or a priest-led federation. A minority of archaeologists argue we simply have not found the elite burials yet, and that the standardisation itself implies strong central authority. Both readings are defensible. What almost nobody argues is that Harappa looked like Egypt or Assyria.

Why did it end?

For about seventy years, Indian schoolbooks taught a simple answer: invading Aryans destroyed the cities. That answer is now rejected by almost all specialists. Here is the current picture, which is messier and more interesting.

Climate. Around 2200 BCE the whole belt from Egypt to India experienced a long drying event. The monsoon weakened. In a semi-arid region utterly dependent on water, a few centuries of reduced rainfall and weaker river flow is a slow death sentence for large cities.

Rivers moving. Rivers on flat alluvial plains do not stay put. They wander, they jump their banks, they abandon whole channels. The Ghaggar-Hakra system — a river network east of the Indus, along which an extraordinary number of Harappan sites are clustered — dried up or shifted. Cities on a river that leaves are cities that end.

Trade collapse. Mesopotamia went through its own upheavals. When your export market disappears, your merchant cities lose their reason to exist.

Not invasion. The timing does not work. The cities were already declining from about 1900 BCE. The genetic evidence for the arrival of Central Asian steppe populations points to roughly 2000–1500 BCE and later, and the archaeological record shows no layer of burned cities and battle casualties of the kind an invasion would leave. The famous "massacre" skeletons at Mohenjo-daro, once presented as evidence, have been re-examined and largely explained by other causes.

The people did not vanish. They dispersed — eastward toward the Ganga plain and southward — and village life continued unbroken. Modern South Asians, including modern Punjabis, carry substantial Harappan ancestry. The cities died; the people did not.

CONTESTED: THE GHAGGAR-HAKRA AND THE "SARASWATI"

The Rigveda praises a mighty river called the **Saraswati**. Many Indian scholars identify it with the Ghaggar-Hakra, and note that a huge share of Harappan sites lie along its dry bed — which, if true, would push the Vedic world and the Harappan world much closer together in time and place, and would suggest an indigenous origin for Vedic culture. Other scholars argue the Ghaggar-Hakra was mainly monsoon-fed and never the vast glacier-fed river the hymns describe, and that "Saraswati" may originally have referred to the Helmand in Afghanistan. This dispute is genuinely unresolved and it is politically charged in India, because it bears on the Aryan migration question. I state it as open, because it is open.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Rigveda: Punjab's first book

India's oldest surviving text is a collection of hymns composed largely in Punjab, about Punjab's rivers, by people fighting over Punjab's land. Almost nobody thinks of it as a Punjabi book. It is.

What the Rigveda is

The Rigveda is a collection of 1,028 hymns in an archaic form of Sanskrit, arranged in ten books. It was composed orally and transmitted orally, memorised syllable by syllable with an accuracy that scholars find close to miraculous, for many centuries before anyone wrote it down.

Mainstream scholarship dates its composition to roughly **1500–1000 BCE**, with the oldest core possibly earlier. A number of Indian scholars argue for substantially earlier dates, some placing it before 2000 BCE and linking it to the Harappan world. I use the mainstream range while telling you the argument exists — that is Rule 2.

Punjab's rivers, in Punjab's oldest book

Read the river hymns and you are reading a map of Punjab.

RIGVEDIC RIVER NAMES AND THEIR MODERN EQUIVALENTS

Rigvedic name	Modern name	Note
Sindhu	Indus	The trunk river. Gave its name to Hindu, India, Sindh and Hindustan.
Vitasta	Jhelum	
Asikni	Chenab	"The dark one."
Parushni (later Iravati)	Ravi	Site of the Battle of the Ten Kings.
Vipas	Beas	
Shutudri	Sutlej	"Swift-flowing."
Saraswati	Disputed — probably the Ghaggar-Hakra	See the contested box in Chapter 4.

The region as a whole is called **Sapta Sindhu**, the land of seven rivers. Whether you count the seven as the five plus the Indus plus the Saraswati, or arrange them some other way, the point is settled: the world of the Rigveda is centred on the Punjab plain and the north-west.

The Battle of the Ten Kings

Now the event, which deserves to be far better known than it is.

Hymns 7.18, 7.33 and 7.83 of the Rigveda describe a war. On one side stood **King Sudas** of the **Bharata** tribe, advised by the priest **Vasishtha**. On the other stood a confederation of ten kings — the Purus, Yadus, Turvashas, Anus, Druhyus, and several smaller peoples with names like Alina, Paktha, Bhalanas, Shiva and Vishanin.

The battle was fought on the banks of the **Parushni** — the Ravi — the third and central river of Punjab. Water was decisive. The hymns describe the river being manipulated, embankments broken, and large numbers of the enemy drowning as they tried to cross.

Sudas and the Bharatas won.

Three things follow from this, and each of them is large.

First: the earliest named battle in Indian literature was fought in Punjab, on a Punjabi river, and won by controlling the water. Three thousand years before the Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal dispute, the decisive weapon on this plain was already a river.

Second: the winning tribe was the Bharatas. The Republic of India's official name in its own Constitution — *Bharat* — traces back to this tribal name. The word by which India names itself has, in its ancestry, a tribe that won a battle on the banks of the Ravi.

Third: this sets a pattern that will repeat for the next three thousand years. Punjab is where the north's power is decided. Alexander and Porus, Mahmud of Ghazni, the three battles of Panipat on Punjab's eastern edge, the Anglo-Sikh wars, the tank battles of 1965 and 1971 — the same plain, over and over.

REMEMBER THIS FOR PART 12

People who argue for Khalistan sometimes describe Punjab as an ancient nation temporarily occupied by India. People who argue against sometimes describe Punjab as merely a province with no separate identity. The Rigveda is bad news for both. It shows Punjab as an old, distinct, self-aware world — *and* shows that world as the origin point of the very name "Bharat." The two histories are not separable. They are the same history.

The Aryan question, handled honestly

You cannot discuss the Rigveda in India without hitting this, so let us hit it directly and fairly.

The question: did the people who composed the Rigveda come into India from outside, or were they always here?

What was taught for a long time (and is now discarded): the "Aryan Invasion Theory" — that fair-skinned Aryans rode in on chariots, destroyed the Harappan cities and enslaved the

locals. This version was heavily shaped by nineteenth-century European racial thinking, and the archaeology does not support it. It is dead.

What most international genetics and linguistics now supports: a slower *migration*, not an invasion. The large 2019 study by Narasimhan, Patterson and colleagues, using ancient DNA from across Central and South Asia, found that ancestry from Central Asian steppe pastoralists spread into South Asia in roughly the first half of the second millennium BCE — around 2000 to 1500 BCE — after the Harappan cities were already declining, and that it contributes up to around 30% of the ancestry of some modern South Asian groups. On this reading, Indo-European languages, including the ancestor of Sanskrit and eventually of Punjabi and Hindi, spread into South Asia in that period.

What the Rakhigarhi study found: in 2019, Shinde, Narasimhan and colleagues published the genome of a single individual from Rakhigarhi. The paper's title is blunt: the genome *lacks* ancestry from steppe pastoralists. In other words, the Harappan person tested had no steppe ancestry at all. The authors themselves caution, in print, that one individual cannot settle the question for a whole civilisation.

What Indian scholars who dispute the migration model argue: that the genetic sampling is thin and heavily weighted toward Central Asia; that the Rigveda contains no memory of a foreign homeland; that the river geography in it is purely Indian; that the Saraswati evidence points to a Vedic culture already present in the Harappan period; and that "steppe ancestry" arriving does not automatically prove the language arrived with it.

WHERE THIS ACTUALLY STANDS

The invasion version is finished. The migration version is the mainstream international position and is supported by the current genetic data. It is not unanimous, the data set is still small, and some serious Indian scholars contest it. Anyone who tells you this question is *completely* settled — in either direction — is overstating.

Why this argument matters less than people think — for our purposes

Here is something worth saying plainly. For the questions this book is really about — Khalistan, 1984, water, Chandigarh, Punjab's future — the Aryan debate changes almost nothing.

Whichever version is true, the outcome is identical: by 1000 BCE there is a settled population on the Punjab plain, speaking an Indo-European language, with a religious literature centred on these rivers, already fighting large organised wars over this land. That population is continuous with the population there today. Nobody in the Punjab of 2026 can claim descent from only one ancient stream, and nobody can be told they do not belong. The genetics, on every reading, show mixture.

People fight about the Aryan question because it is a proxy for a modern political fight about who is "originally" Indian. It is worth understanding, which is why it is here. But it is not

load-bearing for anything in Parts 7 to 13.

CHAPTER SIX

Why geography is destiny here

This is the analytical heart of Part 1. Four permanent facts about the ground itself. They have not changed in five thousand years, and they explain more of Punjab's history than any king, religion or ideology.

Fact One: Punjab is the door

The Indian subcontinent is one of the most naturally sealed regions on earth. Ocean on three sides. The Himalaya to the north — the highest wall on the planet. Dense forest and hill country to the east.

There is one practical land entrance: the north-west, through the passes of the Hindu Kush and Sulaiman ranges — the Khyber, the Bolan, the Gomal, the Kurram.

Walk through any of them and you come down onto a plain. That plain is Punjab.

Not Delhi. Not Uttar Pradesh. Not Rajasthan. Punjab is what an invader sees first, and there is nothing between the mouth of the passes and the Punjabi wheat fields.

Now list who came through: Persians under Darius. Alexander of Macedon. Central Asian Scythians and Parthians. The Kushans. The Hunas. Mahmud of Ghazni, seventeen times. Muhammad of Ghor. Timur. Babur. Nadir Shah. Ahmad Shah Abdali, repeatedly. Every one of them entered India by walking into Punjab.

Punjab was not unlucky. Punjab was *positioned*.

Fact Two: Punjab cannot hide

Some regions absorb invasion by being difficult. The Deccan swallowed armies in its distances and hills. Rajasthan had its desert and its fortress-hills. Assam broke Mughal armies on rivers and jungle. Kashmir sat behind a wall of mountains. Nepal was never conquered by anyone.

Punjab has no such gift. It is flat. Its only obstacles are its five rivers, and rivers on a flat plain can be forded in the dry season. There is no defensible line, no natural fortress, no place to retreat and regroup.

This produces a brutal binary. A society on such ground has exactly two options when an army appears: **submit, or meet it in the open field**. There is no third choice, because there is nowhere to hide.

Now think about what a thousand years of that does to a culture. Communities that could not fight were repeatedly plundered and enslaved. Communities that could fight survived and passed on their institutions, their weapons, their songs and their memory of resistance. This is

not a mystical racial quality. It is straightforward selection pressure applied to a society over an extremely long time.

*Punjabis did not become fighters because of what was in their blood.
They became fighters because of what was under their feet.*

Fact Three: Punjab is worth taking

Being at the door is only dangerous if the room is worth entering.

Poor, dry, empty land at a frontier gets ignored — nobody has repeatedly invaded the Thar desert. Punjab, by contrast, offered the deepest, flattest, most fertile soil in northern India, watered by five rivers, capable of producing a large food surplus. A large food surplus means a large population, tax revenue, horses, grain to feed an army, and a road onward to Delhi and the riches of the Ganga plain.

So Punjab combined the three worst possible attributes for a piece of real estate: **easy to enter, impossible to defend, extremely valuable.**

That combination is the entire explanation for the next four thousand years.

Fact Four: Punjab does not control its own water

This is the fact that will decide Parts 8, 12 and 13, so read it twice.

Punjab's wealth is its rivers. But look at where those rivers begin and end.

- **They are born outside Punjab.** The Jhelum rises in Kashmir. The Chenab, Ravi and Beas rise in Himachal Pradesh and the Lahaul hills. The Sutlej rises in *Tibet*, which means it enters the region from territory controlled by China. Not one of the five rivers has its source inside the Punjab plain.
- **They must leave through somebody else's land.** All five drain into the Indus, and the Indus reaches the sea through Sindh. Punjab has no coastline. It never has had one. There is no port, no harbour, no salt water anywhere in it.

So Punjab is a place whose entire prosperity depends on a resource it does not create and cannot deliver to the sea on its own. It sits in the middle of the pipe, holding neither the tap nor the drain.

For most of history this did not matter much, because the same empire usually held the mountains, the plain and the coast together. It matters enormously the moment borders are drawn across the system. And in the twentieth century, borders were drawn across it twice — once in 1947 between India and Pakistan, and once in 1966 between Punjab, Haryana and Himachal Pradesh.

WHO HOLDS WHAT, TODAY

Part of the system	Who controls it now
Source of the Sutlej	China (Tibet)
Sources of Ravi, Beas, Chenab	Himachal Pradesh and Jammu & Kashmir — Indian states, not Punjab
Source of the Jhelum	Jammu & Kashmir
Waters of Indus, Jhelum, Chenab	Allocated to Pakistan under the Indus Waters Treaty, 1960
Waters of Ravi, Beas, Sutlej	Allocated to India under the same treaty — then divided again between Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan
The mouth of the Indus, and the sea	Pakistan (Sindh)

THE MOST IMPORTANT BOX IN PART 1

An independent Indian Punjab would be a landlocked territory whose rivers are born in India and China and reach the sea only through Pakistan, and whose farms depend on water shared under agreements it would no longer be party to. This is not an argument invented by opponents of Khalistan. It is a description of the ground, and it has been true since the Bronze Age. Part 12 will do the full arithmetic. Part 1 simply establishes that the arithmetic exists.

Putting the four together

Four facts, one sentence each:

1. Punjab is the only easy land door into India.
2. Punjab cannot be defended by terrain, only by people standing and fighting.
3. Punjab is rich enough that everyone wants it.
4. Punjab depends on water it does not own, and has no sea of its own.

Facts 1, 2 and 3 together explain the warrior culture, the martyrdom tradition, the constant invasion, the militarisation, and why Punjab has been fought over more than any other part of South Asia.

Fact 4 explains 1947, 1960, 1966, the Chandigarh dispute, the SYL canal, the groundwater crisis, and the hard limit on any independence project.

The rest of this thirteen-part book is, in a sense, just those four facts colliding with human beings for five thousand years.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Scorecard: what Part 1 proves

At the end of every part, I test the popular claims against what the evidence in that part actually showed. Here is the first scorecard.

"Punjab is one of the oldest civilisations on earth."

TRUE

Continuous settlement for at least 5,000 years, and farming in the wider region for closer to 9,000. Harappa, the city that named the Indus Valley Civilisation, sits on the Ravi in Punjab. This civilisation was larger in area than Egypt and Mesopotamia combined. There is no exaggeration needed here; the plain facts are impressive enough.

"Punjabis have always been warriors. It is in their blood."

FALSE AS STATED

The oldest Punjabi civilisation we can excavate left behind almost no weapons, no royal war-art, no evidence of a standing army, and no palaces — it is the least militaristic major Bronze Age culture known. Punjab's warrior tradition is real, but it is a *response*, developed over millennia because the land is the front door of the subcontinent and cannot be defended by terrain.

Why the correction matters: a trait that was *made* by circumstances can be redirected, exploited, or turned against its own people. If courage is a bloodline, nobody is responsible for how it is used. If it is a cultural inheritance shaped by history, then the people who inherit it are responsible for what they do with it — and the people who manipulate it are responsible too. Part 9 and Part 10 will turn on exactly this distinction.

"Punjab was always a separate nation."

NOT SUPPORTED

In this period Punjab is a region, a river system and a cluster of tribes and kingdoms — never a single sovereign state. It is a name that only appears around 1300 CE. As an independent unified state governing the whole five-river country, Punjab exists for roughly fifty years, from 1799 to 1849, out of five thousand. Even at its greatest, the Sikh Empire did not correspond to today's Indian Punjab. This does not make Punjabi identity fake — but it does mean any claim to a continuously existing Punjabi nation is a claim about something that never existed.

"Punjab is fundamentally Indian" / "Punjab was never Indian."**BOTH ANACHRONISTIC**

For this period, neither statement is meaningful, because neither "India" nor "Punjab" existed as political entities. What can be said is narrower and more interesting: the oldest surviving Indian text was composed largely in Punjab, about Punjab's rivers; and the tribe that won its most famous battle, on the banks of the Ravi, was the Bharatas — the source of the name India uses for itself. Punjab is not a later addition to Indian civilisation. It is one of the rooms the house was built around. That is a historical statement, not a political one, and it does not by itself settle any modern constitutional argument.

"Punjab's water problems started in 1947 / 1966."**PARTLY TRUE — BUT MUCH OLDER**

The specific disputes are modern. The underlying vulnerability is not. Punjab has always been a semi-arid plain, dependent on rivers born outside it, with no access to the sea. Borders drawn in 1947 and 1966 turned a permanent structural weakness into a permanent political fight. Anyone who says the water problem was created by Delhi is ignoring geology. Anyone who says the borders made no difference is ignoring history.

What Part 1 could not answer

Honesty requires listing what remains open after this part:

- We cannot read the Harappan script, so we do not know what those people called themselves, what language they spoke, or how they governed.
- The exact date and origin of the Rigveda remain contested.
- The Saraswati / Ghaggar-Hakra identification is unresolved.
- The precise mechanism by which Indo-European language arrived is still being argued, with the genetic data still thin.

None of these gaps affects the four geographic facts in Chapter 6, which is why I lean on those rather than on the contested prehistory.

Timeline of Part 1

c.	7000	BCE	Farming begins in the wider north-west region (Mehrgarh).
c.	3300	BCE	Early Harappan phase: villages become towns.
c.	2600	BCE	Mature Harappan phase begins. Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Ganweriwala, Rakhigarhi. Planned cities, drains, standard bricks and weights, seals, trade with Mesopotamia.
c.	2200	BCE	A long drying period affects the whole belt from Egypt to India.
c.	1900	BCE	Harappan cities begin to decline and are gradually abandoned. Ghaggar-Hakra river system fails.

c. 2000–1500 BCE	On current genetic evidence, ancestry from Central Asian steppe populations spreads into South Asia.
c. 1500–1000 BCE	The Rigveda is composed, largely in the Punjab region. The land is called Sapta Sindhu.
c. 1400 BCE (est.)	The Battle of the Ten Kings on the Parushni (Ravi). Sudas and the Bharatas defeat a coalition of ten.
c. 1000–600 BCE	Political centre of gravity shifts east to the Ganga plain. The Kuru polity forms. Punjab becomes the frontier rather than the centre.
c. 518 BCE	The Persian Empire under Darius I annexes the Indus region. Punjab becomes the eastern edge of the largest empire in the world — and Part 2 begins.

What happens in Part 2

Part 2, *Porus to the Huns*, covers roughly 500 BCE to 1000 CE. Alexander of Macedon crosses the Jhelum in 326 BCE and meets a Punjabi king the Greeks called Porus in one of the most famous battles in world history — and then his army mutinies on the banks of the Beas and refuses to go further. We will look at what actually happened there, and at what the Greek sources say about Punjabi resistance.

Then: Chandragupta Maurya and Chanakya building India's first great empire from Punjab's edge; Ashoka; the Indo-Greek kingdoms and the strange, brilliant Greco-Buddhist world of Taxila and Gandhara; the Kushans; and finally the Hunas, whose invasions in the fifth and sixth centuries CE shattered north India and set the pattern for everything that came after.

Above all, Part 2 answers a question Part 1 only raised: **how does a land of peaceful city-planners turn into a land famous for producing soldiers?** The answer starts with Alexander.

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 1

I cite my sources so you can check me. Where a claim is contested, I give the competing sources together.

On the Indus Valley Civilisation

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- Wikipedia, *Battle of the Ten Kings* — for the tribal coalition, the location on the Parushni, and the link to the formation of the Kuru polity.
- Michael Witzel's work on Rigvedic geography and river names, and on the location of Vedic tribes.
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On the name, the rivers and the doabs

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On geography, climate and water

- India Meteorological Department rainfall normals for Punjab districts.
- Indus Waters Treaty, 1960 — full text available from the World Bank, which brokered it.
- Recommended for the long view: Alice Albinia, *Empires of the Indus*; Daniel Haines, *Rivers Divided*.

A NOTE ON USING WIKIPEDIA

Several factual figures in this part are drawn from Wikipedia entries. That is appropriate for uncontroversial descriptive facts — site sizes, river names, doab boundaries — where the entries are well sourced to specialist literature. It would not be appropriate for the contested political material in Parts 9 to 13, and I do not use it that way there. When I reach the disputed ground, my sources shift to primary documents, government reports, court judgments, and named scholars on both sides.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 1 —

Part 2: *Porus to the Huns*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART TWO OF THIRTEEN

Porus to the Huns

c. 500 BCE to 1000 CE — fifteen centuries of invasion, and the golden age nobody talks about

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 2

In Part 1 I set out five rules and declared my interest: I am Punjabi, writing about Punjab, with no formal training in history and a deliberate habit — borrowed from security work — of attacking my own conclusions before anyone else gets the chance. Everything in that note still applies. If you have not read it, Part 1 opens with it.

I want to add one thing specific to this part.

Chapter 2 of Part 2 changed how I think about this whole project. I began this research expecting to write about Punjab as a place that fights. I did not know — and I am reasonably well read, and I am from there — that the greatest grammar ever written was composed by a man from a village near Taxila, that a Greek king ruling from Sialkot became a Buddhist saint in a text still studied in Japan, or that the face on every Buddha statue in Asia was designed in the north-west of this subcontinent.

Nobody taught me that. I want to know why, and Chapter 6 turned out to be the answer. That is the shape of this part: a golden age, and then the thing that erased it so completely that its own descendants forgot it happened.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

The question Part 2 has to answer

Part 1 ended with an awkward finding. The oldest Punjabi civilisation we can excavate — Harappa — left behind almost no weapons, no war-art, no palaces and no evidence of an army. So where did the warriors come from?

Part 2 is the answer. It covers roughly fifteen hundred years, from about 500 BCE to about 1000 CE, and it is the period in which Punjab was turned into what it later became.

Three things happen in these fifteen centuries, and they happen at the same time, which is why Punjab's character ends up so contradictory.

The first thing is invasion, on repeat. Persians, Greeks, Scythians, Parthians, Kushans, Hunas — six waves of outsiders, each entering through the north-western passes, each hitting Punjab first. Not one of them lands anywhere else. By the end of this period, a society has been shaped by fifteen hundred years of standing in a doorway that everybody kicks in.

The second thing is a golden age. This is the part almost nobody knows, and it is the reason Part 2 exists. During these same centuries, the north-west — Punjab and the neighbouring region of Gandhara — was one of the most intellectually productive places on the entire planet. It produced the greatest grammar book ever written. It produced Taxila, one of the ancient world's great centres of learning. It produced the first images of the Buddha in human form, which is to say it designed the face that a billion people across Asia have prayed to ever since. If you think Punjab is a place that only produces soldiers and farmers, this part is going to embarrass you — it embarrassed me.

The third thing is a catastrophe, in the fifth and sixth centuries CE, which destroys the golden age so completely that most people have never heard it existed. After that catastrophe, Punjab stops being a place of learning and becomes, permanently, a frontier.

Punjab did not choose to become a warrior society. It was hammered into one, and we can watch the hammer fall, century by century, in this part.

One more thing Part 2 establishes

There is a pattern that begins in this period and never stops. It will come back in Part 5, dominate Part 6, and become the central tragedy of Parts 9 and 10.

The pattern is this: **Punjab always splits.**

When Alexander arrived in 326 BCE, one Punjabi king joined him and marched against another Punjabi king. That is the first documented instance. It is not the last. Punjabis fought for the Mughals and against them; for the British and against them; for the Indian state and against it. Every single time Punjab faces a crisis, some Punjabis are on each side.

People who want a simple story hate this fact. They want Punjab to be a single actor with a single will — either a heroic resister or a loyal servant. It has never once been that. Knowing this from 326 BCE onward will save you from about half the nonsense written about 1984.

What is in Part 2

CHAPTER 1 The Persians arrive: Punjab joins the world, 518 BCE.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Persians arrive

Around 518 BCE, Punjab became a province of the largest empire the world had yet seen — and started getting paid in gold to stay that way.

What happened

The Achaemenid Persian Empire, under Cyrus and then Darius I, expanded until it stretched from Greece and Egypt in the west to the Indus in the east. Sometime around 518 BCE, Darius annexed the Indus region.

Two new provinces — the Persians called them *satrapies*, which simply means governorships — appear in Persian records:

- **Gandhara** — the region around Peshawar and Taxila, straddling today's Pakistan–Afghanistan border.
- **Hindush** — the Indus and Punjab country to the south and east.

The Greek historian Herodotus, writing in the 400s BCE, records something remarkable about this province. He says the Indian satrapy was the **richest in the entire Persian Empire**, paying tribute of 360 talents of gold dust — a colossal figure, far more than any other province.

Herodotus was not always reliable and the number may be inflated. But even allowing for exaggeration, the point stands and it confirms what Part 1 predicted from the geography: the five-river plain was *wealthy*, and everyone knew it.

What Punjab got out of it

Being ruled from Persepolis for roughly two centuries was not just a humiliation. It plugged Punjab into a world system.

WHAT PERSIAN RULE BROUGHT TO THE NORTH-WEST

What arrived	Why it mattered
The Aramaic script	The Persian Empire's administrative script. In the north-west it evolved into Kharosthi , which was written right-to-left and became the everyday script of Gandhara and Punjab for the next 700 years. Punjab's first widely used writing system came in on a Persian tax form.
Coinage	Standardised metal money, replacing barter and bullion-by-weight for many transactions.
Imperial administration	Satrapies, tribute assessment, royal roads, standing garrisons, a postal relay system. Ideas that the Mauryas would later use to run India.
A road west	Punjab became the eastern terminus of a trade and communication network reaching to the Mediterranean.

There is a detail here that most Indians find surprising. Indian soldiers from these satrapies served in Persian armies *in Europe*. Herodotus lists Indian contingents — infantry with cane bows and iron-tipped arrows, and cavalry with chariots — in Xerxes' great invasion of Greece in 480 BCE. Men from the Indus and Punjab fought at Plataea, in Greece, in 479 BCE.

PUT SIMPLY

Two and a half thousand years ago, Punjabi soldiers were fighting in Europe as part of a foreign empire's army, and Punjabi gold was paying that empire's bills. Punjab has never been a sealed-off village. It has been internationally connected — sometimes profitably, sometimes painfully — for as long as we have records.

REMEMBER THIS FOR PART 6

Punjabis serving as the fighting arm of a distant empire, in wars that were not theirs, in exchange for pay and status — this begins in 480 BCE. When the British recruit a third of their Indian Army from Punjab in the 1900s and send them to France and Mesopotamia, it is not a new relationship. It is a very old one.

CHAPTER TWO

Panini and Taxila

If you remember one thing from Part 2, make it this chapter. The single greatest thing ever produced in Punjab is not a battle, a fort or an empire. It is a book about grammar, and it is still being studied by computer scientists.

Taxila: what it actually was

Taxila — Sanskrit *Takshashila* — stood in what is now Rawalpindi district in Pakistani Punjab, about 35 km north-west of Islamabad. It is a UNESCO World Heritage Site today.

It was not one city but a sequence of three, each built by a different power, which tells you everything about the region's history:

THE THREE CITIES OF TAXILA

City	Built by / period	Character
Bhir Mound	From the 6th century BCE	The original town. Winding, organic streets. The Achaemenid and Mauryan-era city. This is the Taxila that Alexander and Chandragupta saw.
Sirkap	2nd century BCE, Greco-Bactrian / Indo-Greek	A completely different thing: a planned grid city on the Greek model, streets crossing at right angles, fortified walls. Inside it, Buddhist stupas stand beside Greek-style temples. The physical evidence of two civilisations sharing one street.
Sirsukh	1st–2nd century CE, Kushan	The Central Asian city, with rounded bastions in the Parthian style.

Around them lie the great Buddhist complexes: the **Dharmarajika Stupa** — built over relics of the Buddha, traditionally attributed to Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE — and the monasteries of Jaulian, Mohra Muradu, Kalawan and others.

Was Taxila a "university"? An honest correction

You will often read that Taxila was "the world's first university," founded in 700 BCE, with 10,500 students from all over Asia. Treat those specifics with caution. They come largely from later Buddhist stories (the Jatakas) rather than from documents or inscriptions.

What the evidence supports is this: Taxila was a **concentration of renowned individual teachers** who took on students, in a city rich enough and connected enough to attract them from across the subcontinent and beyond. There was no single campus, no central administration, no degrees, no examinations in the modern sense. It was closer to Athens in the time of Socrates than to Oxford.

That is still extraordinary. But I do not need to inflate anything, so I will not.

Who studied or taught there, according to tradition and to some reasonably good sources:

- **Chanakya** (also called Kautilya), the political strategist who wrote the *Arthashastra* and engineered the Mauryan Empire — Chapter 4.
- **Jivaka**, the physician of the Buddha's time, remembered across the Buddhist world as the model doctor.
- **Chandragupta Maurya**, reportedly educated there before he became emperor.
- And, from the same region, **Panini**.

Panini: the greatest mind Punjab ever produced

Panini was born at **Salatura**, a village in Gandhara near the confluence of the Indus and Kabul rivers, close to Taxila. He probably lived in the 5th or 4th century BCE, though the date is debated.

He wrote a book called the **Ashtadhyayi** — "Eight Chapters."

Here is what it is. In roughly **3,959 short rules**, Panini describes the complete grammar of Sanskrit. Not a description in the sense of "here are some examples and patterns." A description in the sense of *a formal system that generates the language*. You feed it roots and rules, and correct Sanskrit comes out. Rules are ordered, they reference each other, some override others, and Panini invented a compressed technical notation to state them — including a metalanguage, a set of symbols for talking about the rules themselves.

To put that in plain terms: Panini did for a human language what a modern programmer does when they write the formal specification for a programming language. In the 4th century BCE. With no writing — the text was composed to be memorised.

PUT SIMPLY

Imagine someone wrote a rulebook so precise that a machine could follow it and produce perfect Hindi or English, every time, with no exceptions unaccounted for. Nobody has ever fully managed that for English. Panini did it for Sanskrit two and a half thousand years ago, and his rulebook is still the standard reference.

Modern linguists do not treat this as a historical curiosity. Leonard Bloomfield, one of the founders of modern linguistics, called the *Ashtadhyayi* "one of the greatest monuments of human intelligence." The American linguist Noam Chomsky's approach to generative grammar has been repeatedly compared to Panini's method. In computer science, the notation used to define the syntax of programming languages — Backus–Naur Form — is so similar in spirit to Panini's system that some scholars have proposed calling it "Panini–Backus Form."

Sanskrit, as a formal literary language, is essentially *Panini's Sanskrit*. Every classical Sanskrit text written after him follows his rules. A man from a village in Gandhara fixed the

grammar of the language of Indian civilisation, and it has not needed changing since.

Punjab's greatest export to the world is not the sword. It is a grammar book, and it is still in use.

Why this chapter is here

Two very different insults get thrown at Punjab, and this chapter kills both.

The first insult is the flattering one: *Punjabis are simple, brave fighting people*. It sounds like a compliment. It is not. It quietly says: strong bodies, no brains. Panini answers that.

The second insult is the direct one: *Punjab has no intellectual tradition, it is all farmers and soldiers and loud music*. Taxila, the Ashtadhyayi, the *Milinda Panha* and Gandhara art answer that.

Both insults survive only because most people, including most Punjabis, have never been taught that this period existed. That is a consequence of Chapter 6, where the whole thing gets destroyed.

CHAPTER THREE

Alexander, 326 BCE

Everybody has heard of Alexander in India. Almost nobody knows what actually happened, in either direction. Here is the whole of it — the wins, the losses, the fabrications, and the part where his army told him no.

Before anything else: a warning about the sources

This is the single most important paragraph in the chapter, so read it before the exciting bits.

There is not one Indian account of Alexander's invasion. Not one. No Punjabi chronicle, no inscription, no Sanskrit text describes it. Everything we know comes from Greek and Roman writers: Arrian, Curtius Rufus, Diodorus Siculus, Plutarch, Justin.

And none of them was there. They were writing **three to five hundred years after the events**, working from earlier accounts — some by Alexander's own officers, who had obvious reasons to make their king look good.

So when this chapter gives you a number, understand what kind of number it is: a figure written by a member of the winning civilisation, centuries later, based on a report by someone on the winner's payroll. That does not make it worthless. It does mean I handle it the way I would handle a company's own press release about its own performance.

WHY THE NUMBERS SWING SO WILDLY

For the same battle, Arrian says Porus had 200 elephants and 30,000 infantry; Diodorus says 130 elephants and 50,000 infantry. Indian casualties are given as anywhere from 12,000 to 23,000; Macedonian losses from about 200 to over 1,000. When ancient sources disagree by a factor of two or five, the honest response is to report the range, not to pick the flattering end. I report the range.

The campaign, step by step

327–326 BCE: Alexander crosses into the north-west. He has already destroyed the Persian Empire. He fights his way through the hill country and takes the fortress of Aornos.

Spring 326 BCE: Taxila surrenders without a fight. Its king — the Greeks call him Taxiles or Omphis; Indian tradition calls him **Ambhi** — comes out to meet Alexander with gifts, elephants and troops, and offers his alliance. His reason was straightforward: he had a rival across the Jhelum, and a Macedonian army was a useful thing to point at him.

Hold on to that. The very first Punjabi ruler Alexander met joined him, and then helped him attack another Punjabi ruler.

May 326 BCE: the Battle of the Hydaspes. The Jhelum, swollen by early monsoon rain, separates Alexander from King Porus — *Puru* or *Paurava* in Indian terms, a king of the Bari and Chaj doab country.

THE BATTLE OF THE HYDASPES — THE FORCES, AS REPORTED

Side	According to Arrian	According to Diodorus
Porus	200 elephants; 300–420 chariots; 4,000–6,000 cavalry; 30,000 infantry	130 elephants; 1,000 chariots; 3,000 cavalry; 50,000 infantry
Alexander (the strike force he took across the river, not his whole army)	c. 6,000 infantry; c. 5,000 cavalry	—

How Alexander won. Not by breaking through. By deception. He spent days making noisy fake crossing attempts up and down the bank until Porus stopped reacting to them. Then, on a night of heavy storm, he took a picked force roughly 27 kilometres upstream and crossed in the dark, in the rain, with the thunder covering the noise. He came down on Porus's flank at dawn.

The elephants — Porus's main weapon — turned into his main problem. Wounded, panicked and hemmed in, they trampled backwards through their own infantry. Macedonian troops had learnt to open lanes and let them through, then attack their handlers.

Casualties. Indian dead are reported between about 12,000 and 23,000, including two of Porus's sons. Macedonian losses are reported between about 200 and over 1,000. Even taking the Greek sources at their word, this was a costlier fight than Gaugamela, where Alexander had destroyed the entire Persian imperial army.

The aftermath, and the strangest part. Porus, wounded, surrendered only after his army was destroyed. Brought before Alexander, he was asked how he wished to be treated. His reply, as the Greeks recorded it: "*As a king treats a king.*"

Alexander then did something he did nowhere else in his career. He restored Porus to his throne as a subordinate ally — and *enlarged* his territory.

TWO READINGS OF WHAT THAT MEANS

Reading A (the traditional one): Alexander was genuinely impressed by Porus's courage and bearing, and behaved with the magnanimity the Greek sources love to attribute to him.

Reading B (the sceptical one): Alexander's army was badly hurt, he was deep in hostile country with unfordable rivers behind him, and he urgently needed a strong local ally to hold the region while he pushed on. Restoring Porus was not sentiment; it was necessity — and the Greek sources dressed it up.

Both readings are held by serious historians, and I cannot decisively settle it. What the episode *does* tell us is that the fight was hard enough that Alexander's best option afterwards was to keep his defeated enemy in power.

Sangala: the battle nobody mentions

After the Hydaspes, Alexander moved east and ran into a people the Greeks called the **Cathaeans**, at a fortified town called **Sangala** — its location is disputed but it was somewhere in central Punjab.

They did not negotiate. They ringed their position with wagons and fought. Arrian records that the resistance was fierce enough to maul Alexander's cavalry badly; the Macedonians had to take the place by infantry assault and siege. Alexander then razed Sangala to the ground. Arrian's figures — around 17,000 Indians killed and 70,000 captured — are almost certainly inflated, but the destruction was real.

Sangala is worth knowing about because it is the counter-example to the polite version of the campaign. This was not a tour with occasional duels between noble kings. In places it was a war of extermination against towns that refused to submit.

The mutiny on the Beas

Summer 326 BCE. Alexander reaches the **Hyphasis** — the Beas, the fourth of the five rivers. He wants to keep going east, across the Sutlej and on to the Ganga.

His army refuses.

They had been marching and fighting for eight years. They were thousands of kilometres from home, soaked by monsoon rain that rotted their equipment, and they had just been told what was waiting beyond the Ganga: the **Nanda Empire** of Magadha, whose army was reported to include something on the order of 200,000 infantry, 20,000 cavalry, thousands of chariots and several thousand war elephants. Whatever the true figure, the reports were terrifying, and they had just seen at the Hydaspes what 130 to 200 elephants could do.

An officer named **Coenus** — a respected veteran, not a malcontent — stood up and spoke for the men. Arrian preserves the substance of the speech: they had done everything he asked, most of their friends were dead, and they wanted to see their homes.

Alexander argued. Then he shut himself in his tent for three days, waiting for them to change their minds. They did not.

He turned back. Before leaving he built twelve enormous altars on the bank of the Beas to mark the eastern limit of his empire.

The empire of Alexander the Great ends at a river in Punjab. Not because he was defeated there — because his soldiers, standing in Punjabi mud in the rain, refused to find out what was on the other side.

The way back: the Malli campaign, and the wound

Turning back did not mean going home in peace. Alexander went south down the Jhelum and Indus, fighting the whole way.

From November 326 to February 325 BCE he attacked the **Malli** — the Malava — a confederation living around the meeting point of the Jhelum, Chenab and Ravi. Their principal town is generally identified with modern **Multan**.

The Malli campaign was savage. And at Multan it nearly ended Alexander's life.

Impatient with a slow assault, Alexander went up a scaling ladder and jumped down *inside* the enemy wall with only two or three companions. Cut off, he was hit by an arrow that punched through his breastplate and into his lung. He collapsed, coughing blood.

His army, believing their king was dead, broke into the citadel in a fury and killed everyone inside — men, women and children. It was one of the worst massacres of the entire campaign.

Alexander survived the arrow, but the wound never properly healed and he was in pain for the rest of his life. He died in Babylon less than two years later, aged 32. A number of historians consider the Multan wound a contributing cause.

The honest scorecard on Alexander in Punjab

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

Claim	Reality
"Alexander conquered India."	He entered the north-west and Punjab. He never crossed the Beas. He never saw the Ganga, Magadha, or 95% of the subcontinent.
"Alexander was defeated by Porus."	Every surviving source says Porus lost the battle. This claim is popular online and it is not supported. What <i>is</i> defensible is that the battle was unusually costly and Alexander's subsequent behaviour suggests a harder fight than the propaganda admits.
"Alexander's conquest was permanent."	It lasted about twenty years. By roughly 305 BCE the Mauryas had taken all of it, and the Greeks formally gave it up by treaty — see Chapter 4.
"Punjab united to resist him."	No. Ambhi of Taxila allied with him and fought against Porus. Some kings submitted, some fought, some were annihilated. Punjab split.
"It was an easy campaign."	He lost heavily at the Hydaspes and Sangala, his cavalry was mauled, his army mutinied, and he took a near-fatal wound at Multan. The Indian campaign broke Alexander's momentum and arguably broke Alexander.

THE PATTERN, FIRST SIGHTING

Ambhi joined the invader. Porus fought him. The Cathaeans died rather than surrender. The Malli nearly killed him. All four were Punjabis, at the same time, in the same crisis, on different sides. Write this down, because you will see it again in 1849, in 1919, in 1947 and — most painfully — in 1988. Punjab has never faced anything as one body.

CHAPTER FOUR

Chandragupta and Chanakya

Within twenty years of Alexander's death, a man from the north-west and his teacher from Taxila had built the largest empire India would see for two thousand years — and had taken the Greeks' Indian provinces back by force.

The rise

Alexander died in Babylon in 323 BCE. His generals immediately began carving up his empire. The Macedonian garrisons in the north-west were suddenly a long way from anywhere, with no one coming to help them.

Into that vacuum stepped **Chandragupta Maurya**, advised by **Chanakya** — also known as Kautilya or Vishnugupta — a strategist traditionally associated with Taxila.

The details of Chandragupta's origins are genuinely uncertain and the ancient traditions disagree about his caste and birth. What is well attested is the sequence: he built a power base in the north-west, cleared out the remaining Macedonian positions, and then marched east and destroyed the **Nanda dynasty** of Magadha — the very empire whose reputation had turned Alexander's army back — around 322 to 321 BCE.

Note the direction of travel. The empire that first unified India was assembled starting from **Punjab and Gandhara**, and moved east. Not the other way round.

The rematch: Seleucus, 305–303 BCE

One of Alexander's generals, **Seleucus I Nicator**, took the Asian half of the empire and, around 305 BCE, marched east to reclaim the Indian provinces.

He did not reclaim them.

The details of the fighting are poorly recorded — which itself suggests it did not go well for him — but the outcome is clear and is recorded on both sides. A peace treaty was concluded around 303 BCE with these terms:

- Seleucus **ceded** the eastern territories — broadly Gandhara, the Paropamisadae (the Kabul region), Arachosia (Kandahar) and Gedrosia (Balochistan). The Mauryan frontier was fixed at the **Hindu Kush**.
- Chandragupta gave Seleucus **500 war elephants**.
- Some form of marriage alliance was agreed.
- Seleucus sent an ambassador, **Megasthenes**, to the Mauryan court at Pataliputra. His account, the *Indika*, survives only in fragments quoted by later writers, but it is our best outside description of Mauryan India.

Consider what that treaty means. Alexander's own successor came back with a professional Macedonian army to retake Punjab, and went home having given away Afghanistan.

THE ELEPHANTS THAT CHANGED EUROPE

Those 500 elephants did not sit in a stable. Seleucus took them west and used them at the **Battle of Ipsus** in 301 BCE in Anatolia, where they played a decisive role in destroying his rival Antigonos. The balance of power in the Mediterranean world was altered by animals handed over in a treaty on India's north-west frontier. It is one of the great forgotten connections in world history.

Chanakya's Arthashastra

The *Arthashastra* — roughly, "the science of material gain" — is a manual on how to run a state. It covers taxation, law, agriculture, mining, currency, famine relief, diplomacy, war and, extensively, espionage.

It is startlingly unsentimental. It discusses when to break a treaty, how to run a spy network using disguised monks and courtesans, when assassination is the cheaper option, and how to manage a king's own household as a security risk. It is often compared to Machiavelli's *The Prince* — written about eighteen hundred years later, and considerably less thorough.

Scholars debate how much of the surviving text is by one hand and how much accumulated later; the text as we have it was probably compiled over centuries. But the tradition connecting it to Chanakya and to the north-western intellectual world of Taxila is old and strong.

Ashoka and the north-west

Chandragupta's grandson **Ashoka** (reigned roughly 268–232 BCE) is the emperor everyone knows — the one who, after the bloodbath at Kalinga, turned to Buddhism and inscribed his moral policy on rocks and pillars across the empire.

What is less known is how much of that programme is written in the north-west, and in what languages:

- The rock edicts at **Shahbazgarhi** and **Mansehra**, in Gandhara, are written in the **Kharosthi** script — the Aramaic-descended script that Persian rule had introduced. Everywhere else in India, Ashoka's edicts are in Brahmi. The north-west had its own writing system and the emperor used it.
- At **Kandahar**, Ashoka issued edicts in **Greek and Aramaic** — for the Greek-speaking population living in his empire.
- The **Dharmarajika Stupa** at Taxila is traditionally attributed to Ashoka, built over relics of the Buddha.

An Indian emperor publishing his laws in Greek, in Aramaic, and in a right-to-left script derived from Persian administration, is a good picture of what the north-west actually was: not a border, but a junction.

SOMETHING WORTH NOTICING

Two of the four or five most consequential figures in ancient Indian history — Panini and Chanakya — came out of the same small region in the north-west, within roughly a century of each other. Chandragupta, who built the empire, was reportedly educated there. Whatever was happening around Taxila in the 4th century BCE, it was not a backwater.

CHAPTER FIVE

Four hundred strange years

Between roughly 200 BCE and 300 CE, Punjab and Gandhara were ruled by Greeks, then Scythians, then Parthians, then Central Asians — and in that chaos produced the most influential art in Asian history.

The Indo-Greeks: a Greek king who became a Buddhist saint

The Mauryan Empire collapsed around 185 BCE. The north-west fragmented, and Greek kingdoms from Bactria (northern Afghanistan) came down through the passes.

The greatest of these Indo-Greek rulers was **Menander I** — known in Indian sources as **Milinda** — who reigned roughly 165 to 145 BCE. His capital was **Sagala**, which is modern **Sialkot**, in Pakistani Punjab.

Menander was a successful conqueror. But that is not why he is remembered.

There survives a Buddhist text called the ***Milinda Panha*** — "The Questions of King Milinda." It records a long philosophical dialogue between Menander and a Buddhist monk named **Nagasena**. The king asks hard questions: if there is no permanent self, who is reborn? What is the self, if you take away the body and the mind? Nagasena answers with the famous chariot argument — take a chariot apart and point to the chariot; you cannot, and yet the chariot is real.

It is a genuine classic of philosophy, and it is still read across the Buddhist world. According to the text, Menander became a Buddhist, and it says he attained *arhatship* — liberation — and was cremated and buried in a stupa, in the manner reserved for a holy man.

PUT SIMPLY

A Greek king, ruling from Sialkot in Punjab, argued philosophy with an Indian monk — and the record of that argument became a sacred text that Buddhists in Sri Lanka, Thailand and Japan still study today. That is what Punjab was in 150 BCE.

Then: Scythians, Parthians, Kushans

The Indo-Greeks were pushed out by waves from Central Asia.

- **Indo-Scythians (Sakas)**, from around the 1st century BCE. Rulers like Maues and Azes.
- **Indo-Parthians**, notably **Gondophares**, in the 1st century CE.
- **Kushans**, from the 1st to 3rd centuries CE — the big one. At its height under **Kanishka**, the Kushan Empire ran from Central Asia through Afghanistan and Punjab into the Ganga plain, with capitals at Purushapura (Peshawar) and Mathura. Sirsukh, the third city of Taxila, is theirs.

The Kushans sat astride the Silk Road at exactly the point where the routes from China, Persia, India and the Roman world met. They grew immensely rich on it. Roman gold coins have been found in quantity in their territory.

Gandhara: where the Buddha got a face

Now the thing that matters most in this chapter.

For the first several centuries of Buddhism, **the Buddha was never shown as a person**. Early Buddhist art represents him only by symbols: an empty throne, a pair of footprints, a wheel, a parasol, a tree. To make an image of him was thought inappropriate.

In Gandhara — in the workshops of Taxila, Peshawar, Swat and the surrounding country, under Indo-Greek and then Kushan patronage — that changed. Artists working in a Hellenistic sculptural tradition, carving for Buddhist patrons, began producing the Buddha as a human figure.

And they carved him the way Greek sculptors carved gods: a calm idealised face, wavy hair, and above all those heavy, deeply cut folds of drapery that look exactly like a Greek *himation* because that is precisely what the sculptors knew how to carve.

That image travelled. Along the Silk Road into Central Asia, into China, into Korea, into Japan; and southward through the Indian tradition into Sri Lanka and South-East Asia. Every Buddha statue on earth is a descendant, at some remove, of what was worked out in the north-west of the subcontinent in the first few centuries CE.

The face of the Buddha — the single most widely reproduced religious image in Asia — was designed in the north-west, by sculptors who had learnt their craft from Greeks.

A note of precision: art historians argue about whether Gandhara or Mathura produced the very first human Buddha image, and the two traditions probably developed close together and influenced each other. Gandhara's claim is strong and its influence on the eastward spread is not in doubt.

The blender

Here is what these four centuries actually show.

Persians, Greeks, Scythians, Parthians and Kushans all came into Punjab and Gandhara as conquerors. And within a few generations, most of them were sponsoring Buddhist monasteries, minting coins with Indian deities alongside Greek ones, taking Indian names and titles, and being written into Indian texts.

Menander the Greek becomes a Buddhist saint. Kanishka the Central Asian convenes a Buddhist council. The Sakas produce Indian-style inscriptions. The invaders were absorbed.

DON'T ROMANTICISE THIS

The "India absorbs all invaders" story is popular and it is partly true. But it is often told as though absorption were gentle. It was not. Each of these waves arrived by force, killed people, destroyed towns and displaced rulers. Absorption happened over generations, *after* the killing, and it happened because the conquerors were vastly outnumbered by the people they ruled. Both halves belong in the story: the violence and the eventual synthesis.

CHAPTER SIX

The Hunas: the hinge

In the fifth and sixth centuries CE, something came through the passes that Punjab could not absorb. What happened next changed the direction of Indian history, and it is the reason you were never taught Chapter 2.

Who they were

Indian sources call them the **Hunas**. Modern scholarship generally identifies the group that mattered most for India as the **Alchon Huns** — a Central Asian people, connected to the broader Hunnic movements that were simultaneously wrecking the Roman world at the other end of Eurasia.

They began pressing on the north-west from the mid-5th century CE. The Gupta emperor **Skandagupta** fought them off around 455–460 CE and boasted about it in an inscription, but the effort drained the treasury and the army.

Toramana and Mihirakula

By around 500 CE the Hunas were not raiding. They were ruling.

Toramana (reigned roughly 500–520 CE) established a genuine kingdom, and — this is the detail that matters for us — **its base was the Punjab region**. His inscriptions show him using the titles and administrative style of an Indian monarch. Central Asian nomads had become a settled Indian dynasty ruling from the five-river plain.

His son **Mihirakula** (reigned roughly 520–550 CE) is remembered very differently.

The Chinese Buddhist pilgrim **Xuanzang**, travelling through India in the 7th century, recorded a tradition that Mihirakula was initially interested in Buddhism, felt slighted by the monasteries, and turned on them — destroying monastic establishments across his territory. Other sources, including the Kashmiri chronicle *Rajatarangini*, describe him as exceptionally cruel.

HOW MUCH OF THIS IS TRUE?

Be careful. Xuanzang was writing roughly a century after the events, from Buddhist informants, about a man Buddhists regarded as a persecutor. Hostile traditions exaggerate. Some modern historians think Mihirakula's reputation has been blackened beyond the facts, and note that he issued coins with Hindu imagery and may simply have been a Shaivite ruler who withdrew patronage rather than a systematic destroyer.

But — and this is why the tradition cannot be dismissed — the archaeology of Gandhara does show large-scale destruction and abandonment of Buddhist monastic sites in roughly this period, followed by no recovery. Something happened. The scale of the disaster is not in doubt even if the villain's exact role is.

The end of the Hunas — and the price

Around 528 CE, at the **Battle of Sondani** in central India, a coalition led by **Yashodharman** of Malwa, alongside the Gupta ruler Narasimhagupta, defeated Mihirakula decisively. Yashodharman erected victory pillars that survive and boast of humbling a king whose head had bowed to no one else.

The Alchon remnants were pushed back and confined to Kashmir and Gandhara, and faded out over the following century.

India won. But look at what the war cost.

Four consequences, and they are enormous

1. The Gupta Empire died. Already weakened by the earlier Huna wars, the Gupta state fragmented and was effectively finished by around 550 CE. North India then broke into competing regional kingdoms and stayed broken, with one brief exception, for the next six hundred years. When Mahmud of Ghazni arrives in Part 3, there is no north Indian empire to meet him — and this is why.

2. Gandhara's civilisation was destroyed. The monasteries of Taxila, the workshops, the libraries, the whole Greco-Buddhist world described in Chapters 2 and 5 — it ended here. Taxila had survived Persians, Greeks, Scythians, Parthians and Kushans. It did not survive this. When Xuanzang passed through in the 630s CE, he described a region of ruined and deserted monasteries.

3. The north-west stopped being India's intellectual capital, permanently. The centre of learning moved east — to Nalanda in Bihar, to Vikramashila, to Valabhi in Gujarat. Punjab, which had produced Panini and hosted Chanakya, would not be a centre of scholarship again on anything like that scale. What it would be instead is a frontier.

4. Buddhism in the north-west was broken. The region that had given the Buddha his face largely ceased to be Buddhist. Over the following centuries the north-west's religious

landscape reformed around Hindu Shaiva traditions and, later, Islam.

Before the Hunas, Punjab was a place where people wrote books. After the Hunas, Punjab was a place where people held a line. That switch is the most important thing that ever happened to this region, and almost nobody knows it happened.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR THE WHOLE BOOK

People argue endlessly about whether Punjab's warrior culture is a glory or a curse. Both sides usually treat it as something eternal and given. It is not. Chapter 6 is where you can watch it being installed. A cosmopolitan, literate, mercantile, monastic region gets hit hard enough, often enough, that the parts of it which could not fight stopped existing. What survived was the part that could.

That is not romantic and it is not shameful. It is what happens to any society placed where this one is placed.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The long decline, and the last shield

Between 600 and 1000 CE, Punjab is quiet in the history books. It is the quiet of a region that has been hollowed out and is now, without much help, holding a door shut.

Harsha: the last flicker

Harshavardhana (reigned 606–647 CE) briefly reassembled much of north India. His capital was at **Thanesar** — Kurukshetra, in today's Haryana, which is to say inside historical Punjab — before he moved to Kannauj.

Harsha was a genuine ruler of the old style: a patron of scholars, host to Xuanzang, subject of a biography by the writer Bana. But he was checked in the south by the Chalukyas, and when he died without an heir in 647 CE his empire dissolved immediately.

After Harsha, no one rules north India as a single unit until the Delhi Sultanate, more than five hundred years later.

Xuanzang's Punjab

Xuanzang, the Chinese monk, travelled through the region in the 630s CE. His account is one of the best snapshots we have, and it is melancholy. He describes Taxila as subject to Kashmir and much diminished; he describes monastery after monastery in the north-west as ruined, deserted, or occupied by a handful of monks where hundreds had lived.

He was walking through the wreckage of Chapter 2 and did not know it.

The Hindu Shahis: three hundred years of holding the door

From around 850 CE, a dynasty known as the **Hindu Shahis** (or Kabul Shahis) ruled a kingdom covering eastern Afghanistan, Gandhara and western Punjab, from capitals at **Udabhandapura** (Hund, on the Indus) and later **Nandana** in the Salt Range.

Their significance is simple and heroic and almost entirely forgotten: **for about 170 years they were the only organised force standing between the Central Asian powers and the north Indian plain.** And they did it alone. The kingdoms of the Ganga valley — rich, populous, endlessly quarrelling with each other — sent them essentially nothing.

The end came in stages:

THE FALL OF THE SHAHIS

Date	Event
986–988 CE	Jayapala attacks Ghazni pre-emptively — he could see what was coming — and is defeated by Sabuktigin. Forced to pay a heavy indemnity.
1001 CE	Jayapala is defeated again, this time by Sabuktigin's son Mahmud of Ghazni , near Peshawar, and captured. Released and publicly humiliated, he abdicates and, according to the sources, ends his own life on a funeral pyre.
1008–09 CE	His son Anandapala assembles a confederacy of north Indian rulers and meets Mahmud at Chach, near Waihind. The Shahi army comes close to winning; then Anandapala's elephant panics, the line collapses, and the battle is lost.
c. 1013–1026 CE	Trilochanapala and his son fight on from Nandana and the Kashmir hills. By around 1026 the dynasty is extinguished.

The Muslim scholar **Al-Biruni**, who came to India with Mahmud's court and had no reason to flatter them, wrote about the Shahis with real respect — praising their nobility and lamenting their fall. When an enemy's own chronicler writes your obituary kindly, you did something right.

THE STRUCTURAL POINT, AND IT IS A BITTER ONE

For nearly two centuries, a frontier kingdom in Punjab and Gandhara absorbed every attack from the north-west while the wealthy heartland kingdoms of north India — Pratiharas, Palas, Rashtrakutas, and their successors — spent their strength fighting each other over Kannauj. When the frontier finally broke, there was nothing behind it.

That is the shape of the next thousand years, and Part 3 is about what came through the broken door.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Scorecard: what Part 2 proves

"Alexander the Great conquered India."

FALSE

He entered the north-west and Punjab in 326 BCE, won his battles there, and never crossed the Beas. He saw perhaps five per cent of the subcontinent. His army mutinied rather than go further. His hold on what he did take lasted about twenty years, and Seleucus formally surrendered it by treaty around 303 BCE in exchange for elephants. He also took the worst wound of his life at Multan, from which he arguably never recovered.

"Porus defeated Alexander at the Jhelum."

NOT SUPPORTED

This is popular online and it is not what any surviving source says. Porus lost. His army was destroyed and two of his sons were killed.

What *is* defensible, and worth saying: every source we have is Greek or Roman, written 300 to 500 years later, ultimately drawing on accounts by Alexander's own officers. The reported Macedonian casualties exceed those at Gaugamela. And Alexander's response — restoring his defeated enemy to the throne and enlarging his kingdom — is unique in his career and suggests a fight far harder than a clean victory. The honest position is: Porus lost the battle, and the Greek account of how comfortably he lost it should be read with scepticism. Inventing a victory is not necessary; the truth is impressive enough.

"Punjab is a land of soldiers and farmers with no intellectual tradition."

FALSE, AND BADLY SO

Panini, from a village near Taxila, wrote the most sophisticated grammar produced anywhere in the world before the twentieth century, and it is still the standard reference for Sanskrit. Chanakya, associated with Taxila, wrote the *Arthashastra*. The *Milinda Panha*, a philosophical classic still read across Buddhist Asia, records a debate held in Sialkot. And the first human images of the Buddha — the template for every Buddha statue from Kabul to Kyoto — were developed in Gandhara.

For roughly a thousand years, this region was one of the most intellectually productive places on earth. The reason nobody knows this is Chapter 6.

"Punjab always stood united against invaders."**FALSE — AND THIS IS THE IMPORTANT ONE**

In 326 BCE, Ambhi of Taxila allied with Alexander and marched against Porus. Porus fought. The Cathaeans of Sangala fought to annihilation. The Malli fought so hard they nearly killed Alexander. Four Punjabi responses to one crisis, all at the same time.

Punjab has never faced anything as a single body. Not Alexander, not the Mughals, not the British, not 1947, and not 1984. Anyone selling you a story in which "Punjab" or "the Sikhs" or "the Hindus" acted as one is selling you a story.

"Punjab's warrior culture is ancient and deep."**TRUE BY 1000 CE — BUT IT WAS BUILT, NOT INHERITED**

Part 1 showed that the region's oldest civilisation was strikingly unmilitary. Part 2 shows the machinery that changed that: Persians, Greeks, Scythians, Parthians, Kushans, Hunas, and finally the Ghaznavids — six or seven waves in fifteen centuries, every one of them arriving through the same corridor. By the time the Hindu Shahis are holding the line alone around 1000 CE, the warrior society exists and is doing the job.

Keep hold of the distinction. A culture that was *made* by circumstances belongs to the people who carry it, and they are answerable for what they do with it. A culture that is simply "in the blood" belongs to nobody and excuses everything. I will need this in Part 9.

"India absorbed all its invaders peacefully."**HALF TRUE**

Absorption genuinely happened — a Greek king of Sialkot became a Buddhist saint, Central Asian dynasties took Indian titles and funded Indian temples. But it happened *after* conquest, over generations, and it happened partly because small conquering elites were outnumbered. It also failed at least once, catastrophically: the Hunas were not absorbed. They were fought off, and the region they had ruled never recovered. The pleasant version of this story leaves out the corpses and the ruins.

Timeline of Part 2

c.	518	BCE	Darius I annexes the Indus region. Gandhara and Hindush become Persian satrapies. Kharosthi script and coinage arrive.								
c.	500–400	BCE	Panini,	of	Salatura	near	Taxila,	composes	the	<i>Ashtadhyayi</i> .	
480–479		BCE	Indian	contingents		serve	in	Xerxes'	army	in	Greece.
327–326		BCE	Alexander	enters	the north-west.		Ambhi	of	Taxila	submits	and allies with him.
May	326	BCE	Battle of the Hydaspes (Jhelum). Porus defeated, then restored and given more territory.								
Summer	326	BCE	Siege of Sangala. Then the mutiny on the Hyphasis (Beas). Alexander turns back and builds twelve altars.								

326–325 BCE	The Malli campaign. Alexander is shot through the lung at Multan; his army massacres the town.
323 BCE	Alexander dies in Babylon, aged 32.
c. 322–321 BCE	Chandragupta Maurya, advised by Chanakya, clears the north-west and destroys the Nanda dynasty.
305–303 BCE	Seleucid–Mauryan war. Seleucus cedes Gandhara, Kabul, Kandahar and Balochistan for 500 war elephants. Megasthenes sent as ambassador.
301 BCE	Those elephants help decide the Battle of Ipsus in Anatolia.
c. 268–232 BCE	Ashoka. Edicts at Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra in Kharosthi; at Kandahar in Greek and Aramaic. Dharmarajika Stupa at Taxila.
c. 185 BCE	Mauryan collapse. The north-west fragments.
c. 165–145 BCE	Menander I (Milinda) rules from Sagala (Sialkot). The <i>Milinda Panha</i> .
c. 100 BCE – 50 CE	Indo-Scythians and Indo-Parthians rule the north-west.
c. 50–250 CE	Kushan Empire. Kanishka. Sirsukh built at Taxila. Gandhara art flowers; the first human images of the Buddha.
c. 320–550 CE	Gupta Empire in the east. Punjab is a frontier province.
c. 455–460 CE	Skandagupta repels the first Huna attacks, at heavy cost.
c. 500–520 CE	Toramana establishes a Huna kingdom based in the Punjab region.
c. 520–550 CE	Mihirakula. Widespread destruction of Buddhist monasteries in the north-west.
528 CE	Battle of Sondani. Yashodharman and Narasimhagupta defeat Mihirakula.
c. 550 CE	The Gupta Empire ends. North India fragments for six centuries.
606–647 CE	Harsha rules north India from Thanesar, then Kannauj. Dies heirless; empire dissolves.
630s CE	Xuanzang travels through a north-west of ruined monasteries.
c. 850–1026 CE	The Hindu Shahis hold the north-western frontier alone.
986–1026 CE	Jayapala, Anandapala and Trilochanapala are defeated in turn by Ghazni. The door opens — and Part 3 begins.

What happens in Part 3

Part 3, *The Invasion Highway*, covers roughly 1000 to 1500 CE — the five hundred years in which Punjab is hit harder and more often than any comparable region on earth.

Mahmud of Ghazni raids India seventeen times, every single time through Punjab, and makes Lahore a provincial capital of an Afghan empire. Muhammad of Ghor defeats Prithviraj Chauhan at Tarain in 1192 and the Delhi Sultanate begins. The Mongols arrive at the Indus and Punjab becomes a permanent war zone for a century. Timur sacks Delhi in 1398,

marching in and out through Punjab and leaving, by his own chronicler's account, pyramids of skulls.

Part 3 also covers what Punjab built while all this was happening: the Sufi tradition of Baba Farid and the beginnings of Punjabi as a literary language; the Bhakti movement; and the social conditions — caste rigidity, forced conversion, and an exhausted, plundered peasantry — that made the Punjab of 1469 the exact place where a man named Nanak would say something new.

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- Upinder Singh, *A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India* — thorough, well illustrated, good on archaeology.
- A. K. Narain, *The Indo-Greeks* — still the key work on Menander and his successors.
- Peter Green, *Alexander of Macedon* — a hostile and very useful biography that takes the Indian campaign's difficulties seriously.
- Frank Lee Holt, *Into the Land of Bones: Alexander the Great in Afghanistan* — on how badly the eastern campaign actually went.
- Michel Danino and others on Indian responses to the Alexander sources — for the case that the Greek accounts are systematically self-serving.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 2 —

Part 3: *The Invasion Highway*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART THREE OF THIRTEEN

The Invasion Highway

c. 1000 to 1500 CE — five centuries of being walked over, and what grew anyway

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 3

This is the part where I had to be most careful with myself.

Part 3 covers temple destruction, forced conversion, mass killing, and how Punjab became Muslim-majority — which is to say it covers the four subjects most actively weaponised in Indian public argument right now. Both of the popular positions on them contain real facts and real distortions, and both have organised constituencies that will tell you the other side is lying about everything.

My rule here was simple and I applied it in both directions. Where an atrocity is recorded by the perpetrator's own chronicler — as Somnath is, as Timur's order at Loni is — I state it plainly and I do not soften it. Where a popular explanation does not survive contact with the evidence — as "converted entirely by the sword" does not, because Uttar Pradesh was ruled longer and did not convert — I say so, and I show the working.

Neither of those moves will satisfy someone who arrived with a conclusion. That is not a flaw in the method. It is the method.

One finding in this part genuinely surprised me, and it is in Chapter 6. I knew Baba Farid's verses were in the Guru Granth Sahib. I had not stopped to think about what that means: the founding scripture of Sikhism contains the poetry of a Muslim Sufi, a Hindu weaver and a Dalit leather-worker, deliberately gathered by the fifth Guru and placed beside his own father's compositions. Whatever anyone tells you about eternal enmity in Punjab, it has to get past that book, and it cannot.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

The five hundred worst years

Part 2 ended with the Hindu Shahis destroyed and the north-western door standing open. Part 3 is about what came through it, and about the fact that Punjab built something remarkable anyway.

Between roughly 1000 and 1500 CE, Punjab was invaded, occupied, sacked, garrisoned and fought over more consistently than almost any comparable region on earth. Not once. Not in a bad century. For five hundred years, more or less without a break.

Here is the roll-call, and it is worth reading slowly:

- **Mahmud of Ghazni** raids India roughly seventeen times between 1000 and 1027 CE. Every single raid comes through Punjab.
- **Muhammad of Ghor** takes Lahore in 1186 and wins at Tarain in 1192, founding six centuries of Delhi-based Muslim rule.
- **The Mongols** arrive at the Indus in 1221 and then raid Punjab repeatedly for the next eighty-odd years. Lahore is sacked in 1241.
- **Timur** crosses the Indus in 1398 with something like 92,000 cavalry, kills roughly 100,000 prisoners in a single order, and leaves Delhi a ruin.
- And in 1526, just outside our window, **Babur** comes through the same passes and founds the Mughal Empire.

Every one of these entered India through Punjab. Not one of them landed on a coast, or came through Bengal, or crossed the Himalaya. Punjab was the road, and everyone used it.

For five hundred years, Punjab was not a place people lived in so much as a place armies walked through. And people lived there anyway.

But that is only half of Part 3

If this part were only a list of massacres it would be depressing and not very useful. The more interesting question is the one nobody asks:

What did Punjab build while all this was happening?

The answer turns out to be substantial, and it is the direct setup for Part 4. During these same five centuries:

- Punjabi became a written literary language, for the first time, in the poetry of a Muslim Sufi saint.
- A shared shrine culture developed in which Hindus and Muslims visited the same holy places and revered the same saints.
- A tradition of religious protest grew up — in the local language, addressed to ordinary people — arguing that God does not care about your caste, your rituals, or which book you carry.
- And a society formed with a permanent habit of not relying on the state for protection, because the state had never once protected it.

Put those four things together and you have described, almost exactly, the conditions that produced Guru Nanak in 1469 and the Khalsa in 1699.

A note on how this part is written

Chapter 5 and Chapter 8 deal with religion, conversion and temple destruction. These are live political subjects in India today, and both major positions on them contain real facts and real distortions.

My approach, following Rule 3, is to give each position its strongest form. Temple destruction happened, it was recorded and boasted about by the perpetrators' own chroniclers, and pretending otherwise is dishonest. It is also true that the same rulers sacked Muslim cities, that Timur attacked a Muslim state, and that religion functioned largely as justification for what was fundamentally a business in loot and power. Both of those are true at once. Anybody who needs you to believe only one of them is selling something.

CHAPTER 1 Mahmud of Ghazni: seventeen times through the same door.

CHAPTER 2 Ghor and Tarain: the battle that decided six hundred years.

CHAPTER 3 The Mongols: eighty years of living in a war zone.

CHAPTER 4 Timur, 1398: the worst single thing that happened.

CHAPTER 5 How Punjab became Muslim — and why that decided 1947.

CHAPTER 6 What Punjab built: Baba Farid and the invention of Punjabi literature.

CHAPTER 7 The soil in which Nanak grew.

CHAPTER 8 Scorecard: what Part 3 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

Mahmud of Ghazni

Seventeen invasions in twenty-seven years. Not one of them was an attempt to rule India. All of them were a business — and Punjab was the one thing he decided to keep.

The business model

Mahmud ruled from Ghazni, in what is now eastern Afghanistan. Between roughly 1000 and 1027 CE he raided India about seventeen times.

Understand what these raids were. They were not conquests. Mahmud almost never tried to hold Indian territory east of Punjab. The pattern was:

1. Assemble an army after the harvest, when there is fodder and the rivers are low.
2. Come down through the passes into Punjab.
3. Strike fast at a wealthy target — a rich city, a great temple with a treasury.
4. Take gold, jewels, and thousands of captives to be sold as slaves.
5. Be back in Ghazni before the monsoon makes the rivers impassable.

Mahmud used this money to build Ghazni into a magnificent capital, to pay a large standing army, and to fund a court that included the scholar **Al-Biruni** and the poet **Firdausi**. India paid for the Afghan golden age.

The targets

SOME OF MAHMUD'S PRINCIPAL INDIAN CAMPAIGNS

Date	Target	Note
1001	Peshawar / Jayapala	Defeats the Hindu Shahi king, who later kills himself.
1008–09	Anandapala's confederacy at Chach	The last organised north Indian resistance in the north-west is broken.
1010	Multan	A Muslim city, ruled by Ismaili Shias, whom Mahmud regarded as heretics. Sacked.
1014	Thanesar	Temple town in today's Haryana.
1018	Mathura and Kannauj	Mathura's temples plundered; Kannauj, the great imperial city of north India, taken.
1025	Somnath , Gujarat	His most famous raid. Reported plunder of around two million dinars. The temple's <i>jyotirlinga</i> broken.
1027	Battle of the Indus	Against the Jats of the Indus valley. His last Indian campaign.

Somnath, and how to think about it

The 1025 raid on Somnath is the single most politically charged event in this chapter, so let us handle it carefully.

What is not in dispute: Mahmud attacked the temple at Somnath, killed a great many defenders, looted an enormous treasure, and destroyed the idol. His own court chroniclers describe it, and they describe it as a boast. They were proud of it. There is no serious case for denying that it happened.

What is disputed: what it meant, and how it was remembered. The historian Romila Thapar's study *Somanatha: The Many Voices of a History* shows something that surprises most readers: the raid does not loom large in most contemporary Indian sources. Jain and Sanskrit records from Gujarat carry on discussing trade and temple endowments; some record the temple being rebuilt and functioning again. The idea of Somnath as *the* defining wound of Hindu India took its modern shape much later — substantially in the nineteenth century, in British parliamentary debate and colonial historiography, and then in twentieth-century Indian politics.

Both of these are true. A terrible thing happened, and the way it is remembered today was shaped by people with much later purposes.

WAS MAHMUD A RELIGIOUS FANATIC OR A ROBBER?

The case for religious motive: he took the title of an idol-breaker, his chroniclers framed the raids as holy war, he obtained formal recognition from the Caliph, and he specifically targeted major temples rather than only treasuries.

The case for the loot motive: he sacked Muslim Multan and massacred Ismaili Muslims he considered heretics; he employed Hindu troops and Hindu commanders in his own army, some in senior positions; he minted coins at Lahore with Sanskrit inscriptions; and he spent the rest of his career fighting Muslim rivals in Persia and Central Asia. Temples were targets partly because temples were where the gold was.

The honest answer: both, inseparably. He was a Muslim ruler in an age when plunder needed religious legitimization, and religious legitimization was most profitable when aimed at rich temples. Trying to separate the greed from the ideology is a modern instinct that does not fit an eleventh-century warlord.

The part that actually matters for this book

Forget Somnath for a moment. The most consequential thing Mahmud did was much quieter.

He did not keep Kannauj. He did not keep Mathura. He did not keep Gujarat. He kept Punjab.

Lahore was annexed and made a Ghaznavid provincial capital. And when the Ghaznavids later lost their western territories to the Seljuk Turks, Lahore became the effective capital of what was left of their empire.

Which produces this fact, and it is one of the most important facts in the entire book:

Punjab came under permanent Muslim rule around 1030 CE. Delhi did not until 1192. Punjab was governed by Muslim states for roughly 160 years longer than the rest of north India — and in the end, for over 900 years continuously.

Sit with that number. From about 1030 until the rise of the Sikh misls in the mid-1700s — **seven hundred years** — Punjab was ruled by Muslim states almost without interruption. Under the British it was ruled by Christians. A Punjabi in 1700 would have to go back twenty-five generations to find an ancestor who lived under a ruler of the local religion.

This single fact explains an extraordinary amount of what follows:

- Why Punjab's Muslim population became so large, especially in the west.
- Why Punjabi absorbed so much Persian vocabulary that a Punjabi speaker today uses Persian words constantly without noticing.
- Why Punjabi culture is so thoroughly blended.
- Why undivided Punjab was Muslim-majority in 1941 — and therefore why it had to be partitioned in 1947.
- And why, when a Punjabi religious movement finally did take political power in 1799, it felt to its participants like something that had not happened in seven centuries. Because it had not.

CHAPTER TWO

Ghor and Tarain

In 1192, on a plain in what is now Haryana, a battle was fought that set the political shape of north India for the next six hundred years. It was fought in historical Punjab.

The Ghurids replace the Ghaznavids

By the later 1100s the Ghaznavids were finished as a great power, clinging to Lahore. A rival Afghan dynasty, the **Ghurids** — from Ghor, in central Afghanistan — pushed them out. **Muhammad of Ghor** (Muizz-ud-din Muhammad) took Lahore in 1186.

Unlike Mahmud, Ghori wanted territory, not just loot. And beyond Punjab lay the Chauhan kingdom of Ajmer and Delhi, ruled by **Prithviraj Chauhan**.

The two battles of Tarain

They met at Tarain — modern Taraori, near Karnal — on the flat country between the Sutlej and the Yamuna. In our terms: the eastern edge of historical Punjab.

First Battle of Tarain, 1191. Prithviraj won.

This is worth stating plainly because it is often skipped. The Indian side won. Ghori's centre was broken by a massed Rajput charge, Ghori himself was wounded and had to be carried from the field, and his army fled.

Prithviraj then did not pursue him back to Afghanistan.

Second Battle of Tarain, 1192. Ghori won, decisively.

He came back the following year with a reorganised army, and he had thought hard about the first defeat. The Ghurid force relied on large numbers of **mounted archers** — light cavalry who could shoot from horseback, harass, retreat, and never close with the enemy. Against them, the Rajput system of heavy cavalry and elephants charging in a mass was close to useless. You cannot charge something that will not stand still.

The standard account has Ghori using feigned retreats to draw out and exhaust the Rajput cavalry through the day, then committing a fresh reserve of heavy cavalry at the decisive moment. The Chauhan army broke. Prithviraj was captured and killed.

A WORD ABOUT THE PRITHVIRAJ LEGENDS

You may have heard the story in which Prithviraj, blinded and held captive in Ghazni, kills Ghor with an arrow shot guided by sound. It is a wonderful story. It comes from the *Prithviraj Raso*, a poem composed in something close to its surviving form **centuries** after the events, and historians do not treat it as a reliable record. Muhammad of Ghor was in fact assassinated in 1206, in Punjab, near the Jhelum — most probably by Ismaili or Khokhar assailants.

I flag legends like this not to spoil them but because the same habit — a satisfying story replacing an inconvenient record — is exactly what I will have to fight my way through in Part 9.

What followed

Ghor returned to Afghanistan and left his slave-general **Qutb-ud-din Aibak** in charge of the Indian territories. When Ghor was assassinated in 1206, Aibak declared himself sultan at Lahore, and the **Delhi Sultanate** began.

Five dynasties would follow over the next three centuries — Mamluk (Slave), Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi — until Babur ended the last of them at Panipat in 1526.

Punjab's new job description

Under the Sultanate, Punjab's role became fixed, and it is a role Punjab has occupied ever since in one form or another.

Punjab was a **province**. It was governed from Delhi. It paid revenue to Delhi. And its function was to be the **shield** — to absorb whatever came through the passes, so that Delhi did not have to.

This is the arrangement that Chapter 3 shows in its most brutal form.

REMEMBER THIS FOR PARTS 8 AND 12

Punjab as the province that pays for the centre and takes the hits for the centre is not a 1966 invention or a Congress-era grievance. It is a job description that begins in 1192 and has been renewed, with different capitals and different flags, ever since. Whether that is exploitation or simply geography is one of the real arguments in this book — and it has two serious sides.

CHAPTER THREE

The Mongols

For roughly eighty years, large parts of Punjab were not really governed by anybody. They were a raiding ground. This is where Punjab learns the habit of arming itself.

Genghis Khan looks at India and turns around

In 1221, **Genghis Khan** reached the Indus, chasing the last prince of the Khwarezmian empire, Jalal ad-Din Mingburnu, whom he had already destroyed. Jalal ad-Din swam his horse across the Indus and escaped into Punjab.

Genghis stood on the bank, considered marching through India, and decided against it — the heat, the disease, the distance, and reports of what lay ahead. He went back west.

India got lucky. It would not stay lucky.

Eighty years of raiding

From the 1240s, the Mongols of the **Chagatai Khanate** — based in Central Asia — turned Punjab into a regular target. Major incursions came in **1241, 1245, 1257 and 1285**, and then, under Alauddin Khalji, in a much heavier series through the 1290s and 1300s.

In 1241 they sacked Lahore. The city that had been an imperial capital for two centuries was taken and devastated.

For long stretches, the Delhi Sultanate's real frontier was not the Indus at all. It was the Beas or the Sutlej. Everything west of that — much of central and western Punjab — was a contested zone where Delhi's writ was thin and Mongol raiding parties came and went.

How Delhi responded

Balban (reigned 1266–1287) understood the problem and built for it. He established a chain of forts between Multan and Lahore and along the line of the Beas, garrisoned them, and pursued a forward-defensive policy rather than pulling back to Delhi. He also devastated some frontier areas deliberately, to deny raiders supplies.

Alauddin Khalji (reigned 1296–1316) faced the worst of it. In 1303 a Mongol force under Taraghai besieged Delhi itself for more than two months and looted its suburbs while Alauddin sat inside his own capital, unable to fight them off.

He responded by rebuilding the entire frontier system: repairing and building forts, stockpiling weapons and supplies in them, and posting his best generals to the Punjab frontier commands at **Dipalpur** and **Samana**. His famous economic measures — price controls, market regulation — were largely designed to let him maintain an enormous standing army cheaply, precisely because of this threat.

It worked. At the **Battle of Amroha in 1305**, Delhi's forces destroyed a major Mongol army, and Alauddin had thousands of Mongol prisoners trampled to death by elephants outside Delhi as a public demonstration. The raids tapered off through the 1300s.

What eighty years of that does to a society

This is the analytical point of the chapter, and it matters enormously for Part 5.

If you live in a place where:

- a raiding army may arrive in any given year,
- the government's army is stationed 400 km away and exists to protect the capital, not you,
- the nearest fort is a garrison for the state's troops, not a refuge for your village, and
- anyone who is captured is sold as a slave —

then you do one of three things. You leave. You die. Or you arm yourself and organise your own defence around the people you actually trust: your extended family, your clan, your village.

That third option is what happened, over and over, and it produced a specific kind of society:

THE FRONTIER SOCIETY PUNJAB BECAME

Feature	Consequence
Armed villages	Weapons in ordinary homes were normal, not exceptional. Villages had walls and watchmen.
Clan-based organisation	The unit that mattered was the <i>biradari</i> — the kin group — because it was the unit that would actually turn out to fight for you. Punjab's clan and caste politics today still runs on this.
Local strongmen	Whoever could protect a stretch of country effectively became its real ruler, whatever Delhi's paperwork said.
Deep scepticism about the state	The state took your revenue and did not save you. Paying it was extortion, not citizenship.
A high tolerance for violence	Not as a moral flaw — as an adaptation. Societies where violence is common produce people who are not shocked by it.

REMEMBER THIS FOR PART 5

When the Mughal Empire collapses in the 1700s, Punjab does not descend into chaos. It reorganises almost overnight into the **misls** — twelve armed confederacies, clan-based, each holding a territory, each raising its own cavalry, cooperating loosely against outsiders and fighting each other in between.

People often describe this as a new Sikh invention. It was not. It was Punjab reverting to the survival structure it had been building since the 1240s, now with a new religion at the centre of it. The Khalsa gave the structure a soul. The structure itself was six hundred years old.

CHAPTER FOUR

Timur, 1398

Of everything in this part, this is the worst. It is also, in its details, a useful corrective to anyone who thinks these invasions were simply religion against religion.

The invasion

Timur — Tamerlane — ruled from Samarkand and had already conquered Persia, Central Asia and much of the Middle East. In August 1398 he marched on India with a force reported at around 92,000 cavalry.

On **30 September 1398** he crossed the Indus. His route ran straight through Punjab: Tulamba, which he sacked and whose inhabitants he massacred; then Multan; then east across the doabs toward Delhi, taking and destroying towns as he went.

The pretext, and why it does not survive examination

Timur's stated justification was that the Sultan of Delhi, Nasir-ud-din Mahmud Tughlaq, was being too tolerant of his Hindu subjects, and that a properly Islamic ruler was needed.

Most historians regard this as a transparent excuse, and it is worth understanding why, because it teaches you how to read this whole period.

- Delhi in 1398 was a **Muslim sultanate**. Timur was a Muslim ruler attacking a Muslim state, sacking a Muslim capital, and killing a great many Muslims in the process.
- His route through Punjab destroyed Muslim and Hindu towns without much discrimination.
- Timur had spent his career attacking Muslim powers — the Ottomans, the Mamluks of Egypt, the Golden Horde. India was not a special religious project. It was the richest available target that had just become weak.

The Tughlaq dynasty had been falling apart for a decade. Timur attacked because Delhi was rich and Delhi was weak. The religious framing was, as it usually was, the wrapper.

Loni: the order

By the time Timur's army reached the outskirts of Delhi in December 1398, it had accumulated an enormous number of captives — perhaps **100,000** people, taken across Punjab and marched along with the army to be sold as slaves.

Timur was about to fight the Sultan's army, which included war elephants. He calculated that during the battle his captives might break loose and attack his rear.

So at **Loni**, before the battle, he gave an order: kill them all. His army did.

This is recorded in Timur's own memoirs and by his court chronicler. It was not hidden or denied. It was written down as a sensible military precaution.

It is one of the largest single mass killings in premodern history, and the overwhelming majority of the victims were Punjabis who had been rounded up on the road east.

WHY I STATE IT SO BLUNTLY

Because it is documented by the perpetrator, in his own words, and because atrocity denial in either direction is one of the diseases this work exists to treat. When I reach 1984, I will state what happened to Sikhs in Delhi in November with exactly the same bluntness, and I will state what happened to Hindu bus passengers in Punjab in the years afterwards with exactly the same bluntness. The rule has to be applied consistently or it is not a rule.

Delhi

On **17 December 1398**, Timur destroyed the Tughlaq army outside Delhi. The Sultan's war elephants — armoured, with poisoned tusks — were countered by driving loaded camels at them and setting the loads alight; the elephants panicked and turned on their own lines.

Delhi was then sacked for roughly fifteen days. The killing was on a scale that contemporaries struggled to describe. Timur's chroniclers record towers built of the heads of the dead. Accounts suggest the city was so thoroughly destroyed and depopulated that it took the better part of a century to recover.

Timur left after about a fortnight, carrying loot and, notably, skilled craftsmen — masons and artisans taken back to Samarkand, where they worked on his great buildings.

The Punjab footnote that became a dynasty

On his way out, Timur appointed a local governor over **Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur**: a man named **Khizr Khan**.

The Delhi Sultanate was in ruins. Over the following years Khizr Khan built up his power base in Punjab, and in **1414** he took Delhi and founded the **Sayyid dynasty**, which ruled for about thirty-seven years.

So the dynasty that governed north India for the first half of the fifteenth century came out of Punjab — installed by a Central Asian conqueror as a provincial appointment.

PUT SIMPLY

Punjab was the road every invader used, the province that paid for Delhi, the shield that took the blows for Delhi, and occasionally — when Delhi collapsed entirely — the place the next rulers of Delhi came from. All four of those roles at once. That is what being the front door means.

CHAPTER FIVE

How Punjab became Muslim

This chapter answers a question that decided the fate of fifteen million people in 1947. It is handled here carefully, because both of the popular answers are wrong.

The fact to be explained

By the 1941 census, undivided Punjab was roughly **53% Muslim, 30% Hindu and 15% Sikh**.

That Muslim majority is why Punjab had to be partitioned in 1947 — and the geography of that majority is why the line fell where it did. So the question of how it came about is not an academic one. It is the direct cause of the largest forced migration in human history.

The two popular answers, and why both fail

Popular answer 1: "Punjab was converted by the sword." Force alone cannot explain it. If conversion were simply a function of Muslim political rule, then Uttar Pradesh — ruled from Delhi and Agra by Muslim states for just as long, sitting under the seat of imperial power — would be Muslim-majority. It is not; it was around 15% Muslim. Bihar was ruled just as long and remained overwhelmingly Hindu. Meanwhile Bengal, at the far end of the empire and the least directly governed, became Muslim-majority. Political rule and conversion do not line up.

Popular answer 2: "It was all peaceful and voluntary." Also false. Forced conversion happened. It is documented in Muslim court chronicles that boast of it, in Sikh tradition and history, and in accounts of specific campaigns. The execution of Guru Arjan in 1606 and of Guru Tegh Bahadur in 1675 — Part 4 — are not folklore; they are historical events with an identifiable political and religious context. Jizya, the tax on non-Muslims, was real, was on-and-off enforced, and was a real material pressure.

What actually happened: five mechanisms at once

WHY PEOPLE CONVERTED, IN ROUGH ORDER OF SCALE

Mechanism	How it worked
1. Sufi missionary activity	The biggest single factor in Punjab. Chishti and Suhrawardi Sufi masters settled in the countryside, spoke the local language, offered a direct emotional relationship with God without an intermediary priesthood, fed the poor, and healed the sick. Their shrines became community centres. Conversion often happened over generations, around a shrine, without any dramatic moment.
2. Escape from caste	For groups at the bottom of the caste system — barred from temples, from wells, from touching others — a religion that said all believers pray in one line, shoulder to shoulder, was a genuine offer of dignity. This was not cynical. It was rational.
3. Career and patronage	For centuries the state was Muslim. Office, land grants, army commissions and legal advantage flowed more easily to Muslims. Elite conversion often had a strong practical component.
4. Force and pressure	Real, documented, and concentrated in particular reigns and particular campaigns rather than applied continuously. Jizya, destruction of local shrines, and coerced conversion of captives and prisoners all occurred.
5. Time and proximity	Nine hundred years. Inter-marriage, shared festivals, shared shrines, and simple drift. Most conversion in most places is not an event; it is a slow slide across generations.

The geography — and this is the crucial bit

Now look at *where* Punjab became Muslim, because the pattern is extremely informative.

- **Western Punjab** — Multan, Rawalpindi, Jhelum, Lahore division, the Sindh Sagar and Chaj and Rechna doabs — became heavily Muslim, in many districts over 80%.
- **Eastern Punjab** — the Bist Jalandhar Doab, Ambala, Ludhiana, the Malwa country south of the Sutlej — stayed largely Hindu and Sikh.

Why the split? Three reinforcing reasons. The west was under Muslim rule longest and most continuously — from 1030, versus 1192 for the east. The great Sufi centres were in the west: Pakpattan, Multan, Uch Sharif. And Brahminical institutional infrastructure — temples, endowments, established priestly networks — was thinner in the west and denser in the east, closer to the Gangetic heartland.

So Punjab in 1900 was not a Muslim province with Hindu minorities. It was **a Muslim west and a Hindu-Sikh east, joined together in one administrative unit by the British.**

REMEMBER THIS FOR PART 7 — IT IS THE WHOLE REASON FOR THE RADCLIFFE LINE

When Cyril Radcliffe was given six weeks in 1947 to divide Punjab, he was not inventing a division. He was tracing one that had been forming since the eleventh century. His line ran, roughly, down the middle of the Bari Doab — between Lahore and Amritsar — because that is approximately where the Muslim-majority west met the Hindu-Sikh-majority east.

The line was drawn badly, hastily, and by the wrong person. But the fault line it followed was nine hundred years old, and it was created by the process described in this chapter.

CHAPTER SIX

What Punjab built: Baba Farid

While the armies came through, a man in a small town on the Sutlej did something quietly enormous: he started writing poetry in the language ordinary people spoke.

Who he was

Fariduddin Masud Ganjshakar — universally known as **Baba Farid** — lived from 1179 to 1266. The name *Ganjshakar* means "treasury of sugar," or of sweetness.

He was a Sufi of the **Chishti order**, and one of its founding figures in South Asia. When his master Khwaja Bakhtiyar Kaki died in 1235, Farid became his spiritual successor. And here he did something significant: instead of taking up residence in Delhi, at the centre of power and patronage, he went home to Punjab and settled at **Ajodhan** — today **Pakpattan**, in Pakistani Punjab.

He lived, by all accounts, in extreme simplicity, and his shrine at Pakpattan remains one of the most visited in South Asia.

The thing he did that changed everything

Baba Farid is **generally recognised as the first major poet of the Punjabi language**.

Understand what that means. Before Farid, the languages of writing in Punjab were Sanskrit, Persian and Arabic — the languages of priests, of government and of scholarship. Punjabi was what people spoke at home, in the fields, to their children. Nobody wrote serious literature in it.

Farid did. He wrote about God, death, longing, the shortness of life and the vanity of the world, in the language a farmer in Ajodhan actually used.

By doing that, he made Punjabi a literary language. Everything afterwards — Bulleh Shah, Waris Shah's *Heer*, Shah Hussain, the Punjabi of the Sikh Gurus, and Punjabi literature down to the present day — stands on ground he cleared.

Punjabi became a language you could write God's name in because a Muslim Sufi in a small town decided to stop writing in Persian.

And now the fact that should stop you

In 1604, Guru Arjan compiled the **Adi Granth** — the scripture that became the **Guru Granth Sahib**, which Sikhs today revere as their living Guru.

Into it, he included the compositions of Baba Farid: four hymns and a large body of couplets — the commonly cited figure is 112 *saloks*, though counts vary slightly between traditions.

So: **the verses of a Muslim Sufi saint who died in 1266 are sung as sacred scripture in Sikh gurdwaras, every day, all over the world, in 2026.**

Farid is not alone in there. The Guru Granth Sahib contains the work of fifteen *bhagats* — saints from outside the line of Sikh Gurus — including:

- **Kabir**, a weaver from Banaras, born Muslim, claimed by Hindus and Muslims both, who spent his life mocking the certainties of each.
- **Namdev**, a calico-printer from Maharashtra.
- **Ravidas**, a leather-worker from Banaras — an untouchable by the rules of his time — whose hymns sit in the scripture alongside those of the Gurus.
- **Sheikh Farid**, a Muslim Sufi from Punjab.

A Muslim mystic, a Hindu weaver, a Dalit cobbler and a Maharashtrian printer, gathered by a Punjabi Guru into one book, in the sixteenth century.

KEEP THIS IN YOUR HAND FOR PARTS 9 TO 12

Every argument that Sikh and Hindu and Muslim traditions in Punjab were always separate, always hostile, and always at war has to get past that book. It cannot. The founding scripture of Sikhism was deliberately built as a shared inheritance, by a Guru who went looking for the words of a Muslim and an untouchable and put them next to his own father's.

This does not mean there was no conflict — Part 4 contains two executions of Sikh Gurus by the Mughal state, and Part 10 contains massacres in both directions. It means that anyone who claims eternal, essential enmity is contradicted by the single most authoritative document either tradition possesses.

The shrine culture

Farid was one node in a network. Medieval Punjab was covered in Sufi shrines — *dargahs* — and they were the real religious geography of the region:

- **Pakpattan** — Baba Farid.
- **Multan** — Bahauddin Zakariya and Shah Rukn-e-Alam, of the Suhrawardi order, whose tombs are among the finest medieval buildings in South Asia.
- **Uch Sharif** — a whole complex of shrines.
- **Lahore** — Data Ganj Bakhsh (Ali Hujwiri), whose shrine is still the busiest in the city.

And crucially: **Hindus went to these shrines too.** Not as a curiosity — as a normal part of religious life. People of all communities came for healing, for children, for justice, for the

annual festivals. The shrine was where you went when you had a problem, regardless of what you called God.

That is what Punjabi religion actually looked like on the ground for most of these five centuries, whatever the court chronicles and the theologians were saying.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The soil in which Nanak grew

Part 4 is about the Sikh Gurus. This chapter explains why they appeared where and when they did — because Guru Nanak was not born into a vacuum. He was born into a very specific set of conditions, and every one of them shows up in what he said.

Punjab in 1469, in six facts

- 1. The state was foreign, and had been for four hundred years.** No Punjabi in 1469 had a living memory, or a grandparent's memory, or a great-great-grandparent's memory, of Punjab being ruled by Punjabis. Government meant Persian-speaking officials, Turkish and Afghan soldiers, and a revenue demand.
- 2. Violence was normal and periodic.** Timur had come through seventy years earlier. The Mongol raids were within cultural memory. Nobody expected safety, and nobody expected the state to provide it.
- 3. Two religious establishments had hardened.** On one side, a Brahminical order preoccupied with ritual purity, caste rules, pilgrimage and sacred thread. On the other, an Islamic establishment of qazis and mullahs attached to state power. Nanak would attack both, in almost identical terms, for the same fault: mistaking the outward form for the thing itself.
- 4. Caste had become brutal.** Untouchability, exclusion from wells and temples, occupational imprisonment. A large fraction of the population was told, by their own religion, that they were polluting.
- 5. Women were near-invisible in religious life.** Excluded from scripture, from ritual authority, and in elite practice from public life.
- 6. But there was already a language of protest, and it was in Punjabi.** The Sufi tradition of Farid and the Bhakti tradition of Kabir and Ravidas had been saying, for two hundred years, in the local tongue, to ordinary people: God is not in the temple or the mosque, God does not check your caste, and your ritual is worth nothing without an honest heart.

PUT SIMPLY

Punjab in 1469 was a place where the government was foreign, violence was routine, the priests of both religions were doing well while ordinary people were not, and a tradition already existed of saying so out loud in the local language. Something was going to be said. In 1469, in a village called Talwandi near Lahore, someone said it.

The bridge into Part 4

Here is the connection between this part and the next, and it is a direct one.

Guru Nanak lived from 1469 to 1539. In 1520–21, **Babur** invaded Punjab on his way to founding the Mughal Empire, sacking towns including Saidpur (Eminabad), which Nanak appears to have witnessed.

Nanak wrote about it. Four compositions in the Guru Granth Sahib are known as the ***Babarvani*** — "the utterances concerning Babur." They are extraordinary: an eyewitness account of an invasion, written as scripture, in Punjabi.

And they are not a nationalist war-cry. Nanak describes the horror in unsparing terms — women's hair torn, homes destroyed, the powerful reduced to nothing — and then turns and asks God why He allowed it, and also turns on the Indian rulers whose incompetence and self-indulgence left their people defenceless.

He blames the invader. He also blames the local elite. He also demands an answer from God. In three verses.

The founder of Sikhism watched an invasion of Punjab with his own eyes and wrote it into scripture. Part 3 and Part 4 are not two separate stories. Part 4 is Punjab's answer to Part 3.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Scorecard: what Part 3 proves

"Punjab was invaded more than anywhere else in India."

TRUE, AND DEMONSTRABLY SO

Ghaznavids seventeen times, Ghurids, Mongols across eighty years, Timur, then the Mughals — every land invasion of India between 1000 and 1526 entered through Punjab. No other region in the subcontinent comes close. This is not a claim about Punjabi suffering being more noble than anyone else's; it is a claim about a road, and the road is on the map.

"These invasions were religious wars — Islam against Hinduism."

MOSTLY FALSE AS A FRAMING

Mahmud of Ghazni sacked Muslim Multan and massacred Ismaili Muslims. He employed Hindu commanders and minted coins with Sanskrit inscriptions at Lahore. Timur — whose stated pretext was that Delhi's Sultan was too soft on Hindus — attacked a Muslim sultanate, sacked a Muslim capital and killed enormous numbers of Muslims. The Mongols attacked Muslim Delhi. The driver throughout was wealth and power; religion supplied the justification and the vocabulary.

BUT DO NOT OVERCORRECT

Temple destruction was real, and the perpetrators' own chroniclers recorded it with pride. Jizya was real. Iconoclasm was a genuine ideological commitment for some rulers, not just a cover story. The honest position is that religion and greed were fused, not that one was fake.

"Punjab was converted to Islam by the sword."

NOT SUPPORTED AS A COMPLETE EXPLANATION

If Muslim political rule caused conversion, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar — ruled from the imperial capitals for just as long — would be Muslim-majority. They are not. Bengal, the furthest and least directly governed province, became Muslim-majority. The pattern does not fit.

What fits is a combination: Sufi missionary work in the local language, escape from caste exclusion, career advantage under a Muslim state, real coercion in specific times and places, and nine centuries of proximity. Force was one mechanism among five, and probably not the largest.

"Punjab's Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs were always enemies."**FALSE FOR THIS PERIOD, AND THE EVIDENCE IS UNANSWERABLE**

The Sikh scripture — compiled in 1604 by the fifth Guru — contains the poetry of a Muslim Sufi saint, a Hindu weaver, and a Dalit leather-worker, placed beside the Gurus' own compositions. Hindus and Muslims worshipped at the same shrines as a matter of ordinary practice. Punjabi as a literary language was created by a Muslim and carried forward by Sikhs.

Conflict existed and was sometimes lethal — Part 4 contains the executions of two Gurus by the Mughal state. But "always enemies" is refuted by the founding document of Sikhism itself.

"Nothing was created in Punjab during these centuries."**FALSE**

Punjabi became a written literary language. The Sufi shrine network became the region's real social infrastructure. The Bhakti and Sufi traditions produced poetry still sung today. And a distinctive frontier society formed — armed, clan-organised, sceptical of the state — which is the structure the Sikh misls would later inherit. A society under permanent attack kept making things.

"India kept losing because Indians were weak or cowardly."**FALSE — AND THE REAL REASONS ARE MORE USEFUL**

North India in this period had more people and more wealth than any of its attackers. It lost anyway, for four structural reasons:

No unified command. After the Guptas fell in 550 CE, north India had no single state. Invaders faced one kingdom at a time while the others watched.

Cavalry. India's climate and fodder made it very difficult to breed high-quality warhorses. India *imported* them, at enormous cost — and the supply routes ran through Central Asia and Afghanistan, which is to say through the invaders' own territory. The attackers had unlimited good horses; the defenders had to buy theirs from the attackers' neighbours.

Tactical mismatch. Indian armies were built around heavy cavalry charges and war elephants. Central Asian armies were built around mounted archers — fast, dispersed, refusing close combat. Elephants, spectacular against infantry, panic under sustained arrow fire and trample their own side. Tarain in 1192 and Delhi in 1398 were both decided this way.

Restricted recruitment. Caste rules limited who could bear arms in many Indian armies. The invaders recruited anyone who could ride and shoot.

Courage was not the variable. Horses, command structure and tactical doctrine were. I labour this because "we lost because we were weak" leads to fantasy politics, while "we lost because of horses and disunity" leads to actual understanding.

Timeline of Part 3

c. 1000–1027	Mahmud of Ghazni raids India roughly seventeen times, all through Punjab.
1010	Mahmud sacks Muslim Multan.
c. 1030	Lahore annexed as a Ghaznavid provincial capital. Punjab enters permanent Muslim rule — 160 years before Delhi.
1025	Sack of Somnath.
1179–1266	Life of Baba Farid. Punjabi becomes a literary language.
1186	Muhammad of Ghor takes Lahore, ending Ghaznavid rule.
1191	First Battle of Tarain. Prithviraj Chauhan wins.
1192	Second Battle of Tarain. Ghori wins with mounted archers and feigned retreat. Prithviraj killed.
1206	Ghori assassinated near the Jhelum. Qutb-ud-din Aibak declares himself sultan at Lahore. The Delhi Sultanate begins.
1221	Genghis Khan reaches the Indus, looks at India, and turns back.
1241	The Mongols sack Lahore.
1245, 1257, 1285	Further major Mongol invasions.
1266–1287	Balban builds a fort chain from Multan to Lahore and along the Beas.
1296–1316	Alauddin Khalji. Mongols besiege Delhi itself in 1303. Frontier commands built up at Dipalpur and Samana.
1305	Battle of Amroha. Mongol army destroyed; prisoners trampled by elephants at Delhi.
30 Sept 1398	Timur crosses the Indus. Tulamba and Multan sacked.
Dec 1398	The Loni massacre — roughly 100,000 captives killed on Timur's order.
17 Dec 1398	Timur destroys the Tughlaq army. Delhi sacked for fifteen days.
1414	Khizr Khan, Timur's governor of Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur, takes Delhi and founds the Sayyid dynasty.
1469	Guru Nanak is born at Talwandi, near Lahore.
1520–21	Babur invades Punjab. Nanak witnesses it and composes the <i>Babarvani</i> .
1526	First Battle of Panipat. Babur defeats Ibrahim Lodi. The Mughal Empire begins — and Part 4 is well under way.

What happens in Part 4

Part 4, *Gurus and the Khalsa*, covers 1469 to 1708 — and it is where this book's central subject finally arrives.

Ten Gurus across 239 years. We will follow the whole arc: Nanak's radical simplicity and his attack on ritual and caste; the institutions that made Sikhism a society rather than a philosophy — *langar*, *sangat*, the city of Amritsar, the scripture itself; the execution of Guru Arjan in 1606 under Jahangir, which changed everything; Guru Hargobind's doctrine of **Miri-Piri**, worldly power alongside spiritual power, and the two swords; the execution of Guru Tegh Bahadur in Delhi in 1675 — which he accepted, on the evidence, in defence of the religious freedom of *Kashmiri Hindus*, not of Sikhs; and finally Guru Gobind Singh and the founding of the **Khalsa** at Anandpur in 1699.

Above all, Part 4 answers the question this book has been circling since Part 1: **where does the Punjabi tradition of martyrdom actually come from?** Why is *shaheedi* — being killed for a cause — not merely tolerated in Punjabi culture but understood as the highest achievement available to a human being?

The answer is specific, it is theological, it is historically datable, and it has been used and misused by almost everyone in this story since. Getting it right in Part 4 is what will let me judge Part 9 fairly.

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 3

Primary and contemporary sources (in translation)

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- **Utbi**, *Tarikh-i-Yamini*; **Baihaqi**, *Tarikh-i-Baihaqi* — Ghaznavid court histories, including the boasts about temple destruction.
- **Minhaj-i-Siraj**, *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri* — the key thirteenth-century source for the Ghurid conquest and the early Sultanate.
- **Ziauddin Barani**, *Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi* — on Balban and Alauddin Khalji, including the Mongol wars and the frontier system.
- **Amir Khusrau** — poet and eyewitness to the Khalji period.
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- **Guru Granth Sahib** — the compositions of Sheikh Farid, and the *Babarvani* of Guru Nanak. Multiple translations available; Sant Singh Khalsa's and Gopal Singh's are widely used in English.

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- **Simon Digby**, *War-Horse and Elephant in the Delhi Sultanate* — on the horse-supply problem and its military consequences.
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ON THE CASUALTY AND PLUNDER FIGURES IN THIS PART

Nearly every large number in Chapters 1 and 4 — two million dinars at Somnath, 100,000 killed at Loni, 92,000 cavalry, towers of skulls — comes from chroniclers writing to glorify a conqueror. Medieval court historians inflated routinely, and inflating an atrocity was a way of praising your patron's power. These figures should be read as indicating *order of magnitude and intent*, not as audited counts. What is not in doubt is that the events happened and were catastrophic; the precise arithmetic is unrecoverable.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 3 —

Part 4: *Gurus and the Khalsa*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART FOUR OF THIRTEEN

Gurus and the Khalsa

1469 to 1708 — ten Gurus, two executions, four dead children, and the origin of *shaheedi*

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 4

This is the part I was most afraid of writing.

Everything so far has been about dead empires. Nobody's faith depends on what I concluded about Porus or Mihirakula. Part 4 is different. It is about a living religion, one I was raised in, and about people whom millions of us regard not as historical figures but as Gurus.

So let me be exact about what I am doing, because if I am not, I will offend people for the wrong reasons.

I am writing history, not devotion, and not theology. I am not assessing whether the Gurus' teachings are true. That is not a question historical method can answer, and I would not trust anyone who claimed otherwise. What I am doing is treating the Gurus as people who made decisions in real circumstances, and tracing what those decisions caused. Some Sikh readers will find that flat. It is the cost of the method, and I would rather pay it openly than pretend to a neutrality I do not have.

And I have a specific reason for needing this part to be accurate. Part 9 of this work is about Bhindranwale. Almost every argument in that part — on both sides — is conducted in the vocabulary invented between 1606 and 1708. *Miri-Piri*. *Sant-sipahi*. *Shaheedi*. The Akal Takht. The authority of the Panth. People who have never read the Zafarnama quote its most famous line at each other.

I cannot judge how those words were used in 1984 unless I first establish, carefully and from the record, what they actually meant when they were made. That is what Part 4 is for. Chapter 8 is the one that Part 9 will rest on, and I have tried to write it without flinching in either direction.

One promise. There is a scorecard entry near the end of this part about caste — about the distance between what the Khalsa abolished in principle and what still happens in Punjabi villages. It was uncomfortable to write. It is going in anyway, because a tradition worth defending is one you can be honest about.

— L.S.

INTRODUCTION

Two hundred and thirty-nine years

Part 3 left Punjab in 1469: a place with a foreign government, routine violence, two religious establishments that had hardened into rival businesses, a brutal caste system, and an existing habit of saying so out loud in the local language. Part 4 is Punjab's answer.

Ten Gurus, from Nanak's birth in 1469 to Gobind Singh's death in 1708. Two hundred and thirty-nine years.

In that time a movement goes from one man walking around arguing with priests, to a scripture, a capital city, a bank, an army, a uniform, a code of conduct, and a form of collective sovereignty that has no exact parallel anywhere else. Two of the ten Gurus are executed by the state. All four sons of the tenth are killed, two of them children aged nine and seven.

And at the end of it, the tenth Guru does something that no other founder of a major religion has done: he ends the line of living Gurus altogether and hands authority to a book and to the community jointly.

The question this part has to answer

I have been circling one question since Part 1, and this is where I have to answer it.

Where does *shaheedi* come from?

Every culture honours people who die for something. Punjab is different in degree and in kind. In Punjabi culture, being killed for a cause is not merely respected — it is widely understood as the highest thing a human being can achieve. Higher than long life. Higher than wealth. Higher than success.

Where does that come from? Not from the soil — Part 1 showed that the oldest Punjabi civilisation was strikingly unwarlike. Not from blood or race, which explains nothing because it cannot explain change.

The answer is in this part. It is specific, it is datable, it is theological, and it was built deliberately by identifiable people for identifiable reasons between 1606 and 1708. Chapter 8 lays it out, including the part that is uncomfortable: what that inheritance protects a people from, and what it exposes them to.

A NOTE FOR NON-SIKH READERS

Two things will make the rest of this part easier to follow. First, the **Guru Granth Sahib** is not a book about the religion; for Sikhs it *is* the Guru — a living authority, treated with the courtesies given to a person. When I describe Guru Gobind Singh installing it in 1708, understand that he was not publishing a text. He was naming a successor.

Second, **Guru** in this tradition does not mean "teacher" in the loose modern sense. There were ten, they are understood to have carried one light through ten bodies, and the line is closed. Nobody has been a Sikh Guru since 1708, and any living person who claims the title is, by definition, outside the tradition. That fact will matter in Part 9.

CHAPTER 1 Nanak: what he actually said, and what he built.

CHAPTER 2 The institution-builders: Gurus two to five.

CHAPTER 3 1606: the execution that changed everything.

CHAPTER 4 Miri-Piri: the doctrine that made modern Punjab — and the question it left open.

CHAPTER 5 1675: the Guru who was beheaded defending Hindus.

CHAPTER 6 1699: the Khalsa.

CHAPTER 7 The price: Anandpur, Chamkaur, Sirhind, Nanded.

CHAPTER 8 Where *shaheedi* comes from — and what it costs.

CHAPTER 9 Scorecard: what Part 4 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

Nanak

Guru Nanak lived from 1469 to 1539. He never raised an army, never called for a state, and never preached violence. Everything military in this part comes later, and comes as a response. Getting that order right matters more than almost anything else in this book.

The beginning

He was born in 1469 at Talwandi, a village near Lahore — today **Nankana Sahib**, in Pakistani Punjab. His father was a village accountant. He worked as a storekeeper at Sultanpur Lodhi.

The formative episode, as Sikh tradition records it: one morning he went to the river to bathe and did not come back. He was missing for three days. When he reappeared, his first words were:

*"Na koi Hindu, na koi Musalman."
There is no Hindu, there is no Muslim.*

People misread this constantly, so let me be careful. He was not saying the religions do not exist, and he was not saying they are all the same. He was making a much sharper point: **the labels are not what count**. Being born a Hindu does not make you good. Being born a Muslim does not make you good. What you actually do is what counts, and by that standard he could not see many real Hindus or real Muslims around him.

In 1469, in a society organised entirely around exactly those labels, that was not a gentle observation. It was an attack on the whole arrangement.

The journeys

He then spent roughly two decades travelling — the *udasis*. Traditional accounts take him to Mecca, Baghdad, Sri Lanka, Tibet and across India. Historians disagree about how far he actually got, and I cannot settle it.

What matters is the pattern, and the pattern is well attested: he went to religious centres and argued with the people running them. Pilgrimage sites, temples, mosques, the seats of Yogis. He did not build a following by sitting in one place and receiving visitors. He went to where the authority was and questioned it.

What he taught, in plain words

NANAK'S CORE TEACHING

Idea	What it means
Ik Onkar	One reality, one creator, present throughout creation. The very first characters of the Sikh scripture. Not a god who lives in a building and can be visited.
No intermediaries	You do not need a priest, a Brahmin, a mullah or a ritual specialist to reach God. This removes an entire profession's reason to exist, which is why that profession objected.
Caste is meaningless	Not "caste is unfortunate." Meaningless. Before the creator there is no high birth and no low birth.
Ritual saves nobody	Pilgrimage, idol worship, sacred thread, fasting, ritual bathing — all worthless without honest conduct.
Women are equal	His line is direct: " <i>So kyon manda aakhiye, jit jamme rajaan</i> " — why call her inferior, when she gives birth to kings?

And then the three pillars, which is where he separates from almost every religious teacher India had produced:

- **Naam Japna** — remember the creator.
- **Kirat Karni** — earn your living by honest work.
- **Vand Chhakna** — share what you earn.

The revolutionary bit is the second pillar

Look at *Kirat Karni* again. Earn by honest work.

The dominant Indian religious model held that the highest spiritual life meant renunciation: leave the household, abandon work and family, beg for food, withdraw. The holy man was, by definition, someone who had stopped participating.

Nanak rejected that outright. He said: do not become a monk. Work. Marry. Have children. Pay your way. Be in the world and be good *in* it. He lived it himself — he spent his last years at Kartarpur farming.

The consequence is enormous and it is the reason this movement produced soldiers and farmers and traders rather than ascetics. A religion of working householders is a religion with an economy, a population, and something to defend.

The institutions — why this survived when other movements did not

Here is the analytical point of the chapter. The Bhakti movement produced many extraordinary teachers who said things very close to what Nanak said. Kabir said them. Ravidas said them. Almost all of those movements faded into devotional sects or were absorbed.

Sikhism did not. The difference is not the ideas. It is that Nanak built **machinery**.

Langar. The free kitchen, where everyone sits on the floor in a line — *pangat* — and eats the same food, regardless of caste, religion, wealth or gender. I want to be precise about why this is radical rather than merely kind. In a caste society, the rules about who may eat with whom, and who may accept food from whom, are the machinery by which caste is enforced every single day. Caste does not live mainly in books. It lives at the point of the mouth. Langar attacks it exactly there. It is not charity with a spiritual justification; it is a social technology aimed at the load-bearing wall.

Sangat. The congregation — a standing local community that meets, not a crowd that gathers for a festival.

Kartarpur. An actual town on the Ravi, founded by Nanak, where the teaching was practised as a working farming community rather than discussed.

And the succession. This is the innovation I would rank highest. Nanak had two sons. He passed over both. He tested his followers, and appointed one of them — **Bhai Lehna**, who became **Guru Angad** — and made his own sons bow to the man he had chosen.

A movement that appoints its leader on merit rather than blood is a movement that can survive its founder. That single decision, in 1539, is why there is a Part 4 at all.

Babarvani: Nanak watches an invasion

In 1520–21, Babur invaded Punjab on his way to founding the Mughal Empire, sacking towns including Saidpur (Eminabad). Nanak appears to have witnessed it, and possibly to have been briefly held.

He wrote about it. Those compositions, in the Guru Granth Sahib, are known as the **Babarvani** — the utterances concerning Babur. They are one of the very few eyewitness accounts of a Mughal invasion written by a non-combatant civilian, and they are astonishing.

They do three things at once, and the combination is the whole of Nanak's moral method:

1. **They condemn the invader** without softening anything — the killing, the destruction, the humiliation of women.
2. **They condemn the local rulers** for the incompetence, luxury and self-absorption that left their people defenceless. He does not give the Indian side a pass because it lost.
3. **They demand an answer from God.** He asks, directly, how the creator could watch this and not feel pain.

What they are *not* is a call to arms, and they are not a nationalist text. They are a moral accounting in which nobody with power escapes.

FIX THIS IN YOUR MIND BEFORE PART 9

For seventy years, from 1469 to 1539, Sikhism has no military dimension whatsoever. Nanak witnessed an invasion and responded with poetry and a question to God, not with a militia.

The sword enters this story in 1606, and it enters as a direct response to a state execution. Anyone who tells you Sikhism was militant from the beginning has the chronology backwards — and the chronology is the whole argument.

CHAPTER TWO

The institution-builders

Between 1539 and 1606, four Gurus turned a teaching into a society. By the end of it the Sikhs had their own script, their own ceremonies, their own capital city, their own scripture and their own revenue system. That is also, precisely, why the state killed the fifth one.

Guru Angad (1539–1552): the script

Angad's contribution sounds technical and is actually enormous. He standardised and popularised **Gurmukhi** — literally "from the Guru's mouth" — the script in which Punjabi is written to this day.

Think about what a script does politically. Before Gurmukhi, writing in Punjab meant Sanskrit in Devanagari, controlled by Brahmins, or Persian in the Nastaliq script, controlled by the state. Both were the property of an elite, and both required going through that elite to read anything sacred or official.

A script of your own means your scripture can be written down, copied, and read by ordinary people in their own language, with nobody's permission. It is an independence movement conducted through the alphabet.

He also collected Nanak's hymns and began the process that would end in the Adi Granth, and he ran schools and a wrestling arena — physical training alongside literacy.

Guru Amar Das (1552–1574): the society

Amar Das is the Guru who turns a following into a structure.

- He made **langar compulsory before an audience**. Anybody who wanted to meet the Guru — including, by tradition, the Emperor Akbar — first had to sit on the floor and eat with everyone else.
- He built the **baoli** at Goindwal, a stepwell with eighty-four steps, which became the first Sikh pilgrimage site.
- He created the **manji** system — twenty-two territorial seats, each with an appointed representative, to administer the growing community. An organisational chart.
- He appointed **women as preachers**, and campaigned against *sati* — the burning of widows — and against *purdah*.
- And most consequentially, he established **distinct Sikh ceremonies** for birth, marriage and death.

That last point is the moment of separation. When a community stops using another community's rituals for the three events that structure every human life, it has stopped being

a reform movement inside that community. It has become a separate society. Everything in the endless "are Sikhs Hindus" argument, which I will deal with in the scorecard, traces back to a decision made here.

Guru Ram Das (1574–1581): the city

He founded a town called Ramdaspur, around a pool he had excavated. The town grew into **Amritsar** — "the pool of nectar" — and became the centre of the Sikh world.

He also composed the **Lavan**, the four hymns that constitute the Sikh marriage ceremony and are still sung at every Sikh wedding.

Guru Arjan (1581–1606): the peak

Arjan is where all of it comes together, and where the state starts paying attention.

He completed the Harmandir Sahib — the building the world calls the Golden Temple. Two design decisions in it are theology made out of brick, and both are deliberate:

- **Four doors, one on each side.** Every temple in India has one entrance. Four doors means open from all four directions, to all four castes, to anyone.
- **You walk down to it.** Every other place of worship in India is raised — you climb steps to approach the divine. The Harmandir Sahib sits *lower* than the surrounding ground, in the middle of water. You descend to reach it. The message is not subtle and it was not meant to be.

He compiled the Adi Granth in 1604, installing it in the Harmandir Sahib. He included his own compositions and those of the four Gurus before him — and then he went looking for other people's. Into the scripture went fifteen *bhagats*: Kabir, Namdev, Ravidas, Sheikh Farid and others. A Muslim Sufi. A Dalit leather-worker. A Maharashtrian calico-printer.

I made this point in Part 3 and I will keep making it, because it is the single hardest fact for anyone selling communal history in Punjab: the founding scripture of Sikhism was *deliberately built* as a shared inheritance.

He built an economy. New towns — Tarn Taran, Kartarpur in Jalandhar district, Hargobindpur. Wells and irrigation. Encouragement of trade, including horse trading with Central Asia. And a formalised system of collection through appointed agents, the *masands*, who gathered contributions and brought them to Amritsar.

So by 1605, the Sikhs had: a scripture, a holy city, a distinct set of ceremonies, a script, a network of towns, a revenue system, and a rapidly growing following of both Hindus and Muslims.

They were no longer a sect. They were a parallel society with its own treasury.

Which is exactly why the next chapter happens.

CHAPTER THREE

1606

On 30 May 1606, Guru Arjan was executed at Lahore on the orders of the Emperor Jahangir. This is the hinge of the entire part, and unusually for events of this age, we have the killer's own written account of why he did it.

What we know, and from whom

There are three independent bodies of evidence, which is unusually good for the period. I want to separate them clearly, because people routinely quote one and attribute it to another.

THE THREE SOURCES FOR 1606

Source	What it says
Jahangir's own memoirs <i>Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri</i>	The perpetrator's written account. He describes Arjan as "a Hindu in the garments of sainthood," complains that great numbers of "simple-hearted Hindus and ignorant, foolish Muslims" had been drawn to him, notes that this "shop" had been kept warm for three or four generations, and states that he ordered it ended. He mentions that Arjan had received the fugitive prince Khusrau.
A Jesuit letter from Lahore	A contemporary Portuguese Jesuit account from Lahore records the death. This matters enormously as method: it is a third-party European witness with no stake in either the Mughal or the Sikh version.
Sikh tradition	Supplies the details of the torture — that he was seated on a heated iron plate while burning sand was poured over him, over several days, and that he was then taken to the Ravi, entered the water, and was not seen again.

BEING PRECISE ABOUT WHICH SOURCE SAYS WHAT

Jahangir's memoirs record the order and the reasoning; they use the term *yasa*, a formal political execution. They do not describe hot sand. The torture details come from Sikh tradition. Both are part of the record, and I am telling you which is which rather than blending them into one seamless story — because in Part 9 I will have to do exactly this with 1984, and it is better to establish the habit here.

The Khusrau connection

In April 1606, Jahangir's eldest son **Khusrau** rebelled, was defeated, and fled north through Punjab. He stopped at Goindwal, on the Beas, where he met Guru Arjan. Arjan, by most accounts, blessed him and may have given him money.

Jahangir was a brand-new emperor whose own son had just tried to take his throne. Aiding that son was treason.

Why he was really killed: three readings

Reading A — treason. Arjan helped a rebel prince. Any empire in history executes for that. The religion was incidental; the crime was political.

Reading B — religious persecution. Read Jahangir's own paragraph and notice its proportions. Most of it is about Arjan's *religious* success — the crowds, the conversions of Muslims, the fact that this had been going on for generations and had been tolerated too long. Khusrau appears almost as the occasion rather than the cause. Akbar's policy of tolerance had died with Akbar in 1605, and the orthodox faction at court — associated with Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi, called the Mujaddid — welcomed the execution in writing.

Reading C — a rival power centre. Strip out theology entirely. A large, wealthy, rapidly growing organisation with its own capital city, its own revenue collectors and its own following across two religions is a competing authority. Empires do not tolerate those, whatever they believe.

MY ASSESSMENT

These are not three competing options; they are three layers of one thing, and Jahangir's own text contains all three. The most defensible reading is that the Khusrau meeting supplied the occasion and the legal pretext for a decision that was already forming, and that the underlying driver was Reading C wearing the clothes of Reading B: Sikhism had become a parallel society with its own money, and the new emperor's religious politics made ending it both attractive and easy to justify.

What I will not do is what partisans on both sides do — treat it as *purely* a political execution with no religious dimension, or as *purely* religious persecution with no political trigger. The primary source rules out both simplifications, which is a good reason to read primary sources.

What it changed

Everything. Sikh tradition records Arjan's final instruction to his eleven-year-old son: let him sit fully armed upon his throne, and maintain an army to the best of his ability.

From 1469 to 1606 — one hundred and thirty-seven years — Sikhism had no military dimension at all. From 1606 onward it has one permanently.

The state made that decision, not the Gurus. I want that stated flatly, because it is the single most important causal claim in this part.

CHAPTER FOUR

Miri-Piri

This chapter contains the most consequential idea in Punjabi history, and the unresolved question buried inside it. Read it twice. Part 9 will be unintelligible without it.

Two swords

Guru Hargobind (Guru from 1606 to 1644) was eleven years old when his father was executed.

At his investiture he did something the previous five Gurus had not. The ceremony traditionally involved the *seli*, a woollen cord associated with renunciation. He declined it, and asked instead to be girded with **two swords**:

- **Miri** — from the Persian *amir*, a ruler. Temporal power. Worldly authority. The right and duty to act in the political world.
- **Piri** — from *pir*, a spiritual master. Spiritual authority.

He wore both, at once, for the rest of his life.

The building that is the doctrine

In 1606 he laid the foundation of the **Akal Takht** — the "Throne of the Timeless One" — directly facing the Harmandir Sahib across the pool at Amritsar.

The architecture *is* the argument, and I think it is one of the most elegant pieces of political theology anywhere:

TWO BUILDINGS, ONE DOCTRINE

Harmandir Sahib	Akal Takht
Sits <i>below</i> ground level, in the middle of water.	Sits on a raised platform, deliberately higher than the height a subject's seat was permitted to be under Mughal convention.
Four doors, open to all.	A throne. A place of judgment.
Where you go to pray.	Where the community goes to decide.
Piri — the spiritual.	Miri — the temporal.

They face each other, thirty metres apart. You cannot look at one without seeing the other. That is the entire point.

What Miri-Piri actually says

In the plainest words I can manage:

Spiritual life and worldly power are not separate departments. A religion that tells you to be good, pray, and accept whatever the powerful do to you is a religion that serves the powerful. It converts injustice into a spiritual test and asks the victim to pass it quietly.

Hargobind's answer was: pray *and* be armed. Be a saint *and* a soldier. This is the **sant-sipahi** ideal — the saint-soldier — and it is the template for everything Sikh that follows.

He built it out in practice. He constructed the fort of Lohgarh at Amritsar, raised cavalry, kept horses and hawks, and accepted weapons and horses as offerings. Jahangir imprisoned him at Gwalior for some years; Sikh tradition holds that he refused release unless the fifty-two imprisoned princes held there were freed with him, which is commemorated as *Bandi Chhor Divas*. He fought four battles against Mughal forces — the first Sikh-Mughal military engagements in history.

Now the question the doctrine leaves open

I have to state this carefully, because it is the most important analytical point in Part 4 and it is one that devotional accounts skip.

Miri-Piri establishes that the sword is legitimate. It does not, by itself, establish **who decides when the sword comes out**.

In Hargobind's lifetime the answer was obvious: the Guru decided. There was a living Guru, his authority was undisputed, and the question did not arise.

But after 1708 there is no living Guru — by the tenth Guru's own deliberate design, as Chapter 7 will show. Authority passes to the scripture and to the community acting collectively. Which is a magnificent defence against a state that wants to decapitate a movement by killing one man.

It also means that **there is no living office that can authoritatively say "no."**

Miri-Piri says the sword is legitimate. It does not say who gets to draw it. For three hundred years that gap was filled by consensus. In 1980 it was filled by a man with a microphone.

THE MOST IMPORTANT BOX IN PART 4

Every significant actor in Parts 9 through 12 claims Miri-Piri. Bhindranwale claimed it explicitly and repeatedly. The Akal Takht's authority is invoked by militants, by moderates, by political parties, and by the Indian state's Sikh allies — often against each other, often in the same week.

The doctrine is genuine, ancient and central. It is not a militant invention and it cannot be dismissed as one. That is exactly what makes it usable: because it is real, an appeal to it is powerful; and because it names no arbiter, the appeal is available to anyone who can gather a following.

When I get to Part 9 I will not be asking "was Bhindranwale allowed to invoke Miri-Piri?" Anyone can. I will be asking the question the doctrine itself poses and that Chapter 8 will give me the tools for: **had all other means genuinely failed?** That is the test the tenth Guru set, in writing, and it is the only one that can be applied from outside.

CHAPTER FIVE

1675

In November 1675 the ninth Guru was beheaded in Delhi. He was not killed for defending Sikhs. He was killed for defending Hindus — specifically, Kashmiri Brahmins, whose religion he did not share and whose caste system his own faith rejected.

The two Gurus in between

Guru Har Rai (1644–1661) maintained the cavalry force but avoided using it, and concentrated on consolidation and on a dispensary of medicines. One episode from his time is worth keeping.

Aurangzeb summoned him to Delhi. He sent his elder son, Ram Rai, instead. At court, asked about a line in the scripture that appeared to reflect poorly on Muslims, Ram Rai altered the wording to please the emperor.

Har Rai disinherited him permanently and never saw him again.

The principle established there is severe and it is worth naming: **the text is not negotiable, not even a single word, not even to save your life or please an emperor.** Sikhism's attitude to its own scripture — including the extreme sensitivity around any perceived disrespect to the Guru Granth Sahib, which will become directly relevant in Part 13 — begins with decisions like this one.

Guru Har Krishan (1661–1664) became Guru at five. During a smallpox epidemic in Delhi he tended the sick, contracted the disease, and died at eight. Gurdwara Bangla Sahib marks the place.

Guru Tegh Bahadur and the Kashmiri Pandits

Guru Tegh Bahadur (Guru from 1665) founded the town of **Anandpur** in the Shivalik foothills, and travelled extensively through Bihar, Bengal and Assam. His son Gobind was born at Patna in 1666.

The context for what follows: from 1669, Aurangzeb abandoned the relative tolerance of his predecessors and pursued an active policy of religious persecution against non-Muslims, including the destruction of temples and schools. Jizya, the tax on non-Muslims, was reimposed in 1679. In Kashmir, under the governor Iftikhar Khan, pressure on the Brahmin community was severe.

A delegation of **Kashmiri Pandits**, led by **Kirpa Ram Datt**, travelled to Anandpur and asked the Guru for help.

According to Sikh tradition — including the account given by his own son in the *Bachitar Natak* — the response was to send word to the Emperor that if the Guru could be converted, the Pandits would all convert with him.

What happened

He was arrested in July 1675 with three companions, imprisoned at Sirhind, and taken to Delhi. He was ordered to convert to Islam or to perform a miracle to prove his standing. He refused both.

His three companions were killed in front of him first, to break him. **Bhai Mati Das** was sawn in half. **Bhai Dyala** was boiled alive. **Bhai Sati Das** was wrapped in cotton and burned.

He was then beheaded publicly at Chandni Chowk. The date is given as **11 November 1675** in the Nanakshahi calendar and as 24 November in some other reckonings; the discrepancy is a calendar-conversion issue, not a factual dispute.

Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib marks the site of the execution. Gurdwara Rakab Ganj marks where his body was cremated.

Why this is the most important fact in Sikh-Hindu relations

I want to slow down here, because this fact does more analytical work in this book than almost any other.

Guru Tegh Bahadur did not die defending Sikhs. Sikhs were not the ones being forcibly converted in Kashmir. He died defending **Kashmiri Brahmins** — members of the very caste hierarchy that his own tradition explicitly rejects, performing rituals that Nanak had criticised by name.

He had no theological agreement with them whatsoever. He defended their right to be, in his own tradition's terms, wrong.

That is the definition of religious freedom as a principle rather than a preference. A preference protects the people you agree with. A principle protects the people you do not.

Guru Gobind Singh's own verse names his father "*Hind di Chadar*" — the shield of India.

KEEP THIS IN YOUR HAND FOR PARTS 9, 10 AND 11

In Part 10 I will have to write about Sikh militants pulling Hindu passengers off buses and shooting them because they were Hindus. In Part 11 I will have to examine an ideology that treats Hindus as the enemy of Sikhs by definition.

The ninth Guru was beheaded in Delhi, and had three of his companions tortured to death in front of him, for the specific and sole purpose of defending Hindus' right to remain Hindu.

There is no way around that fact. It is not a liberal gloss or a modern reinterpretation — it is the reason the execution happened, recorded in the tradition's own foundational sources. Any account of Sikhism that places Hindus as the natural enemy has to explain away the death of its own ninth Guru. It cannot, and I will say so every time it comes up.

CHAPTER SIX

1699: the Khalsa

A nine-year-old boy was brought his father's severed head. Twenty-four years later he created the most unusual institution in Indian religious history — and then knelt down and asked it to initiate him.

Gobind Rai

Born at Patna in 1666. He became Guru at **nine years old**, in the circumstances described in the last chapter.

He was not only a soldier. He kept fifty-two poets at his court at Anandpur, commissioned translations of classical works into Braj, and wrote extensively himself in Braj, Persian and Punjabi. The intellectual output of Anandpur in this period was substantial and is usually forgotten in favour of the battles.

Vaisakhi 1699

He called the Sikhs to Anandpur for Vaisakhi in 1699. The date is given as **30 March 1699** in the reckoning most commonly used, and as 13 April in others — again a calendar-conversion difference rather than a dispute about the event.

Before a very large gathering, he drew his sword and asked for a head.

One man stood up. The Guru took him into a tent. There was a sound, and the Guru came out alone with a bloodied sword, and asked for another. This happened five times.

Then he brought all five out alive.

The Panj Piare, and why the details matter

The five became the **Panj Piare** — the Five Beloved. Look carefully at who they were, because the selection was clearly deliberate:

THE FIVE BELOVED — WHERE FROM, AND WHAT CASTE

Name	Home	Caste background
Daya Ram → Daya Singh	Lahore, Punjab	Khatri — a high commercial caste
Dharam Das → Dharam Singh	Hastinapur, near Delhi	Jat — a cultivating caste
Himmat Rai → Himmat Singh	Jagannath Puri, Odisha	Kumhar — potter / water-carrier
Mohkam Chand → Mohkam Singh	Dwarka, Gujarat	Chhimba — washerman / calico-printer
Sahib Chand → Sahib Singh	Bidar, Karnataka	Nai — barber

Two patterns, and neither is an accident.

Geography: Punjab, Delhi, Odisha, Gujarat, Karnataka. Five men from five corners of the subcontinent, at a gathering in a Himalayan foothill town. This was not a Punjabi event that happened to include outsiders.

Caste: one from a high caste, four from artisan and service castes traditionally treated as low. In 1699, in a caste society, this was not symbolism. It was demolition.

The initiation, and the reversal

He initiated them with **Khande di Pahul** — water stirred with a double-edged sword, the *khanda*, while the scriptures were recited. Mata Sahib Kaur added *patashe*, sugar crystals, to the water.

Steel and sweetness in the same bowl. That is the sant-sipahi in a sentence.

And then he did the thing that I think has no parallel in the history of religion.

He knelt and asked the Five to initiate him.

The Guru received initiation at the hands of his own disciples, and became Gobind Singh. He is recorded as saying that the Khalsa is the Guru and the Guru is the Khalsa.

Every founder of every faith has stood above the community he created. This one knelt down in front of five men — a shopkeeper, a farmer, a potter, a washerman and a barber — and asked them to make him one of them.

Names, and what they abolish

All initiated men took the name **Singh** — lion. All women took **Kaur** — which carries the sense of princess, or sovereign in her own right.

Understand the mechanism. In India, the surname *is* the caste marker. It is how strangers place you in the hierarchy within three seconds of meeting. Replacing every surname with two universal names does not merely discourage caste — it deletes the instrument by which caste is operated in daily life.

And note that women received a name of their own, not their husband's. In 1699.

The Five Ks

THE PANJ KAKAAR

Article	What it is	What it means
Kesh	Uncut hair	Acceptance of the form in which you were made; rejection of the idea that you must alter yourself to be acceptable.
Kangha	A small wooden comb	Cleanliness and discipline. Not a renunciate's matted hair — a working person's kept hair.
Kara	An iron or steel bracelet	A circle with no beginning or end. Worn on the working hand, so that whatever that hand reaches for, the wearer is reminded.
Kachera	A specific cotton undergarment	Self-restraint and modesty; also, practically, clothing you can fight in.
Kirpan	A blade	The duty to defend the defenceless. Note the doctrine attached: it is for protection, including the protection of others, and not for aggression.

The function nobody explains

There is a practical logic to the Five Ks that I rarely see stated, and it is the sharpest thing about them.

They make you impossible to hide.

A Khalsa Sikh is visually identifiable from across a street. In a period when the Mughal state was executing Sikhs, and would shortly place a price on Sikh heads, this is the deliberate removal of the option of anonymity.

You cannot quietly deny what you are. You cannot blend in when it gets dangerous. Having accepted the uniform, you have only two remaining options: defend yourself, or be killed.

It is a commitment device, engineered so that going back is not available. I find it one of the most audacious pieces of institutional design in any religion.

What the Khalsa actually is

Analytically, strip away the reverence and look at the components:

- **Nanak's ideas** — one creator, no caste, honest work, service, equality of women.
- **Amar Das's institutions** — separate ceremonies, an administrative structure, a distinct society.
- **Arjan's assets** — a scripture, a capital, a revenue system.
- **Hargobind's Miri-Piri** — the legitimacy of temporal power and arms.
- **The frontier society of Part 3** — armed villages, clan organisation, self-defence, deep scepticism of the state.
- **And now: a uniform, an initiation, a code of conduct, and collective sovereign authority.**

The result is a religion, an army and a republic occupying the same body at the same time. I do not know of another one.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The price

Between 1704 and 1708 the tenth Guru lost his fortress, his mother and all four of his sons. What he did in response — twice — tells you more about the Khalsa than any doctrine.

Anandpur, December 1704

Anandpur was besieged repeatedly by the surrounding hill rajas allied with Mughal forces. In December 1704, after a long siege, the Sikhs were offered safe passage out under a sworn oath — the Mughal commanders swearing on the Qur'an, the hill rajas on the cow.

The Guru's own view, as recorded later, was that the oath would be broken. He evacuated anyway, under pressure from those inside.

The oath was broken. The column was attacked while crossing the flooded **Sarsa** river. In the chaos the family was scattered. Much of the manuscript library was lost in the water.

Chamkaur, 22 December 1704

The Guru, his two elder sons and around forty Sikhs took shelter in a mud-walled house at Chamkaur. Outside was a Mughal army.

They went out to fight in small groups. **Ajit Singh**, aged seventeen, went out and was killed. **Jujhar Singh**, aged fourteen, asked to follow his brother, and was killed.

Then the surviving Sikhs took a decision. Constituting themselves as the Khalsa — five of them, in the form of the Panj Piare — they issued the Guru an *order* to leave and survive.

He obeyed.

I want to stop on that. The Guru of the Sikhs, having just watched two of his sons die, was given an instruction by five ordinary Sikhs and he followed it. That is not a story about humility. It is the constitutional mechanism established at Vaisakhi 1699 operating under maximum stress: the Khalsa is the Guru, and its collective decision binds even him.

Sirhind, December 1704

The Guru's mother, **Mata Gujri**, and his two younger sons had been separated at the Sarsa. They were betrayed by a former servant and handed to the authorities.

Zorawar Singh was nine. **Fateh Singh** was seven.

They were brought before **Wazir Khan**, the Mughal governor of Sirhind, and ordered to convert to Islam. They refused. They were executed — Sikh tradition and most accounts record that they were bricked up alive in a wall.

Mata Gujri died the same day.

BEING CAREFUL WITH THIS ONE

Some historians debate the precise mechanism — whether the children were bricked up and then executed by sword, or died in the wall. Persian sources of the period record the executions; the details vary between accounts.

The core facts are not in dispute in any source I have found: two children, aged nine and seven, were executed by the state for refusing to convert. I do not need the most dramatic version of this to be true. The undisputed version is sufficient.

The Zafarnama

From Dina, in Punjab, the Guru wrote a letter in Persian verse to Aurangzeb. It is called the **Zafarnama** — the Epistle of Victory. It is included in the Dasam Granth.

One line from it is quoted constantly, usually by people who have read nothing else in it:

"When all other means have failed, it is righteous to draw the sword."

Read the whole letter and the emphasis changes completely. The Zafarnama is overwhelmingly an **accusation of oath-breaking**. Again and again it charges the Emperor with perjury: you swore on your holy book, and you broke the oath. What kind of ruler are you? What is your faith worth?

The moral claim is not "my religion is right and yours is wrong." It is **"you gave your word and you broke it."** The Guru is holding a Muslim emperor to the standard of his own scripture — which is a very different argument from a religious war, and a much harder one to answer.

THE TEST, IN THE GURU'S OWN WORDS

Note what the famous line actually contains: a **condition**. The sword is righteous *when all other means have failed*. Not when other means are inconvenient, not when they are slow, and not when they have not been tried.

That is a test with a threshold, set in writing by the tenth Guru. It is the single most useful instrument I will carry into Part 9, because it is the tradition's own standard rather than one I have imported from outside — which means it cannot be dismissed as an alien framework imposed on Sikh history.

Muktsar, and the end

At **Muktsar** in 1705, a group of Sikhs who had earlier deserted at Anandpur — signing a written disclaimer renouncing the Guru — returned and died fighting a Mughal force. The

Guru tore up their disclaimer over the body of their leader, Mai Bhago's companion Mahan Singh. They are remembered as the *Chali Mukte*, the forty liberated ones.

Aurangzeb died in 1707. Guru Gobind Singh supported Bahadur Shah in the succession struggle and travelled south with his camp.

At **Nanded**, in present-day Maharashtra, he was stabbed by an assassin — generally reported as sent by Wazir Khan of Sirhind. He died on **7 October 1708**.

The last decision, and the one that shapes everything after

Before his death he did not appoint an eleventh Guru. He ended the line of human Gurus permanently and conferred the guruship on the **Guru Granth Sahib**. *Guru Maneyo Granth* — accept the Granth as Guru.

Authority in Sikhism from that day is held jointly by two things: the **Guru Granth Sahib**, the scripture, and the **Guru Khalsa Panth**, the community acting collectively.

Why this was brilliant. No more succession disputes — and Sikh history to that point had been full of them, with rival claimants backed by the Mughal state. No individual who can be arrested, tortured or bought to decapitate the movement. No pope, no clergy with the power to reinterpret at will. The Mughal state had killed two Gurus. After 1708 there was nobody left to kill.

And now the cost, which I have to state honestly.

A community with no living central authority is a community that can be spoken for by anyone who gathers a following. There is no office empowered to say, with binding force, *this man does not speak for us*. The Akal Takht issues edicts, and they carry real weight — but its jurisdiction, its appointments and its independence have been contested throughout the modern period, and it has at various times been influenced by whoever held political power in Punjab.

In 1708 the absence of a single living authority was a shield against an empire that killed leaders. In 1980 it was an opening for anyone who could claim to speak for the Panth. The same design feature, in different circumstances, produced opposite results.

I am not criticising the decision. Given what Guru Gobind Singh had just lived through — two Gurus executed, his own four sons dead, rival claimants installed by the state — it was the correct decision and probably the only one that would have preserved the tradition at all.

But structures have consequences beyond the circumstances they were built for, and this one is the most important structural fact in this whole book for understanding what happens in

Part 9. I will return to it there.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Where *shaheedi* comes from

This is the chapter the whole part exists for. It is also the one I rewrote most times, because getting it wrong in either direction would poison everything after it.

The theology, in four steps

Every culture honours people who die for a cause. What is distinctive here is the *centrality* of it, and the specific reasoning behind it. Set out plainly, the argument runs:

1. **Death is certain, and the body is temporary.** This is not unique; most religions say it.
2. **Therefore fear of death is irrational** — you are afraid of something that is going to happen regardless.
3. **And fear of death is the machinery by which tyranny works.** Every oppressive power, in the end, rests on the threat of killing you. Take away the fear and you have taken away the lever.
4. **So a person who does not fear death cannot be ruled by force.** Overcoming that fear is therefore not only a spiritual attainment. It is a *political* capability.

Guru Gobind Singh's famous line — "*sava lakh se ek ladaun*," I will make one fight a hundred and twenty-five thousand — is not a boast about physical strength. It is a claim about arithmetic. One person who genuinely cannot be frightened is worth an enormous number of people who can be.

Why it is not abstract in Punjab

Theology alone does not produce a culture. What made this real was that the record backed it up, relentlessly, for over a century:

THE RECORD BEHIND THE DOCTRINE

When	What happened
1606	Guru Arjan executed at Lahore.
1675	Guru Tegh Bahadur beheaded at Delhi; three companions tortured to death in front of him.
1704	Ajit Singh (17) and Jujhar Singh (14) killed at Chamkaur. Zorawar Singh (9) and Fateh Singh (7) executed at Sirhind. Mata Gujri dies in custody.
1716	Banda Singh Bahadur tortured to death at Delhi with hundreds of his followers — Part 5.
1730s–40s	Bhai Mani Singh dismembered joint by joint. Bhai Taru Singh's scalp removed rather than cut his hair. A price placed on Sikh heads.
1746 and 1762	The <i>Chhota</i> and <i>Vadda Ghallughara</i> — the Lesser and Greater Massacres. Part 5.

Two of ten Gurus executed by the state. All four sons of the tenth killed, two of them small children. This is not a tradition of remembered grievance built on one incident. It is an unbroken run of documented state killing across five generations.

And then it was made into a daily practice

Here is the mechanism that turns history into culture, and it is the part I find most remarkable.

The **Ardas** — the formal Sikh prayer, recited at the end of every service, in every gurdwara, every day, everywhere in the world — contains an explicit remembrance of the martyrs. It names, in sequence, those who were cut apart limb by limb, who were scalped, who were broken on the wheel, who were sawn asunder, who gave their heads but not their faith.

And then it asks for the same courage.

This is not history being remembered once a year. It is history being rehearsed, out loud, daily, by millions of people, as a request.

That is how a datable series of seventeenth and eighteenth century events becomes a permanent feature of how a people understand themselves in 2026.

What it gives, and what it costs

Now the honest part, and I have tried to write both halves with the same force.

What it gives. An extraordinary resistance to intimidation. It is not a coincidence that a community which is roughly 1.7% of India's population produced a wildly disproportionate share of the freedom movement's executed and imprisoned, and of the Indian Army's gallantry decorations. Threatening a population raised on the Ardas with death is a strategy with a known and poor track record. Part 6 will show the British discovering this, and Part 10 will show the Indian state discovering it again.

What it costs. A culture that ranks dying for a cause as the highest human achievement is a culture in which **the person who gets to define the cause holds enormous power.**

The theology says: do not fear death. It does not, by itself, say: *verify that the man telling you this cause is worth dying for is telling you the truth about the cause.*

That gap is not a defect in what the Gurus built. They were addressing a specific tyranny with specific, documented, undeniable crimes — an emperor who had beheaded a Guru for defending other people's religion and executed two children for refusing conversion. In that situation the question "is this cause real?" answers itself.

The gap opens later, when the inheritance passes to people who face no such tyranny — or who are told they do, by someone with something to gain.

What the tradition itself says about limits

This is the part that is almost always left out when *shaheedi* is invoked, and it is the reason I do not accept that the tradition is simply open to any use.

The Zafarnama sets a test. The sword is righteous *when all other means have failed*. That is a condition, and it can be examined from outside by asking a factual question: had they?

The Rahit forbids attacking non-combatants. The code of conduct is explicit that the kirpan is for defence and for the defence of others, not for aggression.

And there is Bhai Kanhaiya. During the fighting at Anandpur, a Sikh named Kanhaiya was seen carrying water to wounded men on the battlefield — including wounded Mughal soldiers. He was reported to the Guru as a traitor.

Asked to explain himself, he said he did not see Mughals and Sikhs; he saw the Guru's face in all of them.

Guru Gobind Singh's response was to approve, and to hand him ointment as well, and tell him to treat their wounds too. That is the founding story of Sikh humanitarian service, and it is not a marginal anecdote — it is in the tradition's core narrative of its most desperate battle.

THE STANDARD I WILL APPLY IN PART 9

Anyone can invoke *shaheedi*. Anyone can invoke Miri-Piri. They are real, central and available.

But a person invoking them while ignoring the Zafarnama's last-resort condition, and ignoring the prohibition on attacking non-combatants, and ignoring Bhai Kanhaiya carrying water to enemy wounded, is quoting **half a tradition** — and specifically the half that authorises violence while discarding the half that restrains it.

That is the test I will use in Part 9, and I want it on the record here, established from seventeenth-century sources, before I have met the man I will be applying it to. I would rather set the standard before I know who it convicts.

CHAPTER NINE

Scorecard: what Part 4 proves

"Sikhism was founded as a militant religion."

FALSE — AND THE CHRONOLOGY IS THE ARGUMENT

For the first 137 years, from 1469 to 1606, Sikhism has no military dimension at all. Nanak personally witnessed Babur's invasion and responded with poetry, criticism of the local rulers, and a question addressed to God. Not a militia.

Arms enter in 1606, in the year the state tortured and killed the fifth Guru, and they enter as an explicit response to it. The state made that decision, not the Gurus.

"Sikhism is just a sect of Hinduism."

CONTESTED — AND ALMOST ALWAYS ASKED FOR POLITICAL REASONS

The strongest case that it is: it emerged from the Indian religious world and shares its vocabulary and cosmology; the scripture contains Hindu bhagats; Punjabi Hindu and Sikh families intermarried extensively and many Hindu families raised their eldest son as a Sikh; and Indian law itself, in Explanation II to Article 25 of the Constitution, groups Sikhs with Hindus for certain purposes.

The strongest case that it is not: a separate scripture, treated as a living Guru; a separate initiation; separate ceremonies for birth, marriage and death, established deliberately by Guru Amar Das in the 1500s; explicit rejection of caste, idol worship, and the authority of the Vedas; a separate script; and the Gurus' own repeated statements of distinctness.

My assessment: Sikhism emerged from the Indian religious world in roughly the way Buddhism did, and is theologically and institutionally distinct from Hinduism while being historically inseparable from its context. Both of those are true and neither cancels the other.

What I will add is this: in Indian public life this question is very rarely asked for theological reasons. It is asked to determine who is entitled to what. And Explanation II to Article 25 — a clause of the Indian Constitution that defines Sikhs, for the purpose of that article, as included within "Hindus" — is a long-standing and genuinely felt Sikh grievance that goes directly into Part 8. Whatever one thinks of the theology, a community objecting to being legally defined as part of another religion is not making an unreasonable complaint.

"Sikhs and Hindus are natural enemies."

FALSE — DECISIVELY, AND ON THE TRADITION'S OWN EVIDENCE

The ninth Guru was beheaded in Delhi, after watching three companions tortured to death, for defending the right of Kashmiri Brahmins to remain Hindu. He shared none of their theology. The Sikh scripture contains Hindu saints, including a Dalit. Punjabi Hindu and Sikh families were, for centuries, one social world.

Any ideology that positions Hindus as the definitional enemy of Sikhs must explain away the death of Sikhism's own ninth Guru. It cannot.

"Sikhs and Muslims are natural enemies."**ALSO FALSE**

The Sikh scripture contains the poetry of a Muslim Sufi. **Pir Budhu Shah**, a Muslim holy man, fought for Guru Gobind Singh and lost two sons doing it. **Nabi Khan and Ghani Khan**, two Muslim brothers, hid the Guru and carried him to safety at Machhiwara after Chamkaur at enormous personal risk. Mughal officials and Sufi figures interceded for the Gurus more than once.

The conflict was with the **Mughal state**, and the Sikh sources are notably careful about that distinction — which is remarkable, given that they were written by people whose Gurus and children were being killed at the time. Guru Gobind Singh's argument in the Zafarnama is not that Islam is false; it is that Aurangzeb betrayed his own oath on his own scripture.

"The Khalsa abolished caste."**TRUE IN PRINCIPLE. UNFINISHED IN PRACTICE — AND I AM NOT GOING TO PRETEND OTHERWISE**

Theologically it is unambiguous, and the institutional design was serious: langar, the Panj Piare drawn deliberately from four service castes and one high caste, the abolition of surnames in favour of Singh and Kaur, a scripture containing a Dalit saint's compositions.

In practice, caste persists in Punjab today. Some villages have separate gurdwaras for Dalit Sikhs. Marriage advertisements specify Jat Sikh. Mazhabi and Ramdasia Sikhs face real discrimination in land, marriage and social access. Punjab has one of the highest Scheduled Caste population shares of any Indian state, at roughly 32%, and one of the lowest rates of Dalit land ownership.

Both halves are true. The Gurus attempted the most direct assault on caste that any Indian tradition has attempted, and it is not finished. Saying so is not an attack on Sikhism; it is taking its own stated project seriously. I return to it with the data in Part 13.

"Where does *shaheedi* come from?"**ANSWERED**

Not from Punjabi character, blood or soil. From a specific theology — that fear of death is the mechanism of tyranny, so a person without that fear cannot be ruled — developed between 1606 and 1708; validated by an unbroken record of actual state executions across five generations, including two Gurus and four children; and then institutionalised into a daily prayer recited by millions.

It is datable, traceable and deliberate. Which means it can be understood — and, crucially, it means the tradition's own internal limits (the Zafarnama's last-resort test, the ban on attacking non-combatants, Bhai Kanhaiya's water) are as much a part of it as the courage is. Anyone who takes one half and discards the other is not carrying the tradition. They are using it.

Timeline of Part 4

1469 Guru Nanak born at Talwandi (Nankana Sahib), near Lahore.

1520–21	Babur invades Punjab. Nanak witnesses it and composes the <i>Babarvani</i> .
1539	Nanak dies at Kartarpur, having appointed Bhai Lehna — Guru Angad — over his own sons.
1539–1552	Guru Angad standardises the Gurmukhi script.
1552–1574	Guru Amar Das: langar made compulsory before audience, the Goindwal baoli, 22 manjis, opposition to sati and purdah, and separate Sikh ceremonies for birth, marriage and death.
1574–1581	Guru Ram Das founds Ramdaspur, which becomes Amritsar. Composes the Lavan.
1581–1606	Guru Arjan. Harmandir Sahib completed; Adi Granth compiled 1604; new towns and a revenue system.
30 May 1606	Guru Arjan executed at Lahore on Jahangir's orders.
1606	Guru Hargobind takes the two swords of Miri-Piri and founds the Akal Takht.
1620s–1630s	Gwalior imprisonment and release; four battles against Mughal forces — the first Sikh-Mughal wars.
1644–1661	Guru Har Rai. Disinherits Ram Rai for altering a line of scripture.
1661–1664	Guru Har Krishan, Guru at five, dies of smallpox at eight while tending the sick in Delhi.
1665	Guru Tegh Bahadur founds Anandpur.
1666	Gobind Rai born at Patna.
1669	Aurangzeb begins active persecution of non-Muslims.
1675	Kashmiri Pandits led by Kirpa Ram come to Anandpur. Guru Tegh Bahadur arrested in July.
11 Nov 1675	Guru Tegh Bahadur beheaded at Chandni Chowk, Delhi , defending the religious freedom of Hindus. (24 November in some reckonings.)
30 March 1699	The Khalsa founded at Anandpur. The Panj Piare. Khande di Pahul. The Guru asks the Five to initiate him.
Dec 1704	Anandpur evacuated under a broken oath. The Sarsa crossing.
22 Dec 1704	Chamkaur. Ajit Singh (17) and Jujhar Singh (14) killed. The Khalsa orders the Guru to leave; he obeys.
Dec 1704	Sirhind. Zorawar Singh (9) and Fateh Singh (7) executed for refusing conversion. Mata Gujri dies.
1705	The <i>Zafarnama</i> written to Aurangzeb. Battle of Muktsar; the Forty Liberated.
1707	Aurangzeb dies.
7 Oct 1708	Guru Gobind Singh dies at Nanded , assassinated. Ends the line of human Gurus and installs the Guru Granth Sahib . <i>Guru Maneyo Granth</i> .

What happens in Part 5

Part 5, *The Sikh Empire*, covers 1708 to 1849 — and it is the only period in five thousand years when Punjab was an independent sovereign state governed by Punjabis. It lasts fifty years.

It opens at the worst possible moment. Within two years of the tenth Guru's death, **Banda Singh Bahadur** raises a peasant army, takes Sirhind, executes Wazir Khan, and does something genuinely revolutionary: he abolishes the zamindari system and gives land to the tillers. He is captured in 1716 and tortured to death in Delhi with hundreds of his followers.

Then comes the worst period in Sikh history. A price on Sikh heads. The *Chhota Ghallughara* of 1746 and the *Vadda Ghallughara* of 1762, when Ahmad Shah Abdali's forces killed a very large share of the entire Sikh population in a single day. Bhai Mani Singh dismembered. Bhai Taru Singh scalped.

And out of that, the **misls** — twelve armed confederacies, reverting to exactly the frontier structure Part 3 described — and then **Ranjit Singh**, who takes Lahore in 1799 at nineteen and builds an empire running from the Khyber Pass to Tibet, with a Muslim majority population, Hindu and Muslim and European ministers, and no state religion.

Part 5 also asks the two questions that matter most for Part 12. Why did the empire collapse within ten years of Ranjit Singh's death? And what does the only working example of a Punjabi state actually tell us about whether another one could work?

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 4

Primary sources

- **Guru Granth Sahib** — including the compositions of Guru Nanak (the *Babarvani*, Rag Asa and Rag Tilang), and the works of the bhagats Kabir, Namdev, Ravidas and Sheikh Farid.
- **Jahangir**, *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri* — the emperor's own account of ordering Guru Arjan's death. Rogers and Beveridge translation. This is the key primary document for Chapter 3 and should be read in full rather than in fragments.
- **Guru Gobind Singh**, *Bachitar Natak* and *Zafarnama*, in the Dasam Granth. The Zafarnama is essential and is much more than its one famous couplet.
- Contemporary Jesuit correspondence from Lahore — a third-party European record of Guru Arjan's death, valuable precisely because it is neither Mughal nor Sikh.
- **Sainapati**, *Sri Gur Sobha* (early 18th century) — the earliest substantial Sikh account of Guru Gobind Singh's period.
- Later Sikh chronicles: *Gurbilas* literature, Bhai Santokh Singh's *Suraj Prakash*, Rattan Singh Bhangu's *Prachin Panth Prakash*. These are devotional and later; I have used them for tradition, and flagged them as such rather than as contemporary evidence.

Modern scholarship

- **J. S. Grewal**, *The Sikhs of the Punjab* (New Cambridge History of India) — the standard scholarly single-volume history.
- **W. H. McLeod**, *Guru Nanak and the Sikh Religion*, *The Evolution of the Sikh Community* and *Sikhism*. McLeod's source-critical approach is contested and in places resented within the Sikh community; he is nonetheless unavoidable, and reading him alongside his critics is the honest approach.
- **Harjot Oberoi**, *The Construction of Religious Boundaries* — on how Sikh identity hardened in the modern period. Also controversial, also useful.
- **Louis E. Fenech**, *Martyrdom in the Sikh Tradition* and *The Sikh Zafar-namah of Guru Gobind Singh* — the key modern study of *shaheedi* and the best English treatment of the Zafarnama.
- **Pashaura Singh**, *Life and Work of Guru Arjan* — the fullest treatment of 1606 and the competing readings of Jahangir's account.
- **Pashaura Singh and Louis Fenech (eds.)**, *The Oxford Handbook of Sikh Studies* — the best single reference for competing scholarly positions on almost everything in this part.
- **Khushwant Singh**, *A History of the Sikhs*, vols. 1–2 — readable, narrative, occasionally loose on detail but a good entry point.
- **Purnima Dhavan**, *When Sparrows Became Hawks* — on the making of Khalsa martial tradition, and excellent on the eighteenth-century transition into Part 5.

Reference sources used for dates and details

- SikhiWiki entries on the martyrdoms of Guru Arjan and Guru Tegh Bahadur, the Panj Piare, Miri-Piri and Nanded 1708; *The Sikh Encyclopedia* on Miri-Piri; Britannica on Guru Hargobind, Guru Tegh Bahadur and the Khalsa; Wikipedia on Guru Tegh Bahadur, Guru Gobind Singh, the Khalsa, Saka Sirhind, the Five Ks and the individual Sahibzade.
- Sikh Research Institute (sikhri.org) on Guru Arjan; the University of California Santa Barbara *Journal of Punjab Studies* paper on understanding the martyrdom of Guru Arjan.

A NOTE ON DATES IN THIS PART

Several dates here appear differently in different sources — Vaisakhi 1699 as 30 March or 13 April, Guru Tegh Bahadur's martyrdom as 11 or 24 November 1675. These are almost always **calendar-conversion differences** between the Bikrami, Nanakshahi and Gregorian systems, not disagreements about what happened. I have given both where they occur, so that you are not confused when you see the other figure elsewhere.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 4 —

Part 5: *The Sikh Empire*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART FIVE OF THIRTEEN

The Sikh Empire

1708 to 1849 — two massacres, twelve republics, one Maharaja, and the only fifty years Punjab ruled itself

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 5

This is the part I most wanted to write and least trusted myself to write.

Everything before this has been about Punjab being invaded, ruled, converted or crossed by somebody else. Part 5 is the exception. For fifty years, Punjab was a sovereign state governed by Punjabis, and it was genuinely magnificent — an empire that took Peshawar, reversed eight hundred years of one-way traffic through the Khyber, and was run by a one-eyed illiterate man from Gujranwala who never signed his own name.

Which is exactly the problem. Glory is the most seductive material a researcher can handle, and this is the one chapter of Punjabi history where the glory is real and does not need inflating. That makes it more dangerous, not less. It would be very easy to write forty admiring pages here and quietly skip the parts that do not fit.

So I have set myself two rules for this part.

First, the criticisms go in at full strength. Ranjit Singh dismantled the Sarbat Khalsa and the Gurmata — Punjab's own working system of collective decision-making — and replaced it with himself. Kashmiri accounts of Sikh rule are not warm. He conceded the Sutlej to the British by treaty in 1809 and never tested them. All of that is in Chapter 4, not buried in a footnote.

Second, Chapter 6 is an audit, not a tribute. Part 12 of this work asks whether an independent Punjab is feasible. The single most important piece of evidence for that question is the one time it actually existed. So I have gone through what Ranjit Singh's state required in order to function, line by line, and checked each item against what Indian Punjab has in 2026. The result is a table, and it is not a comfortable one for anybody — including for people who assume the answer is obviously no.

I have also put the strongest pro-independence counter-argument into that chapter in its own words, because if I only test the weak version I have proved nothing. Rule 3 applies here more than anywhere so far.

One last thing. Chapter 2 contains casualty figures for the two Ghallugharas that range from 5,000 to 50,000 for a single event. I have not picked the biggest number, and I have not picked the smallest. Both temptations were real.

— L.S.

INTRODUCTION

Fifty years out of five thousand

In Part 1 I made a claim and promised to prove it later: that Punjab has existed as an independent sovereign state for roughly fifty years out of five thousand. This is the part where I show my working.

Part 5 covers 141 years, from the death of Guru Gobind Singh in 1708 to the British annexation on 29 March 1849. It contains both the worst period in Sikh history and the only genuinely successful Punjabi state.

The sequence is almost unbelievable if you set it out plainly:

- **1708.** No living Guru. Punjab under Mughal rule. The Sikhs are a persecuted community with no state and no territory.
- **1710.** A former ascetic raises a peasant army, kills the governor of Sirhind, sets up a state, strikes coins, and abolishes landlordism.
- **1716.** He is dismembered alive in Delhi with seven hundred followers.
- **1716–1762.** A price is placed on Sikh heads. Two mass killings — the *Chhota* and *Vadda Ghallughara* — one of which may have destroyed a third of the entire Sikh population in two days.
- **1765.** Three years after that, the Sikhs take Lahore and strike their own coin.
- **1783.** Sikh forces occupy Delhi.
- **1799–1839.** Ranjit Singh builds an empire of roughly 520,000 square kilometres, from the Khyber Pass to Tibet, and the British spend forty years not fighting him.
- **1849.** Ten years after his death, it is all gone.

*From a price on your head to the throne of Lahore in fifty-five years.
Then from the throne of Lahore to nothing in ten. Both halves of that
need explaining, and the second half matters more.*

The exam question

Underneath the narrative, Part 5 is doing one specific job for later in this work.

Part 12 asks whether an independent Punjab is practical. Almost everyone who argues about that question argues from theory, emotion, or analogies to other countries. Almost nobody starts from the obvious place:

Punjab has actually been independent. Recently enough that we have detailed records. So what did it need in order to work?

That is a question with a real answer, and Chapter 6 answers it as an audit — a checklist of what Ranjit Singh's state required, tested against what Indian Punjab possesses today. I have tried to run it the way I would run due diligence on a business plan, because that is the only honest way to run it.

CHAPTER 1 Banda Singh Bahadur: the first Sikh state, and the first land reform in Indian history.

CHAPTER 2 The killing years: a price on your head, and two massacres.

CHAPTER 3 The misls: Punjab governs itself, and discovers its own failure mode.

CHAPTER 4 Ranjit Singh: the only Punjabi state, and what it was actually like.

CHAPTER 5 Ten years: how the strongest state in India destroyed itself.

CHAPTER 6 The audit: what the Sikh Empire proves about Khalistan.

CHAPTER 7 Scorecard: what Part 5 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

Banda Singh Bahadur

In 1710 a man who had spent most of his life as a wandering ascetic did two things nobody expected. He captured the city that had killed the Guru's children. And then he abolished landlordism — two hundred and forty years before independent India got round to it.

From Madho Das to Banda Singh

At Nanded in 1708, Guru Gobind Singh met a Bairagi ascetic named Madho Das, who kept a hermitage there. What passed between them is described in various ways, but the outcome is clear.

Madho Das became **Banda Singh Bahadur**. The Guru gave him five arrows, a small band of Sikhs, a drum and a banner, and a *hukamnama* — a written order to the Sikhs of Punjab to support him. He sent him north.

Within weeks of that meeting, the Guru was dead. Banda arrived in Punjab as the representative of a man who no longer existed, carrying letters and arrows.

The army nobody expected

He raised his force from the countryside, and this is the detail that shapes everything that follows: he recruited overwhelmingly from the **peasantry, including the lowest castes** — people who under Mughal law and Hindu custom alike had never been permitted to bear arms at all.

Give a man who has been told his whole life that he may not carry a weapon a weapon, and tell him the land he works could be his, and you have created something the state has no idea how to fight.

Chappar Chiri and Sirhind, May 1710

On **12 May 1710**, at **Chappar Chiri** near Sirhind, Banda's force met the army of **Wazir Khan** — the governor who six years earlier had ordered two children, aged nine and seven, bricked up for refusing to convert.

Wazir Khan was killed in the battle. Two days later Sirhind fell.

The state

What Banda did next is the part that qualifies this as a state rather than a rebellion. He established a capital at **Lohgarh** (Mukhlispur) in the Shivalik foothills, and he issued the three things that only a sovereign issues:

- **Coins**, struck not in his own name but in the names of Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh.
- **An official seal** for state documents.
- **A new calendar**, dated from the victory.

In the language of the eighteenth century, that is a declaration of independence.

The land reform

And then he did the thing almost nobody knows about, which I think is the most remarkable act of his life.

He abolished the zamindari system in the territory he controlled, and gave ownership of the land to the people who actually farmed it.

Sit with the date. This is **1710**. India would not legislate comparable land reform until after 1947. The French Revolution was seventy-nine years away. The Russian revolutionaries who made "land to the tiller" a slogan were two centuries in the future.

A peasant in Punjab in 1710, who had paid a share of his crop to a landlord his whole life as his father had, was told the field was his.

THE PART THAT GETS LEFT OUT

This is also why Banda fell, and it is a class story as much as a religious one.

The land reform made him the hero of the Punjabi peasantry. It also made him the mortal enemy of the Punjabi landholding elite — and that elite was **Muslim, Hindu and Sikh**. Established Sikh families with land did not want their land redistributed either.

When the Mughal state moved against Banda in force, a significant section of Punjab's propertied classes, across all three religions, was content to see him go. Devotional accounts of this period tend to describe a united Sikh community crushed by a Mughal empire. The reality includes Sikhs who had property and did not like what he was doing with it.

The Muslim question, handled properly

Banda has a reputation for anti-Muslim violence, particularly over what happened at Sirhind, and I am not going to skip it.

What the hostile sources say: Persian chronicles of the period describe severe destruction at Sirhind and considerable killing. Some later accounts describe the city as devastated wholesale.

What complicates it: Banda had Muslim followers in his own force — figures of around five thousand appear in some accounts — and is recorded as permitting them to pray and appointing Muslims to positions. Some modern Sikh historians have argued that the scale of

destruction at Sirhind was exaggerated by chroniclers writing for a Mughal audience that wanted the rebels portrayed as monsters.

Where I land: Sirhind was sacked and there was real killing, including of civilians; that is not seriously deniable. Whether it reached the scale the Persian sources claim is contested, and those sources had obvious motives. What can be said with confidence is that this was a campaign of vengeance against a specific city and a specific governor, conducted by a force that included Muslims, rather than a war of religious extermination. The distinction is real, and it does not make the killing acceptable.

Gurdas Nangal and Delhi

The empire eventually concentrated against him. In 1715 Banda was besieged at **Gurdas Nangal** for roughly eight months. The defenders ate their horses, then bark and leaves. He was captured in December 1715.

He and around seven hundred prisoners were taken to Delhi and paraded through the city in June 1716, with severed heads carried on poles alongside them.

The prisoners were executed at a rate of roughly a hundred a day over several days. Contemporary European observers in Delhi recorded that not one accepted the offer of life in exchange for conversion.

Banda was kept until last. He was offered his life if he converted. He refused. His four-year-old son, Ajai Singh, was killed in front of him — the accounts say his heart was cut out and thrust into his father's mouth. Banda's eyes were then gouged out, his limbs severed one by one, and his flesh torn with red-hot pincers.

What the six years proved

Banda's state lasted about six years and then was extinguished completely.

But it had established two facts that could not be un-established. The first: **a Sikh state was possible**. It had coins, a seal, a capital and a policy. It had beaten a Mughal army in the field.

The second: **what it would cost**.

CHAPTER TWO

The killing years

Between 1716 and 1762 the Sikh community came closer to being destroyed than at any point in its history — twice. What happened immediately afterwards is the part that requires explanation.

A price on your head

After Banda, the Mughal administration in Punjab — particularly under **Zakariya Khan**, governor of Lahore from 1726 to 1745 — set out to eliminate the Sikhs as a community rather than merely defeat them.

A formal scale of rewards was established: payment for information about a Sikh's whereabouts, a larger payment for a Sikh brought in alive, a larger one still for a Sikh's head.

The Sikhs left the settled districts. They went into the **Lakhi Jungle** in the south-west, into the Shivalik foothills, and across the Sutlej into the deserts of Rajasthan. Small mobile bands, living off the country, striking and vanishing.

Two names from this period are recited in the Ardas to this day:

- **Bhai Mani Singh** (1738), the custodian of the Harmandir Sahib, executed by being dismembered joint by joint for failing to pay a tax imposed on a Sikh gathering. Tradition records that when the executioner began at the wrist, he pointed out that the order specified *joint by joint*, and that the fingers came first.
- **Bhai Taru Singh** (1745), a young farmer arrested for feeding Sikhs. Offered his life if he cut his hair. His scalp was removed instead.

Chhota Ghallughara, 1746 — the Lesser Massacre

In 1746, a force under **Yahya Khan**, governor of Lahore, and **Diwan Lakhpat Rai** trapped a large body of Sikhs in the marshes near **Kahnuwan**, in Gurdaspur district.

Estimates: around **7,000 Sikhs killed**, with a further **3,000 captured and subsequently executed** at Lahore.

The Punjabi word used for it is *Ghallughara* — massacre, or holocaust. It was called the *Chhota*, the lesser, only because of what happened sixteen years later.

Vadda Ghallughara, 5–6 February 1762 — the Greater Massacre

Ahmad Shah Abdali — also called Ahmad Shah Durrani — invaded India nine times between 1748 and 1767. In February 1762 he came specifically for the Sikhs.

He caught the main Sikh body near **Kup–Rohira**, in today's Sangrur district. Critically, this was not an army on campaign. It was a moving community: fighters travelling together with their families — women, children, the elderly — trying to reach safety in the south.

The Sikh fighters formed a defensive cordon around the non-combatants and moved while fighting, trying to shield the column. The killing ran from Kup–Rohira through to Gehal, across a single day and into the next.

THE CASUALTY FIGURE, HONESTLY

The estimates for Sikhs killed on 5–6 February 1762 range from **5,000 to 50,000**. The most commonly cited figure is around **30,000**.

Some historians have suggested this represented as much as a third of the entire Sikh population at the time. That estimate depends on a population figure we do not reliably have, so I would treat it as an indication of scale rather than a measurement.

I am not going to pick one number. What is not in dispute is that this was a mass killing of a civilian population in the tens of thousands, in one to two days, and that it is remembered as the worst day in Sikh history before 1947.

Abdali then went to Amritsar. He blew up the Harmandir Sahib with gunpowder and had the sacred pool filled with the carcasses of slaughtered cattle.

And then the part that needs explaining

Here is what happened next, and it is the reason this chapter exists.

By **October 1762** — eight months later — the Sikhs fought Abdali again at Amritsar on Diwali.

By **1764** they had sacked Sirhind again and killed its governor.

By **1765** they had taken **Lahore**, the capital of Punjab, and struck their own coin in the name of the Gurus.

Tens of thousands killed in two days, the holiest site in the religion blown up, the pool filled with dead cattle — and three years later they held the capital. That is not a miracle. It has mechanisms, and they are worth understanding.

Five reasons it worked

1. There was nothing to capture. The Sikhs at this point had no fixed capital, no treasury in one place, no standing army that could be destroyed in a single set-piece battle. They were

small mobile cavalry bands — *jathas* — that dispersed under pressure and reassembled afterwards. You cannot behead an organisation with no head.

2. They funded themselves off the invader. Abdali's great weakness was that he had to go home, and going home meant moving enormous baggage trains of loot and captives back through Punjab. Sikh cavalry specialised in hitting those columns. Horses, weapons and treasure flowed from the invasion into the resistance.

3. Rakhi. This is the institutional innovation and it is underrated. The Sikhs offered villages *rakhi* — protection — in exchange for a share of the harvest, typically around one-fifth. In return, the village was defended against raiders, including Afghan ones.

Understand what that actually is. A body that provides security over a defined territory and collects a regular proportional levy from it is not a bandit gang. It is a government. *Rakhi* converted the Sikhs from fugitives into a de facto administration with tax revenue, years before they held a single city.

4. The theology of Part 4, operating exactly as designed. A bounty system works by making people afraid. It does not work well on a community that recites a daily prayer listing its own dismembered and scalped, and asks for the same courage. Chapter 8 of Part 4 was not an abstraction; this is the field test.

5. Abdali kept leaving. He raided nine times and never once stayed to govern. The Sikhs were permanently there. In a contest between a visitor and a resident, the resident eventually wins.

CHAPTER THREE

The misls

Between 1765 and 1799, Punjab governed itself through twelve armed republics and a biannual general assembly. It worked — and then it stopped working, in a way that tells you a great deal about Punjab.

The structure

At a **Sarbat Khalsa** — a general assembly of the whole Panth — held at Amritsar in **1748**, a *Gurmata* was passed reorganising the scattered *jathas* into **twelve misls**, together forming the **Dal Khalsa**, under the leadership first of Nawab Kapur Singh and then of Jassa Singh Ahluwalia.

The word *misl* comes from Persian and Arabic usage meaning "equal," or a file or record. Both senses are apt.

HOW THE MISL SYSTEM WORKED

Element	What it meant in practice
The misl	A confederacy with its own territory, its own chief (<i>misl</i> <i>dar</i>) and its own cavalry. Conquered territory was divided by agreement among the participants.
Membership by choice	A horseman was not bound to a misl by birth or law. If a sardar led badly or shared unfairly, men left and joined another. Leadership rested on consent and performance.
The Sarbat Khalsa	The whole Panth assembled at Amritsar twice a year — Vaisakhi and Diwali — in the presence of the Guru Granth Sahib.
The Gurmata	A resolution passed by that assembly. It bound all the misls: war, peace, alliances, disputes between chiefs.

The twelve were: Ahluwalia, Bhangi, Kanhaiya, Ramgarhia, Sukerchakia, Nakai, Dallewalia, Nishanwalia, Karorsinghia, Shaheedan (the Nihangs), Singhpuria, and the Phulkian group — the last of which produced the states of Patiala, Nabha and Jind, and which for that reason survives in the political geography of Indian Punjab today.

PUT SIMPLY

Punjab between 1765 and the 1790s was run by twelve armed groups who each held their own territory, chose their own leaders, and met twice a year at Amritsar to make joint decisions in front of the scripture. It was a confederal republic with a functioning general assembly, in the eighteenth century, and it emerged spontaneously out of a persecuted guerrilla movement.

1783: the Sikhs in Delhi

In 1783 a Sikh force under **Baghel Singh** of the Karorsinghia misl entered Delhi and occupied parts of the city, including the Red Fort area.

The settlement negotiated with the Mughal emperor gave Baghel Singh permission to identify and build gurdwaras at the sites in Delhi associated with the Gurus. That is how **Sis Ganj** — where Guru Tegh Bahadur was beheaded — **Rakab Ganj** and **Bangla Sahib** came to be built.

In 1675 the Mughal state beheaded the ninth Guru in Chandni Chowk. In 1783 his people rode into Delhi and were handed the spot to build on. It took a hundred and eight years.

The honest assessment

What the misl period got right: Punjab was governed by Punjabis for the first time in seven centuries. The Afghan invasions stopped — Abdali's successors could not hold anything. Agriculture recovered. And there was a genuine, functioning mechanism for collective decision-making that had real authority over powerful armed men.

What went wrong: the misls fought each other. Constantly. The Kanhaiya against the Sukerchakia. The Bhangi against almost everyone. Territory changed hands between Sikh chiefs as often as it was taken from outsiders.

And as individual misldars grew rich and their positions became hereditary, the authority of the Sarbat Khalsa declined. By the 1790s the assembly had largely stopped functioning as a binding institution, and Punjab was a patchwork of feuding principalities.

PUNJAB'S FAILURE MODE, IDENTIFIED

The misl period demonstrates two things simultaneously, and both matter for Part 12.

Punjabis can govern Punjab. Not in theory — they did it, effectively, for a generation, with a working representative mechanism.

And the specific way it fails is fragmentation. Under external threat, the misls cooperated and the Sarbat Khalsa had teeth. When the external threat receded, they turned on each other and the assembly withered.

This is the same pattern as Part 2's Ambhi and Porus, and it recurs in Part 6 and Part 10. Punjabi political cohesion has historically been a function of pressure from outside. Remove the pressure and it dissolves. Anyone designing a future Punjabi polity has to solve that problem, and I have never seen a Khalistan proposal that even acknowledges it exists.

CHAPTER FOUR

Ranjit Singh

A one-eyed, illiterate teenager from Gujranwala took Lahore in 1799 and built the last independent state in India. He also, in the process, quietly dismantled the thing that had made Punjab governable.

The man

Born 1780 at Gujranwala, into the **Sukerchakia** misl — one of the smaller ones. Smallpox in childhood cost him an eye and scarred his face. He never learned to read or write, and never pretended otherwise.

In **1799**, aged nineteen, he took **Lahore**. And the manner of it is worth noting: he was effectively invited. The city's leading residents, including Muslim notables, had had enough of the Bhangi misldars who held it and appealed to him to come. He entered without a serious fight.

In 1801, on Vaisakhi, he was proclaimed **Maharaja**.

The coins, and what they say

Here is a detail I find genuinely striking. Ranjit Singh did not put his own name or face on his currency.

The coins of his empire — the **Nanakshahi rupee** — were struck in the names of **Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh**. He called his government the **Sarkar Khalsaji** — the government of the Khalsa — and described himself as its servant.

Whether that was sincere humility, shrewd politics, or both, it is a remarkable thing for an absolute monarch to do, and it tells you where legitimacy was understood to reside.

The empire

THE SIKH EMPIRE AT ITS HEIGHT

Dimension	Extent
West	The Khyber Pass and Peshawar (taken 1834)
East	The Sutlej — fixed by treaty with the British in 1809
North	Kashmir (1819) and Ladakh
South	Multan (1818), to the edge of Sindh
Area	Roughly 520,000 square kilometres

One line in that table deserves its own paragraph.

Ranjit Singh is the last Indian ruler to conquer and hold Afghan territory. For eight hundred years — Part 2 and Part 3 of this work — the traffic through the Khyber Pass ran one way. Ghazni, Ghor, the Mongols, Timur, Babur, Nadir Shah, Abdali. All of them came down through those passes into Punjab.

Ranjit Singh reversed it. Peshawar under Punjabi administration, and a Punjabi governor at the mouth of the Khyber. Whatever else is argued about this period, that fact stands alone in the subcontinent's history.

The army

He built it deliberately and expensively. The **Fauj-i-Khas** was drilled to European standards by officers he recruited from Napoleon's disbanded armies:

- **Jean-Baptiste Ventura** and **Jean-François Allard**, both former Napoleonic officers, who arrived in 1822 and trained the infantry and cavalry.
- **Claude Auguste Court**, who reorganised the artillery.
- **Paolo Avitabile**, an Italian, who governed Peshawar with a severity that is still remembered there.

The result was widely regarded as the most formidable indigenous army in India. The British, who fought everyone else in the subcontinent during those decades, did not fight Ranjit Singh. For forty years they signed treaties with him instead. That is the clearest testimony available.

Who actually ran the Sikh Empire

This section contains what I regard as the single most useful set of facts in Part 5, and I want to lay it out carefully because it cuts in more than one direction.

The population of the Sikh Empire was overwhelmingly Muslim. Once Multan, Kashmir, Peshawar and western Punjab were absorbed, Muslims formed a large majority — most estimates put them in the region of 70 to 80 per cent. Sikhs were a minority in their own empire, probably around a tenth of the population. Hindus were a substantial share.

Now look at the government:

THE LAHORE DARBAR

Office	Held by	Community
Prime Minister	Raja Dhian Singh	Dogra Hindu
Finance Minister	Diwan Dina Nath	Brahmin
Foreign Minister	Fakir Azizuddin	Muslim
Governor of Lahore	Fakir Nur-ud-Din	Muslim (Azizuddin's brother)
Commandant, Gobindgarh fort	Fakir Imam-ud-Din	Muslim (Azizuddin's brother)
Senior artillery commanders	incl. Mian Ghausia	Muslim
Army training and divisional command	Ventura, Allard, Court, Avitabile	European Christians

And the policy:

- **No state religion.** The Sikh Empire never declared one.
- **Jizya abolished.** The tax on non-Muslims was gone; there was no equivalent tax imposed on non-Sikhs.
- **Endowments to all.** He funded gurdwaras, and also Hindu temples and Muslim shrines. The Badshahi Mosque in Lahore, which had been used as a military magazine, was eventually restored to religious use.
- **Cow slaughter was banned** — a genuine restriction on the Muslim majority, and it belongs in an honest account.
- **He never imposed the death penalty.** This is widely reported across sources and, if accurate, is extraordinary for any nineteenth-century sovereign anywhere in the world.

He also had the Harmandir Sahib rebuilt in marble and covered in gold leaf, which is why the world calls it the Golden Temple. That building's appearance is his doing.

WHY THIS TABLE MATTERS TWICE OVER

First, against those who say a Sikh-majority state would inevitably persecute minorities: the only Sikh state that has ever existed was ruled over a Muslim majority, with a Hindu prime minister and a Muslim foreign minister, and it abolished the discriminatory tax rather than inventing a new one. That is not a theoretical rebuttal. It is the actual record.

Second, against the modern Khalistan movement: the rhetoric of that movement — which Part 11 will examine in its own words — is frequently far more sectarian than Ranjit Singh ever was. A movement that invokes the Sikh Empire as its precedent while treating Hindus as an enemy population is invoking a state whose finance minister was a Brahmin and whose foreign minister was a Muslim.

The precedent does not support the project. It embarrasses it.

The criticisms, at full strength

Now the other side, because Rule 3 applies to people I admire as much as to anyone else.

He killed Punjab's own political institutions. This is the most serious charge and I think it is correct. The Sarbat Khalsa and the Gurmata — the assembly and the binding collective resolution described in Chapter 3 — did not survive him as functioning bodies. He replaced a confederal republic with a personal autocracy. It worked brilliantly, because he was brilliant. It left nothing behind that could function without him. Chapter 5 is the invoice for that decision.

Kashmir. Kashmiri accounts of Sikh rule are not warm. Taxation was heavy, the shawl industry was squeezed, and a severe famine in the 1830s was badly handled. The empire's periphery was governed as conquered revenue territory, and it felt like it.

Avitabile's Peshawar. The Italian governor's methods — public hangings in numbers, bodies left displayed — are remembered locally as a byword for terror.

The Sutlej line. In the **Treaty of Amritsar, 1809**, he accepted the Sutlej as his eastern boundary, effectively conceding the cis-Sutlej states — Patiala, Nabha, Jind — to British protection. He never fought the British and never tested them.

WAS THE SUTLEJ TREATY WISDOM OR THE FATAL ERROR?

The case that it was wisdom: in 1809 the East India Company had already destroyed Tipu Sultan and broken the Marathas. Ranjit Singh had a realistic assessment of British power, and he used the forty years of peace he bought to take Multan, Kashmir and Peshawar instead. He died in his bed, sovereign, at the head of an intact empire. Almost no other Indian ruler of that era managed it.

The case that it was the fatal error: he permanently conceded eastern Punjab, gave the British a secure forward base on the Sutlej, and allowed them to consolidate the whole of the rest of India at his back. When the confrontation came in 1845 there was no possible ally left anywhere in the subcontinent, because the British had already absorbed them all. The one moment when a combination against the Company was conceivable passed while he was taking Peshawar.

I lean toward the first reading, but the second is serious and I do not think it can be dismissed.

CHAPTER FIVE

Ten years

Ranjit Singh died on 27 June 1839 in possession of the strongest state in India. By March 1849 it did not exist. Understanding how is more useful than admiring how it was built.

The succession, in four years

THE COLLAPSE OF THE LAHORE DARBAR

Date	What happened
June 1839	Ranjit Singh dies. Kharak Singh , his son, succeeds.
1840	Kharak Singh is deposed and dies — widely believed to have been slowly poisoned.
Nov 1840	Nau Nihal Singh , his son, is killed the same day, when a gateway at Lahore Fort collapses on him as he returns from his father's cremation. Very widely suspected to have been murder.
1841	Sher Singh takes the throne after a brief armed struggle with Chand Kaur, who is later killed.
Sept 1843	Sher Singh is assassinated along with his son. The prime minister Dhian Singh is assassinated the same day.
1843	Duleep Singh , aged five, becomes Maharaja, with his mother Rani Jindan as regent.

Four rulers in four years, and all but one violently removed.

Why it collapsed — five reasons

1. There was no institution. This is the central one. Ranjit Singh had concentrated every function of the state in himself: he was the final authority on appointments, revenue, war, justice and diplomacy. There was no council with independent standing, no law of succession, and no functioning Sarbat Khalsa to arbitrate. When he died, the state had no skeleton — only muscle.

2. An enormous army with no master. The Khalsa Army was around a hundred thousand strong, professional, well paid and European-trained. Suddenly it had no commander whose authority it recognised. It organised itself into regimental committees — *panchayats* — and became a political actor in its own right, effectively deciding who sat on the throne and demanding pay increases from whoever did. An army that chooses the government is a phase most collapsing states pass through.

3. Factions. The Dogra brothers against the Sikh sardars, both against the army panchayats, everyone against Rani Jindan. The court became a place where ministers were murdered as a routine political method.

4. A child on the throne.

5. The British were next door and had finished everything else.

The First Anglo-Sikh War, 1845–46

The Khalsa crossed the Sutlej on **11 December 1845**.

Four major battles followed: **Mudki**, **Ferozeshah**, **Aliwal** and **Sobraon**.

The fighting was extremely hard. At **Ferozeshah** in December 1845 the British came close to catastrophe; the Governor-General, Hardinge, was present and reportedly made arrangements to destroy state papers in case of defeat. British accounts of these battles are consistently, almost uncomfortably, admiring of the Sikh infantry and artillery.

And the reason they lost

The Wazir, **Lal Singh**, and the commander-in-chief, **Tej Singh**, were in secret communication with the British throughout the war.

This is not Punjabi folklore. It is documented in the British records. Both men were in contact with **Captain Peter Nicholson**, a British officer at Ferozepur, sending information and receiving instructions.

The consequences showed on the field. Reserves were withheld at moments when they would have been decisive. Withdrawals were ordered from positions that were winning. At **Sobraon**, the final battle, Tej Singh left the field early, crossed the bridge of boats over the Sutlej, and the bridge was destroyed behind him — trapping his own army on the wrong bank with the river at its back.

The Khalsa Army was not beaten in the field. It was sold by its own commanders, and the receipts are in the British archives.

I want to be careful here, because "we were betrayed" is a story defeated peoples tell themselves everywhere and it is usually a comfort rather than an analysis. In this case the documentation is unusually good, and it is the *victors'* documentation, which is the kind that counts. The soldiers fought. The generals did not.

The treaties, and the sale of Kashmir

The Treaty of Lahore, March 1846: a heavy indemnity, the cession of the Jalandhar Doab, and a drastic reduction of the Khalsa Army.

The Treaty of Amritsar, March 1846: the Lahore Darbar could not pay the indemnity. So **Kashmir was sold** — transferred to **Gulab Singh Dogra** for seventy-five lakh rupees.

WHERE THE KASHMIR DISPUTE BEGINS

Kashmir became a Dogra princely state in 1846 because the British needed cash and Gulab Singh had it. That transaction created the state of Jammu and Kashmir under a Hindu Dogra dynasty ruling a Muslim-majority population — the exact configuration that would produce the accession crisis in 1947 and the dispute that continues today.

The single most intractable problem in South Asian politics has its origin in a Punjabi indemnity payment.

The Second Anglo-Sikh War, 1848–49

It began in April 1848 with the revolt of **Mulraj**, the governor of Multan, and the killing of two British officers. It spread until much of the Sikh army had joined what became a general rising.

Chillianwala, January 1849, was one of the bloodiest actions the British fought in India. British casualties were around 2,300, several regiments lost their colours, and the result was at best a draw. In Britain it was received as a disaster and there were calls for the commander's removal.

Gujrat, February 1849, was decisive — won largely by overwhelming British artillery.

The Khalsa surrendered at Rawalpindi. **Annexation was announced on 29 March 1849.**

Duleep Singh, aged ten, was deposed and pensioned. The **Koh-i-Noor** was taken and sent to Queen Victoria. Duleep Singh was converted to Christianity, taken to England, became a favourite at court, later attempted to return to India and reclaim his throne, was stopped at Aden, and died in a Paris hotel in 1893.

Of the surrender itself, one line survives. As the Khalsa soldiers laid down their weapons, a veteran is recorded as saying:

"Aaj Ranjit Singh mar gaya."

Today, Ranjit Singh has died.

CHAPTER SIX

The audit

Punjab has been independent. We have the records. So instead of arguing about whether it could be again, let us establish what it actually took the first time, and check the list.

The method

I am going to treat the Sikh Empire the way I would treat a company that once worked and is now proposed to be restarted. What were the inputs that made it function? Are those inputs available now?

This is not a rhetorical exercise and I am not stacking it. Where Indian Punjab today has something, I will say so.

WHAT THE SIKH EMPIRE REQUIRED, VERSUS WHAT INDIAN PUNJAB HAS IN 2026

Requirement	Ranjit Singh's state	Indian Punjab today
All five rivers, from source to plain	Yes. Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej all inside the empire, with Kashmir and the hill country holding the headwaters.	No. Three rivers allocated to Pakistan by the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty. Sources lie in Himachal, Jammu & Kashmir and Tibet — none of them in Punjab.
A great capital city	Lahore — a capital of Punjab for eight hundred years, with its own treasury, court and arsenal.	No. Lahore is in Pakistan. Chandigarh is shared with Haryana and administered by the Centre as a Union Territory.
Revenue provinces beyond the core	Multan, Kashmir, Peshawar, Ladakh, Hazara.	None.
Strategic depth	About 520,000 sq km — room to trade space for time.	50,362 sq km, roughly one-tenth, with no defensible terrain anywhere in it (Part 1, Chapter 6).
A power vacuum in Delhi	Yes, decisively. The Mughals were a ruin; the Marathas had been broken at Panipat in 1761. There was no central Indian power at all.	No. A nuclear-armed state with one of the largest standing armies in the world.
Weak or distracted neighbours	Afghanistan in dynastic chaos after Abdali; the British still consolidating in the east and unwilling to fight him.	No. Pakistan on one side, India on the other three, both nuclear-armed and both with a direct interest in the outcome.
Trade routes and an export economy	Multan and Peshawar sat on the Central Asian trade. Kashmir shawls were a luxury export. Horse trading was significant.	Landlocked with no port and no international frontier that is open for trade. The Wagah crossing handles negligible volume.
An army the neighbours respect	The Fauj-i-Khas, around 100,000 men, European-trained, feared by the East India Company for forty years.	No independent military. Punjabis serve in the Indian armed forces, which is a different thing entirely.
Population that supports the project	Not really — this was a conquest state ruling a Muslim majority that had no say. Ranjit Singh managed it by not being sectarian, but consent was never tested.	Indian Punjab is roughly 58% Sikh and 39% Hindu. No secession has majority support in any credible survey. This is examined properly in Part 12.
One exceptional leader	Yes — and it is worth noting how much of the whole thing rested on that single variable.	Cannot be planned for, and Chapter 5 shows what happens when the variable is removed.

The finding that ought to trouble everybody

Look at the last row again, and then at Chapter 5.

Even the *successful* version of an independent Punjab had a fatal structural defect. It was held together by one man's ability, because he had dismantled the collective institutions that might have outlasted him. It survived forty years while he lived and disintegrated in ten once he did not.

The only period of Punjabi sovereignty in five thousand years lasted fifty years, and it could not survive a single funeral.

That is not an argument that Punjabis cannot govern — the misl period in Chapter 3 shows they can. It is an argument that the specific model everyone reaches for as the precedent was, on its own record, structurally fragile in exactly the way Punjab has historically been fragile: brilliant under a unifying figure or an external threat, and prone to fragmentation without one.

The counter-argument, at full strength

I promised in the Author's Note that I would state the other side properly, so here it is, made as well as I can make it.

THE CASE A SERIOUS KHALISTAN ADVOCATE WOULD MAKE AGAINST THIS CHAPTER

"This audit is rigged, because it asks whether a modern state could replicate a nineteenth-century conquest empire. That is not what statehood requires today and you know it.

The Sikh Empire did not fail because Punjabis cannot govern. It failed because of a dynastic succession crisis and a colonial power that had already absorbed the entire subcontinent. Neither condition applies now.

Modern states do not need to hold Peshawar. They need institutions, trade agreements, currency arrangements and international recognition. Look at the actual examples. Singapore has no natural resources whatsoever and is one of the richest countries on earth. Switzerland is landlocked, mountainous and surrounded by larger powers, and has been stable for centuries. Israel was created surrounded by hostile states with no strategic depth and survives. Slovakia, Slovenia, the Baltic states — all left larger unions within living memory and function perfectly well.

Your table measures Punjab against Ranjit Singh. Measure it against Slovakia and the answer changes."

My answer, and where I am deferring it

That is a serious argument and it deserves a serious response rather than a dismissal. It is right that I should not measure a hypothetical modern state against a nineteenth-century conquest empire, and Chapter 6 alone does not settle the question.

But I will note one thing here and hold the rest for Part 12.

Every example in that list has a **specific compensating asset**, and the asset is usually the whole explanation. Singapore has the world's busiest transshipment port sitting on the Strait of Malacca — its entire economy is that location. Switzerland is landlocked but surrounded by friendly, wealthy, integrated European states, with five centuries of accumulated institutions and capital and a banking system that everyone needs. Israel has the largest sustained military and economic aid relationship in modern history. Slovakia and the Baltics joined the European Union and NATO, which means they exchanged one union for a larger and richer one rather than becoming genuinely independent actors.

So the honest form of the question is not "can small states succeed?" — obviously they can. It is: what is Punjab's compensating asset?

That is the question Part 12 will answer, with numbers rather than adjectives: water rights, procurement dependence, fiscal transfers, trade access, and what happens to a landlocked territory whose only two possible transit neighbours are the two states it would have just separated from.

I am not going to pre-judge it here. I have put the counter-argument in its own words, and I have told you where I will meet it.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Scorecard: what Part 5 proves

"Punjab has never been an independent country."

FALSE

Banda Singh Bahadur's state, 1710–1716, issued coins, a seal and a calendar. The misls governed Punjab as a self-ruling confederacy from roughly 1765. The Sikh Empire, 1799–1849, was a fully recognised sovereign state with which the British signed treaties as equals.

My Part 1 estimate of "roughly fifty years" refers to the unified empire specifically. Counting the misl period as de facto self-rule, the figure is closer to eighty-five. Either way it is a small fraction of five thousand years — but it is not zero, and anyone who claims it is zero is wrong.

"The Sikh Empire was a Sikh theocracy that would persecute minorities."

FALSE — AND THIS IS THE STRONGEST EVIDENCE IN THE BOOK ON THE POINT

The only Sikh state that has ever existed governed a population that was roughly 70–80% Muslim. Its prime minister was a Dogra Hindu, its finance minister a Brahmin, and its foreign minister a Muslim whose two brothers governed Lahore and commanded Gobindgarh fort. It had no state religion, abolished jizya rather than replacing it with an equivalent, endowed temples and mosques alongside gurdwaras, and by most accounts never once imposed the death penalty.

Note that this cuts both ways, and the second direction is the more important one. A modern movement that invokes the Sikh Empire as its precedent while treating Hindus as an enemy population is invoking a state considerably less sectarian than itself. The precedent does not support that project — it embarrasses it. I will return to this in Part 11.

"The Sikhs were beaten fairly by a better army in 1846."

CONTESTED — AND THE VICTORS' OWN RECORDS ARE THE PROBLEM

The Khalsa infantry and artillery performed extremely well; British accounts say so repeatedly, and Ferozeshah and Chillianwala were near-disasters for the British.

Lal Singh and Tej Singh were in documented secret communication with Captain Peter Nicholson of the East India Company during the First Anglo-Sikh War. Reserves were withheld and withdrawals ordered at decisive moments; at Sobraon the commander-in-chief left the field and the bridge behind his own army was destroyed.

I am cautious about betrayal narratives in general — defeated peoples reach for them everywhere. This one is unusual in that the evidence is in British records rather than Punjabi memory, which is the kind of evidence that counts.

"Punjab is strongest when it is united."**TRUE, AND ALMOST NEVER ACHIEVED**

The misls fought each other continuously. The Sarbat Khalsa lost its authority as chiefs became hereditary. Ranjit Singh unified Punjab by conquering other Sikhs, then abolished the collective institutions that had unified them before him. His own court then murdered four rulers in four years, and his commanders sold the war.

The recurring pattern, first seen with Ambhi and Porus in 326 BCE: **Punjabi cohesion is a function of external pressure.** It appears under threat and dissolves when the threat lifts. Any serious proposal for a Punjabi polity has to solve that, and I have not yet found one that acknowledges the problem exists.

"Sikhs and Muslims were historic enemies."**TOO SIMPLE TO BE USEFUL**

Abdali destroyed the Harmandir Sahib and killed Sikhs in tens of thousands. That is real and it is remembered.

And: Ranjit Singh was invited into Lahore partly by its Muslim notables; his foreign minister and two provincial governors were Muslim brothers; his empire's population was overwhelmingly Muslim; and he abolished jizya. Banda Singh Bahadur had Muslim troops.

The conflicts were with the Mughal state, and then with Abdali's Durrani state. Treating those as "Islam versus Sikhism" requires ignoring who was in the Sikh government and who was in the Sikh army.

"The Sikh Empire proves Khalistan would work."**NOT AS STATED — AND THE AUDIT IS IN CHAPTER 6**

The Sikh Empire required all five rivers from source to plain, Lahore, Multan, Kashmir and Peshawar, half a million square kilometres, a total power vacuum in Delhi, weak neighbours on every side, an army of a hundred thousand, and one exceptional leader. Indian Punjab in 2026 has none of these.

That is not a knockout blow, because modern statehood does not require a conquest empire, and I have set out the strongest counter-argument in Chapter 6 in its own words. The honest position at the end of Part 5 is this: **the historical precedent shows an independent Punjab is possible under a specific set of conditions, and not one of those conditions currently exists.** Whether some *different* set of modern conditions could substitute is a real question, and it gets a full audit with numbers in Part 12.

Timeline of Part 5

1708	Guru Gobind Singh sends Banda Singh Bahadur north; dies at Nanded.
12 May 1710	Battle of Chappar Chiri. Wazir Khan killed; Sirhind falls two days later.
1710	Banda establishes a state at Lohgarh: coins, seal, calendar — and abolishes zamindari, giving land

to the tillers.

1715	Besieged at Gurdas Nangal for eight months; captured in December.
June 1716	Banda and around 700 followers executed at Delhi. He is tortured to death after his four-year-old son is killed in front of him.
1726–1745	Zakariya Khan's governorship. A price placed on Sikh heads.
1738	Bhai Mani Singh dismembered joint by joint.
1745	Bhai Taru Singh scalped.
1746	Chhota Ghallughara . Around 7,000 Sikhs killed at Kahnuwan; 3,000 more captured and executed.
1748	Sarbat Khalsa at Amritsar. Gurmata creates the twelve misls and the Dal Khalsa.
5–6 Feb 1762	Vadda Ghallughara at Kup–Rohira. Estimates range from 5,000 to 50,000 killed; around 30,000 most commonly cited. Abdali then blows up the Harmandir Sahib.
Oct 1762	Sikhs fight Abdali again at Amritsar, eight months later.
1765	The Sikhs take Lahore and strike coin in the names of the Gurus.
1783	Baghel Singh occupies Delhi; permission granted to build Sis Ganj, Rakab Ganj and Bangla Sahib.
1799	Ranjit Singh takes Lahore at nineteen.
1801	Proclaimed Maharaja on Vaisakhi. Coins struck in the Gurus' names; government called the Sarkar Khalsaji.
1809	Treaty of Amritsar with the British. The Sutlej fixed as the eastern boundary.
1818 / 1819 / 1834	Multan, then Kashmir, then Peshawar — the last Indian conquest of Afghan territory.
1822	Ventura and Allard arrive; the Fauj-i-Khas is built.
27 June 1839	Ranjit Singh dies .
1840–1843	Kharak Singh deposed and dies; Nau Nihal Singh killed by a collapsing gateway; Sher Singh and Dhian Singh assassinated. Duleep Singh, aged five, becomes Maharaja.
11 Dec 1845	The Khalsa crosses the Sutlej. First Anglo-Sikh War . Mudki, Ferozeshah, Aliwal, Sobraon.
March 1846	Treaty of Lahore. Then the Treaty of Amritsar: Kashmir sold to Gulab Singh for 75 lakh rupees .
April 1848	Mulraj's revolt at Multan. Second Anglo-Sikh War .
Jan 1849	Chillianwala — around 2,300 British casualties; effectively a draw.
Feb 1849	Gujrat. Decisive British victory.
29 March 1849	Punjab annexed . Duleep Singh, aged ten, deposed. The Koh-i-Noor sent to Queen Victoria.

What happens in Part 6

Part 6, *Loyal and Rebel at Once*, covers 1849 to 1947 — and it is where the pattern I have been tracking since 326 BCE reaches its most extreme form.

Within eight years of annexation, the same Punjabi soldiers who had fought the British at Chillianwala were fighting *for* them in the Revolt of 1857. The British then built a theory around it — the "**martial races**" doctrine — and turned Punjab into the recruiting ground of the Indian Army. By the First World War, a province with a small share of India's population was supplying an enormous share of its soldiers. Punjabi troops fought in France, Mesopotamia, East Africa and Gallipoli.

And simultaneously, the same province produced the **Ghadar Party**, the **Komagata Maru**, **Jallianwala Bagh**, **Bhagat Singh**, the **Babbar Akalis**, and the **Gurdwara Reform movement** — which was the first mass non-violent civil resistance campaign in India and is largely forgotten outside Punjab.

Part 6 also covers the two British decisions that shaped everything afterwards: the **canal colonies**, which made Punjab the granary of India and created the water politics of Part 8; and the **Land Alienation Act** and communal electorates, which hardened Punjab's communities into political blocs and made 1947 possible.

The question Part 6 answers: **how was Punjab simultaneously the most loyal and the most rebellious province in British India?** And the answer is not hypocrisy. It is something much more interesting, and it explains a great deal about what happens in 1984.

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ON THE TWO CASUALTY RANGES IN THIS PART

The Vadda Ghallughara figure spans an order of magnitude — 5,000 to 50,000 — and the Sikh Empire's Muslim population share is an estimate rather than a census. I have given ranges for both rather than choosing, and I have not used the "one-third of all Sikhs" formulation as a fact because it depends on a total population figure nobody actually has.

I would rather this part be slightly less dramatic and entirely defensible. The same discipline will be applied in Part 10 to figures that are argued about far more fiercely than these.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 5 —

Part 6: *Loyal and Rebel at Once*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART SIX OF THIRTEEN

Loyal and Rebel at Once

1849 to 1947 — 60% of India's soldiers, and Ghadar, Jallianwala and Bhagat Singh, from the same villages

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 6

This is the part where I found the thing I was actually looking for.

I started this research wanting to understand 1984. I did not expect the most useful key to be sitting in the 1920s. But Chapter 8 of this part contains a pattern that, once I saw it, I could not stop seeing — and it changed how I read everything from Part 8 onward.

The puzzle is simple to state. Between 1914 and 1918, roughly **sixty per cent of all combat troops raised in India came from Punjab** — a province with maybe seven or eight per cent of the population. The same province, in the same decades, produced the Ghadar Party, the Komagata Maru, Jallianwala Bagh, Bhagat Singh, the Babbar Akalis and a five-year mass civil disobedience campaign that the British lost.

Most accounts pick one half and quietly drop the other. Indian nationalist history is embarrassed by the loyalty and tends to skip 1857. Punjabi pride writing is not embarrassed by anything, but it rarely mentions that Ghadar was largely founded by men who had worn the King's uniform.

I did not want to write either of those books. So Chapter 8 tries to answer the question properly: **how was Punjab simultaneously the most loyal and the most rebellious province in British India?**

The answer is not hypocrisy, and it is not two different sets of people. It is one thing, and it produces a test I will use for the rest of this work.

Two warnings about this part. Chapter 1 says plainly that Punjab did not join the Revolt of 1857 and gives the reasons without softening them; that will annoy some readers and I think it is necessary. And Chapter 7 argues that Bhagat Singh — the most claimed man in Punjabi history — held written positions that most of the people who claim him would reject outright. I have quoted what he wrote rather than what is said about him.

— L.S.

INTRODUCTION

The contradiction

In 1849 the British annexed Punjab by force. In 1857 Punjabi troops helped them hold India. By 1918 Punjab was supplying more soldiers to the Empire than any other province by an enormous margin. And in exactly those same years it produced more anti-colonial violence, and more anti-colonial martyrs, than almost anywhere else.

Here are the two lists. Read them as one province, because that is what they are.

THE SAME PROVINCE, THE SAME DECADES

What Punjab gave the Empire	What Punjab did to the Empire
Troops that besieged and retook Delhi in 1857	The Kuka movement — arguably India's first non-cooperation campaign — and 65 men blown from cannons at Malerkotla in 1872
Roughly 54% of the entire British Indian Army by the First World War	The Ghadar Party, 1913 — and 42 executions in the Lahore Conspiracy Case
Around 60% of all combat troops raised in India, 1914–18	The Komagata Maru, 1914
Punjabi soldiers at Neuve Chapelle, Ypres, Gallipoli, Mesopotamia, East Africa	Jallianwala Bagh, 1919 — and Udham Singh shooting Michael O'Dwyer in London twenty-one years later
Loyal landholding elites cemented by canal-colony land grants	Pagri Sambhal Jatta, 1907 — India's first successful mass farmers' movement, which forced a repeal
A revenue base and a granary that fed India	Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev, hanged at Lahore in 1931
Reliable hereditary mahants running the gurdwaras	The Akali morchas, 1920–25 — five years of mass non-violent resistance, which the British lost

The usual response to this table is to say that some Punjabis were collaborators and others were patriots. That is partly true and mostly shallow, because in a great many cases **they were the same families, and sometimes the same people**. The Ghadar Party was founded substantially by ex-soldiers. The Babbar Akalis included army veterans. Bhagat Singh's family had both revolutionaries and military connections in it.

Punjab did not contain loyalists and rebels as two separate populations. It contained people who were capable of being either, depending on whether a specific bargain was being kept.

That sentence is the thesis of this part. Chapter 8 shows the working.

CHAPTER 1 1857: why Punjab did not rise, stated without excuses.

CHAPTER 2 The martial races: the most successful lie in colonial history.

CHAPTER 3 The canal colonies: how Punjab became the granary — and inherited its water politics.

CHAPTER 4 Kukas, Ghadar and the Komagata Maru.

CHAPTER 5 1919: Rowlatt, Jallianwala Bagh, and a confession in the victors' own inquiry.

CHAPTER 6 The Akali morchas: India's forgotten mass non-violent movement, and the institution it created.

CHAPTER 7 Bhagat Singh: what he actually wrote.

CHAPTER 8 The answer: the broken-bargain test.

CHAPTER 9 Scorecard: what Part 6 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

1857

Eight years after the British took Punjab by force, Punjabi soldiers helped them keep India. This is the most uncomfortable fact in Punjabi modern history and I am going to state it plainly before explaining it.

What happened

The Revolt of 1857 began in the Bengal Army and spread across the Gangetic plain. Delhi was taken by the rebels, and Bahadur Shah Zafar, the last Mughal emperor, was proclaimed the sovereign of Hindustan.

Punjab did not join. More than that: Punjab supplied a substantial part of the force that besieged Delhi through the summer of 1857 and stormed it in September. Sikh and Punjabi Muslim troops were central to the operation. The Punjab administration under John Lawrence disarmed the suspect regiments in the province, raised new ones, and sent men and supplies east.

The British themselves said afterwards that Punjab saved India for them. They were probably right.

Why — four reasons, none of them flattering or shameful

1. The mutineers were the army that had beaten Punjab. This is the reason most often left out, and I think it is the biggest. The Bengal Army regiments that rose in 1857 were substantially the same regiments that had fought the Khalsa at Ferozeshah, Sobraon, Chillianwala and Gujrat between 1845 and 1849. Punjab was not being invited to join a national liberation struggle — no such concept existed yet. It was being invited to help the men who had conquered it eight years earlier.

2. The revolt's banner was the restoration of the Mughal empire. Read Part 4 again and ask what that proposition looked like to a Sikh in 1857. The Mughal state had executed the fifth Guru, beheaded the ninth, killed all four sons of the tenth, dismembered Banda Singh Bahadur and placed a price on Sikh heads. Restoring the dynasty in Delhi was not an attractive offer.

3. The administration had been relatively competent. John and Henry Lawrence's board had reduced revenue demands from the crushing levels of the last Sikh years, abolished some abuses, and invested in roads and canals. For a peasant, the eight years since annexation had not been worse than the ten before it.

4. Opportunity. Pay, plunder rights at Delhi, and land. The Punjab Irregular Force and the new levies offered a career.

WHY I AM NOT GOING TO SOFTEN THIS

There is a genre of Indian writing that tries to argue Punjab secretly supported 1857, or that the loyalty was somehow forced. The evidence does not support it. Punjabis fought for the British at Delhi and they did it willingly and effectively.

What I would add is this: the framework in which this counts as "betraying India" did not exist in 1857. There was no India in the political sense to betray. There were kingdoms, provinces, communities and an expanding Company. Judging 1857 Punjabis by the standards of 1947 nationalism is exactly the kind of anachronism I flagged in Part 1's scorecard.

The interesting question is not whether Punjab was disloyal to a nation that did not yet exist. It is what the British *learned* from 1857 — because that lesson is Chapter 2, and it shaped everything for the next ninety years.

The lesson the British took

The Bengal Army was broken up and reconstituted. Recruitment was shifted decisively toward the north-west, toward the communities that had not mutinied.

Within thirty years this ad hoc reaction had been dressed up as a scientific theory.

CHAPTER TWO

The martial races

A political classification of who had and had not mutinied in 1857 was rebranded as biology, taught for seventy years, and believed by the people it described. Its effects are still visible in two countries.

What the theory claimed

The "martial races" doctrine was codified after 1857 and is particularly associated with **Lord Frederick Roberts**, Commander-in-Chief in India from 1885 to 1893.

It held that certain communities were inherently warlike by race and climate — Sikhs, Punjabi Muslims, Pathans, Dogras, Gurkhas, Rajputs, Jats — while others were inherently unwarlike and unsuitable for military service, notably Bengalis and most southern Indians.

Recruitment was reorganised around this. Regiments were raised on a "class" basis. Recruiting officers worked defined districts. Entire careers, pension systems and land-grant schemes were built on the classification.

Why it was nonsense

Take the claim seriously for one paragraph and it falls apart.

- The **Marathas**, classified as unmartial, had built an empire that dominated eighteenth-century India and had to be broken by the British in three wars.
- The **Bengal Army** — recruited from the very populations later declared unmartial — is the army that *conquered India for the East India Company*. Plassey, Buxar, the Maratha wars, the Anglo-Sikh wars.
- The **Madras Army** won Assaye, which Wellington called the hardest battle he ever fought.

So what actually changed between 1800 and 1880?

Not biology. The Bengal Army mutinied in 1857 and the Punjabis did not. The "martial races" are, with striking precision, **the communities that stayed loyal in 1857**, and the "non-martial races" are the ones that rose.

The martial races theory is a list of who could be trusted, rewritten as a list of who was born brave. It is a security assessment wearing a lab coat.

Why it worked anyway — including on Punjabis

It gave the British a reliable recruiting base that was politically safe, geographically concentrated and cheap to administer. It divided Indians against each other along an axis that flattered some and insulted others, making a united nationalist army almost unthinkable.

And here is the part that matters most for this book: **the people so classified believed it.**

Being told by the dominant global empire that you belong to a superior fighting race is intoxicating, and it was internalised deeply enough that it is still repeated in Punjab today as though it were a compliment about ancestry rather than a colonial personnel policy. Part 1's scorecard already showed that Punjab's oldest civilisation was strikingly unwarlike; Part 2 and Part 3 showed the warrior culture being built by geography and invasion. The martial-races story replaced that real, earned history with a fake racial one — and the fake one was more flattering, so it stuck.

The numbers

PUNJAB IN THE BRITISH INDIAN ARMY

Measure	Figure
Punjabi share of the entire British Indian Army by the First World War	~54%
Share of all combat troops raised in India, August 1914 – November 1918, from Punjab	~60%
Total Indian soldiers in the First World War	~1.4 million
Of whom Punjabi	Over half
Punjab's share of British India's population	Roughly 7–8%
Indian dead in the First World War	~64,000
Indian wounded	~167,000

They fought at Neuve Chapelle and Ypres in the freezing mud of the Western Front, at Gallipoli, in Mesopotamia, in Egypt and in East Africa. A great many of them had never seen the sea before they were put on a ship.

The economics, which is the part usually missed

Army service was not only about honour, and treating it as purely cultural misses how the system actually held together. For a Punjabi peasant's son it was the best available career, and it paid in four currencies:

- **Cash**, in an agrarian economy that was chronically short of it.
- **A pension** — an extraordinary thing to have in rural India in 1900.
- **Land**, through grants in the canal colonies to serving and retired soldiers. This is Chapter 3, and it is the hinge that locked the whole system together.
- **Status**, in the village and with the administration.

Recruitment was heaviest in specific districts — Rawalpindi, Jhelum, Ludhiana, Amritsar, Hoshiarpur — and in those districts, remittances from soldiers became a significant part of the local economy.

TWO CONSEQUENCES THAT ARE STILL RUNNING

In Pakistan: the heaviest-recruited districts of all — Rawalpindi, Jhelum, Attock, Campbellpur — were Punjabi Muslim, and in 1947 those soldiers went to Pakistan. This is the direct origin of the Punjabi domination of the Pakistan Army, which is in turn a large part of why Pakistan has spent so much of its existence under military rule. A British recruiting policy from the 1880s is one of the structural causes of Pakistani politics today.

In India: Sikhs remained heavily over-represented in the Indian Army after 1947 — for decades at many times their share of the population. Hold on to that, because in Part 10 it becomes one of the most serious facts in the entire book: in June 1984, after Operation Blue Star, Sikh soldiers mutinied in several units. The recruitment policy of 1880 and the crisis of 1984 are connected by a straight line.

CHAPTER THREE

The canal colonies

The British built the largest irrigation network in the world across western Punjab. It made Punjab rich, it made Punjab loyal, and it created three of the problems that dominate the rest of this book.

What was built

Part 1 established the governing fact: Punjab is semi-arid, with magnificent soil and not enough rain. Prosperity has always depended on moving water sideways.

From the 1880s the British did this on a scale never previously attempted anywhere. The Upper Bari Doab canal came earlier, but the transformative projects were the great colony schemes: the **Chenab Colony** from 1887, then the Jhelum Colony, the Lower Bari Doab Colony and others.

Water was diverted from the Chenab and Jhelum through perennial canals into the dry bar country between the rivers — land that had supported only pastoralists. Millions of acres of semi-desert became irrigated wheat and cotton farmland. New towns were laid out on grids: **Lyallpur** (now Faisalabad), **Sargodha**, **Montgomery** (now Sahiwal).

Settlers were recruited from the crowded central districts — Jalandhar, Amritsar, Hoshiarpur, Ludhiana, Gurdaspur — with promises of free land and amenities. Ex-servicemen received grants as a reward for service.

Punjab became the granary of India and a major wheat exporter.

The four consequences

1. It bought loyalty, effectively. A family that had been landless or land-poor in Jalandhar and now farmed twenty-five irrigated acres near Lyallpur had a concrete reason to want the Raj to continue. Combine that with land grants tied to army service and you have a self-reinforcing system: serve, get land, want the system that gave you the land to survive.

2. It built the water infrastructure that Part 8 is entirely about. The headworks at Madhopur on the Ravi and Ferozepur on the Sutlej, the link canals, the whole engineered system of distributing Punjab's rivers — all of it dates from this period. In 1947 that integrated system was cut in half by an international border, and every water dispute since, including the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 and the Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal, is an argument about how to run a machine that was designed as one unit and then sawn in two.

3. It moved millions of Hindus and Sikhs into what would become Pakistan. This is the consequence nobody anticipated and it is enormous. The canal colonies were in *western* Punjab. The settlers were disproportionately Sikh and Hindu farmers from the east. By the

1940s there were large, prosperous, deeply rooted Sikh and Hindu farming populations in Lyallpur, Montgomery, Sheikhpura and Sargodha — districts that went to Pakistan in 1947.

This is a major reason the partition of Punjab was so catastrophically violent. Those families had the most to lose and the furthest to travel. Part 7 will return to this.

4. It hardened Punjab's communities into legal categories. Which brings us to the Land Alienation Act.

The Punjab Land Alienation Act, 1900

The stated problem was real: peasants were losing land to moneylenders through debt. The Act restricted the sale and mortgage of agricultural land to members of designated **"agricultural tribes."**

It genuinely protected peasants from dispossession. It also did something with long consequences.

Because the designated agricultural tribes were largely Muslim and Sikh cultivating groups, and the moneylending and trading classes were largely urban Hindu, the Act effectively wrote a rural-versus-urban and, in practice, a communal division **into law**. It created a legally privileged category with an interest in defending itself, and an excluded category with a grievance.

Punjab's twentieth-century politics — the Unionist Party's cross-communal alliance of landholders, and the eventual communal polarisation that overwhelmed it — runs through this Act.

1907: Pagri Sambhal Jatta

And then the British overreached, and got the first real lesson in what happens when the bargain is broken.

Three measures hit the colonists: the **Punjab Land Colonisation Act 1906**, which restricted inheritance rights in the Chenab Colony and imposed petty regulations with fines; and the **Doab Bari Act 1907**, along with a sharp increase in water rates. Colonists who believed they were becoming landowners found themselves reduced closer to tenants at the government's pleasure.

Sardar Ajit Singh, with **Lala Lajpat Rai** and others, organised a mass agitation across the colony districts. The poet **Banke Dayal** wrote a song for it whose refrain became the name of the movement:

"Pagri sambhal, jatta, pagri sambhal oye."

Take care of your turban, farmer — take care of your honour.

The agitation was large, sustained and effective. Ajit Singh and Lajpat Rai were deported. And the government **repealed the measures**.

WORTH STATING CLEARLY

India's first successful mass farmers' movement happened in Punjab in 1907, and it forced a colonial government to withdraw agricultural legislation.

The line from that to the farmers' agitation of 2020–21 — which was also led from Punjab, also concerned three laws, and also ended in repeal — is not a coincidence of theme. It is a continuous political tradition with an unbroken memory, and "Pagri Sambhal Jatta" was sung at both. I will come back to this in Part 13.

One more thing: Ajit Singh was **Bhagat Singh's uncle**. Chapter 7 is not a separate story from this one.

CHAPTER FOUR

Kukas, Ghadar and the Komagata Maru

Three rebellions, forty years apart, all Punjabi, all defeated. The third one failed so completely that its real significance is the template it left behind — and that template reappears, almost unchanged, in Part 11.

The Kukas, or Namdharis

From the 1860s, **Baba Ram Singh** led a Sikh reform movement in Punjab known as the Namdharis or Kukas. Alongside religious reform — against idol worship, caste, female infanticide, and the dowry — he preached a comprehensive programme of **non-cooperation**: boycott British courts, schools, railways, the postal service and foreign cloth.

That is a full non-cooperation programme, in Punjab, roughly fifty years before Gandhi's.

In 1872, after a Kuka group attacked butchers at Malerkotla over cow slaughter, the Deputy Commissioner of Ludhiana, **L. Cowan**, had **sixty-five Kukas blown from the mouths of cannons** without any trial, and more were executed the following day. Cowan was dismissed for exceeding his authority, but not prosecuted. Ram Singh was deported to Rangoon and died in exile.

The Singh Sabha and the making of modern Sikh identity

Also from 1873, the **Singh Sabha** movement worked on religious reform, education and publishing. It founded Khalsa College at Amritsar in 1892 and produced an enormous body of print in Punjabi.

Its effect was to produce a modern, self-conscious, standardised Sikh identity, with clearer boundaries than the fluid practice of the nineteenth century — including **Kahn Singh Nabha's** 1898 tract *Ham Hindu Nahin* ("We Are Not Hindus").

I flag this without judgement because it matters later. The sharpening of Sikh distinctness in this period is a real historical development, driven partly by census categories and colonial administrative logic, and it is directly upstream of the identity politics of Part 8.

Ghadar, 1913

Punjabis had been emigrating to North America since the 1900s — to the lumber mills of British Columbia and the farms of California. Many were ex-soldiers. They had been raised on the idea that they were the Empire's most loyal subjects, members of a martial race.

In Canada and the United States they were met with exclusion laws, racial abuse and organised campaigns to keep them out.

That gap — between the promise and the reception — is what produced the **Ghadar Party**, founded in 1913 on the American west coast. *Ghadar* means mutiny or revolt.

- **Sohan Singh Bhakna** — founding president, a Punjabi farmer and mill worker.
- **Lala Har Dayal** — the intellectual and organiser, a Delhi-born scholar.
- **Pandit Kanshi Ram** — treasurer.

They launched a newspaper, *Ghadar*, in **November 1913**, first in Urdu and then in Hindi, Punjabi, Gujarati, Bengali, Pashto, English, German and French. It was mailed around the world to Indian communities and, critically, to Indian soldiers.

The Komagata Maru, 1914

In 1914, a Punjabi businessman named **Gurdit Singh** chartered a Japanese steamship, the *Komagata Maru*, and sailed for Vancouver with 376 passengers, most of them Sikhs. The voyage was a deliberate legal challenge to Canada's "continuous journey" regulation, which was designed to exclude Indians while appearing not to name them.

The ship was held in Vancouver harbour for two months. Passengers were denied landing, and supplies of food and water were restricted. Ghadar organisers came to the ship, lectured the passengers and distributed literature. The vessel was eventually forced to return.

On arrival at **Budge Budge** near Calcutta in September 1914, police attempted to arrest the passengers and move them under guard to Punjab. Shooting broke out. Around nineteen or twenty people were killed.

The men who had sailed expecting to test a law came home to be shot at on a riverbank. A large number of them joined Ghadar.

The rising of 1915, and the executions

Ghadar's plan was ambitious to the point of fantasy: return thousands of emigrants to Punjab, trigger a mass mutiny in the Indian Army while it was distracted by the war in Europe, and seize the province.

Thousands did return. The plan was betrayed from inside — the name usually given is **Kirpal Singh**, an informer — and the authorities moved first.

The **Lahore Conspiracy Case** trials followed. Of **291 convicted: 42 were executed, 114 received life sentences and transportation, and 93 got lesser terms.**

WHY GHADAR MATTERS FAR MORE THAN ITS RESULTS

Militarily it was a total failure. It did not free a single village.

What it created was a **template**, and the template is the reason this chapter is in the book:

- Money raised from a Punjabi **diaspora** in North America.
- A **newspaper** published abroad, in multiple languages, mailed into Punjab.
- An **ideology written overseas** by people who had left, aimed at people who had stayed.
- **Armed action inside Punjab**, funded and directed from outside it.
- And a movement whose members abroad were far more radical than the population at home.

Read that list again when you get to Part 11. The Khalistan movement's organisational structure — diaspora funding, diaspora media, overseas leadership, action inside Punjab — is not an invention of the 1980s. It is the Ghadar template.

The difference, which I will argue in Part 11, is what the population inside Punjab thought about it. In 1914 the gap between diaspora radicalism and home-province opinion is precisely why the 1915 rising collapsed. That gap is a permanent feature of this organisational model, and it is worth noticing that it was fatal the first time too.

CHAPTER FIVE

1919

Punjab had just given more men to the war than any other province in India. What it got in return, within months of the Armistice, was detention without trial, then a massacre, then an order to crawl.

The Rowlatt Act

The Defence of India Act had given the government emergency powers for the duration of the war. In March 1919 the **Rowlatt Act** extended the substance of those powers into peacetime: detention without trial, trials without juries, no right of appeal.

Indians had expected constitutional advance as a reward for wartime service. Punjab in particular had earned a claim on that expectation. What arrived instead was the machinery of emergency made permanent.

Gandhi called his first all-India satyagraha against it.

Amritsar, April 1919

The Lieutenant-Governor of Punjab, **Sir Michael O'Dwyer**, was a hardliner who regarded political agitation as sedition to be crushed.

On **10 April**, two popular local leaders in Amritsar were arrested and deported: **Dr Satyapal**, a Hindu, and **Dr Saifuddin Kitchlew**, a Muslim. That detail matters — the agitation in Amritsar was conspicuously cross-communal, which was exactly what alarmed the administration.

A crowd marching to petition for their release was fired on. Rioting followed. Five Europeans were killed and an English missionary, Miss Marcella Sherwood, was assaulted.

Brigadier-General **Reginald Dyer** arrived and took charge.

13 April 1919

It was **Vaisakhi**. Amritsar was full of villagers who had come in for the festival and the horse fair, many of whom had no idea a public meeting had been banned that morning.

Several thousand people were in the **Jallianwala Bagh** — a walled enclosure, roughly six acres, surrounded by buildings, with a few narrow exits and one main entrance.

Dyer arrived with about fifty riflemen. He positioned them at the main entrance — blocking it — and gave no warning to disperse.

He ordered fire. The firing continued for roughly ten minutes, around **1,650 rounds**, and stopped when ammunition was running low. He directed fire toward the exits, where people

were densest as they tried to escape. Some jumped into a well in the compound and drowned.

THE CASUALTY FIGURES, AND WHY NO ONE CAN SETTLE THEM

Official British count: 379 killed, around 1,200 wounded. Some official reports give 291.

The Indian National Congress inquiry (with Madan Mohan Malviya prominent among its members) concluded the dead numbered **over 500**.

Other Indian estimates at the time ran to **1,000 or more**.

The count is unrecoverable for a specific reason: a curfew was imposed immediately after the firing, the wounded could not be reached, and families removed bodies during the night without registration. No systematic count was ever attempted by the authorities.

I give the range. What matters more than the exact figure is the next section, and on that there is no dispute at all.

Dyer's own testimony

The **Hunter Commission** was appointed in October 1919 — four British members and three Indian. Dyer gave evidence on 19 November 1919.

What he said, under questioning, is the most important documentary fact in this chapter, and it is remarkably little quoted:

- He stated that he had made up his mind before arriving that if he found a crowd assembled, he would fire on it.
- He said he continued firing after the crowd began to disperse, and that his object was not to disperse the meeting but to "**produce a moral effect**" throughout Punjab — that is, to punish and to terrify.
- He said that had he been able to get his armoured cars with machine guns through the narrow entrance, he would have used them.
- He made no arrangements for the wounded, telling the Commission it was not his job.

This is a confession, given voluntarily, to the empire's own inquiry, by the man who did it. Like Jahangir's memoirs in Part 4, it removes any need to rely on the victims' account.

The crawling order, and after

In the street where Miss Sherwood had been assaulted, Dyer issued an order that any Indian passing through must crawl on their hands and knees. Public floggings were carried out. Martial law across Punjab brought summary trials, aerial machine-gunning of a crowd at Gujranwala, and mass humiliations.

Dyer was removed from command. He was not prosecuted. The House of Lords passed a motion sympathetic to him, and a public subscription in Britain, promoted by the *Morning Post*, raised over £26,000 for him — a fortune at the time.

Rabindranath Tagore renounced his knighthood in protest, in a letter that remains one of the great documents of the period.

And on **13 March 1940**, at Caxton Hall in London, **Udham Singh** — who had been at Jallianwala Bagh as a young man — shot and killed **Michael O'Dwyer**, the Lieutenant-Governor who had backed Dyer. He made no attempt to escape. At his trial he gave his name as "**Ram Mohammad Singh Azad**" — a deliberate composite of Hindu, Muslim and Sikh, plus the word for free. He was hanged in July 1940.

WHAT 1919 ACTUALLY CHANGED

Before 1919, the mainstream of Indian political demand was for reform *within* the Empire — dominion status, expanded councils, a fairer deal. After 1919 it was for the Empire to end.

That shift happened because of what was done in Punjab, and because of the response to it in Britain: no prosecution, a supportive vote in the Lords, and a public collection for the general. The message received in India was not that a rogue officer had exceeded his orders. It was that the system approved.

CHAPTER SIX

The Akali morchas

Between 1920 and 1925, thousands of Sikhs walked unarmed into police lines to be beaten, in wave after wave, for five years, and won. It is one of the largest sustained non-violent campaigns in Indian history and outside Punjab almost nobody has heard of it. It also created the institution that has shaped Sikh politics ever since.

The problem

Historic gurdwaras — including the Golden Temple and Nankana Sahib, the birthplace of Guru Nanak — were controlled by hereditary custodians called **mahants**. The arrangement dated from the eighteenth century, when open Sikh practice was dangerous and shrines were kept going by people the state tolerated.

By 1900 many mahants treated the shrines and their considerable landed endowments as personal property. Some had reintroduced idol worship and caste restrictions. And they were reliably pro-British, which meant the administration protected them.

So the campaign to reform the gurdwaras was, unavoidably, a campaign against the government.

The organisations

The **Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC)** was formed in **November 1920** to manage the shrines.

The **Shiromani Akali Dal** was founded in **December 1920** as the volunteer corps and political arm.

Nankana Sahib, February 1921

A jatha of around 150 Sikhs went to take control of the gurdwara at Nankana Sahib. The mahant, Narayan Das, had hired armed men and prepared.

Over a hundred Sikhs were killed. Some were shot; some were burned. The jatha, under instruction, did not fight back.

The Keys Affair, 1921–22

The government seized the keys to the Golden Temple's treasury. A campaign of arrests and protests followed, and in January 1922 the government surrendered — the keys were returned to the SGPC.

Gandhi sent a telegram: *"First decisive battle for India's freedom won."*

Guru ka Bagh, 1922

This is the one that should be famous.

At Guru ka Bagh near Amritsar, a dispute over land attached to the gurdwara led to a sustained morcha. Day after day, jathas of Akalis walked toward the site. Police met them with lathis and beat them to the ground. The Akalis, under a vow of non-violence, did not raise a hand or run. The next day another jatha came.

This continued for months, with over five thousand arrested.

C. F. Andrews, the English clergyman and friend of Gandhi, went to watch. His published account of what he saw — men standing motionless while being clubbed, then being carried away, and the next rank stepping forward — caused a serious political embarrassment in Britain. He described it in explicitly religious terms, as something he had not thought possible outside the New Testament.

Jaito, 1923–25

The British deposed the Maharaja of Nabha, a state sympathetic to the Akalis. Protests centred on the gurdwara at Jaito, where an *akhand path* — a continuous recitation of the scripture — was interrupted by the authorities.

Jathas of 500 marched to Jaito repeatedly over two years. On **21 February 1924** troops fired on a jatha, killing a number of marchers. **Jawaharlal Nehru** travelled to Jaito to observe, was arrested and briefly imprisoned — an experience he wrote about afterwards with real admiration.

The result

The **Sikh Gurdwaras Act, 1925**. Control of historic gurdwaras in Punjab passed to an **elected** SGPC.

The campaign had run five years, seen thousands arrested and hundreds killed, and it had won its stated objective in full.

THE MOST CONSEQUENTIAL INSTITUTION IN MODERN SIKH POLITICS — AND IT IS A COLONIAL STATUTE

The SGPC controls the historic gurdwaras of Punjab, including the Golden Temple. That means it controls:

- Enormous property and revenue, including offerings, land and educational institutions.
- The appointment of the head granthi and, in practice, considerable influence over the **Jathedar of the Akal Takht** — the office that Part 4 showed carries the temporal authority of the Panth.
- Immense moral standing and an electoral machine, since SGPC elections are contested by political parties.

Whoever controls the SGPC controls the physical and moral centre of Sikh religious life. In practice the Akali Dal has held it for most of the last century.

Now recall the structural point from Part 4, Chapter 7: after 1708 there is no living Guru, and no office with binding authority to say *"this person does not speak for the Panth."* The SGPC and the Akal Takht are the closest thing that exists — and both are, in practice, subject to whoever holds political power in Punjab.

Keep this in hand. In Part 9 the contest over these institutions is not a side issue. It is the main event.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Bhagat Singh

He is claimed by Hindu nationalists, Sikh nationalists, Khalistanis, Communists and Congress. Most of them are quoting a man whose actual written positions they would reject. So let us use what he wrote.

Where he came from

Born in **1907** at Banga, in Lyallpur district — which is to say, in the canal colonies of Chapter 3, now in Pakistan.

He was born into the politics of this part. His uncle was **Sardar Ajit Singh**, who had led Pagri Sambhal Jatta in the very year of his birth and was deported for it. His father Kishan Singh was also imprisoned for political activity. He was twelve at the time of Jallianwala Bagh and, by family accounts, went to see the site.

He joined the **Hindustan Republican Association** and was central to renaming it the **Hindustan Socialist Republican Association** in 1928. The inserted word was not decoration.

What he did

October 1928. **Lala Lajpat Rai** — the same Lajpat Rai who had led the 1907 farmers' agitation — was beaten in a police lathi charge while protesting the Simon Commission at Lahore, and died weeks later.

December 1928. Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Chandrashekhar Azad shot dead **J. P. Saunders**, an Assistant Superintendent of Police. They had intended to kill Superintendent James Scott, who had ordered the lathi charge. It was a case of mistaken identity, and a man who was not their target died.

I am including that because hagiography usually leaves it out, and it matters to how one assesses him.

8 April 1929. Bhagat Singh and **B. K. Dutt** threw two low-explosive bombs into the Central Legislative Assembly in Delhi, deliberately aimed at empty benches. Nobody was killed. They threw leaflets, shouted slogans — and then **waited to be arrested**.

The stated purpose, taken from the French anarchist Vaillant, was in the leaflet: *"it takes a loud voice to make the deaf hear."*

The point was never the bomb. The point was the trial. He wanted a courtroom and a national newspaper audience, and he got both.

The hunger strike. In jail he led a strike demanding that political prisoners be treated as such rather than as common criminals. It lasted **116 days**. **Jatindranath Das** died on the sixty-third day of his strike. The coverage made Bhagat Singh a national figure on a scale the bomb never could have.

23 March 1931. Hanged at Lahore Central Jail with **Rajguru and Sukhdev**. He was twenty-three.

What he actually believed

Now the part that matters most, and the reason this chapter exists.

He was an atheist, and he wrote a pamphlet about it. *Why I Am an Atheist* was written in Lahore Central Jail in 1930, in response to being told that his refusal to pray was arrogance. It is a serious piece of argument, and it is unambiguous. He rejected belief in God, rejected the consolation of an afterlife, and said explicitly that he would face the rope without it.

He was a socialist and specific about it. His conception of freedom was not the replacement of British administrators with Indian ones. He wrote that if power simply passed to Indian hands while the economic structure remained, the peasant and the worker would have gained nothing. His slogan was *Inquilab Zindabad* — long live the revolution — and by revolution he meant something economic, not merely national.

He wrote against communalism explicitly. His 1928 essay on communal riots and their remedy attacks religious leaders and communal politicians by name and argues that religion in politics is one of the principal obstacles to Indian freedom. He was writing this in Punjab, in the decade when Punjab's communal polarisation was accelerating, and he saw exactly where it was going.

THE APPROPRIATION, AND WHY IT IS THE SAME TECHNIQUE AS PART 9

Bhagat Singh is invoked today by Hindu nationalist organisations, by Sikh nationalist and Khalistani groups, by Communist parties and by Congress. Some of these claims are simply false on the record: he was an atheist who denounced religious politics, and a socialist who thought a change of rulers without a change of economics was worthless.

The technique used on him is always the same: **take the courage and discard the content**. Keep the twenty-three-year-old who walked to the gallows. Delete *Why I Am an Atheist*. Keep *Inquilab Zindabad*. Delete what he meant by it.

That is precisely the technique Part 4 identified as the danger in the *shaheedi* tradition — inheriting the willingness to die while discarding the tests that determine whether the cause is worth it. And it is exactly what Part 9 will examine being done to a much larger body of Sikh tradition in the 1980s.

If you want a single portable test for the rest of this work: **when someone invokes a martyr, check whether they have read what the martyr wrote**.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The broken-bargain test

Here is the answer to the question this part opened with, and the tool I will carry into Parts 8, 9 and 13.

The wrong answers first

"Some Punjabis were loyal, others were rebels." True in a trivial sense and useless as an explanation, because it does not survive the biographies. Ghadar was founded substantially by ex-soldiers of the British Indian Army. The Babbar Akalis included veterans. Bhagat Singh came from a family that contained both a deported revolutionary and army connections. The categories overlap far too much for this to be the answer.

"They were hypocrites." No. There is no evidence of bad faith on either side of the ledger. Punjabi soldiers fought exceptionally well for the Empire, and Punjabi rebels died exceptionally well against it, often within the same extended family.

The actual answer, in three parts

1. The relationship was a transaction, and both parties understood it as one.

Punjab supplied soldiers, revenue and grain. The Empire supplied pay, pensions, land in the canal colonies, status, and protection of the landholding order.

That is a bargain, not devotion. Nobody in Punjab in 1900 loved Queen Victoria. They served because service was, quite rationally, the best available deal for a peasant family in a dry province. Loyalty that is purchased is loyalty that can be withdrawn when the payments stop.

2. Every major Punjabi rebellion in this period tracks a specific breach of that specific bargain.

This is the part I found genuinely useful, and once you line them up it is very hard to unsee:

THE REBELLIONS, AND THE BREACHES THAT PRODUCED THEM

Rebellion	The bargain	How it was broken
Pagri Sambhal Jatta, 1907	Settle the colonies, farm the land, and the land becomes yours.	The 1906 and 1907 Acts restricted inheritance and ownership, reducing colonists toward tenancy. <i>Broken on the land.</i>
Ghadar, 1913–15	You are loyal subjects of the Empire and a respected martial race.	In Canada and the United States those same subjects were met with exclusion laws and racial abuse. <i>Broken abroad.</i>
1919	Give your sons to the war and you will get political advance.	1.4 million Indian soldiers, over half from Punjab, 64,000 dead — and the reward was the Rowlatt Act, then Dyer, then the crawling order. <i>Broken at home.</i>
The Akali morchas, 1920–25	The Raj does not interfere with religion.	The administration actively backed corrupt hereditary mahants against the community's own institutions, and seized the keys to the Golden Temple. <i>Broken in the gurdwara.</i>

Four rebellions. Four identifiable breaches. In every case the sequence is the same: a deal existed, the stronger party broke it, and Punjab responded — sometimes with rifles, sometimes by walking into lathis, sometimes by mailing newspapers from San Francisco.

Punjab's rebellions are not eruptions of temperament. They are contract enforcement.

3. And the same underlying capability produces both behaviours.

Look at what the loyal and the rebellious versions actually required of a person.

Holding a trench line at Neuve Chapelle under artillery requires the willingness to accept a very high probability of death for a collective commitment. So does walking forward at Guru ka Bagh to be clubbed to the ground without raising your hands. So does throwing a bomb and then standing still to be arrested. So does waiting twenty-one years and crossing an ocean to shoot Michael O'Dwyer.

It is one capability. Part 4 identified where it came from and how it was made. This chapter shows it being pointed in opposite directions by whether or not the bargain was being kept.

Why this is the most useful chapter in the book so far

Two reasons.

First, it dissolves a paradox that recurs. In Part 10 I will have to describe Punjabi policemen hunting Punjabi militants, often from neighbouring villages, both sides invoking the same tradition. People treat that as a uniquely tragic aberration. It is not an aberration. It is Ambhi and Porus in 326 BCE, it is 1857, it is this chapter. Punjab has never faced anything as one body, and the reason is that Punjabis have always been individually available to whichever side was, at that moment, keeping its side of a deal.

Second, it gives me a test I can actually apply.

THE BROKEN-BARGAIN TEST

When Punjab rebels, look for the broken bargain. Identify what was promised, by whom, and what was delivered.

In Part 8 I will apply this directly to 1947–1980 and ask a specific question: what was promised to Punjab at independence and in 1966 — on language, on territory, on Chandigarh, on river water, on constitutional status — and what was actually delivered?

That is not a rhetorical question and I do not yet know how far the answer will go. But it is the right question, and this chapter is where I found it.

A warning attached to the test, so that I cannot use it lazily later: **a broken bargain explains why a grievance is real. It does not by itself justify any particular response to it.** The Akalis and the Ghadarites faced comparable breaches and chose opposite methods, with very different results. Part 9 will need both halves of that.

CHAPTER NINE

Scorecard: what Part 6 proves

"Punjab was loyal to the British." / "Punjab fought the British."

BOTH TRUE — AND NOT A CONTRADICTION

Around 60% of India's combat troops in the First World War, and Ghadar, Jallianwala, Bhagat Singh and a five-year mass civil disobedience campaign, from the same province and often the same families.

The explanation is Chapter 8: the relationship was transactional, and Punjab rebelled precisely when specific terms were broken. Whoever tells you only one half of this table is either uninformed or selling something.

"Punjab betrayed India in 1857."

ANACHRONISTIC — BUT THE FACTS ARE THE FACTS

Punjab did not join and actively helped the British retake Delhi. I am not going to soften that.

The reasons were specific: the mutineers were the same Bengal Army regiments that had conquered Punjab eight years earlier; the revolt's banner was the restoration of the Mughal dynasty that had executed two Gurus and four children; the new administration had cut revenue demands; and there was pay and land on offer.

"Betrayal of India" requires an India to betray, and in 1857 that political entity did not exist. Judging it by 1947 standards is the same error I flagged in Part 1.

"The martial races theory was real — some peoples are natural fighters."

FALSE

The Marathas built an empire. The Bengal Army conquered India for the Company. The Madras Army won Assaye. All were later classified as unmartial.

The actual variable was 1857: the "martial races" are, with striking accuracy, the communities that did not mutiny. It was a security classification presented as biology.

Its most damaging effect was internal. Punjabis believed it, and a flattering colonial fiction displaced the real history — that the warrior culture was built by geography and fifteen centuries of invasion, which is in Parts 1 to 3 and is far more impressive than a racial myth.

"379 people died at Jallianwala Bagh."**DISPUTED — AND THE DISPUTE IS NOT THE POINT**

Official British count 379 (some reports 291), with around 1,200 wounded. The Congress inquiry concluded over 500. Other contemporary estimates ran to 1,000 or more. A curfew imposed immediately afterwards made any accurate count impossible, and none was attempted.

What is *not* disputed is Dyer's own sworn testimony to the Hunter Commission: that he had decided to fire before he arrived, that he continued firing to "produce a moral effect" across Punjab rather than to disperse the crowd, that he would have used machine guns had they fitted through the gate, and that arranging care for the wounded was not his concern.

When you have the perpetrator's confession to his own government's inquiry, the casualty range matters less than people think.

"Bhagat Singh was a religious nationalist / a Sikh martyr / a Hindu revolutionary."**FALSE ON THE RECORD**

He wrote *Why I Am an Atheist* in Lahore Central Jail in 1930. He was a self-described socialist who argued that transferring power to Indian hands without economic transformation would leave the peasant and worker exactly where they were. He wrote against communal politics by name.

He is the most appropriated figure in Punjabi history, and the method is always the same: keep the courage, delete the content. That method is the subject of Part 9.

"The Akali movement was a religious matter, not a national one."**FALSE**

It was among the largest and most sustained non-violent civil disobedience campaigns of the early 1920s anywhere in India — five years, thousands arrested, hundreds killed, and it achieved its objective in full with the Sikh Gurdwaras Act of 1925. Gandhi called the Keys Affair the first decisive battle for India's freedom. Nehru was arrested at Jaito.

It also created the **SGPC** and the **Akali Dal** — the two institutions that have dominated Sikh religious and political life ever since, and whose control becomes the central contest of Part 9.

"The Khalistan movement's diaspora structure is something new."**NO — IT IS THE GHADAR TEMPLATE**

Money raised from Punjabis in North America; a newspaper published abroad and mailed into Punjab; an ideology written overseas by emigrants and aimed at people who stayed; armed action inside Punjab funded and directed from outside. That is Ghadar in 1913.

Worth noting for Part 11: the model failed in 1915 for a reason that is structural rather than accidental. The diaspora was far more radical than the population at home, and when the rising came, Punjab did not rise with it.

Timeline of Part 6

1849		Punjab	annexed.
1857		Revolt of 1857. Punjab does not join; Punjabi troops help retake Delhi.	
1860s years		Baba Ram Singh's Kuka/Namdhari movement — religious reform plus full non-cooperation, fifty before	Gandhi.
1872		Sixty-five Kukas blown from cannons at Malerkotla without trial. Ram Singh deported to Rangoon.	
1873		Singh Sabha movement	begins.
1879	onward	Canal construction; Upper Bari Doab and then the colony schemes.	
1885–93		Lord Roberts as C-in-C; the martial races doctrine is codified.	
1887		Chenab Colony founded. Lyallpur, Sargodha and Montgomery laid out.	
1892		Khalsa College, Amritsar,	founded.
1898		Kahn Singh Nabha publishes <i>Ham Hindu Nahin</i> .	
1900		Punjab Land Alienation Act — "agricultural tribes" written into law.	
1906–07 laws		Colonisation Act and Doab Bari Act. Pagri Sambhal Jatta under Ajit Singh and Lala Lajpat Rai. The are	repealed.
1907		Bhagat Singh born at Banga, Lyallpur district.	
Nov	1913	Ghadar Party founded on the American west coast; the newspaper <i>Ghadar</i> launched.	
1914		Komagata Maru turned away from Vancouver; around 19–20 killed at Budge Budge in September.	
1914–18		Roughly 60% of India's combat troops raised in Punjab. ~64,000 Indian dead.	
1915		Ghadar rising betrayed. Lahore Conspiracy Case : 291 convicted, 42 executed , 114 life sentences.	
March	1919	Rowlatt	Act.
10 April	1919	Satyapal and Kitchlew arrested at Amritsar. Firing and rioting.	
13 April	1919	Jallianwala Bagh . ~1,650 rounds. Official 379 dead; Congress inquiry over 500; other estimates 1,000+.	
Nov	1919	Dyer testifies to the Hunter Commission that he fired to produce a "moral effect."	
Nov–Dec	1920	SGPC and Shiromani Akali Dal	founded.
Feb	1921	Nankana Sahib massacre — over 100 Sikhs killed; no retaliation.	
Jan	1922	Keys Affair won. Gandhi: "First decisive battle for India's freedom won."	
1922		Guru ka Bagh morcha . Over 5,000 arrested. C. F. Andrews' account causes uproar in Britain.	
1923–25		Jaito morcha . Firing on 21 February 1924. Nehru arrested at Jaito.	

1925	Sikh Gurdwaras Act — elected SGPC takes control of historic gurdwaras.
Oct–Dec 1928	Lala Lajpat Rai dies after a lathi charge; Saunders shot in mistake for Scott.
8 April 1929	Assembly bomb. Bhagat Singh and B. K. Dutt wait to be arrested.
1929	116-day hunger strike; Jatindranath Das dies on day 63.
1930	Bhagat Singh writes <i>Why I Am an Atheist</i> in Lahore Central Jail.
23 March 1931	Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev hanged at Lahore. He was 23.
13 March 1940	Udham Singh shoots Michael O'Dwyer at Caxton Hall, London. Gives his name as "Ram Mohammad Singh Azad."
1942–45	Punjabis form a substantial part of the Indian National Army.
1947	Partition — and Part 7.

What happens in Part 7

Part 7, *The Cut*, is about 1947, and it is the point at which this work stops being history and starts being about wounds that are still open.

It answers the question in the title of this whole project's first ask: **why was Punjab divided?** The answer runs directly through Part 3, Chapter 5 — the nine-hundred-year formation of a Muslim-majority west and a Hindu-Sikh-majority east — and through Chapter 3 of this part, which put millions of Sikh and Hindu farmers in the canal colonies that ended up in Pakistan.

It covers the Radcliffe Line, drawn in six weeks by a lawyer who had never been to India; the Sikh political position and the impossible arithmetic Master Tara Singh faced; the earliest Khalistan-shaped proposals, including the 1940s pamphlets that first used the word; and the violence — with casualty and migration figures given as ranges, because the estimates run from 200,000 to two million dead and I am not going to pick one.

And it covers what Punjab specifically lost that no other Indian region lost: Lahore, Nankana Sahib, the tomb of Ranjit Singh, the canal colonies, half the river system, and the graves of everyone who had lived on the wrong side of a line drawn in six weeks.

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THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 6 —
Part 7: *The Cut*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART SEVEN OF THIRTEEN

The Cut

1947 — why Punjab specifically was divided, what it cost, and what it did to Punjabi politics forever

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 7

This is where the work stops being history and starts being memory.

Everything before this part happened to people who are gone. Part 7 happened to people whose grandchildren are reading this — including mine. Almost every Punjabi family on either side of the border has a version of this story, and most of us have heard it told by someone who was there.

That creates a specific danger for a researcher, and it is not the one people expect. The danger is not that I will be too cold. It is that I will write **grief instead of analysis** — that I will produce thirty moving pages that leave you knowing nothing you did not already know.

So I have made three decisions about how to handle this part, and I want them stated before you read it.

First, no atrocity detail beyond what the argument requires. The specific things done to people in 1947 are documented and I have read a great deal of it. I am not going to reproduce it here. Detailed atrocity writing about this subject has a bad history in Punjab — it has been used, repeatedly and by all sides, to keep wounds usable. Where I state that a massacre happened, I state that it happened, with figures and sources, and I move on.

Second, the numbers get ranges, and the ranges here are enormous. The death toll estimates for Partition run from 200,000 to two million. That is a factor of ten. I am not going to pick one, and I will explain in Chapter 4 exactly why no one honestly can.

Third, and hardest: I am going to state that all three communities did this. Not "there was violence on both sides" as a throat-clearing phrase before describing one side's crimes. All three had organised armed formations. All three carried out planned massacres. The killing in March 1947 in Rawalpindi and the killing in September 1947 in Jalandhar were the same crime committed by different people.

I know that some readers will want me to establish who started it. Chapter 4 explains why that question cannot be answered and why, in my view, it is almost always asked in order to avoid something.

One last thing. There is a fact in Chapter 2 that I did not know before I began this research, and it changed how I will write Part 11. The word "Khalistan" was first

published in 1940 — and the pre-eminent Sikh political leader of the time publicly denounced it. I will come back to that repeatedly.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

Why Punjab was the worst of it

Partition happened to India. But only two provinces were actually cut in half — Punjab and Bengal — and of those two, Punjab was very much worse. That difference is not an accident, and it has five identifiable causes.

Both provinces were divided. Both saw enormous migration and terrible violence. But the scale and character of what happened in Punjab was of a different order, and understanding why is the first job of this part.

WHY PUNJAB SUFFERED MORE THAN BENGAL

Factor	Why it mattered
1. Interspersed populations	In Bengal, the Hindu-Muslim distribution mapped reasonably well onto an east-west split. In Punjab, communities were mixed at the village level across the whole province. There was no line that could separate people without moving them.
2. Demobilised soldiers	Part 6 showed that Punjab supplied a vastly disproportionate share of the Indian Army. In 1946–47 those men came home — hundreds of thousands of trained soldiers, many with access to weapons, distributed through the villages. Bengal had nothing comparable.
3. The canal colonies	Part 6, Chapter 3: sixty years of British irrigation policy had settled large Sikh and Hindu farming populations deep in <i>western</i> Punjab — Lyallpur, Montgomery, Sargodha, Sheikhupura. These were prosperous, rooted communities on the wrong side of any possible line, with the most to lose and the furthest to travel.
4. The Sikhs had nowhere else	Bengali Hindus who fled had the rest of India. Punjabi Muslims who fled had the rest of Pakistan. The Sikhs existed almost entirely in Punjab. They had no other province to fall back on, and their sacred geography ran across the whole of it. A line through Punjab did not relocate them. It cut them apart.
5. No functioning authority	The Punjab Boundary Force — about 25,000 men for twelve districts and fourteen million people — was overwhelmed within weeks and disbanded on 1 September 1947.

Punjab was not unlucky in 1947. It was the province where every factor that makes partition lethal happened to be present at once.

A NOTE ON WHAT THIS PART WILL AND WILL NOT DESCRIBE

This part deals with mass violence, forced migration and the abduction of women. I have kept description to what the analysis requires and no further, for the reasons set out in the Author's Note. Readers who have family experience of 1947 may still find Chapters 2 and 4 difficult.

CHAPTER 1 The arithmetic: why Punjab had to be divided.

CHAPTER 2 The Sikh position — and where the word "Khalistan" actually comes from.

CHAPTER 3 The Radcliffe Line: five weeks, no visits, published two days late.

CHAPTER 4 The killing: the numbers, the mechanics, and why "who started it" cannot be answered.

CHAPTER 5 The ledger: what Punjab specifically lost.

CHAPTER 6 The water, within eight months.

CHAPTER 7 What 1947 did to Punjabi politics permanently.

CHAPTER 8 Scorecard: what Part 7 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

The arithmetic

The first question this whole work was asked to answer is: why was Punjab divided? The answer is not a conspiracy or a betrayal. It is a census table, and the census table was nine hundred years in the making.

The numbers

By the 1941 census, undivided Punjab was approximately:

UNDIVIDED PUNJAB, 1941 CENSUS (APPROXIMATE)

Community	Share of population
Muslim	~53%
Hindu	~29%
Sikh	~15%
Others (Christian and others)	~3%

Now recall Part 3, Chapter 5, which explained where that Muslim majority came from and — crucially — **where it was**.

Punjab was not a province with a uniform 53% Muslim population. It was a **heavily Muslim west** — Multan, Rawalpindi, Jhelum, the Lahore division, many districts over 80% Muslim — joined administratively to a **Hindu and Sikh east**: the Jalandhar Doab, Ambala, Ludhiana, the Malwa country south of the Sutlej.

That division was formed over nine hundred years, by the mechanisms set out in Part 3: the west came under Muslim rule from around 1030, 160 years before the east; the great Sufi centres were in the west; and Brahminical institutional infrastructure was denser in the east.

Why the division followed mechanically

Once the principle was accepted — first in the Muslim League's Lahore Resolution of 1940, then definitively in the **3 June Plan of 1947** — that British India would be partitioned according to religious majority, Punjab's fate was arithmetic rather than choice.

- A province with a Muslim majority could not go wholly to India.
- A province with a 44% non-Muslim minority, concentrated in a contiguous eastern block, could not go wholly to Pakistan.

So Punjab was divided. Bengal, for exactly the same reason, was divided too. No other province was, because no other province had this configuration.

PUT SIMPLY

Punjab was cut in half because it was roughly half Muslim and half not, and the two halves lived at opposite ends of the province. Once everyone agreed that the country would be split according to which religion was in the majority, there was no way to keep Punjab whole. The line had to go somewhere in the middle.

And the part that made it a catastrophe for one community

Now apply that arithmetic to the Sikhs, and you find the specific tragedy of 1947 in Punjab.

- Sikhs were about **15% of Punjab** and roughly **2% of India**.
- **They were not a majority in a single district anywhere in the province.** Not one. Their population was spread across central Punjab in a band, dense in places, dominant nowhere.
- Their sacred geography was split down the middle. Amritsar and the Golden Temple in the east. **Nankana Sahib — Guru Nanak's birthplace — in the west.** Panja Sahib in the far north-west. Kartarpur, where Nanak died, in the west. Dera Sahib in Lahore, where Guru Arjan was martyred.
- Their most valuable landholdings were in the canal colonies of the **west**.

Put those four facts together and you get a conclusion that ought to be stated as flatly as possible:

*Any line, drawn anywhere in Punjab, would tear the Sikh community.
Not as a matter of politics or bad faith — as a matter of geography.
There was no possible border that did not do this.*

That is why the Sikh leadership's position in 1946 and 1947 looks, in retrospect, like a man being asked to choose which of his own limbs to keep. Chapter 2 is about what they actually chose, and why.

CHAPTER TWO

The Sikh position, and the word "Khalistan"

Four options were on the table between 1940 and 1947. Understanding why three of them failed is essential — and one fact in this chapter reshapes the entire argument of Part 11.

Option 1: an undivided India

This was the Akali Dal's actual preference and it was consistent. Master Tara Singh, the pre-eminent Sikh political leader of the period, opposed the creation of Pakistan and campaigned against it. On **3 March 1947**, outside the Punjab Assembly in Lahore, he publicly raised the slogan against Pakistan before a hostile crowd.

The option failed because it was not in Sikh hands. Once Congress accepted partition in principle, it was over.

DID 3 MARCH 1947 TRIGGER THE RAWALPINDI MASSACRES?

Tara Singh's gesture outside the Assembly is frequently blamed for triggering the massacres of Sikhs and Hindus that swept the Rawalpindi division days later.

The case that it did: the timing is close, the gesture was inflammatory in a charged city, and contemporary accounts link them.

The case that it did not, or not primarily: the violence in Rawalpindi, Attock, Jhelum and Multan was organised, simultaneous across a wide area, and directed at specific villages — which indicates planning rather than spontaneous reaction to a speech in a different city. Organised communal formations had been arming across Punjab through 1946.

My assessment: a single gesture does not produce coordinated attacks across four districts within days. It may well have been a trigger. It was not a cause. But I hold this loosely, and it is genuinely contested.

Option 2: join Pakistan

This was a real option, seriously offered. Jinnah made approaches to Sikh leaders with proposals of autonomy and constitutional safeguards. Some Sikh figures considered it.

It was rejected, for three reasons that were all rational at the time:

- **Historical memory.** Part 4 is not distant history to Sikhs; it is recited daily. A state defined by Islam did not look like a safe home to a community whose founding narrative includes two Gurus executed by a Muslim empire and four children killed at Sirhind. Whether that inference was fair to Jinnah's Pakistan is a separate question. It was the inference that was drawn.

- **The Muslim League's recent record in Punjab.** The communal campaigning of 1946 and the violence of early 1947 had destroyed whatever trust existed.
- **The arithmetic.** Sikhs would have been roughly 2% of Pakistan, with no leverage and constitutional guarantees enforceable by nobody.

Option 3: Azad Punjab

This is the proposal the Akali Dal actually put forward, from around 1943, and it deserves far more attention than it gets because it was constitutionally interesting.

Azad Punjab — "Free Punjab" — proposed redrawing the province's boundaries by detaching some heavily Muslim western districts and some heavily Hindu eastern ones, so that the resulting province would have **no community with an absolute majority**.

The logic was elegant. If nobody has 51%, everybody must negotiate. A Sikh bloc of perhaps 20% becomes a permanent, decisive balancing force — never able to rule, never able to be ignored. Power-sharing is not a matter of goodwill; it is arithmetically compulsory.

Note what this was: a proposal for **a differently-drawn province inside India**. Not separation. Not a Sikh state. A constitutional mechanism to make domination impossible.

It was rejected by both Congress and the Muslim League, and it died.

Option 4: a separate Sikh state — and where the word came from

Now the fact that changes things.

The word "**Khalistan**" was first used as the title of a pamphlet published in **1940** by **V. S. Bhatti**, a doctor from Ludhiana, shortly after the Muslim League's Lahore Resolution. That appears to be its first recorded appearance anywhere.

And here is what happened to it:

Master Tara Singh denounced it. The pre-eminent Sikh political leader of the era publicly rejected the pamphlet, on the grounds that it added confusion to the confusion the Muslim League had already created.

THE MOST IMPORTANT BOX IN PART 7 — CARRY THIS TO PART 11

The word "Khalistan" was coined in 1940 and **immediately repudiated by the mainstream Sikh leadership**.

At the single moment in modern history when a separate Sikh state was most plausibly available — when the British were partitioning the subcontinent, when new countries were being created out of nothing, when the Sikh community had maximum leverage as the third party whose consent both sides wanted — **the elected Sikh leadership did not ask for one**.

They asked for an undivided India. Then they asked for Azad Punjab: a redrawn province, inside India, with no absolute majority.

This matters because the Khalistan movement of the 1980s presents itself as the continuation of a long-standing Sikh national demand. It is not. In 1947 it was a fringe pamphlet that the leadership rejected. Khalistan has never been the position of the elected Sikh leadership at any point in its history, and I will demonstrate that again with the electoral evidence in Part 11.

Why a Sikh state was impossible anyway

Even setting aside what the leadership wanted, the option was not available, for reasons that are arithmetic rather than political:

- **No Sikh-majority district existed.** A state has to be somewhere, and there was nowhere with a Sikh majority to put it.
- **No contiguous territory.** The Sikh population ran in a band through central Punjab, mixed everywhere with Hindus and Muslims.
- **No sponsor.** Neither the British, nor Congress, nor the League had any interest in creating a third dominion.
- **And the sacred sites were on both sides of any possible line** — so even a successful Sikh state would have lost Nankana Sahib.

March 1947: the killing begins before independence

In March 1947, months before either country existed and five months before Radcliffe's line was published, organised massacres of Sikhs and Hindus swept the **Rawalpindi division** — Rawalpindi, Attock, Jhelum — and parts of Multan. Villages were attacked systematically. Thousands were killed.

At **Thoa Khalsa**, in Rawalpindi district, around ninety Sikh women died in a well rather than be taken. I state it because it happened and because it is remembered; I am not going to elaborate on it.

The significance of March 1947 for the argument of this part is this: **the violence did not begin when the border was announced**. It was already running, in an organised form, five months earlier. Chapter 4 returns to this.

CHAPTER THREE

The Radcliffe Line

A London barrister who had never been to India was given five weeks, outdated maps and no site visits, and told to decide where fourteen million people would live. The result was published two days after independence.

The facts of the process

HOW THE BORDER WAS DRAWN

Element	Detail
The man	Sir Cyril Radcliffe, an eminent English barrister. He had never been to India before . This was considered a qualification — it meant he had no prior connections and therefore no bias.
Arrival	Delhi, 8 July 1947 .
Time available	Roughly five weeks , for two boundary commissions — Punjab and Bengal.
The commissions	Four judges nominated by Congress, four by the Muslim League, with Radcliffe as chairman. They deadlocked completely. Radcliffe alone made the award .
His information	The 1941 census — six years out of date, and taken in circumstances where communal enumeration was already politically charged — and imprecise maps.
Site visits	None . He did not preside over the public hearings either; he read the transcripts.
Terms of reference	Demarcate on the basis of contiguous majority areas of Muslims and non-Muslims, " <i>taking into account other factors</i> ." That last phrase was never defined, and it is the source of every subsequent controversy.
Award made	12 August 1947 .
Award published	17 August 1947 — two days after independence .

The two days that killed people

That last row deserves to be sat with.

India became independent on 15 August 1947. Pakistan on 14 August. The boundary between them was not published until **17 August**.

So for the first days of both countries' existence, **millions of people in Punjab did not know which country they were in**. Villages celebrated independence without knowing whose independence it was. Families made decisions about whether to move based on rumour. Administrators did not know whose orders to follow. Police did not know who they worked for.

The delay is generally attributed to Mountbatten's desire not to have the announcement mar the independence celebrations. Whatever the reason, the effect was that the most dangerous information in the subcontinent was withheld from the people it concerned during precisely the days when the violence was accelerating.

The two controversies

Gurdaspur. Gurdaspur district had a narrow Muslim majority overall, and most of it was awarded to India. Pakistani critics have long argued this was deliberate, to give India a land route to Kashmir — which it did.

The case for the accusation: the district had a Muslim plurality; the award gave India the only viable road access to Jammu and Kashmir; and Mountbatten had both motive and access to Radcliffe.

The case against: at tehsil level — the unit Radcliffe actually worked with — the picture is more mixed, with some tehsils non-Muslim majority. The Madhopur headworks on the Ravi, which fed the canal system of eastern Punjab, were also in play. And Radcliffe's terms of reference explicitly allowed "other factors."

Ferozepur. The Ferozepur headworks on the Sutlej were awarded to India, giving India control of water feeding canals in West Punjab. There is evidence in the record that the line here was altered late in the process.

I cannot resolve either dispute and I am not going to pretend to. Both remain genuinely contested by serious historians, and the documentary record is incomplete because **Radcliffe burned his working papers** before leaving India. He also declined his fee.

What Radcliffe actually got wrong

Here is my assessment, and it is more specific than "he drew a bad line."

The general placement was largely unavoidable. The line ran roughly down the middle of the Bari Doab, between Lahore and Amritsar, because that is approximately where the Muslim-majority west met the Hindu-Sikh-majority east. As Part 3 showed, that fault line was nine hundred years old. Radcliffe did not invent it. He traced it.

The failures were procedural, and each one had a body count:

1. **Five weeks** for a task requiring years.
2. **No site visits**, so no knowledge of which villages actually shared wells, roads and irrigation channels.
3. **Six-year-old census data** as the sole demographic basis.
4. **Publication two days after independence**, which left millions in the dark during the most dangerous week.

5. **No population transfer plan** and no adequate security arrangement, which is Chapter 4.

The tragedy of the Radcliffe Line is not mainly where it went. It is that a border affecting fourteen million people was drawn in five weeks by a man who never visited the ground, and announced after the fact.

CHAPTER FOUR

The killing

This chapter gives the numbers, explains why they cannot be made precise, describes the mechanics, and then addresses the question everybody asks and nobody should.

The numbers, with their ranges

PARTITION: THE FIGURES AND THEIR SPREAD

Measure	Estimates
Deaths	Estimates range from 200,000 to 2,000,000 . Frequently cited middle estimates fall between 500,000 and 1,000,000 ; some scholars give 600,000–800,000 . The bulk of these deaths occurred in Punjab.
Displaced, Punjab alone	Around 12 million .
Displaced, subcontinent	Up to 20 million .
Punjabis who crossed the new border	Pakistan's 1951 census indicates around 14 million : roughly 8 million Muslims moving west, and 6 million Hindus and Sikhs moving east.
Women abducted	Estimates range from around 50,000 to 75,000–100,000 , with some scholarly accounts giving substantially higher figures.

Why the death toll cannot be established

A factor-of-ten range is unusual even for historical atrocity figures, so the reasons are worth stating:

- **There was no functioning administration.** The civil service, police and courts were themselves being partitioned, and their staff were themselves fleeing.
- **The victims were in motion.** People died on trains, on roads, in fields, in canals, hundreds of kilometres from anywhere they were registered.
- **Nobody was counting.** No systematic effort at enumeration was made at the time by either new state.
- **And both new governments had reasons not to look too hard.** A precise figure would have been an indictment of the transfer of power that both had just accepted, and of their own failure to protect their citizens.

What is not in dispute is the order of magnitude: **hundreds of thousands dead, and the largest forced migration in recorded human history, most of it inside one province, in roughly three months.**

The mechanics: what made it so lethal

Trains. Refugee trains ran in both directions and were attacked in both directions. There are multiple documented cases of trains arriving at their destination with everyone aboard dead.

The kafilas. Foot columns of refugees — sometimes tens of thousands of people moving together, with carts and cattle, at walking pace, for weeks. They were attacked on the road, and they were almost impossible to defend.

Organised formations, not just mobs. This is the point I most want to establish, because it is routinely softened. The violence was substantially carried out by **organised armed groups with command structures**, on all three sides. The Muslim League National Guard. Hindu organisations including the RSS. Sikh jathas, some organised around ex-servicemen. These groups planned attacks, coordinated across villages, and in many cases had lists.

Demobilised soldiers. Part 6's recruitment figures become a weapon here. Punjab was full of men who had recently returned from the Second World War with infantry training, and in many cases with access to weapons.

And no authority. The **Punjab Boundary Force**, about 25,000 men under Major-General T. W. Rees, was supposed to police twelve districts containing some fourteen million people. It was a mixed-community force, and it fractured — many of its soldiers had families among the victims on one side or the other. It was overwhelmed almost immediately and was disbanded on **1 September 1947**, about a month after it began.

"Who started it?"

Now the question, and my answer to it.

The honest response is that it cannot be established, and that in practice the question is almost always asked as a way of avoiding something.

Here is what the record actually shows:

- Organised massacres of **Sikhs and Hindus** in the Rawalpindi division took place in **March 1947** — five months before independence, before Radcliffe's line existed.
- Organised massacres of **Muslims** in East Punjab — Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Amritsar, Gurdaspur, Ambala — in **August and September 1947** were as systematic, as planned and as lethal.
- Communal killing in Punjab had precedent going back through the 1920s and 1930s, and both Bengal and Bihar had already seen mass violence in 1946.

Anyone can find an earlier atrocity to justify a later one. That is what a cycle is. Setting the clock's start point is a choice, and everybody chooses the point that makes their own community the responder rather than the initiator.

THE FACT I WANT LEFT STANDING

The killing in Punjab in 1947 was not done by a foreign army. It was done by neighbours.

By people who spoke the same language, ate the same food, wore the same clothes, farmed adjacent fields, drew water from the same wells, and in many cases had known each other's families for generations. Punjabi Muslims, Punjabi Hindus and Punjabi Sikhs killed each other, in Punjabi, over a line drawn in London.

That is the fact I want you to carry out of this chapter, because it is the one that makes every subsequent claim about eternal communal enmity *and* every claim about eternal communal harmony equally inadequate. Neither explains what happened. What explains it is that ordinary societies can be made to do this, quickly, under specific conditions — and that Punjab in 1947 had every one of those conditions at once.

Malerkotla

One exception is worth recording, because it shows what was possible.

Malerkotla was a Muslim-ruled princely state in East Punjab. During Partition, it saw essentially none of the massacre that engulfed the districts around it, and its Muslim population largely remained. It is today the one significant Muslim-majority town in Indian Punjab.

The explanation given in Punjabi tradition goes back to Part 4. When Guru Gobind Singh's two youngest sons were sentenced at Sirhind in 1704, **Sher Mohammad Khan**, the Nawab of Malerkotla, raised a formal protest against the execution of children — the *haa da naara*, the cry for justice. The tradition holds that the Guru blessed his house for it.

Whether the causation is that simple, historians can argue. What is not in doubt is that in 1947, when almost everywhere else in East Punjab was killing, Malerkotla did not, and Sikhs in the surrounding area actively protected it.

CHAPTER FIVE

The ledger

Every part of India lost something in 1947. Punjab lost a category of things that no other region lost, and it is worth listing them explicitly, in both directions.

What went west, to Pakistan

WHAT INDIAN PUNJAB LOST

Lost	What it was
Lahore	The capital of Punjab for a thousand years. The centre of Punjabi publishing, education, law and culture. Ranjit Singh's capital and the seat of the Sikh Empire.
Nankana Sahib	The birthplace of Guru Nanak.
Kartarpur Sahib	Where Guru Nanak spent his last years and died.
Panja Sahib	At Hasan Abdal, one of the most visited Sikh shrines.
Dera Sahib, Lahore	The site associated with the martyrdom of Guru Arjan.
The tomb of Ranjit Singh	Beside the Badshahi Mosque in Lahore.
The canal colonies	Lyallpur, Montgomery, Sargodha, Sheikhupura. The most productive irrigated farmland in Punjab, built over sixty years, much of it settled and developed by Sikh and Hindu farmers from the east.
Half the river system	The Indus, Jhelum and Chenab, and the great headworks and link canals of western Punjab.

The scale of the religious loss in particular has no parallel. **The majority of the most sacred sites of Sikhism ended up in another country**, one that Indian Sikhs would need a visa to enter and which has been at war with India four times since.

What went east, to India

The other side of the ledger is equally real and gets far less attention in Indian writing, so it goes here explicitly.

Around eight million Punjabi Muslims lost their homes, land, businesses and ancestral villages in Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Ambala, Hoshiarpur, Gurdaspur, Amritsar and Ferozepur. Families that had farmed the Doab for centuries walked west with what they could carry. The shrines, mosques and graves they left behind are in India.

Their descendants are Pakistani Punjabis today, and a great many of them can still name the village in Indian Punjab their grandparents came from.

And what happened to the language

One loss is rarely counted and it is substantial. Punjabi was split into two scripts and two states.

- In India: written in **Gurmukhi**, and eventually the official language of a Punjabi-speaking state — after the struggle described in Part 8.
- In Pakistan: written in **Shahmukhi**, a Perso-Arabic script. And Pakistani Punjab adopted **Urdu** as its official language.

The result is that in the province containing the largest number of Punjabi speakers on earth, Punjabi has no official status and is not the medium of education. And a Punjabi in Amritsar cannot read a book printed in Lahore, or vice versa, without learning a second script — despite speaking the same language.

Partition did not only divide the land and the people. It divided the alphabet.

CHAPTER SIX

The water, within eight months

Part 1 predicted this in the Bronze Age. Part 6 built the machine. Part 7 cuts it in half — and the first crisis arrives before Punjab has finished burying its dead.

The problem, immediately

Part 6, Chapter 3 described the canal system the British built: an integrated network designed as a single machine, with headworks controlling flow to canals hundreds of kilometres downstream.

The Radcliffe Line cut that machine in half — and, critically, it left the **headworks in India** and much of the **irrigated land in Pakistan**:

- **Madhopur headworks** on the Ravi fed the Upper Bari Doab Canal, which watered both Amritsar (India) and Lahore (Pakistan).
- **Ferozepur headworks** on the Sutlej fed the Dipalpur Canal into West Punjab and Bahawalpur, and the Bikaner Canal into India.

What happened

20 December 1947: the chief engineers of East Punjab and West Punjab signed a **Standstill Agreement** — the existing distribution of water would continue until **31 March 1948**, covering the rabi crop.

1 April 1948: the day after the agreement expired, East Punjab stopped the flow. Canals in West Punjab — including the Central Bari Doab Canal serving Lahore — ran dry.

18 April 1948: an agreement was reached between the two sides.

30 April 1948: water was restored.

A month, in the sowing season, in a semi-arid region. The economic damage and the political damage were both severe, and the episode established for Pakistan a permanent strategic anxiety about upstream control that has never gone away.

What it led to

The 1948 crisis began the negotiations that produced the **Indus Waters Treaty of 1960**, brokered by the World Bank. Its allocation:

INDUS WATERS TREATY, 1960

Rivers	Allocated to
Indus, Jhelum, Chenab (the western rivers)	Pakistan
Ravi, Beas, Sutlej (the eastern rivers)	India

THE STEP THAT PART 8 IS ABOUT — AND THE POINT MOST PEOPLE MISS

The 1960 treaty gave India the Ravi, Beas and Sutlej. That is three of Punjab's five rivers.

But those waters were then divided **again** — by the Government of India, between **Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan**.

This is the single most misunderstood point in the entire Punjab water argument, and I want it stated as plainly as possible: **Punjab's water grievance is not primarily against Pakistan. It is about how the water India received was subsequently allocated by Delhi.**

The Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal dispute, the Anandpur Sahib Resolution's demands on river waters, and a great deal of what fuelled the politics of the 1970s and 1980s all sit downstream of that second division — not the first.

Part 8 is largely about that second division, and about the broken-bargain test from Part 6 applied to it.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What 1947 did to Punjabi politics permanently

Five structural consequences, all of which are still operating. The first one surprised me most.

1. It created a Sikh-majority Punjab for the first time in history

Before 1947, Sikhs were about **15% of undivided Punjab** and were not a majority in a single district.

After the population exchange, with roughly six million Hindus and Sikhs arriving in East Punjab and eight million Muslims leaving, the Sikh share of the remaining province rose dramatically. After the further reorganisation of 1966 — Part 8 — Sikhs became a **majority** in the state of Punjab, at roughly 57–58% today.

A Sikh-majority Punjab has existed for less than sixty years. It is not an ancient condition being defended. It is a product of the partition of 1947 and the reorganisation of 1966.

I find this genuinely important and rarely stated. The political fact that underpins every argument in Parts 8 through 12 — that Punjab is a Sikh-majority state — is younger than most of the people arguing about it, and it was created by the two events that Punjabis remember as catastrophes.

2. It destroyed the Unionist Party

From 1923 to 1947, Punjab was governed largely by the **Unionist Party** — a cross-communal alliance of Muslim, Hindu and Sikh landholders, organised around agrarian interest rather than religion. Under Sikandar Hayat Khan it was the dominant force in the province and had specifically kept the Muslim League weak in Punjab.

It collapsed in the 1946 elections as communal polarisation overwhelmed class interest. Its destruction is a precondition of partition, not just a casualty of it: as long as Punjab had a functioning cross-communal governing party, the province could not be mobilised along purely religious lines.

Nothing has replaced it. No cross-communal governing formation has held Punjab since.

3. It created a refugee politics

East Punjab absorbed millions of people who had lost everything, arrived with nothing, and carried a verified first-hand grievance. That energy — hard, mobile, unsentimental, willing to

take risks because there was nothing left to lose — went into Punjabi politics, business and agriculture for decades. The Green Revolution's success in Punjab owes a great deal to refugee farmers rebuilding from zero.

4. It established the precedent: when Punjab has a problem, Punjab gets smaller

This is the one with the longest reach.

THE PATTERN

Year	Basis of division	Result
1947	Religion	Punjab divided in two. India's share: roughly one-third of the old province.
1966	Language	East Punjab divided into three — Punjab, Haryana, Himachal. Punjab reduced to 50,362 sq km.

Twice in nineteen years, Punjab's political problems were resolved by redrawing its boundaries along community lines. Twice, the outcome was a smaller Punjab.

That precedent matters enormously for Parts 11 and 12, and it cuts in two directions at once. It is the reason a section of Punjabi opinion regards further territorial argument as the natural way to seek redress. It is also the reason another section regards it with dread, having watched where the last two rounds led.

5. It gave everyone a verified grievance

After 1947, nobody in Punjab needed to be persuaded that mass atrocity was possible, that the state could fail to protect them, or that their neighbours could turn. They had seen it, personally, within living memory.

That is the emotional ground on which Parts 9 and 10 take place. When people in 1984 reacted to events with a speed and an absoluteness that outsiders found baffling, it was not because they were irrational. It was because a very large number of them, or their parents, had already lived through the thing they were afraid of.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Scorecard: what Part 7 proves

"Why was Punjab divided?"

ANSWERED — AND IT IS ARITHMETIC, NOT CONSPIRACY

Undivided Punjab was roughly 53% Muslim, with that majority concentrated in the west and a 44% non-Muslim minority concentrated in a contiguous eastern block. That configuration was formed over nine hundred years by the processes in Part 3, Chapter 5.

Once the principle of partition by religious majority was accepted, a Muslim-majority Punjab could not go wholly to India and a Punjab with a 44% non-Muslim minority could not go wholly to Pakistan. Bengal was divided for the identical reason. No other province was, because no other province had this shape.

"Khalistan was demanded by Sikhs in 1947."

FALSE — AND THIS IS THE MOST CONSEQUENTIAL FINDING IN PART 7

The word first appears as the title of a 1940 pamphlet by V. S. Bhatti of Ludhiana, and **Master Tara Singh publicly denounced it.**

The Akali Dal's actual proposals were, in order: an undivided India; and then **Azad Punjab** — a redrawn province *within India* in which no community held an absolute majority, forcing permanent power-sharing.

At the one moment when a Sikh state was most plausibly obtainable — during an active partition, with new countries being created, with the Sikhs holding real leverage as the third party — the elected Sikh leadership did not ask for one. Khalistan has never been the position of the elected Sikh leadership at any point. Part 11 tests that claim again with electoral data.

"The Sikhs chose India over Pakistan."

TRUE, BUT THE FRAMING FLATTERS EVERYONE INVOLVED

Jinnah did make real offers of autonomy and safeguards, and they were rejected — on grounds of historical memory of Mughal rule, the League's record in Punjab in 1946–47, and the arithmetic of being 2% of a religiously-defined state.

But "choice" overstates it. Sikhs were not a majority in any district in Punjab. A separate state was arithmetically impossible, not merely politically refused. And whichever side they chose, roughly half the community and most of its sacred sites would end up on the other side of a line. There was no good option, only a least-bad one.

"[One community] started the killing."

UNANSWERABLE, AND USUALLY ASKED IN BAD FAITH

Organised massacres of Sikhs and Hindus swept the Rawalpindi division in March 1947, five months before independence. Organised massacres of Muslims across East Punjab in August–September 1947 were as systematic and as lethal. Communal violence in the subcontinent had already run through Bengal and Bihar in 1946 and through Punjab in earlier decades.

All three communities had organised armed formations with command structures. All three carried out planned attacks. Choosing where to start the clock is a choice, and everyone chooses the point at which their own side becomes the responder.

The fact worth holding instead: this was done by neighbours, in the same language, over a line drawn in London.

"Radcliffe deliberately drew an unfair line."

CONTESTED AT THE MARGINS, LARGELY UNAVOIDABLE IN GENERAL

The broad placement traced a nine-hundred-year-old demographic fault line and was largely forced by the census.

Gurdaspur and Ferozepur remain genuinely disputed, the terms of reference contained an undefined "other factors" clause, and Radcliffe burned his working papers — so the record is incomplete and will stay that way.

The demonstrable failures are procedural: five weeks, no site visits, six-year-old census data, no population transfer plan, an inadequate security force, and publication **two days after independence**, which left millions not knowing which country they were in during the most dangerous week of the century.

"Partition was worse in Punjab than anywhere else."

TRUE, WITH FIVE IDENTIFIABLE CAUSES

Interspersed populations with no clean line available; hundreds of thousands of recently demobilised soldiers; canal-colony settlement that had placed Sikh and Hindu farmers deep in the west; a Sikh community with nowhere to retreat to and sacred sites on both sides; and a Boundary Force of 25,000 for fourteen million people that collapsed within a month.

"Punjab's water problems are Pakistan's fault."

FALSE AS THE PRINCIPAL CLAIM

The 1960 Indus Waters Treaty allocated the Ravi, Beas and Sutlej to India. Punjab's substantive grievance concerns what happened *next*: the division of those Indian waters between Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan by the central government.

The SYL canal dispute, the river-water clauses of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution, and a large share of the politics of the 1970s and 1980s sit downstream of that **second** allocation, not the first. Part 8 examines it.

Timeline of Part 7

1940	Muslim League's Lahore Resolution. V. S. Bhatti publishes the pamphlet <i>Khalistan</i> ; Master Tara Singh denounces it.
1941	Census: undivided Punjab ~53% Muslim, ~29% Hindu, ~15% Sikh.
c. 1943	Akali Dal proposes Azad Punjab — a redrawn province inside India with no absolute majority.
1946	Punjab elections. The cross-communal Unionist Party collapses. Communal violence in Bengal and Bihar.
3 March 1947	Master Tara Singh raises the anti-Pakistan slogan outside the Punjab Assembly, Lahore.
March 1947	Organised massacres of Sikhs and Hindus across the Rawalpindi division, Attock, Jhelum and Multan. Thoa Khalsa.
3 June 1947	The Mountbatten Plan. Partition confirmed; Punjab and Bengal to be divided.
8 July 1947	Cyril Radcliffe arrives in Delhi , having never been to India. Five weeks to draw two borders.
Aug 1947	Punjab Boundary Force — 25,000 men for 12 districts and 14 million people — deploys.
12 Aug 1947	Radcliffe completes the awards.
14–15 Aug 1947	Pakistan and India become independent. The border has not been published.
17 Aug 1947	The Radcliffe Award is published — two days after independence.
Aug–Nov 1947	The main period of killing and migration. Estimates: 200,000 to 2 million dead; ~12 million displaced in Punjab; 50,000–100,000+ women abducted.
1 Sept 1947	The Punjab Boundary Force is disbanded, overwhelmed.
20 Dec 1947	Standstill Agreement on canal water between East and West Punjab, valid to 31 March 1948.
1 April 1948	East Punjab stops the water. Canals serving Lahore run dry.
18 April 1948	Agreement reached. 30 April : water restored.
1960	Indus Waters Treaty. Indus, Jhelum and Chenab to Pakistan; Ravi, Beas and Sutlej to India — to be divided again between Indian states.

What happens in Part 8

Part 8, *Redrawing Punjab*, covers 1947 to 1980, and it is the part where the modern crisis is actually built. Everything people argue about when they argue about 1984 was decided in these thirty-three years.

It covers the **Punjabi Suba movement** — a fifteen-year campaign for a Punjabi-speaking state, which raises the uncomfortable question of why Punjabi Hindus declared Hindi as their mother tongue in the 1951 and 1961 censuses. It covers the **1966 reorganisation** that

created Haryana and Himachal and reduced Punjab to a seventh of its historical size. It covers **Chandigarh** — a capital built for a province that no longer exists, promised to Punjab repeatedly and never delivered. It covers the **river waters** and the origins of the Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal.

It covers the **Green Revolution**, which made Punjab rich and India food-secure, and which planted every ecological and economic problem that Part 13 will have to account for.

And it covers the **Anandpur Sahib Resolution of 1973** — the document at the centre of everything that follows, which is quoted constantly by people who have not read it, and which I will reproduce and examine clause by clause.

Above all, Part 8 applies the **broken-bargain test** from Part 6 to the Indian state's dealings with Punjab. What was promised — on language, territory, the capital, the rivers and constitutional status? What was delivered? And how much of what happened afterwards is explained by the gap?

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 7

Primary and documentary sources

- **Report of the Punjab Boundary Commission, 1947** (the Radcliffe Award) — the full text, including the terms of reference and the dissenting notes of the four Congress and four League members, is available online.
- **Census of India, 1941** — the demographic basis on which the award was made.
- **Census of Pakistan, 1951** — the source for the migration figures.
- **Transfer of Power papers** (ed. Nicholas Mansergh) — the British documentary record of 1942–47.
- **Standstill Agreement**, 20 December 1947, and the Inter-Dominion Agreement of May 1948 on canal waters; **Indus Waters Treaty**, 1960 (full text from the World Bank).
- The **1947 Partition Archive** and Citizens Archive of Pakistan — oral history collections holding thousands of first-person testimonies from all three communities.

Modern scholarship

- **Ian Talbot** and **Gurharpal Singh**, *The Partition of India* — the best short scholarly overview, and careful on the casualty estimates.
- **Ishtiaq Ahmed**, *The Punjab Bloodied, Partitioned and Cleansed* — the most thorough district-by-district account of the violence in Punjab, drawing on interviews on both sides of the border. Notable for its even-handedness.
- **Yasmin Khan**, *The Great Partition* — excellent on the administrative collapse and the failure of planning.
- **Urvashi Butalia**, *The Other Side of Silence* — the essential work on women, abduction and recovery, and on what the "recovery" operations themselves did to women.
- **Ritu Menon** and **Kamla Bhasin**, *Borders and Boundaries* — on women and Partition.
- **Anders Bjørn Hansen**, *Partition and Genocide* — on the organised character of the violence in Punjab.
- **Lucy Chester**, *Borders and Conflict in South Asia: The Radcliffe Boundary Commission* — the standard scholarly account of how the line was actually drawn.
- **Ayesha Jalal**, *The Sole Spokesman* — the essential revisionist account of Jinnah's actual objectives.
- **J. S. Grewal**, *The Sikhs of the Punjab*, and **Harnik Deol**, *Religion and Nationalism in India* — on the Sikh political position in the 1940s.
- **Daniel Haines**, *Rivers Divided: Indus Basin Waters in the Making of India and Pakistan* — on the 1948 crisis and the road to the 1960 treaty.
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- Wiley's *Encyclopedia of Global Human Migration* (Zamindar) and the *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society* for migration and casualty ranges.

ON THE RANGES IN THIS PART

The death toll estimates in Chapter 4 span a factor of ten and the abduction figures span a factor of six. I have given the ranges and explained why they cannot be narrowed.

Anyone who gives you a single confident figure for Partition deaths — in either direction, and there are people with strong motives in both — is telling you about their politics rather than about 1947.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 7 —

Part 8: *Redrawing Punjab*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART EIGHT OF THIRTEEN

Redrawing Punjab

1947 to 1980 — the language, the map, the capital, the water, and the document at the centre of everything

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 8

This is the part where the modern crisis is actually built, and it is the part I expect to be attacked from both directions — which is usually a sign that the method is working.

In Part 6 I found a tool I called the **broken-bargain test**: when Punjab rebels, look for the specific promise that was broken, by whom, and what was delivered instead. I promised to apply it to the Indian state's dealings with Punjab. Chapter 8 does that,

file by file, in a table.

The result is not what either camp wants. On one file the Centre's failure is total and indefensible. On another, Punjab's case is genuinely contestable and the other side has a serious argument. On one, the promise was actually *kept*. And on one of the loudest grievances, the legal reality is considerably narrower than Sikh nationalist writing claims — while the political handling of it was still stupid and needlessly wounding.

Two things I want to say plainly before you start.

First, one of the wounds in this part was not inflicted by Delhi. Chapter 1 deals with the 1951 and 1961 censuses, in which large numbers of Punjabi Hindus recorded Hindi as their mother tongue, under organised encouragement, in order to defeat the demand for a Punjabi-speaking state. That is Punjabis acting against Punjabis, and an honest accounting has to say so rather than folding it into a story about central government oppression. I have given the Punjabi Hindu case at full strength

too, because there was one.

Second, on the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. It is the most quoted and least read document in this entire story. Chapter 7 examines it properly — including the fact that *there is no single agreed text*, that the 1973 and 1978 versions differ in important ways, and that this is precisely why both "federalism charter" and "secessionist charter"

can be argued from real material.

Chapter 8 ends with a tension I have deliberately not resolved. Part 4 gave me the tenth Guru's own test — the sword is righteous only when all other means have failed. Part 8 is where I have to establish, from the record, whether they had. My honest answer at the end of 1980 is *no, not all of them* — and also that a constitutional route which produces two signed agreements and two broken deadlines across fifteen years is

a route that has stopped functioning as one.

Both of those are true. I take them into Part 9 unresolved, because that is the state the actual participants were in.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

Thirty-three years

Everything that people argue about when they argue about 1984 was decided between 1947 and 1980. If you understand these thirty-three years, Part 9 becomes explicable. If you do not, it looks like madness arriving from nowhere.

There are six files, and this part takes them one at a time.

THE SIX FILES

File	The question at issue
Language	Would Punjab get a Punjabi-speaking state, as every other major linguistic region of India did?
Territory	Where would its boundaries run, and which Punjabi-speaking areas were left out?
The capital	Who gets Chandigarh?
Water	How are the Ravi, Beas and Sutlej divided between Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan?
Constitutional status	Article 25 and the legal definition of Sikhs.
The economy	The Green Revolution bargain — Punjab grows India's food, India guarantees to buy it.

Each file gets the same treatment: what was promised, what was delivered, and what the other side's strongest argument is. Chapter 8 assembles the results into a single verdict table.

THE WARNING ATTACHED TO THE TEST

I set this out in Part 6 and it applies with maximum force here: **a broken bargain explains why a grievance is real. It does not by itself justify any particular response to it.**

The Akalis and the Ghadarites faced comparable breaches in the colonial period and chose opposite methods with entirely different results. Establishing that Punjab was wronged — and on at least one file it plainly was — settles nothing about what followed. Part 9 is where that second question gets asked.

CHAPTER 1	The language file: Punjabi Suba, and the census nobody wants to discuss.
CHAPTER 2	The territory file: what 1966 actually did to the map.
CHAPTER 3	The capital file: Chandigarh, promised twice, delivered never.
CHAPTER 4	The water file: SYL, the riparian argument, and the part nobody mentions.
CHAPTER 5	The economic file: the Green Revolution bargain and its hidden invoice.

CHAPTER 6 The constitutional file: Article 25, and a signature withheld in 1949.

CHAPTER 7 The Anandpur Sahib Resolution: the document at the centre of everything.

CHAPTER 8 The broken-bargain audit — and the Zafarnama question.

CHAPTER 9 The Emergency, and how Part 9 begins.

CHAPTER ONE

The language file

India reorganised itself on linguistic lines through the 1950s. Punjab was the one major linguistic region refused. It took fifteen years, tens of thousands of arrests, and a war to get what Andhra got in 1953.

What India did for everyone else

After independence, the demand for states drawn on language grew across India. The government resisted, then gave way:

- **1953** — **Andhra State** created for Telugu speakers, after Potti Sriramulu died on hunger strike.
- **1956** — the **States Reorganisation Act** redrew most of India on linguistic lines: Kerala, Karnataka, and a much-enlarged Andhra Pradesh.
- **1960** — Bombay State split into **Maharashtra** and **Gujarat**.

The principle was settled and applied nationally: *a language community with a contiguous territory gets a state.*

What India did not do for Punjab

The Akali Dal demanded a **Punjabi Suba** — a Punjabi-speaking state — from the early 1950s.

The States Reorganisation Commission of 1955 **rejected it**. Its reasoning had two parts:

1. That Punjabi and Hindi were not sufficiently distinct languages to justify a separation.
2. That the demand was, in substance, communal rather than linguistic.

The second reason was the real one, and everyone knew it. In Punjab, "Punjabi-speaking area" meant, in practice, "Sikh-majority area," because Punjabi in Gurmukhi script was identified with Sikhs. Creating a Punjabi Suba meant creating India's only state with a non-Hindu majority, less than a decade after a partition on religious lines. The government of India was not willing to do that.

THE GOVERNMENT'S CASE, STATED FAIRLY

It was not an unreasonable worry, and I should say so. Nehru's government had just watched a religious-majority argument tear the country in half and kill hundreds of thousands of people. Conceding a state defined — however indirectly — by religious demography looked, from Delhi in 1955, like re-running the experiment that had just failed.

The counter-argument is equally strong: refusing the only linguistic community in India denied a linguistic state, on the grounds that its members were the wrong religion, is precisely the kind of exception that converts a linguistic demand into a communal one. The policy created the outcome it feared.

And now the part that is hardest to write

In the **1951 and 1961 censuses**, very large numbers of Punjabi Hindus — particularly in the towns — recorded their mother tongue as **Hindi**.

This was not random. Organised campaigns by Hindu organisations in Punjab — the Arya Samaj, the Jan Sangh, the Punjab Hindi Raksha Samiti — actively urged Punjabi Hindus to declare Hindi, explicitly in order to reduce the recorded number of Punjabi speakers and thereby defeat the Punjabi Suba demand.

It worked. The census produced a Punjab in which a large share of the population officially did not speak the language they actually spoke at home, and that data was then used to argue that no Punjabi-speaking state was justified.

BOTH SIDES OF THE CENSUS QUESTION

HOW THIS LOOKED TO PUNJABI SIKHS

Your neighbours — people who spoke Punjabi in their homes, whose mothers sang Punjabi songs, whose ancestors had spoken it for a thousand years — publicly denied their own mother tongue in an official government count, specifically in order to stop you having a state.

The message received was not about administration. It was: *your language is a problem, and we will lie on a form to make sure it does not get recognised*. Fifty years later, this is still cited in Punjabi Sikh political writing, and I do not think that is disproportionate. It is a genuinely wounding thing to have happened.

HOW THIS LOOKED TO PUNJABI HINDUS

They had reasons that were not merely malicious, and honesty requires stating them.

They had just fled West Punjab as refugees, and Hindi as the national language felt like the guarantee of belonging to an Indian nation that had just been proved fragile. Punjabi was, in official use, written in Gurmukhi — a script created by a Sikh Guru and inseparably associated with Sikh religious life; accepting it as their official language felt to many like accepting a Sikh cultural framework. And they had a concrete political fear: in a Sikh-majority state, they would be a permanent minority, in a country where being on the wrong side of a majority had just cost a million lives.

Wrong, in my view, and disastrous in effect. But not motiveless.

THE FINDING I WANT ON THE RECORD

This wound was not inflicted by Delhi. It was inflicted by Punjabis on Punjabis.

And its effect was to make **language a communal marker in Punjab permanently**. After the 1961 census, Punjabi Suba could never again be a purely secular linguistic demand, because one community had publicly disowned the language and the other had been forced to defend it as a religious inheritance.

Every account of this period that presents Punjab's grievances as purely a Punjab-versus-Centre story is leaving this out. I am not going to.

How it was finally won

The Akali campaign ran for fifteen years: fasts by **Master Tara Singh**, then leadership passing to **Sant Fateh Singh**, repeated *morchas*, and mass arrests. In the 1960–61 agitation alone, around **26,000 people** courted arrest.

The concession came in 1966, and the timing tells you a great deal. It followed the **1965 war with Pakistan**, in which Sikh soldiers had again served in numbers far beyond their share of the population and with conspicuous distinction. A parliamentary committee under **Hukam Singh** recommended reorganisation, and Indira Gandhi's government accepted it.

The **Punjab Reorganisation Act, 1966** was passed on 18 September and came into effect on **1 November 1966**.

Punjab got its state. Thirteen years after Andhra, and only after another war.

CHAPTER TWO

The territory file

The 1966 Act gave Punjab a state and, in the same stroke, created almost every dispute of the next sixty years.

What the Act did

The old East Punjab was divided into four pieces:

THE 1966 REORGANISATION

Unit	Basis	Result
Punjab	Punjabi-speaking	50,362 sq km
Haryana	Hindi-speaking	44,212 sq km. India's seventeenth state.
Himachal Pradesh	Hill areas transferred	Union Territory, becoming a full state in 1971
Chandigarh	Contested	Union Territory , joint capital of Punjab and Haryana — "temporarily"

The size arithmetic

Set the numbers out in sequence and the scale of the reduction becomes visible.

PUNJAB, SHRINKING

Period	Approximate area	Share of the historical province
Undivided British Punjab, pre-1947	~350,000 sq km	100%
East Punjab, 1947	~96,000 sq km	~27%
Punjab, from 1966	50,362 sq km	~14%

In nineteen years, Punjab went from 350,000 square kilometres to 50,000. Twice, the way its political problems were resolved was by making it smaller.

The boundary grievance

The Punjabi complaint about 1966 is that the linguistic principle was applied inconsistently, and that Punjabi-speaking areas were assigned to Haryana and Himachal.

The named areas most often cited include parts of the Kharar and Kandaghat regions, and villages in the Ambala and Sirsa belts.

The Punjabi case: the boundary was drawn using the contaminated census data described in Chapter 1. If a large share of Punjabi Hindus had recorded Hindi as their mother tongue, then any boundary drawn from that data would systematically under-count Punjabi-speaking territory and hand it to Haryana. The distortion was not incidental to the outcome; it produced the outcome.

The counter-case: census data is the only workable basis for a linguistic boundary, and no government can draw a line from what it suspects people would have said if they had answered differently. The Act also provided for later adjustment through commissions.

My assessment: the Punjabi objection here is logically sound and practically unanswerable — a boundary drawn from data that was deliberately corrupted will be wrong. But the corruption was not the Centre's doing, and there was no fair alternative method available in 1966. This is a real grievance whose author is largely local.

What Punjab lost in practical terms

- **Its capital.** Chandigarh became a Union Territory administered by the Centre — Chapter 3.
- **Its High Court.** Shared with Haryana, and still shared today.
- **Control of Bhakra-Nangal.** The great dam complex was placed under the **Bhakra Beas Management Board**, a central body — so Punjab's principal water infrastructure was no longer under Punjab's control.
- **Control over the allocation of its own rivers**, by way of Section 78 of the Act — Chapter 4.

THE STRUCTURAL POINT

The 1966 Act settled the language question and left three things open: **Chandigarh, the boundary, and the water.**

Every major Punjab-Centre dispute for the next sixty years is one of those three. The Act did not resolve Punjab's politics. It converted one large question into three permanent ones.

CHAPTER THREE

The capital file

Of the six files in this part, this is the only one where the verdict is not difficult. A capital was promised to Punjab in writing, with a deadline, by two Prime Ministers, fifteen years apart. Neither promise was kept.

How Chandigarh came to exist

Punjab lost Lahore in 1947. East Punjab needed a capital, and there was none — every significant city of the old province was on the other side of the line.

So one was built. Chandigarh was designed from scratch in the 1950s, with Le Corbusier as its principal planner, on land acquired from **Punjabi-speaking villages** in the Kharar area. It opened as the capital of East Punjab.

In 1966 the state that had built it was divided, and rather than assign the capital to one successor, the Act made Chandigarh a **Union Territory** and the joint capital of both — explicitly as a temporary arrangement.

It has now been temporary for sixty years.

The promises, in sequence

CHANDIGARH: WHAT WAS COMMITTED, AND WHAT HAPPENED

Date	The commitment	Outcome
1970	Indira Gandhi's award: Chandigarh to Punjab , with the Fazilka–Abohar area transferred to Haryana in compensation, plus central funds for a new Haryana capital. Transfer to be completed by January 1975 .	Not implemented.
1985	Rajiv–Longowal Accord , 24 July 1985: Chandigarh to Punjab, with a firm date — 26 January 1986 . Hindi-speaking areas to Haryana, to be determined by a commission.	Not implemented.
1986 onward	A succession of commissions — Venkataramiah, Desai and others — to determine the compensating territory.	No implementable settlement produced.
2026	—	Chandigarh remains a Union Territory.

Why it kept failing

The mechanism of failure is worth understanding, because it is not simple bad faith.

Both settlements were structured as a **swap**: Punjab gets Chandigarh, Haryana gets compensating Hindi-speaking territory. The territory identified was the **Abohar and Fazilka** belt.

There were two problems with that.

First, Punjab would not give it up. Abohar and Fazilka are prime cotton-growing country, and no Punjab government could survive handing them over.

Second — and this is the decisive technical point — the swap was geographically impossible. The Mathew Commission found that Abohar and Fazilka tehsils **are not contiguous with Haryana**. There is Punjabi territory in between. You cannot transfer a district to a state it does not touch without also transferring a corridor, which nobody had agreed to.

The Government of India promised Punjab its capital in 1970, in exchange for territory that could not physically be transferred — and then made the same promise again in 1985 without having fixed the problem.

The verdict, and Haryana's case

Haryana's argument, at full strength: Haryana has never had a capital of its own either. It has built sixty years of administration, courts and infrastructure in Chandigarh. It did not make or break the promise — the Centre did. And Haryana was offered compensating territory that Punjab then refused to hand over, so from Haryana's side the deal collapsed because Punjab would not perform its half.

That is a fair argument and it should be stated. But it does not change the finding.

VERDICT ON THE CAPITAL FILE

This is a broken promise, and it is not arguable.

Two Prime Ministers, two written commitments, two specified deadlines, sixty years, zero delivery. The Centre committed to something it had not verified it could deliver, and then re-committed to the same thing fifteen years later without having solved the obstacle that defeated it the first time.

Whatever else is contested in this part, this file is not. When Punjabis say promises were made and broken, this is the file they are entitled to point at.

CHAPTER FOUR

The water file

Part 1 predicted this from the geology. Here is the argument itself, explained as simply as I can manage — including the element of it that is genuinely indefensible and that almost nobody discusses.

The setup

From Part 7: the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 gave India the **Ravi, Beas and Sutlej**. Those waters then had to be divided between Indian states.

1955: the allocation that started it

Before reorganisation, in **1955**, the Centre allocated the available Ravi and Beas waters — around 15.85 million acre-feet (MAF) — as follows:

THE 1955 ALLOCATION OF RAVI-BEAS WATERS

State	Allocation	Is it on these rivers?
Rajasthan	8.00 MAF	No — not a riparian state of the Ravi or Beas
Undivided Punjab	7.20 MAF	Yes
Jammu & Kashmir	0.65 MAF	Yes

Read the first row again, because this is the part that gets lost in the noise about Haryana.

In 1955, Rajasthan — through which neither the Ravi nor the Beas flows — was allocated more of those rivers' water than Punjab, through which both flow.

This predates the 1966 reorganisation entirely. It is not about Haryana. And in my view it is the single strongest and least-discussed element of Punjab's entire water case.

1966 and 1976: Section 78

Section 78 of the Punjab Reorganisation Act gave the **central government** the power to allocate the waters between the successor states.

In **1976**, acting under that section, the Centre allocated **3.5 MAF each to Punjab and Haryana**, and 0.2 MAF to Delhi.

To deliver Haryana's share physically, a canal was needed to carry water from the Sutlej system across to the Yamuna. That is the **Sutlej–Yamuna Link canal** — 214 kilometres, of which the Haryana portion was built and the Punjab portion was not.

The two arguments, at full strength

THE WATER DISPUTE, BOTH SIDES

PUNJAB'S CASE

The riparian principle. In water law and in Indian practice, river water belongs to the basin states the river runs through. **None of the Ravi, Beas or Sutlej flows through Haryana** — Haryana lies in the Yamuna–Ganga basin. Punjab argues that no other Indian state is required to hand river water to a non-riparian state, and that being made to do so is an exception applied to Punjab alone.

Section 78 is an intrusion. Water is a State subject under the Constitution. Section 78 handed a central government the power to allocate a state's rivers, which Punjab argues is constitutionally improper.

And there is no surplus. Punjab's groundwater table is collapsing — Part 13 has the data. The state is not withholding a surplus; it is over-drawing an already failing resource. The 1976 allocation was calculated on flow estimates that are now widely regarded as optimistic.

HARYANA'S CASE

Successor-state obligation. Haryana was part of Punjab until 1966. Its farmers were inside the same irrigation system and were covered by the same 1955 allocation to "undivided Punjab." Punjab kept the assets, the institutions and the infrastructure of the joint state; it cannot keep the water and disclaim the corresponding obligation to the other successor.

The allocation is lawful. It was made under Section 78 of an Act passed by Parliament, and Punjab accepted the framework at the time.

And the courts agree. The Supreme Court has repeatedly ruled in Haryana's favour, including striking down Punjab's Termination of Agreements Act of 2004 as unconstitutional in its 2016 Presidential Reference opinion.

MY ASSESSMENT ON WATER

This file is genuinely hard, and I am not going to pretend otherwise for the sake of a clean verdict.

The riparian principle is a real principle with real force. The successor-state obligation is also a real principle with real force. When a state is divided, the assets and liabilities of the joint state have to be apportioned somehow, and "the river happens to run through my half" is not a complete answer to that.

But the 1955 allocation of 8 MAF to Rajasthan is a different matter. Rajasthan is neither riparian nor a successor state of Punjab. It has no claim under either principle. It received the largest single share, and that allocation has never been seriously revisited.

That is the part of Punjab's case I find strongest, and it is striking how rarely it features in the public argument — which tends to be conducted entirely as Punjab versus Haryana, with the largest allocation of all sitting outside the frame.

CHAPTER FIVE

The economic file

The one bargain in this part that was kept. It made Punjab the richest state in India, it fed the country, and it planted every ecological problem that Part 13 will have to account for.

The deal

In the mid-1960s India was importing wheat under American food aid and facing serious famine risk. The response was the **Green Revolution**: high-yielding seed varieties, chemical fertiliser, assured irrigation, and — critically — a guaranteed purchase price.

Punjab was selected as the lead region for a specific reason set out in Part 6: it already had the irrigation infrastructure. Eighty years of canal building, plus the Bhakra-Nangal complex, meant Punjab could deliver assured water, which is what the new seeds required.

The bargain, stated plainly:

THE GREEN REVOLUTION BARGAIN

Punjab grows what India needs — wheat and rice — and India guarantees to buy it at a set price.

That is the deal. It is worth stating explicitly because it is still running, it is the single largest fact about Punjab's economy, and it becomes decisive in Part 12.

It worked, spectacularly

Punjab — around 1.5% of India's land area — came to supply an enormous share of the central grain pool, at times in the region of 60% of the wheat and 40% of the rice procured nationally. India moved from food imports to self-sufficiency. By the 1970s and 1980s Punjab had the highest per-capita income of any Indian state.

This is not a small achievement and it should not be grudged. A great deal of what India became after 1970 rests on what Punjabi farmers did in this period.

The invoice, which arrives in Part 13

Every element of the success carried a cost that was not visible at the time:

- **Monoculture.** Punjab's cropping collapsed into a wheat–paddy cycle, because those were the two crops with guaranteed procurement. Diversity disappeared.
- **Paddy.** Rice is not a natural Punjab crop. It is a wetland crop being grown in a semi-arid plain, and it consumes water on a scale the region does not have. Punjab grows rice it does

not eat, using water it does not have, because that is what the procurement system pays for.

- **Groundwater.** Free or heavily subsidised electricity for tubewells, from the 1970s onward, made it rational for every farmer to pump. The water table began falling and has not stopped.
- **Soil and chemicals.** Fertiliser and pesticide dependence, declining soil organic matter, and the health consequences that Part 13 examines.
- **Debt.** Mechanisation required capital. Input costs rose faster than support prices. Farm debt became structural rather than occasional.
- **Fragmenting holdings.** Punjabi inheritance divides land among sons. Prosperous farms became several small ones, then several unviable ones.

The political consequence, which is counterintuitive

Here is a point I think is underrated, and it matters for Part 9.

The Green Revolution created a **prosperous, confident, politically assertive rural class** — Jat Sikh farmers with cash, tractors, education for their sons, and time. And that is precisely the class that provided the membership, the money and the organisational muscle of the Akali movement through the 1970s.

Prosperity did not reduce Punjab's political demands. It financed them. The most assertive phase of Punjabi politics coincides exactly with Punjab being the richest state in India.

Anyone who explains the 1980s as a product of poverty or backwardness has the economics backwards. Punjab in 1980 was not a deprived region. It was a rich region with a list of grievances and the means to press them.

CHAPTER SIX

The constitutional file

The most-cited Sikh grievance against the Indian Constitution. Its legal effect is much narrower than nationalist writing claims — and the political handling of it was still needlessly stupid.

What Article 25 actually says

Article 25 of the Constitution guarantees freedom of conscience and the right to profess, practise and propagate religion. Attached to it is **Explanation II**, which provides that in the relevant sub-clause, the reference to Hindus "*shall be construed as including a reference to persons professing the Sikh, Jaina or Buddhist religion.*"

What it does and does not do

Let me be precise, because both sides overstate this.

What it does: the sub-clause it attaches to concerns throwing open Hindu religious institutions of a public character to all classes and sections. Its purpose was to ensure that reform legislation — particularly temple-entry laws abolishing caste exclusion — applied to Sikh, Jain and Buddhist institutions too. Read narrowly, it is an anti-caste provision.

What it does not do: it does not declare Sikhs to be Hindus for all purposes. Sikhs have distinct legal recognition elsewhere: the **Anand Marriage Act 1909** (amended in 2012 to provide for separate registration of Sikh marriages), and recognition as a minority under the **National Commission for Minorities Act 1992**. Article 25 itself explicitly protects the wearing and carrying of kirpans as part of the Sikh religion.

So why does it matter so much?

Because constitutions are symbolic documents as well as legal ones, and being defined inside another religion in your country's founding text is not a small thing for a community whose entire modern history — Part 4, and Kahn Singh Nabha's *Ham Hindu Nahin* in 1898 — has been an assertion of distinctness.

And there is a fact from 1949 that is rarely mentioned and should be.

THE SIGNATURE THAT WAS WITHHELD

The Sikh members of the Constituent Assembly — **Sardar Hukam Singh** and **Sardar Bhupinder Singh Mann** — **refused to sign the Constitution of India** in 1949, in protest at the failure to provide the safeguards Sikhs had sought.

This is documented, it happened at the founding moment of the republic, and it is almost never taught. It matters because it establishes that Sikh constitutional dissatisfaction is not a product of the 1970s or of Bhindranwale. It is dated to the day the Constitution was adopted.

My assessment

On the law: the practical effect of Explanation II is limited, and Sikh nationalist writing routinely overstates it — it is not a declaration that Sikhism is a branch of Hinduism, and it has not been used as one.

On the politics: this clause has been cited as a grievance in every significant Akali document since 1950. Amending or clarifying it would have cost the Indian state essentially nothing — no revenue, no territory, no water, no precedent that threatens anyone. It is the cheapest concession on the entire list.

It has not been made in seventy-five years.

That is not a failure of law. It is a failure of political imagination, and of the most ordinary kind: a grievance that could have been closed for free was left open, and it kept being available to whoever wanted to use it.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Anandpur Sahib Resolution

The most quoted and least read document in this story. Before you can judge what anyone did with it, you have to know what it says — and the first surprising fact is that there is no single agreed text.

The context

By 1973 the Akali Dal was out of power in Punjab, internally factional, and needed a platform. Its working committee adopted a set of resolutions at Anandpur Sahib on **16–17 October 1973**.

What it demanded

Grouping the demands honestly, they fall under five heads:

THE ANANDPUR SAHIB DEMANDS

Category	Substance
Territorial	Chandigarh to Punjab. Transfer of the Punjabi-speaking areas left out in 1966.
Water	Control of Punjab's river waters and headworks; application of the riparian principle.
Constitutional / federal	The Centre's powers to be limited to defence, foreign affairs, currency and communications , with all residual powers to the states.
Religious	Recognition of Sikhism as a religion distinct from Hinduism; an All-India Gurdwara Act; amendment of Article 25.
Economic and social	Industrial development for Punjab; continued army recruitment; welfare measures; representation.

Notice how much of that list is simply the earlier chapters of this part. Chandigarh is Chapter 3. Water is Chapter 4. Article 25 is Chapter 6. The boundary is Chapter 2. **The Anandpur Sahib Resolution is, in substantial part, a bill for unpaid promises.**

The versions problem, which is the crux

Here is the thing that makes every argument about this document so slippery, and it is rarely stated plainly.

There is no single canonical text.

- The **1973** working-committee resolutions focused substantially on a special constitutional status for Sikhs and on Punjab's specific demands.

- The **1978 Ludhiana version**, endorsed at the 18th All-India Akali Conference on 28–29 October 1978, **widened the autonomy demand to all states**, recasting Centre–State relations generally rather than seeking a special arrangement for Punjab alone.
- Multiple translations circulated, differing in emphasis and in some cases in substance, and the Akali Dal itself issued different formulations at different times.

This is not a technicality. It means that **both** readings — "federalism charter" and "secessionist charter" — can be argued from real text, and that people quoting it at each other are frequently quoting different documents.

The two readings, at full strength

WHAT THE ANANDPUR SAHIB RESOLUTION MEANT

THE CONGRESS READING: A SECESSIONIST CHARTER

It sought a special constitutional status for a **religious community**, not merely for a state — which is a different and more dangerous thing in a secular republic. Some versions contain language about the pre-eminence of the Khalsa and about a Sikh homeland that has no parallel in any other state-autonomy document.

Reducing the Union to four subjects — defence, foreign affairs, currency and communications — would functionally dismember India. A Centre without control of finance, planning, or internal security is not a federal centre; it is a confederal shell.

And the framing was religious throughout, adopted at a sacred site, invoking the Khalsa. In a country partitioned on religious lines within living memory, that is not an innocent choice of language.

THE AKALI READING: A FEDERALISM DOCUMENT

The 1978 version demands greater autonomy for **all states**, not special treatment for Punjab. That is a federalism argument, and it was being made across India at the time — by the DMK in Tamil Nadu (the Rajamannar Committee, 1971), by the CPI(M) in West Bengal, and later by many state governments in the Sarkaria Commission process.

The specific demands — Chandigarh, water, Punjabi-speaking areas — were not new claims. They were **demands for the implementation of commitments the Centre had already made**. Chapter 3 of this part shows the Chandigarh commitment in writing with a deadline.

And the resolution explicitly affirmed that Punjab would remain within India. It did not ask to leave.

My assessment

On the substance: read as a whole, and particularly in the 1978 version, this is a **federalism document**. Its central constitutional demand is a maximalist version of an argument that was mainstream in Indian politics at the time and is not, in itself, secessionist.

It is not more extreme than what the Rajamannar Committee had already proposed in Tamil Nadu.

On the framing: and yet. The religious language, the invocation of the Khalsa, the claim to special status for a community rather than a state — these have no equivalent in the DMK's or the CPI(M)'s federalism arguments. That framing is what made the document usable in two opposite directions: by Congress as proof of secessionism, and later by militants as proof of an unfulfilled national demand. The Akali Dal wrote a document that could be read against itself, and then spent a decade being surprised that it was.

THE DECISIVE FACT IS NOT WHAT IT MEANT

It is what was *done* with it.

Indira Gandhi and the Congress leadership declared the Anandpur Sahib Resolution a secessionist charter and refused to treat it as a basis for negotiation. That decision closed the constitutional route on the one comprehensive statement of Akali demands that existed.

Hold on to this, because it goes directly into the Zafarnama test in the next chapter. If a document that is substantially a bill for unpaid promises is declared treasonous rather than negotiated, the question "have all other means been exhausted?" becomes considerably harder to answer with a confident no.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The broken-bargain audit

Six files, one table. This is the analytical purpose of Part 8, and the answer is more mixed than either side of this argument wants it to be.

THE BROKEN-BARGAIN TEST APPLIED, 1947–1980

File	Promised	Delivered	Verdict
Language / statehood	Linguistic reorganisation, applied across India from 1953.	Refused for Punjab until 1966 — thirteen years after Andhra, and only after a war.	DELAYED, THEN DELIVERED. The grievance is about the delay and its stated reason, not the outcome.
Territory	A state comprising the Punjabi-speaking areas.	A boundary drawn from census data that had been deliberately corrupted.	DISPUTED — and the corruption was largely local, not central.
Chandigarh	Transfer to Punjab. Indira Gandhi, 1970, deadline January 1975. Rajiv Gandhi, 1985, deadline 26 January 1986.	Nothing. Still a Union Territory in 2026.	BROKEN. Two Prime Ministers, two written commitments, two deadlines, sixty years, zero delivery. Not arguable.
Water	An allocation on recognised principles.	1955: 8 MAF to non-riparian Rajasthan, more than Punjab. 1976: central allocation under Section 78. SYL ordered.	GENUINELY CONTESTED — with one indefensible element, the Rajasthan share, which almost nobody argues about.
Constitutional status	Nothing was explicitly promised.	Article 25 Explanation II left unamended for seventy-five years.	NOT A BROKEN PROMISE — but a cost-free concession never made, and a grievance left permanently available.
The economy	Grow India's food; India buys it at a guaranteed price.	Delivered. Punjab became the richest state in India.	KEPT. This one was kept, and it should be said.

What the table shows

Three things, and none of them is the story either camp tells.

1. The grievances are real, but they are not of one kind. One file is an unambiguous broken promise. Two are genuinely contested with a serious opposing case. One is a symbolic injury rather than a breach. One was delivered late. One was kept. Anyone who describes Punjab 1947–1980 as a uniform record of betrayal is not describing this table. Anyone who describes it as a list of unreasonable demands is not describing it either.

2. Not every wound came from Delhi. The census episode of Chapter 1 is the clearest case of Punjabis damaging Punjabis, and it corrupted the boundary that produced the territorial grievance. Attributing that to the central government is factually wrong and, I think, politically convenient for everyone involved.

3. Punjab was rich while this was happening. The most assertive phase of Punjabi politics coincides exactly with Punjab being the wealthiest state in India. Deprivation is not the explanation.

And now the Zafarnama question

Part 4 gave me a test drawn from the tradition's own foundational sources rather than imported from outside. Guru Gobind Singh, in the Zafarnama: the sword is righteous **when all other means have failed**. Not when they are slow. Not when they are frustrating. When they have failed.

So: by 1980, had they?

HAD ALL OTHER MEANS FAILED BY 1980?

THE CASE THAT THEY HAD NOT

The Akali Dal had contested elections, won them, and formed governments in Punjab — in 1967, 1977 and after. It had negotiated with two Prime Ministers and obtained written agreements. It had access to Parliament, the Supreme Court, the press, and the machinery of a functioning democracy.

It had also, between 1975 and 1977, run the largest and most sustained agitation against the Emergency of any political party in India — using entirely constitutional and non-violent methods, at considerable cost — and had been vindicated when the Emergency ended and Congress lost power. That is the constitutional route working.

Above all, Part 6 shows Punjab had already won this kind of fight with these methods: the Akali morchas of 1920–25 defeated a colonial government through sustained non-violent mass action, and the Gurdwara Act of 1925 delivered everything demanded.

THE CASE THAT THEY EFFECTIVELY HAD

Fifteen years, two Prime Ministers, two signed commitments on Chandigarh, two published deadlines, and nothing delivered. At some point a route that never arrives stops functioning as a route, whatever it looks like on paper.

The one comprehensive statement of Akali demands — the Anandpur Sahib Resolution, which was substantially a bill for those unpaid promises — was declared a secessionist charter and ruled out as a basis for negotiation. That is not the constitutional route being slow. That is the constitutional route being closed.

Elected Punjab governments were repeatedly dismissed by the Centre. Winning an election did not secure the ability to govern.

And the promise that *was* kept — procurement — is precisely the one where Punjab was doing something India needed. The pattern a Punjabi could reasonably read from the table is: obligations flowing to the Centre are enforced; obligations flowing to Punjab are not.

I AM LEAVING THIS UNRESOLVED ON PURPOSE

My honest reading at the end of 1980 is that **not all constitutional means had failed** — the machinery was still there, still being used, and had recently worked against the Emergency.

And also that a route producing two signed agreements and two broken deadlines across fifteen years had lost most of its credibility, and that declaring the central Akali document treasonous rather than negotiating it removed the last comprehensive channel.

Both of those are true at once, and the participants in Part 9 were standing inside exactly that contradiction. I would rather carry it forward honestly than resolve it early in a direction that flatters my conclusion.

What I will not accept — and Part 9 will test this hard — is the claim that *nothing* had been tried. The record in this part shows a great deal had been.

CHAPTER NINE

The Emergency, and how Part 9 begins

Two facts about the second half of the 1970s that almost never appear in national accounts, and which change how the next part reads.

The Akali Dal and the Emergency

Indira Gandhi declared a state of Emergency on 25 June 1975. Civil liberties were suspended, the press was censored, and opposition politicians were jailed in large numbers.

The **Shiromani Akali Dal** launched a sustained campaign against it — the *Save Democracy morcha* — using the morcha method described in Part 6: successive batches of volunteers courting arrest, continuously, for as long as it took.

Estimates of the numbers arrested run to around **40,000 Akali volunteers** over the period of the Emergency. It is generally reckoned the largest and most sustained organised resistance to the Emergency mounted by any single political party in India.

The party that Congress would shortly describe as a secessionist threat to India had just spent two years filling Indian jails in defence of the Indian Constitution.

I want that stated because it is verifiable, it is rarely mentioned, and it materially affects how one reads the accusation that follows.

1977 to 1980

The Emergency ended in 1977. Congress was defeated nationally. In Punjab, an **Akali Dal–Janata coalition** formed a government under **Parkash Singh Badal**.

In 1980, Indira Gandhi returned to power at the Centre, and the Congress government dismissed the Akali government in Punjab, as it did several other opposition state governments.

And the accusation that opens Part 9

The Akali Dal held the SGPC, the gurdwaras and the rural Sikh vote. For Congress, breaking that hold was the central problem of Punjab politics.

The allegation — which is one of the most consequential claims in modern Indian political history — is that senior Congress figures, with **Giani Zail Singh** and **Sanjay Gandhi** named

most often, deliberately cultivated a young, uncompromising, orthodox religious preacher who could challenge the Akali Dal's religious authority and split its vote.

That preacher was **Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale**.

Part 9 examines that allegation properly — what evidence exists, who has said what and when, what is documented and what is inference, and what it does and does not explain about everything that followed.

Timeline of Part 8

1949	Sikh members of the Constituent Assembly, Hukam Singh and Bhupinder Singh Mann, refuse to sign the Constitution .
1951	Census. Organised campaigns encourage Punjabi Hindus to record Hindi as mother tongue.
1953	Andhra State created for Telugu speakers.
1955	Ravi–Beas waters allocated: 8 MAF Rajasthan , 7.20 MAF undivided Punjab, 0.65 MAF J&K.
1955	States Reorganisation Commission rejects the Punjabi Suba demand.
1956	States Reorganisation Act. PEPSU merged into Punjab.
1960–61	Punjabi Suba agitation. Around 26,000 arrested.
1961	Census. The mother-tongue campaign is repeated.
1965	India–Pakistan war. Sikh soldiers again serve far beyond their share of the population.
18 Sept 1966	Punjab Reorganisation Act passed. Effective 1 November.
1 Nov 1966	Punjab (50,362 sq km), Haryana, and hill areas to Himachal. Chandigarh becomes a Union Territory and joint capital. Section 78 gives the Centre power over river-water allocation.
1970	Indira Gandhi's award : Chandigarh to Punjab, Fazilka–Abohar to Haryana, transfer by January 1975. Never implemented .
16–17 Oct 1973	Anandpur Sahib Resolution adopted by the Akali Dal working committee.
1975–77	The Emergency. Akali Dal's Save Democracy morcha; around 40,000 arrested.
1976	Centre allocates 3.5 MAF each to Punjab and Haryana under Section 78. SYL canal proposed.
1977	Congress defeated. Akali–Janata government in Punjab under Parkash Singh Badal.
28–29 Oct 1978	Ludhiana version of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution endorsed, widening autonomy demands to all states.
1980	Indira Gandhi returns to power. The Akali government in Punjab is dismissed. Part 9 begins .
1985	Rajiv–Longowal Accord: Chandigarh to Punjab by 26 January 1986. Never implemented .

What happens in Part 9

Part 9 is *Bhindranwale — Full Autopsy*, and it is the part this whole work has been building toward.

I will establish who he actually was and where he came from; examine the evidence for the claim that Congress cultivated him, and separate what is documented from what is inference; go through his **actual recorded statements** rather than the versions that circulate on both sides, including the ones that are fabricated; cover the Nirankari clash of 1978, the murder of Lala Jagat Narain in 1981, the Dharam Yudh Morcha, the fortification of the Akal Takht, and Operation Blue Star in June 1984 — with casualty figures given as ranges and sources named.

And then I will apply the two tests I have built for this purpose, both drawn from Sikh tradition rather than imposed from outside: **the Zafarnama's last-resort condition**, established in Part 4 before I had met the man it would judge, and **the broken-bargain test** from Part 6, whose evidence base is the table in Chapter 8 of this part.

I do not intend to deliver a verdict of saint or monster. Both are available cheaply and neither survives the record.

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 8

Primary documents

- **The Punjab Reorganisation Act, 1966** (Act No. 31 of 1966) — full text available from the Government of Haryana. Section 78 in particular.
- **Report of the States Reorganisation Commission, 1955** — including its reasoning for rejecting Punjabi Suba.
- **The Anandpur Sahib Resolution** — 1973 working-committee text and the 1978 Ludhiana version. English versions are available from the Sikh Missionary Society and SikhiWiki; note that they differ, which is itself the point of Chapter 7.
- **Rajiv–Longowal Accord (Memorandum of Settlement), 24 July 1985** — full text available at sikhtimes.com and elsewhere.
- **Constitution of India**, Article 25 and Explanation II.
- **Census of India**, 1951 and 1961 — Punjab language tables.
- Supreme Court of India, *Presidential Reference on the Punjab Termination of Agreements Act*, 2016.
- **Indus Waters Treaty, 1960** (World Bank).

Modern scholarship

- **Paul R. Brass**, *Language, Religion and Politics in North India* — the standard analysis of the Punjabi Suba movement and the census question.
- **Baldev Raj Nayar**, *Minority Politics in the Punjab* — detailed on the 1950s and 1960s.
- **J. S. Grewal**, *The Sikhs of the Punjab*, chapters on the post-independence period.
- **Gurharpal Singh**, *Ethnic Conflict in India: A Case-Study of Punjab* — particularly good on centre-state relations.
- **Harnik Deol**, *Religion and Nationalism in India: The Case of the Punjab*.
- **Ramachandra Guha**, *India After Gandhi* — for the national context of linguistic reorganisation and the Emergency.
- **Francine Frankel**, *India's Political Economy 1947–2004*, and **Ashutosh Varshney**, *Democracy, Development and the Countryside* — on the Green Revolution's political consequences.
- **Vandana Shiva**, *The Violence of the Green Revolution* — the critical case, contested but worth reading.
- **Daniel Haines**, *Rivers Divided*, and **Ramaswamy Iyer**'s writing on Indian inter-state water disputes.

Reference sources used for dates and figures

- Wikipedia, *Punjabi Suba movement*, *Punjab Reorganisation Act 1966*, *Anandpur Sahib Resolution*, *Rajiv–Longowal Accord*, *Sutlej Yamuna link canal*, *Chandigarh*.
- The Tribune archives on Chandigarh's status, the Punjabi Suba anniversary, and the assembly resolutions on Chandigarh; ThePrint's explainer on the Chandigarh dispute.
- SANDRP's chronology of the Sutlej-Yamuna Link dispute; Drishti IAS and Vajiram & Ravi summaries, cross-checked against Brass and Gurharpal Singh.
- The Punjab Pulse, "The Anandpur Sahib Resolution: Origins, Intent, and Contested Legacy" — useful specifically on the differences between versions.

A NOTE ON THE ANANDPUR SAHIB RESOLUTION SOURCES

I want to flag a research problem honestly. Different published "full texts" of this resolution do not agree with each other, and some circulating versions appear to be later reconstructions or translations with significant variation.

Where I have described its contents, I have relied on formulations that appear consistently across multiple independent sources, and I have said explicitly where the 1973 and 1978 versions diverge. Anyone quoting a single dramatic sentence from this document — in either direction — should be asked which version they are quoting and where they got it.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 8 —

Part 9: *Bhindranwale* — *Full Autopsy*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART NINE OF THIRTEEN

Bhindranwale: Full Autopsy

1977 to June 1984 — who he was, who built him, what he actually said, and the two tests he fails

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 9

This is the part the whole work was built for, and I want to be exact about how I have gone about it.

Eight parts ago I said that everybody in Punjab has an opinion about Bhindranwale and almost nobody arguing has read anything. That included me. What I have tried to do since is assemble the evidence in an order that makes an honest judgement possible rather than a comfortable one.

The tests in this part were built before I met the man they judge. That was deliberate and it is the single most important methodological decision in this work.

In Part 4, writing about the year 1705, I set out the Zafarnama's condition — Guru Gobind Singh's own written standard that the sword is righteous *when all other means have failed* — along with the Rahit's prohibition on attacking non-combatants and the story of Bhai Kanhaiya carrying water to wounded Mughal soldiers. I said then, in print, that this was the standard I would carry into Part 9, and that I was setting it before I knew who it would convict.

In Part 6, writing about 1907 and 1919, I built the broken-bargain test. In Part 8 I applied it to the Indian state and produced a table with six verdicts, one of which — Chandigarh — is an unambiguous, indefensible broken promise by two Prime Ministers.

Chapter 6 of this part is where those tests get applied. Both to him, and to the state.

What I am not going to produce is a verdict of saint or monster. Both are available cheaply, both have large constituencies, and neither survives contact with the record. What I have found is a man with real personal integrity, addressing real grievances, who failed his own tradition's explicit test — and a state that created him for electoral advantage, protected him from a murder investigation, and then destroyed the holiest site in his religion on the anniversary of a martyrdom, with tanks, on a day it knew the building was full of pilgrims, and has refused for forty-two years to permit an independent count of the dead.

Both of those sentences are in this part. Anyone who wants only one of them will be unhappy, and I think that is the correct outcome.

One practical note. Chapter 4 separates what he demonstrably said from what is attributed to him, because there is a great deal of fabricated material circulating in

both directions. Where I could not verify a quotation, I have left it out rather than use it — including quotations that would have strengthened the case against him.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

How to read a contested life

Almost everything written about Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale comes from a source with a stake in the answer. Before assembling any of it, I need to say what kind of evidence each claim rests on.

The four categories

Throughout this part I sort claims into four boxes, and I will say which box I am in.

HOW CLAIMS ARE CLASSIFIED IN THIS PART

Category	Meaning
DOCUMENTED	Recorded at the time by identifiable sources, ideally more than one, ideally including sources hostile to the conclusion. Dates, FIRs, parliamentary statements, recorded interviews.
DISPUTED	Real evidence exists on both sides and the question is not settled. I give both and say so.
INFERRED	Reasonable conclusions drawn from documented facts, but not themselves documented. I flag these explicitly rather than letting them pass as fact.
FABRICATED	Circulating material that does not trace to any verifiable source. There is a great deal of this, in both directions.

ON THE FABRICATIONS, SPECIFICALLY

Quotations attributed to Bhindranwale circulate very widely. Some are from recorded speeches and filmed interviews — he spoke publicly almost daily for years, journalists including the BBC's Mark Tully and Satish Jacob interviewed him, and audio recordings survive. Others appear to have no traceable origin at all.

This runs in both directions. There are invented quotations designed to make him sound like a genocidal maniac, and invented quotations designed to make him sound like a constitutional liberal. I have used only material I could trace to a recorded source or to a contemporaneous account by a named journalist, and where I could not verify something I have left it out — **including material that would have made the case against him easier.**

CHAPTER	1	Who	he	actually	was.
CHAPTER	2	The Congress question:	what is documented	and what is inferred.	
CHAPTER	3	The	escalation,	1978	to 1983.
CHAPTER	4	What he actually said	— and what he refused to say.		
CHAPTER	5	Operation	Blue	Star.	

CHAPTER 6 The verdict: the two tests, applied to him and to the state.

CHAPTER 7 What he got right, and what he got people killed for.

CHAPTER 8 Scorecard: what Part 9 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

Who he actually was

Before the politics, the man. A village-born seminary student who became head of a centuries-old religious institution at thirty, and whose personal integrity is not seriously disputed even by people who hated him.

The basic facts

JARNAIL SINGH BHINDRANWALE — THE RECORD

Item	Detail
Born	2 February 1947, Rode village , Faridkot district (now Moga district), Punjab. Six months before Partition.
Family	Father Joginder Singh, a farmer and local Sikh figure; mother Nihal Kaur. One of eight sons. Not a wealthy or politically connected family.
Education	Sent to the Damdami Taksal as a boy. Traditional Sikh seminary education: scripture, Gurmukhi, exegesis, kirtan, and the martial tradition. No English-medium or university education.
Family life	Married Pritam Kaur. Two sons.
Became head of the Taksal	His predecessor Kartar Singh Khalsa died after a road accident on 16 August 1977. Bhindranwale was nominated and formally installed at a bhog ceremony at Mehta Chowk on 25 August 1977 . He was thirty years old .
Killed	6 June 1984, in the Akal Takht complex, aged 37.

What the Damdami Taksal is

This matters, because people describe him as a "militant leader" as though he emerged from nowhere with a gun.

The **Damdami Taksal** is a traditional Sikh seminary — an itinerant institution of scriptural learning that traces its lineage to Baba Deep Singh and, through him, to Guru Gobind Singh. Its business is teaching correct pronunciation and interpretation of the Guru Granth Sahib, training granthis and preachers, and maintaining Khalsa discipline.

Its head is a **religious office**, not a political one. When Bhindranwale took it in 1977, he was becoming the fourteenth head of a centuries-old seminary — roughly the equivalent, in institutional terms, of becoming the principal of a very old and very orthodox theological college.

What he actually did first

His initial programme, in 1977 and 1978, was overwhelmingly religious and it is worth listing because it explains his following far better than any conspiracy theory:

- **Amrit prachar** — mass baptism campaigns. He travelled village to village persuading young Sikhs to take initiation into the Khalsa.
- Campaigns against **tobacco, alcohol and drugs**.
- Campaigns against **cutting the hair** — against the drift of young Sikhs away from visible Sikh identity.
- Campaigns against **dowry** and against extravagant weddings.
- Campaigns against **female foeticide**.

This is a revivalist programme aimed at rural Sikh youth, and it addressed things that were genuinely happening. Punjab in the late 1970s did have a rising drug and alcohol problem. Dowry demands were real and ruinous. Young men were drifting from religious practice.

The personal question

DOCUMENTED: His personal austerity and incorruptibility are attested across the sources, including hostile ones. He lived simply. He did not accumulate money or property. He was accessible to ordinary villagers in a way that established politicians were not. Journalists who interviewed him, including those who found his politics appalling, consistently describe considerable personal presence.

WHY I AM STARTING HERE

Because the two lazy explanations of his rise both fail on these facts.

"He was a Congress puppet" does not explain why tens of thousands of rural Sikhs followed a man they had never been paid to follow, or why they were still following him after his patrons had turned against him.

"He was a criminal who exploited religion" does not explain the personal austerity, the absence of accumulated wealth, or the fact that he stayed and died in a building he could have left.

He was a genuinely charismatic orthodox religious leader with a real following built on a real revival. Everything difficult in this part follows from taking that seriously rather than explaining it away.

CHAPTER TWO

The Congress question

"Congress created Bhindranwale" is one of the most repeated claims in modern Indian politics. Here is what the evidence actually supports — which is less than the slogan and more than his defenders admit.

The strategic problem Congress had

From Part 8: the Akali Dal held the SGPC, the gurdwaras and the rural Sikh vote. It had just spent the Emergency filling jails and had emerged vindicated. In 1977 Congress lost nationally, and in Punjab an Akali-Janata government took office.

For Congress, breaking the Akali Dal's hold on the Sikh vote was the central problem of Punjab politics. And the obvious method — used everywhere in Indian politics before and since — was to find a rival who could split it.

What is documented

THE CONGRESS CONNECTION: THE RECORD

Status	Claim
DOCUMENTED	After the 1977 defeat, Congress figures — Sanjay Gandhi and Giani Zail Singh most prominently — extended political support to Bhindranwale as a counterweight to the Akali Dal.
DOCUMENTED	Candidates backed by Bhindranwale contested the 1978 SGPC elections against the Akali Dal. They were heavily defeated, winning only a handful of seats.
DOCUMENTED	In the 1980 general election , Bhindranwale campaigned for Congress candidates in Punjab constituencies.
DOCUMENTED	Zail Singh , as Union Home Minister from 1980, intervened repeatedly on his behalf — most consequentially in the Jagat Narain case below.
DOCUMENTED	Senior Congress figures have subsequently acknowledged the strategy in public. It is no longer a contested allegation within Indian political discussion; it is broadly conceded.
INFERRED	That financial support flowed. Widely alleged, plausible given the political relationship, but the specific mechanics remain undocumented in any form I would rely on.
OVERSTATED	That Congress created him. He was already head of the Damdami Taksal, an institution far older than the Congress party, with an existing following built on the religious programme in Chapter 1.

The single most consequential decision in this whole story

On **9 September 1981**, **Lala Jagat Narain** — proprietor of the Hind Samachar newspaper group, a prominent Punjabi Hindu figure, and a leading organiser of the Hindi mother-tongue

campaign described in Part 8 — was shot dead near Ludhiana.

He had been a consistent and prominent critic of Bhindranwale.

What happened next:

1. Bhindranwale was **named in the FIR**.
2. He left Punjab for Chando Kalan in Haryana. Police raided the location; his vehicles and literature were burned, which became a grievance in itself.
3. He **surrendered voluntarily at Mehta Chowk on 20 September 1981** — having first been permitted to address a large gathering, which turned the surrender into a demonstration of strength.
4. He was **released on 15 October 1981 without charge**.
5. **Zail Singh, the Union Home Minister, stated in Parliament that there was no evidence against him.**

A man named in a murder FIR was released within four weeks, and the Home Minister of India stood up in Parliament and declared him innocent. Everything that follows in this part runs through that decision.

Consider what that communicated, to three audiences at once:

- **To his followers:** he had been falsely accused, had surrendered on his own terms, and had been vindicated by the government itself. His standing was transformed.
- **To him:** that he was protected.
- **To everyone in Punjab, including the police:** that the Indian state would not act against him. Police officers drew the obvious conclusion about what investigating his network would cost them.

My assessment

WHERE I LAND ON THE CONGRESS QUESTION

"Congress created Bhindranwale" is too strong. He was a real religious leader with a real institutional base and a real following before Congress took an interest, and his appeal rested on things Congress could not manufacture.

"Congress promoted, protected and shielded him for electoral advantage, and thereby made him vastly more powerful than he would otherwise have become" is well supported — by the electoral record, by Zail Singh's conduct as Home Minister, and by subsequent admissions from within Congress itself.

And here is the part both camps skip. This does not diminish his own responsibility by one degree. A man who is protected by a cynical patron remains responsible for what he does with the protection. Cultivating him was a grave and calculated wrong by Congress; it is also an explanation of *how* he became powerful, not a justification of *what he did* with the power.

The Congress camp wants only the second half. The Bhindranwale camp wants only the first. Both halves are true and they do not cancel.

CHAPTER THREE

The escalation, 1978–1983

Six years, traced by date. The pattern that emerges is a sequence of failures — one of them a failure of justice so plain that it did more to radicalise Punjab than any speech.

13 April 1978: the Nirankari clash

On Vaisakhi at Amritsar, the **Sant Nirankari Mission** held a convention. Members of the **Akhand Kirtani Jatha** and the **Damdami Taksal**, led by **Bhai Fauja Singh**, marched to stop it.

Firing broke out. **Sixteen people were killed: thirteen Sikhs and three Nirankaris.**

THE NIRANKARI CLASH: BOTH CASES AT FULL STRENGTH

THE NIRANKARI CASE

They were holding a lawful, licensed convention. A large group marched on it with the declared intention of stopping it. The Nirankaris say they were attacked and defended themselves, and a court accepted a version consistent with that.

Freedom of religion covers unpopular sects. A group's beliefs being heretical to another group is not a licence to march on their gathering.

THE ORTHODOX SIKH CASE

The Sant Nirankari leader was accorded the standing of a living Guru by his followers. After 1708 (Part 4), the line of human Gurus is closed by the tenth Guru's own decision — so this was not a doctrinal disagreement at the margins but a direct challenge to the foundational structure of the faith. The Akal Takht had issued a hukamnama against the Nirankaris.

The convention was held at Amritsar, on Vaisakhi — the anniversary of the founding of the Khalsa — which was read as deliberate provocation. And the administration licensed it despite explicit warnings that it would produce violence.

1980: the acquittals

The Nirankari accused were tried and, in **1980, acquitted** by a court in Karnal, in Haryana — the case having been transferred out of Punjab.

I want to slow down here, because I think this is one of the most underrated turning points in the entire story.

Thirteen Sikhs were killed. Nobody was convicted. The trial was moved out of the state. From inside Punjab, the message received was not a technical one about evidentiary standards. It was: **Sikh lives do not produce convictions.**

THE GRIEVANCE THAT MATTERED MOST

People looking for the cause of Punjab's radicalisation usually reach for Blue Star, or the Anandpur Sahib Resolution, or Congress manipulation.

I would put the 1980 acquittals higher than most accounts do. A functioning justice system is the thing that makes non-violent politics rational. When thirteen people are killed and nobody is convicted, the argument that the system will deliver justice loses its factual basis — and the argument that only force works gains one.

Bhindranwale did not have to construct that argument. The Karnal court handed it to him.

The killings begin

THE ESCALATION BY DATE

Date	Event
24 April 1980	Nirankari head Baba Gurbachan Singh assassinated in Delhi. Ranjit Singh — later, remarkably, appointed Jathedar of the Akal Takht — was eventually convicted.
9 Sept 1981	Lala Jagat Narain murdered near Ludhiana.
20 Sept 1981	Bhindranwale surrenders at Mehta Chowk.
15 Oct 1981	Released without charge; Zail Singh declares in Parliament that there is no evidence.
1981–83	A rising campaign of targeted killings: police officers, Nirankaris, Congress workers, journalists — and increasingly, ordinary Hindus.
4 Aug 1982	The Akali Dal launches the Dharam Yudh Morcha under Harchand Singh Longowal , demanding implementation of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. Bhindranwale merges his agitation into it.
1982–83	Over 21,000 arrests recorded in the Morcha by mid-1983 — a mass non-violent campaign in the classic morcha tradition of Part 6.
Oct 1983	The Dhilwan bus massacre : a bus is stopped, Hindu passengers separated from the others, and six shot dead. President's Rule is imposed on Punjab.
15 Dec 1983	Bhindranwale moves from the Guru Nanak Niwas into the Akal Takht.

The scale of the killing before Blue Star

DISPUTED, WITH RANGES. The figures for the pre-Blue Star period vary by source and by what is being counted.

- One commonly cited figure is around **165 Hindus killed** in the period leading up to Operation Blue Star.

- Broader estimates put total killings in Punjab from all causes and all communities at around **500 to 1,000 by 1983**.
- The counting is complicated by the fact that victims included Sikhs — police officers, Nirankaris, rival Sikh political figures, and Sikhs who criticised the movement, of whom there were many.

This last point deserves emphasis and is routinely dropped from both narratives. A substantial share of those killed in this period were Sikhs. The movement killed Sikh policemen, Sikh journalists, Sikh moderates and Sikh political rivals. Framing this period as Sikhs versus Hindus is factually wrong.

15 December 1983: the Akal Takht

This is the decisive act, and it needs stating plainly.

Bhindranwale moved his headquarters into the **Akal Takht** — the seat of the temporal authority of the Sikh Panth, built by Guru Hargobind in 1606 as described in Part 4, Chapter 4.

The complex was then fortified under **Major General Shabeg Singh** — a decorated Indian Army officer who had trained the Mukti Bahini in the 1971 Bangladesh war, and who had been dismissed from service on corruption charges he denied, one day before his retirement. Firing positions were prepared, sandbagged emplacements built, and light machine guns brought in.

WHY THIS ACT, ABOVE ALL OTHERS, DETERMINED WHAT FOLLOWED

By fortifying the Akal Takht, the movement guaranteed that any state response would necessarily be a **military assault on the holiest complex in Sikhism**.

That is not an incidental consequence. It is the predictable and, I think, foreseeable one. A state that will not tolerate an armed base directing killings has two options: leave it alone permanently, or attack a shrine.

Whether one regards this as a defensive decision forced by circumstances or as a deliberate strategic choice to place the state in an impossible position, the outcome was the same: the Akal Takht became a military objective, and every Sikh in the world would experience the consequence as a desecration inflicted on them personally.

That effect — which is precisely what happened in June 1984 and November 1984 — was available to be predicted in December 1983.

CHAPTER FOUR

What he actually said

He spoke publicly, often daily, for years. Journalists recorded him. Audio survives. So there is no need to rely on paraphrase — and no excuse for using the fabrications that circulate in both directions.

On Khalistan

DOCUMENTED: He consistently declined to demand Khalistan in explicit terms. His recorded formula, repeated to many interviewers including foreign journalists, was in substance: *I have not asked for Khalistan. But if the government gives it, I will not refuse it.* He framed the responsibility for separation as lying with the government rather than with him.

He demanded implementation of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution — which, as Part 8 Chapter 7 established, was substantially a bill for unpaid promises.

WHAT THAT FORMULA MEANS — TWO SERIOUS READINGS

READING A: A GENUINE CONSTITUTIONAL POSITION

He meant what he said. His demand was autonomy and the implementation of existing agreements, not separation. He was pointing out — correctly, on the evidence of Part 8 — that a state which breaks its written commitments for fifteen years manufactures separatism, and that if separation came, its authors would be in Delhi.

Supporters note he never once, in any recording, issued a call for an independent Khalistan.

READING B: A LEGALLY CAREFUL WAY OF PROMOTING IT

The formula is precisely calibrated to build a separatist constituency while remaining outside the language of sedition. "I will not refuse it" tells a follower which way to face. Meanwhile his organisation was arming, and his rhetoric described Sikhs as living in slavery within India — which is a separatist premise whether or not the word is used.

The test is not what he avoided saying. It is what his listeners understood, and what they then did.

I am not going to declare one of these correct. Both are held by serious people, both fit the recorded evidence, and the ambiguity was — on either reading — deliberate.

What else is documented

He repeatedly urged Sikhs to **acquire weapons**, and specifically motorcycles and firearms. He described Sikhs as living in **slavery** in India. He emphasised the sword and armed self-defence constantly. He spoke openly and calmly about his own expected death, and described it in advance as martyrdom.

What is not established

NOT ESTABLISHED: That he issued explicit orders to kill Hindus as a category. I have not found a reliable recording or a contemporaneous account by a named journalist in which he issues such a command in those terms, and I am not going to assert one on the strength of material I cannot trace.

I say this knowing that it will be read as a defence of him. It is not, and the next section explains why.

What he refused to say — and this is the damaging part

DOCUMENTED, AND DECISIVE: He was asked repeatedly, by journalists and by political figures, to condemn specific killings — including the killings of Hindus. He **consistently declined to condemn them in unqualified terms**. He praised those who took up arms. He offered rewards and honour to those who acted against declared enemies of the Panth. He gave shelter and standing to men wanted for killings.

The strongest case against Bhindranwale does not require a single disputed quotation. It rests entirely on what he was asked to say and would not say, in front of journalists, on the record.

Let me be exact about why this matters, because the distinction is legal as well as moral.

Legally, "he ordered killings" and "he declined to condemn killings" are very different claims requiring very different evidence, and I am not going to blur them for rhetorical convenience.

Morally and by the standards of his own tradition, the distinction provides him with almost no shelter at all. He was the authority the movement looked to. When the authority is asked whether the killing of unarmed civilians is legitimate and declines to say no, the answer that his followers hear is not silence.

And there is a specific tradition-internal reason this is damning, which Chapter 6 develops: the Rahit prohibits attacking non-combatants, and the tradition's founding story of its own most desperate battle is Bhai Kanhaiya carrying water to the wounded on the *other side*, with the tenth Guru's explicit approval. A leader claiming that tradition, asked to condemn the shooting of bus passengers, had an answer available to him from within his own scripture. He did not give it.

CHAPTER FIVE

Operation Blue Star

1 to 8 June 1984. The facts, the disputed casualty range, and the specific decisions that were the state's own and cannot be attributed to anybody else.

The situation by mid-1984

DOCUMENTED: The Golden Temple complex was fortified and garrisoned by armed men under a former Major General. Killings across Punjab were continuing at a substantial rate. Police were reluctant or unable to act. The state's practical authority over parts of Punjab had substantially collapsed. Weapons and men moved in and out of the complex.

The operation

OPERATION BLUE STAR: THE RECORD

Element	Detail
Dates	1–8 June 1984; main assault on the night of 5–6 June .
Command	Assault commanded by Major General Kuldip Singh Brar , under Lt Gen Ranjit Singh Dyal and Lt Gen Krishnaswamy Sundarji.
The timing	It began on the eve of the martyrdom anniversary of Guru Arjan — one of the most heavily attended days in the Sikh calendar. Thousands of pilgrims were inside the complex.
Resistance	Far heavier than anticipated. Shabeg Singh's prepared positions held against repeated infantry assaults, inflicting significant army casualties.
Tanks	Vijayanta tanks were brought into the complex and fired into the Akal Takht.
Destruction	The Akal Takht was largely destroyed. The Sikh Reference Library , containing irreplaceable manuscripts including handwritten copies of the Guru Granth Sahib and original hukamnamas, was burned . The circumstances remain disputed.
Deaths	Bhindranwale killed on 6 June, aged 37. Also killed: Shabeg Singh and Amrik Singh .

The casualty figures

THE RANGE, AND WHY IT CANNOT BE CLOSED

Government of India White Paper: 493 militants and civilians killed. Army: 83 killed (4 officers, 79 other ranks) and 236 wounded.

Other official figures put combined militant and civilian deaths at 554.

Independent and Sikh sources give figures very much higher — accounts citing 4,000 to 5,000 or more civilians in the complex, with some human rights bodies claiming higher totals still. The journalist Kuldip Nayar reported Rajiv Gandhi privately acknowledging army losses considerably above the official figure.

Why the gap cannot be resolved: a total news blackout was imposed. Foreign journalists were expelled from Punjab. Telephone and transport links were cut. Bodies were cremated in bulk without individual identification. The number of pilgrims inside on the anniversary was never established. And — the decisive fact — **no independent inquiry into Operation Blue Star has ever been permitted, in forty-two years.**

I am not going to pick a number. What I will say is that the impossibility of picking one is a direct product of decisions taken by the Government of India, and that a state which prevents counting does not get to rely on the resulting uncertainty.

Was it necessary? The two cases

OPERATION BLUE STAR

THE CASE THAT IT WAS NECESSARY

A government that cannot enter a building from which armed men are directing killings across a state has ceased to govern. The complex was fortified with machine guns by a former general. Negotiations had run for over a year. Police could not act. Killings were continuing.

No state in the world tolerates an armed base operating with impunity inside its territory indefinitely, regardless of the building's religious status. Sovereignty is not optional.

THE CASE AGAINST HOW IT WAS DONE

The timing. Launching on the eve of Guru Arjan's martyrdom anniversary, when the army knew the complex would be full of pilgrims, is the single least defensible decision. No adequate explanation has ever been offered.

The method. A siege was militarily available — cutting water, power and supply and waiting. It was rejected in favour of assault. Tanks firing into the Akal Takht was a choice.

The library. The burning of the Sikh Reference Library destroyed manuscripts that cannot be replaced and served no military purpose whatsoever.

The aftermath. Operation Woodrose swept rural Punjab with mass detentions of young Sikh men, many with no connection to anything.

And the inquiry. Forty-two years, no independent inquiry.

The mutinies

DOCUMENTED: In the days following Blue Star, Sikh soldiers mutinied in several units of the Indian Army. The most serious was at the Sikh Regimental Centre at **Ramgarh in Bihar**, where a large body of troops — figures around 1,400 are commonly cited — broke out, seized weapons and headed for Amritsar. A brigadier was killed. There were smaller incidents at several other stations. Total desertions ran into the low thousands. Many were subsequently court-martialled and dismissed.

PART 6 ARRIVING

This is the recruitment policy of the 1880s meeting the crisis of 1984.

The British built the Indian Army disproportionately out of Punjab, and after 1947 Sikhs remained heavily over-represented in it. That gave India an exceptional fighting force. It also meant that when the state attacked the Golden Temple, a very large number of the men holding rifles for India had an immediate and personal stake in what had just happened.

A state whose army is recruited disproportionately from one community should expect that community's grievances to have a military dimension. This was foreseeable in a way that has nothing to do with anybody's loyalty.

CHAPTER SIX

The verdict

Here are the tests I set in Part 4 and Part 6, before I knew who they would judge. I apply them now — to him, and then to the state.

TEST ONE — The Zafarnama condition (established in Part 4, from a 1705 source)

The standard: Guru Gobind Singh, writing to Aurangzeb: the sword is righteous *when all other means have failed*. Not when they are slow. Not when they are frustrating. When they have failed.

The case that they had failed. Part 8's table is real and I am not going to soften it. Chandigarh promised in writing by two Prime Ministers with two deadlines and never delivered. Fifteen years of unimplemented agreements. The Anandpur Sahib Resolution — substantially a bill for those unpaid promises — declared a secessionist charter and refused as a basis for negotiation. Elected Punjab governments dismissed by the Centre. And the Karnal acquittals in 1980, which removed the factual basis for believing the justice system would deliver.

The case that they had not. And this is the one that decides it.

On **4 August 1982**, the Akali Dal launched the **Dharam Yudh Morcha**. By mid-1983 it had produced over **21,000 arrests** — a mass, sustained, non-violent civil disobedience campaign using precisely the method that, as Part 6 documented, had defeated a colonial government between 1920 and 1925 and won everything it demanded in the Sikh Gurdwaras Act.

That method was in operation. It had been running for less than two years. It had not failed. It had not been given time to fail.

Bhindranwale did not turn to the sword after the constitutional and non-violent routes were exhausted. He merged his agitation into a live non-violent mass campaign and progressively shifted its centre of gravity toward arms while it was still running.

VERDICT: FAILED. By the tradition's own written standard, the condition for the sword had not been met.

TEST TWO — The non-combatant prohibition and Bhai Kanhaiya (established in Part 4)

The standard: the Rahit forbids attacking non-combatants. And the tradition's own account of its most desperate battle, at Anandpur, has Bhai Kanhaiya carrying water to *wounded Mughal soldiers* — and Guru Gobind Singh, told of it, approving and handing him ointment as well.

The facts: passengers pulled off a bus at Dhilwan, separated by religion, and shot are non-combatants by any definition anyone has ever used. So were the journalists, and a substantial number of the other dead.

What is not established: that Bhindranwale ordered these specific killings. I have said so in Chapter 4 and I maintain it.

What is established: that he was the movement's authority; that he was asked repeatedly and directly to condemn such killings; that he consistently declined to do so in unqualified terms; that he praised and honoured those who took up arms; and that he sheltered men wanted in connection with killings.

The tradition he claimed gave him an answer to that question, in its own founding narrative, with the tenth Guru's personal endorsement. He did not give it.

VERDICT: FAILED. Not on disputed evidence — on his own documented conduct in front of journalists.

And now the same discipline applied to the state

It would be dishonest to build two tests, apply them to one party, and stop.

THE STATE — the broken-bargain test (Part 6) and proportionality

On the bargain: Part 8's audit stands. Chandigarh is an unambiguous broken promise by two Prime Ministers with two published deadlines. The Rajasthan water allocation of 1955 is indefensible under any principle. Article 25's Explanation II was a cost-free concession never made in seventy-five years. Elected governments were dismissed. And the one comprehensive statement of Akali demands was declared treasonous rather than negotiated.

On creating the problem: Congress promoted and protected Bhindranwale for electoral advantage, and the Home Minister of India told Parliament there was no evidence against a man named in a murder FIR. The state built the instrument it later needed tanks to remove.

On the operation: the decision to act may have been necessary — a government that cannot enter an armed fortress in its own territory has stopped governing. But four decisions were the state's own and cannot be attributed to anyone else: **the timing on a major martyrdom anniversary with the complex full of pilgrims; the choice of assault over siege; tanks firing into the Akal Takht; and the destruction of the Sikh Reference Library**, which served no military purpose.

On accountability: forty-two years and no independent inquiry. No agreed count of the dead. The uncertainty that both sides now argue over is a direct product of that refusal.

VERDICT: The operation was arguably necessary. Its timing, method and aftermath were not defensible, and the failure to permit any inquiry since is a continuing one.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What he got right, and what he got people killed for

What he got right

This list is real and I am not going to shorten it to make the conclusion tidier.

- **The grievances were genuine.** Part 8's audit is not a Bhindranwale document; it is my own table, and it contains one unambiguous broken promise and one indefensible water allocation. He was not inventing a wrong.
- **The justice failure was real.** Thirteen Sikhs killed in 1978 and nobody convicted. That is not paranoia; it is a court record.
- **The social problems he attacked were real.** Drug and alcohol use among rural Sikh youth, dowry, female foeticide, the drift from religious practice. His campaigns on these were substantive and, on the evidence of Part 13, prophetic.
- **He was right that the Akali Dal was ineffectual.** Fifteen years of accords and no delivery is a fair summary of its record.
- **His personal integrity is not seriously disputed.** He did not enrich himself. He did not run. He died in the building.

What he got wrong, and what it cost

- **He answered a political problem with a religious-military one**, and the tradition he invoked contains an explicit test — set in writing by the tenth Guru — which he did not meet, because a live non-violent mass campaign was running at the time.
- **He made the Hindus of Punjab into a category.** Not by documented order, but by refusing to say the word "no" when asked whether killing them was legitimate. Part 4's ninth Guru was beheaded defending Hindus' right to remain Hindu. That is the tradition he was claiming.
- **He fortified the Akal Takht**, which made a desecration the predictable outcome of any state response — and thereby handed the Indian state the ability to wound every Sikh in the world.

The outcome, stated without cushioning

WHAT FOLLOWED

Consequence	Scale
Operation Blue Star	Casualty range disputed from ~500 to several thousand. The Akal Takht destroyed. The Reference Library burned.
The November 1984 pogrom	Thousands of Sikhs killed across India, most in Delhi — Part 10.
The insurgency, 1984–1995	Tens of thousands dead over a decade, on all sides — Part 10.
Punjab's economy and society	A decade of capital flight, halted investment, and a generation lost.
The six files from Part 8	None resolved.

Every single thing Bhindranwale was fighting for is less achieved in 2026 than it was in 1980. Chandigarh is still a Union Territory. The water is still allocated the same way. Article 25 is unamended. That is the hardest sentence in this part, and it is simply a fact.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Scorecard: what Part 9 proves

"Bhindranwale was created by Congress."**PARTLY — AND THE FRAMING MATTERS**

He was already head of the Damdami Taksal, an institution far older than the Congress party, with a following built on a genuine religious revival Congress could not have manufactured.

What is documented is that Congress **promoted, protected and shielded** him for electoral advantage — support from Sanjay Gandhi and Zail Singh, candidates run against the Akalis in 1978, campaigning for Congress in 1980, and above all the release without charge in October 1981 with the Home Minister declaring in Parliament there was no evidence against a man named in a murder FIR.

And this does not reduce his responsibility by one degree. Being protected by a cynical patron explains how he became powerful. It says nothing about what he did with it.

"Bhindranwale demanded Khalistan."**NOT IN THOSE TERMS — AND GENUINELY CONTESTED**

His recorded formula, repeated to many interviewers, was that he had not asked for Khalistan but would not refuse it if the government gave it.

Reading A: a real constitutional position — the demand was autonomy and implementation of existing agreements, and responsibility for separation lay with a state breaking its own commitments. Reading B: a legally careful way of building a separatist constituency without using the word.

Both are seriously held, both fit the evidence, and the ambiguity was deliberate on either reading. I am not going to resolve it, and anyone who tells you it is obvious has not looked at the recordings.

"Bhindranwale ordered the killing of Hindus."**NOT ESTABLISHED — AND HE DOES NOT NEED IT TO BE**

I have not found a reliable recording or a contemporaneous account by a named journalist in which he issues such an order, and I will not assert one on untraceable material.

What *is* documented is worse for him than most people realise, because it requires no disputed evidence at all: he was asked repeatedly, on the record, to condemn the killing of unarmed civilians, and consistently would not. He praised those who took up arms. He sheltered men wanted in connection with killings.

A leader claiming the tradition of Bhai Kanhaiya, asked whether shooting bus passengers is legitimate, had an answer available from his own scripture. He did not give it.

"He was a saint and a martyr."**NOT BY HIS OWN TRADITION'S TESTS**

Personal austerity, incorruptibility and physical courage are not in dispute and I have said so plainly.

But the tradition he invoked has written standards, and I established them in Part 4 from seventeenth and eighteenth century sources before I had examined his life. He fails both. The Zafarnama's last-resort condition was not met, because a mass non-violent morcha with 21,000 arrests was running at the time and had not been given the chance to fail. And the non-combatant prohibition was not upheld, on his own documented refusals.

Invoking *shaheedi* and Miri-Piri while discarding the Zafarnama's condition and Bhai Kanhaiya's water is carrying half a tradition. Part 4 said that would be the test. It is.

"He was just a terrorist, and that is the whole story."**INCOMPLETE — AND THE INCOMPLETENESS IS DANGEROUS**

This account cannot explain why tens of thousands of ordinary rural Sikhs followed him, because it has to treat them as either stupid or evil, which they were not.

It cannot explain the grievances, which Part 8's audit shows were real, including one broken promise that is not arguable. It cannot explain the Karnal acquittals. And it conveniently omits that the Indian state promoted and protected him for years for electoral advantage before deciding he was a threat to the nation.

An explanation that requires the Indian state to be innocent is not an explanation. It is a press release.

"Operation Blue Star was necessary."**ARGUABLY YES. HOW IT WAS DONE, NO.**

A state that cannot enter a fortified armed base directing killings in its own territory has stopped governing. That argument is serious and I accept it as serious.

Four decisions were the state's own and cannot be attributed to anyone else: the **timing** on the eve of Guru Arjan's martyrdom anniversary with the complex full of pilgrims; the choice of **assault over siege**; **tanks** firing into the Akal Takht; and the burning of the **Sikh Reference Library**, which served no military purpose and destroyed manuscripts that cannot be replaced.

And forty-two years without an independent inquiry is not a detail. It is why nobody can settle the next question.

"How many died in Operation Blue Star?"

UNRESOLVED — AND THAT IS THE STATE'S DOING

White Paper: 493 militants and civilians, 83 army dead. Other official figures: 554. Independent and Sikh sources: several thousand.

News blackout, journalists expelled, communications cut, bodies cremated in bulk without identification, pilgrim numbers never established, and no independent inquiry in forty-two years.

A government that prevents counting does not then get to rely on the uncertainty it produced.

Timeline of Part 9

2 Feb 1947	Jarnail Singh born at Rode village, Faridkot district.
25 Aug 1977	Installed as fourteenth head of the Damdami Taksal at Mehta Chowk, aged 30.
1977–78	Amrit prachar campaigns; campaigns against drugs, alcohol, dowry, female foeticide.
13 April 1978	Nirankari clash at Amritsar. Sixteen killed — thirteen Sikhs, three Nirankaris.
1978	Bhindranwale-backed candidates defeated heavily in the SGPC elections.
1980	Karnal court acquits the Nirankari accused. Bhindranwale campaigns for Congress candidates in the general election.
24 April 1980	Nirankari head Baba Gurbachan Singh assassinated in Delhi.
9 Sept 1981	Lala Jagat Narain murdered near Ludhiana. Bhindranwale named in the FIR.
20 Sept 1981	Surrenders at Mehta Chowk after addressing a large gathering.
15 Oct 1981	Released without charge. Zail Singh tells Parliament there is no evidence against him.
4 Aug 1982	Akali Dal launches the Dharam Yudh Morcha under Longowal. Bhindranwale merges his agitation into it.
by mid-1983	Over 21,000 arrests in the Morcha — a live non-violent mass campaign.
Oct 1983	Dhilwan bus massacre — Hindu passengers separated and shot. President's Rule imposed on Punjab.
15 Dec 1983	Bhindranwale moves into the Akal Takht . Fortification under Major General Shabeg Singh.
10 March 1984	Mark Tully and Satish Jacob interview him — one of the last major recorded interviews.
1–8 June 1984	Operation Blue Star. Main assault 5–6 June. Tanks fire into the Akal Takht. The Sikh Reference Library burns.
6 June 1984	Bhindranwale killed , aged 37, along with Shabeg Singh and Amrik Singh.
June 1984 onward	Operation Woodrose. Mutinies in Sikh units of the Indian Army, most seriously at Ramgarh.
31 Oct 1984	Indira Gandhi assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards — Part 10.

What happens in Part 10

Part 10, *The Dark Decade*, covers 1984 to 1995 and it is the hardest part of this work to write, because it requires holding two atrocities in view at once without using either to excuse the other.

It covers the **assassination of Indira Gandhi** on 31 October 1984 and the **organised pogrom against Sikhs** that followed across India — the death tolls, the documented involvement of local Congress figures, the electoral rolls used to identify Sikh homes, and the forty-year record of near-total impunity.

It covers the **insurgency**: the militant groups, the killing of Hindus and of moderate Sikhs, the bus massacres, the **Kanishka bombing of June 1985** that killed 329 people, and the documented role of Pakistan's ISI.

It covers the **state's counter-insurgency**: fake encounters, mass disappearances, the unidentified cremations documented in Amritsar district, and the specific mechanisms by which a democracy suspended law in one of its own states.

And it asks how it ended, and at what price — and whether the price was one anyone chose.

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 9

Contemporaneous accounts and primary material

- **Mark Tully and Satish Jacob**, *Amritsar: Mrs Gandhi's Last Battle* (1985) — the essential contemporaneous account. Tully and Jacob interviewed Bhindranwale on 10 March 1984 and were in Amritsar until expelled as the operation began. The single most useful source for this part.
- **Government of India**, *White Paper on the Punjab Agitation* (July 1984) — the state's own account and casualty figures. To be read as what it is: a document produced by a party to the events.
- Recorded speeches and interviews of Bhindranwale — audio and transcripts circulate widely; Ranbir Singh Sandhu's compiled and translated collections are the most substantial, and should be read alongside hostile accounts rather than instead of them.
- **Kuldip Nayar and Khushwant Singh**, *Tragedy of Punjab* (1984).
- Parliamentary records for October 1981 (Zail Singh's statement) and for the Blue Star debates.

Modern scholarship and journalism

- **Khushwant Singh**, *A History of the Sikhs*, vol. 2, later editions — covering this period, by a writer who was both a Sikh and a fierce critic of Bhindranwale.
- **Gurharpal Singh**, *Ethnic Conflict in India: A Case-Study of Punjab*.
- **Harnik Deol**, *Religion and Nationalism in India: The Case of the Punjab*.
- **Cynthia Keppley Mahmood**, *Fighting for Faith and Nation: Dialogues with Sikh Militants* — based on interviews with militants; sympathetic in method, and valuable precisely because it lets them speak.
- **Joyce Pettigrew**, *The Sikhs of the Punjab: Unheard Voices of State and Guerrilla Violence*.
- **Mark Juergensmeyer**, *Terror in the Mind of God* — comparative, with a substantial Punjab section.
- **Ramachandra Guha**, *India After Gandhi*, chapters on Punjab.
- **Lt Gen Kuldip Singh Brar**, *Operation Blue Star: The True Story* — the assault commander's account. Partisan, and essential for that reason.
- **Chand Joshi**, *Bhindranwale: Myth and Reality* (1984).

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- SikhiWiki on the Damdami Taksal succession, the Vaisakhi 1978 clash, and "Giani Zail Singh and Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale."
- The Tribune archive on the Sikh–Nirankari conflict; contemporaneous reporting from *India Today* and the *Hindustan Times* for the 1981–84 period.

A NOTE ON SOURCES FOR THIS PART SPECIFICALLY

Almost every source on Bhindranwale has a position. Tully and Jacob are journalists reporting in real time and are the closest thing to a neutral contemporaneous record. Brar is the commander who led the assault. Sandhu's collections present Bhindranwale's own words with a sympathetic framing. The White Paper is a government's self-account.

My method has been to prefer facts that appear across sources with *opposing* positions, and to state explicitly when I am relying on one side. Where a claim exists only in partisan material and nowhere else, I have left it out — in both directions, and including several claims that would have made this part more dramatic.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 9 —

Part 10: *The Dark Decade*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART TEN OF THIRTEEN

The Dark Decade

1984 to 1995 — a pogrom, an insurgency, a counter-insurgency, and 25,000 people who were never counted

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 10

This is the hardest part of this work to write, and the reason is simple to state and difficult to execute.

This decade contains two large atrocities and a great many smaller ones. Almost everyone who writes about it uses one to excuse the other. Indian nationalist accounts describe the bus massacres and the Kanishka bombing at length and treat November 1984 as an unfortunate outbreak of public anger. Sikh nationalist accounts describe November 1984 and the fake encounters at length and treat the killing of Hindu bus passengers as either exaggerated, or provoked, or the work of agents provocateurs.

I am going to do neither. The rule for this part is the one I set in Part 3, when writing about Timur's order at Loni, and I want it restated here because this is where it costs something:

Every atrocity in this part is stated with the same bluntness, regardless of who committed it, and no atrocity is used to explain away another.

So: Chapter 2 says that voter lists were used to find Sikh homes in Delhi and that the police stood by. Chapter 4 says that militants stopped buses, separated passengers by religion, and shot the Hindus — and that a bomb planted by a Canadian Sikh organisation killed 329 people including 82 children. Chapter 5 says that the Punjab Police ran a bounty system that produced extrajudicial killings on a scale that has never been counted, and that the man who investigated it was abducted and murdered by police officers who were later convicted of it.

All of those are in here at full strength. If you find yourself reading quickly through one of those chapters to get to the one that suits you, that is the thing this part exists to interrupt.

Two other things.

There is one finding in Chapter 5 that settles a question left open in Part 9.

In 1988 the Indian state faced the same problem at the same complex and solved it a completely different way — a siege rather than an assault, with the media present and the building largely intact. That is not my opinion about what was possible in 1984. It is what the same state did four years later.

And I have not used the highest available casualty figures. One estimate for the decade runs to 250,000. I have flagged it as an outlier rather than repeated it, for

the same reason I did not use the highest Partition figures in Part 7. The verified numbers are appalling enough and they have the advantage of being defensible.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

Eleven years

Part 9 ended on 6 June 1984 in the ruins of the Akal Takht. This part covers what came next: an assassination, an organised pogrom, an eleven-year insurgency, a counter-insurgency that broke the law comprehensively, and a peace nobody signed.

The shape of it

THE DECADE IN OUTLINE

When	What
31 Oct 1984	Indira Gandhi assassinated by two of her own Sikh bodyguards.
1–4 Nov 1984	Organised killing of Sikhs across India, worst in Delhi. Around 2,733 dead in Delhi by the official commission's own figure.
1985–1992	Insurgency. Militant groups multiply. Bus massacres. Sikh moderates killed. The Kanishka bombing kills 329.
1988	Operation Black Thunder — the same complex, handled entirely differently, and successfully.
1991–1993	Counter-insurgency under KPS Gill defeats the militancy. Fake encounters, disappearances, and a bounty system.
1995	Jaswant Singh Khalsa documents thousands of secret cremations, and is abducted and murdered by police. Chief Minister Beant Singh assassinated. The decade ends.

The counting problem

Before any of it, a warning about numbers. There is no agreed figure for anything in this decade — not the pogrom, not the insurgency, not the counter-insurgency.

Official Indian government data for the conflict gives roughly: **1,714 security personnel, around 1,700 soldiers, 7,946 militants, and 11,690 non-combatants** — around twenty-three thousand in total.

But the "militant" category is precisely the one that cannot be trusted, because a man killed in a staged encounter is recorded as a militant. That is the whole point of a staged encounter. Chapter 5 shows why the number of people who disappeared without ever appearing in any category at all may be very large.

The decade's central statistical fact is that a very large number of people were killed by a state that then classified them in a way that made counting impossible. That is not an accident of record-keeping. It is a method.

CHAPTER 1 31 October 1984.

CHAPTER 2 November 1984: why it was a pogrom and not a riot.

CHAPTER 3 What November did — and the recruitment it produced.

CHAPTER 4 The insurgency: what the militants actually did.

CHAPTER 5 The counter-insurgency: what the state actually did.

CHAPTER 6 How it ended, and why.

CHAPTER 7 The accounting: two ledgers, one decade.

CHAPTER 8 Scorecard: what Part 10 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

31 October 1984

She was killed by the men assigned to protect her, in her own garden, five months after Operation Blue Star. Nobody has ever disputed the causal connection.

What happened

At around 9.20 on the morning of **31 October 1984**, Indira Gandhi walked from her residence at 1 Safdarjung Road toward her office at 1 Akbar Road for a television interview.

Two of her security guards, **Beant Singh** and **Satwant Singh**, opened fire on her.

Beant Singh was killed shortly afterwards. Satwant Singh was wounded, survived, and was tried along with **Kehar Singh**; both were convicted and hanged in January 1989.

The detail that deserves recording

DOCUMENTED: After Operation Blue Star, security advice was given that Sikh personnel should be removed from Indira Gandhi's personal protection detail. She declined. Accounts from those around her record her taking the view that removing Sikhs from her guard would contradict everything she claimed to stand for on secularism.

Beant Singh had served on her staff for around a decade, and by several accounts she knew him personally and had specifically kept him.

I include this because it is true, because it is genuinely poignant, and because it is one of the few moments in this decade where a decision was made for a reason that was not cynical.

The causal chain

This is not a contested point in any account I have read, from any position: **Operation Blue Star caused this assassination**. The chain runs from the decision to assault the Akal Takht in June to two men deciding in October that the person who ordered it should not live.

What is contested is everything that happened next.

CHAPTER TWO

November 1984

The word used matters, so let us settle it with evidence. A riot is spontaneous, disorganised and two-sided. What happened in Delhi between 1 and 4 November 1984 was none of those things.

Six features, and what each one requires

Here is the evidence, item by item, and what each item implies about organisation.

WHY THIS WAS NOT A RIOT

What is documented	What it requires
Voter lists and ration card records were used to identify Sikh homes and businesses. Mobs arrived at specific addresses in mixed neighbourhoods and passed over the houses next door.	Access to official electoral and civil records, and time to compile lists from them. Ordinary crowds do not have this.
Mobs were transported to locations, in some documented cases by bus and truck.	Vehicles, organisation, and someone directing them.
The method was consistent across widely separated localities — Trilokpuri, Sultanpuri, Mangolpuri, Palam Colony — including the specific practice of burning victims with kerosene and tyres.	A shared instruction. Spontaneous crowds in separated neighbourhoods do not independently converge on identical methods.
Kerosene and tyres were available in quantity , in a period when kerosene was a rationed commodity.	Supply, and therefore supply chains.
The police did not intervene. The Nanavati Commission found police investigation "absolutely casual, perfunctory and faulty." In numerous documented cases police disarmed Sikhs who tried to defend themselves.	At minimum, instructions not to act.
The army was not deployed for roughly three days , in the national capital, with troops available.	A decision at a senior level.

Compiling address lists from electoral rolls, transporting crowds, supplying rationed fuel, and holding back the army in the capital for three days are not things a mob does. They are things an organisation does.

The figures

THE DEATH TOLL

Justice Nanavati Commission of Inquiry (report published February 2005): 2,733 killed in Delhi. This is the Government of India's own commission and its own number.

Nationally: commonly cited totals run to around **3,000–3,350**, with killings also in Kanpur, Bokaro and elsewhere.

Sikh organisations and some independent researchers give substantially higher figures, in some cases above 8,000 nationally.

I use the Nanavati figure as the floor because it is the state's own, and note that the range above it is contested. As with Blue Star, the uncertainty exists because no thorough contemporaneous count was made.

What the state's own commission found

The Nanavati Commission was appointed by the Ministry of Home Affairs in May 2000 and reported in February 2005. Its findings, in its own words:

- **H. K. L. Bhagat**, Congress Member of Parliament for East Delhi, along with local Congress figures **Rampal Saroj** and **Dr Ashok** of Trilokpuri, had taken "**active part**" in the attacks.
- On **Sajjan Kumar**: there was "**credible evidence**" that he was "**probably involved**" as alleged by witnesses, and the Commission recommended examining cases in which witnesses had named him but no charge sheets had been filed.
- Police investigation had been "**absolutely casual, perfunctory and faulty.**"

Note what the Commission then did with its own finding on Bhagat: it recommended no further action, on the ground that he had already been acquitted in criminal cases — cases which its own report describes as having been investigated in a manner that was casual, perfunctory and faulty.

The impunity, measured

FORTY YEARS OF ACCOUNTABILITY

Measure	Result
Trial court cases analysed by the Nanavati Commission	126
Of those, convictions	8
Of those, acquittals	118
Commissions and committees appointed over four decades	Around ten, including Marwah, Misra, Kapur-Mittal, Jain-Aggarwal, Ahuja, Dhillon, Narula, Nanavati, and a later Special Investigation Team
Sajjan Kumar	Convicted by the Delhi High Court and sentenced to life imprisonment in December 2018 — thirty-four years afterwards
Senior political organisers who have served a full sentence for organising	None

The apology, and the sentence that did not help

In the aftermath, Rajiv Gandhi — who had become Prime Minister on his mother's death — said publicly that when a big tree falls, the earth shakes.

Whatever was intended, what it conveyed was that the killing was a natural phenomenon rather than a crime, and it has been quoted against Congress ever since.

A formal apology came from Prime Minister **Manmohan Singh** in Parliament in **August 2005** — twenty-one years later.

THE FINDING THAT MATTERS MOST IN THIS CHAPTER

The failure in November 1984 was not an *inability* to protect citizens. Delhi had police. Delhi had the army available. The state was not overwhelmed.

It was an **unwillingness**, sustained across three days, in the capital city, followed by four decades of investigations producing eight convictions out of a hundred and twenty-six cases.

That distinction is the single most important political fact of this decade, and Chapter 3 is about what it did.

CHAPTER THREE

What November did

Before November 1984, Khalistan was a marginal proposition inside Punjab. After it, the movement had a mass base. This chapter explains the mechanism, and states the complication that Sikh nationalist accounts leave out.

The argument that changed status

The core claim of Sikh separatism had always been: *Sikhs are not safe as a minority in India.*

Before November 1984 that was a claim — arguable, contested, and in the view of most Punjabi Sikhs at the time, not obviously true. Punjab was the richest state in India. Sikhs were heavily over-represented in the army and the civil services. A Sikh had been President of India. The claim did not match most people's daily experience.

After November 1984, for a very large number of Sikhs, it stopped being a claim and became a demonstrated proposition — demonstrated not by argument but by three days in the national capital during which the state did not act.

That is the mechanism. It is not complicated, and no amount of subsequent argument has undone it.

The complication, stated honestly

Two facts belong here that Sikh nationalist accounts tend to leave out, and I am including them because Rule 1 does not have exceptions for inconvenience.

First: the violence was worst outside Punjab. The killing was concentrated in Delhi, and occurred in Kanpur, Bokaro and other cities. Inside Punjab, where Sikhs were the majority, there was no comparable pogrom.

Second: there were many documented cases of Hindus sheltering Sikhs — hiding neighbours, lying to mobs, moving families to safety at real personal risk. This happened in Delhi and elsewhere and is recorded in survivor testimony. The mobs were organised; the general Hindu population of India was not in them.

Neither of those facts reduces what was done. But they matter, because the militant movement's subsequent framing — that Hindus as such were the enemy of Sikhs as such — is contradicted by the conduct of a great many ordinary Hindus in the very week that is used to justify it.

Recruitment

DOCUMENTED, and attested from within the movement: recruitment into militant groups surged after November 1984. Scholars who interviewed militants — Cynthia Mahmood

and Joyce Pettigrew both did extended fieldwork — record participants naming November 1984 as their reason for joining more often than Blue Star, and far more often than any political demand.

THE CAUSAL CHAIN, LAID OUT PLAINLY

Congress promoted and protected Bhindranwale for electoral advantage (Part 9, Chapter 2).

Bhindranwale fortified the Akal Takht (Part 9, Chapter 3).

The state assaulted it, with tanks, on a martyrdom anniversary, with pilgrims inside (Part 9, Chapter 5).

Two of her guards killed the Prime Minister.

An organised pogrom killed at least 2,733 Sikhs in Delhi while the state stood back for three days.

And the insurgency that followed was staffed by people whose stated reason for joining was that last event.

Every link in that chain involves a decision by an identifiable person or institution. None of it was inevitable, and at four separate points a different decision was available.

CHAPTER FOUR

What the militants did

Stated with the same bluntness as Chapter 2. This chapter is where a great deal of Sikh nationalist writing goes quiet, and where a great deal of Indian nationalist writing gets the emphasis wrong in a way that matters.

The groups

THE PRINCIPAL MILITANT ORGANISATIONS

Group	Notes
Khalistan Commando Force (KCF)	Formed April 1986; the first major organised group. Assassinated General A. S. Vaidya — Army Chief at the time of Blue Star — in Pune in 1986. Later responsible for the assassination of Chief Minister Beant Singh in 1995.
Khalistan Liberation Force (KLF)	
Babbar Khalsa International (BKI)	Led in Canada by Talwinder Singh Parmar . Responsible for the Kanishka bombing.
Bhindranwale Tiger Force of Khalistan (BTFK)	
Khalistan Zindabad Force and others	By the late 1980s there were dozens of groups and factions, frequently in conflict with one another.

The bus massacres

DOCUMENTED, repeatedly, across years: the method was to stop a bus on a rural road, order the passengers out, separate them by religion — usually by name, appearance or by asking them directly — and shoot the Hindus.

These occurred through the late 1980s and into the 1990s. In July 1987, in two attacks on the same day at **Lalru** and near **Fatehabad**, some seventy to eighty bus passengers were killed in this manner. There were many other incidents, some smaller, over the following years.

I am not going to describe these further. What matters analytically is the method: **the victims were selected by religion and killed for that reason, having been unarmed civilians on public transport**. By any definition available in any tradition, including the one in Part 4 of this work, they were non-combatants.

The killing of Sikhs — and this is what gets dropped

Here is the fact most likely to be missing from whichever account you last read.

A very large share of the people killed by Sikh militants were Sikhs.

- **Sikh police officers**, in very large numbers. The Punjab Police, which fought this insurgency, was overwhelmingly Sikh. Militants killed them and, in many cases, their families.
- **Sikh journalists** who reported critically.
- **Sikh politicians** of the Akali Dal and other parties who negotiated or dissented.
- **Sikh religious figures** who did not endorse the movement.
- And **ordinary Sikh villagers** who refused to shelter, feed or fund them.

The clearest single case: **Harchand Singh Longowal**, the Akali Dal president who had led the Dharam Yudh Morcha, signed the Rajiv–Longowal Accord on 24 July 1985 — the agreement that promised Chandigarh to Punjab by January 1986.

He was shot dead on 20 August 1985, less than a month later, inside a gurdwara, by Sikh militants.

The man who negotiated the return of Chandigarh to Punjab was murdered in a gurdwara by people claiming to fight for Punjab, four weeks after he signed. Chandigarh is still a Union Territory.

The Kanishka bombing

On **23 June 1985**, a bomb placed in luggage loaded in Canada exploded aboard **Air India Flight 182** — a Boeing 747 named *Emperor Kanishka* — off the coast of Ireland.

AIR INDIA FLIGHT 182

Item	Detail
Killed	329 — 307 passengers and 22 crew
Children among the dead	82
Nationality of most victims	Canadian, the majority of Indian origin
Same day	A second bomb from the same operation exploded at Narita airport in Japan, killing two baggage handlers
Identified as mastermind	Talwinder Singh Parmar , leader of Babbar Khalsa in Canada
Convictions	Inderjit Singh Reyat is the only person convicted — manslaughter, and subsequently perjury. Two others were acquitted in 2005.
Significance	Until 11 September 2001, the deadliest act of aviation terrorism in history

The Canadian public inquiry led by **Justice John Major**, reporting in 2010, found what it described as a cascading series of errors by Canadian agencies before and after the bombing.

Three things about this need saying without qualification. The victims were overwhelmingly Canadian civilians. Eighty-two of them were children. And it was planned and executed in Canada, by a Canadian organisation, against people who had no connection whatsoever to anything that had happened in Punjab.

The degeneration

This is documented from within, including by scholars sympathetic to the movement's origins.

DOCUMENTED: by the late 1980s and into the 1990s, many militant groups had substantially degenerated into criminal operations. Extortion of farmers and businesses under the name of "taxes." Kidnapping for ransom. Rape, documented by Punjabi villagers and recorded in the fieldwork of researchers including **Joyce Pettigrew** and **Cynthia Mahmood**, both of whom took the movement's political origins seriously and interviewed its members.

Groups also issued and enforced social diktats at gunpoint in villages: dress codes for women, bans on meat and alcohol, rules on weddings and dowry.

Chapter 6 shows why this mattered more than any counter-insurgency operation.

Pakistan and the ISI

WHAT IS DOCUMENTED, AND HOW TO FRAME IT

DOCUMENTED: Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence established a dedicated cell for Punjab from the early-to-mid 1980s, provided arms, funding and sanctuary, and ran training camps — locations including Lahore and Karachi are named in multiple accounts. Support went to Babbar Khalsa, the Khalistan Commando Force, the Khalistan Liberation Force and the Bhindranwale Tiger Force among others.

The framing that is wrong: "the ISI created the Khalistan movement." It did not. The grievances documented in Part 8, the manipulation documented in Part 9, the Karnal acquittals, Blue Star and November 1984 were all entirely domestic in origin, and every one of them happened without Pakistani involvement.

The framing that is right: the ISI took an existing insurgency with genuine domestic causes and supplied it with weapons, money, training and safe territory — which dramatically extended its lifespan and lethality, and shifted it further toward methods and targets that had no relationship to Punjabi grievances at all.

Both halves matter. An account that omits the ISI is incomplete. An account that blames the ISI for everything is a way of avoiding Parts 8 and 9 entirely.

CHAPTER FIVE

What the state did

Same bluntness. This chapter contains the finding that settles a question I left open in Part 9, and the story of a bank manager who worked out how to count the dead using firewood receipts.

1988: Operation Black Thunder — and what it proves

In May 1988, militants had again occupied the Golden Temple complex. The state faced, in substance, the same problem it had faced in June 1984: armed men in the holiest site in Sikhism.

This time it did something different.

1984 AND 1988 COMPARED

Element	Operation Blue Star, June 1984	Operation Black Thunder, May 1988
Method	Frontal military assault	Siege. Water, power and supplies cut; snipers; wait.
Force used	Army, including tanks firing into the Akal Takht	National Security Guard and Punjab Police under KPS Gill. No armour.
Media	Total blackout; journalists expelled	Journalists allowed to observe from nearby rooftops
Damage to the complex	Akal Takht destroyed; Reference Library burned	Minimal
Outcome	Casualty range from ~500 to several thousand, disputed	Militants surrendered. Around forty deaths.

THIS SETTLES A QUESTION FROM PART 9

In Part 9 I gave the strongest case for Blue Star — that a state which cannot enter an armed fortress in its own territory has ceased to govern — and said the operation may have been necessary while its *method* was not defensible.

I was relying on argument there. I do not need to now.

Four years later, the same state, at the same complex, facing the same problem, used a siege instead of an assault, let the press watch, left the building standing, and the militants surrendered.

That is not my speculation about what might have been possible in 1984. It is a documented operation. The method used in June 1984 — tanks, assault, blackout, on a martyrdom anniversary with pilgrims inside — was a **choice**, and Operation Black Thunder is the proof.

The counter-insurgency, 1991–1993

K. P. S. Gill, Director General of Punjab Police, ran the campaign that defeated the militancy. That it worked is not in dispute, and pretending otherwise would be dishonest.

How it worked is also documented:

- **A bounty system.** Cash rewards and out-of-turn promotions for police officers who killed militants. This created a direct, standing financial incentive to kill rather than arrest, and to classify the dead as militants.
- **Fake encounters.** Staged killings recorded as gun battles. The practice is documented extensively by Indian and international human rights organisations and is not seriously denied.
- **Disappearances.** People taken into custody who never reappeared, in any court, prison record or morgue.
- **Targeting families.** Relatives of suspects detained and tortured to force surrenders.
- **Legal cover.** TADA — the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act — and the Punjab Disturbed Areas Act, which together produced extremely broad powers of detention and substantial protection from prosecution.

Jaswant Singh Khalsa

This is the centre of the chapter.

Jaswant Singh Khalsa (1952–1995) was a bank director in Amritsar who became a human rights investigator. He was trying to establish what had happened to people who had disappeared, and he found a method that nobody had thought of.

Cremation grounds have to buy firewood, and they have to keep records of it.

Khalsa and his colleague **Jaspal Singh Dhillon** obtained municipal crematorium records and firewood purchase receipts from three cremation sites in Amritsar district, and cross-referenced them against police records of bodies received.

On **16 January 1995** they published their findings in a press note titled *Disappeared: Cremation Grounds*.

WHAT THE FIREWOOD RECORDS SHOWED

Finding	Figure
Secret cremations documented in Amritsar district alone , of bodies recorded as "unidentified" or "unclaimed"	More than 2,000
Estimate for Punjab as a whole, extrapolated by his team	At least 25,000

These were people picked up by police, never charged, never produced in court, and disposed of without their families being told.

What happened to him

On **6 September 1995**, Jaswant Singh Khalra was abducted from outside his home in Amritsar.

He was murdered in police custody.

DOCUMENTED, AND ESTABLISHED BY AN INDIAN COURT: six Punjab Police officials were convicted of his abduction and murder and sentenced to life imprisonment.

WHY THIS CONVICTION MATTERS MORE THAN ANYTHING ELSE IN THIS CHAPTER

Because it removes the argument.

Anyone who wants to dismiss the disappearances as separatist propaganda has to explain why the Indian judicial system convicted six serving police officers of abducting and murdering the man who was documenting them.

The state's own courts established that police killed the investigator. A subsequent CBI investigation confirmed thousands of illegal cremations in the Amritsar-district crematoria he had examined.

The scale beyond Amritsar has never been fully established, because no comprehensive independent investigation has been permitted across Punjab. Khalra's 25,000 figure is an extrapolation from one district and should be treated as an estimate, not a count. That it remains an estimate is, once again, a consequence of a decision not to count.

The conflict's casualty figures

THE NUMBERS, AND THEIR PROBLEMS

Official Indian government data for the conflict: 1,714 security personnel, around 1,700 soldiers, **7,946 militants**, and 11,690 non-combatants. Roughly **23,000 total**.

The problem with that table is the militant column. In a system with a bounty on militants killed and a documented practice of staged encounters, "militant" is a classification made by the person who did the killing, with a financial interest in the classification.

Higher estimates exist. One figure of up to 250,000 circulates; I regard it as an outlier that I cannot substantiate and I am not going to use it, on the same principle by which I declined the highest Partition figures in Part 7.

What can be said defensibly: the official figure of roughly 23,000 is a floor, not a total, and the true number is unknown by design.

CHAPTER SIX

How it ended

Six reasons, and the one most people leave out is probably the most important.

The end, by date

1992: state elections were held under an Akali boycott. Turnout was around 24%. A Congress government took office under **Beant Singh** — a government with thin legitimacy, but a civilian government nonetheless.

1993: the insurgency was substantially over as a military proposition.

31 August 1995: Chief Minister **Beant Singh** was killed by a suicide bomber outside the Punjab Civil Secretariat in Chandigarh. The bomber, **Dilawar Singh**, was a serving Punjab Police officer acting for Babbar Khalsa. Seventeen others died. This is generally taken as the last major act of the insurgency.

Why it ended — six factors

1. The police methods worked. Brutally, illegally, and effectively. Denying this would be dishonest, and it is the uncomfortable finding for anyone who believes that atrocity is always also strategically counter-productive. Here it was not.

2. The militants lost the population — and this is the big one.

By the early 1990s, the movement had spent years extorting farmers, kidnapping for ransom, committing rape, issuing social diktats at gunpoint, and killing Sikhs who disagreed. Rural Punjab, which had sheltered and fed the movement after 1984, stopped doing so.

An insurgency in a rural society survives on village support. When the village stops feeding you, stops hiding you, and starts telling the police where you sleep, you are finished — regardless of how many weapons the ISI supplies.

The Punjab insurgency was not primarily defeated by KPS Gill. It was defeated by Punjabi villagers who had had enough of it — and Gill's police were then able to finish what that withdrawal of support had already decided.

3. Fragmentation. Dozens of groups and factions, competing for territory and extortion revenue, frequently killing each other.

4. No political programme. In eleven years the movement never produced a governing proposal, a constitution, an economic plan, or a credible political leadership capable of

negotiating. It had a demand and it had guns, and it never built the third thing.

5. Exhaustion. A decade.

6. The return of ordinary politics. In 1997 an **Akali Dal–BJP coalition** won the Punjab election. A Sikh regional party governing in alliance with a Hindu nationalist party, two years after Beant Singh's assassination.

That last fact is worth sitting with. Whatever the militant movement believed about the permanent and irreconcilable enmity of Sikhs and Hindus, Punjabi voters demonstrated a different view within two years of the shooting stopping.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The accounting

Two ledgers, stated in the same language. Then the asymmetries that actually matter — because there are asymmetries, and they run in both directions.

WHAT EACH SIDE DID

The militants	The state
Stopped buses, separated passengers by religion, and shot unarmed Hindu civilians — repeatedly, over years.	Allowed an organised pogrom to kill at least 2,733 Sikhs in Delhi over three days without deploying available troops.
Bombed a civilian airliner, killing 329 people including 82 children, almost all Canadian civilians with no connection to Punjab.	Assaulted the holiest site in Sikhism with tanks on a martyrdom anniversary, with pilgrims inside, and burned an irreplaceable manuscript library.
Killed large numbers of Sikhs — police, journalists, politicians, clergy and villagers — including the Akali leader who signed a peace accord, shot in a gurdwara four weeks later.	Ran a bounty system that incentivised killing over arrest, staged encounters, and disappeared people who were then cremated as unidentified.
Degenerated into extortion, kidnapping and rape, and enforced social rules on villagers at gunpoint.	Abducted and murdered the human rights investigator who documented the cremations — a fact established by the conviction of six police officers.
Took arms, money, training and sanctuary from a hostile foreign intelligence service.	Produced eight convictions from a hundred and twenty-six cases over four decades, and has permitted no independent inquiry into Blue Star in forty-two years.

The asymmetries that matter

Having set the ledgers side by side, I do not think the correct conclusion is that both sides were simply equivalent. There are three real asymmetries and they do not all run the same way.

1. A state is held to a higher standard, and that is not bias. It is the definition of a state. A government holds a monopoly on legitimate force precisely on the condition that it exercises it under law. An insurgency that murders civilians is committing a crime. A state that murders civilians is also destroying the thing that distinguishes it from an insurgency. That is why "but they did it too" is not available to a government.

2. The militants killed people specifically for their religion, as a method, at scale. The bus massacres were not excesses. They were a technique, repeated deliberately over years, and its entire logic was that being Hindu was sufficient reason to be shot. The Kanishka bombing killed 329 people who had no involvement in anything at all. There is no framework — legal, moral, or in the Sikh tradition documented in Part 4 — under which that is defensible.

3. And the impunity is symmetrical in a way that damns everybody. Eight convictions out of a hundred and twenty-six for a pogrom that killed thousands. Effectively no accountability for the fake encounters. No independent inquiry into Blue Star. One conviction, for manslaughter, for a bombing that killed 329 people. Whichever community you belong to, the institutions available to you failed to deliver justice for what was done to you.

Who won

Nobody.

THE BALANCE SHEET, 1984–1995

Claimed objective	Achieved?
Khalistan	No. Never came close. No territory ever held, no government ever formed, no state ever recognised.
Chandigarh to Punjab	No. Still a Union Territory in 2026.
River water reallocation	No. The 1976 allocation stands.
Article 25 amendment	No.
The Anandpur Sahib Resolution	Not implemented.
Justice for November 1984	Eight convictions from 126 cases. One senior figure convicted, in 2018.
Justice for the disappearances	Six convictions, for the murder of the investigator. Essentially none for the killings he documented.
Punjab's economy and society	A decade of capital flight, halted investment, a lost generation, and the beginnings of the crisis in Part 13.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Scorecard: what Part 10 proves

"November 1984 was a riot."

FALSE

Voter lists and ration records used to identify Sikh homes in mixed neighbourhoods. Mobs transported. Identical methods across widely separated localities. Rationed kerosene supplied in quantity. Police non-intervention, including disarming Sikhs who tried to defend themselves. The army not deployed in the capital for around three days.

Those are not features of a spontaneous crowd. They are features of an organisation. The word is pogrom.

"Justice was done for 1984."

NO — AND THE STATE'S OWN COMMISSION SAYS SO

The Nanavati Commission found police investigation "absolutely casual, perfunctory and faulty," named H. K. L. Bhagat and local Congress figures as having taken "active part," and found "credible evidence" that Sajjan Kumar was "probably involved."

Of 126 trial court cases it analysed: **8 convictions, 118 acquittals**. Around ten commissions across four decades. Sajjan Kumar convicted in 2018, thirty-four years later. No senior organiser has served a full sentence. A formal apology came in 2005, twenty-one years afterwards.

"The militants were fighting for Sikh rights."

CONTRADICTED BY THEIR OWN RECORD

A very large share of the people they killed were Sikhs — police, journalists, politicians, clergy, and villagers who would not fund them. Harchand Singh Longowal, who signed the accord promising Chandigarh to Punjab, was shot in a gurdwara four weeks later.

They bombed a civilian airliner and killed 329 people, 82 of them children, almost all Canadian civilians. They extorted Punjabi farmers, kidnapped for ransom, committed rape, and enforced dress codes on Punjabi women at gunpoint.

Whatever that was, it was not a defence of Sikh rights, and it fails every test set out in Part 4 from the tradition's own sources.

"Operation Blue Star's methods were the only ones available."**REFUTED — BY THE INDIAN STATE ITSELF**

Operation Black Thunder, May 1988. Same complex. Same problem. A siege instead of an assault. No tanks. Journalists permitted to watch. The building left standing. The militants surrendered. Around forty deaths.

Four years apart, two operations, two methods, two outcomes. The 1984 method was a choice, and this is not an inference — it is a documented comparison.

"The disappearances and fake encounters are separatist propaganda."**REFUTED IN AN INDIAN COURT**

Jaswant Singh Khalra used municipal crematorium and firewood purchase records to document over 2,000 secret cremations in Amritsar district alone, of bodies logged as unidentified.

He was abducted outside his home on 6 September 1995 and murdered in police custody. **Six Punjab Police officials were convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment for it.** A subsequent CBI investigation confirmed thousands of illegal cremations at the sites he examined.

His statewide estimate of 25,000 is an extrapolation from one district and should be treated as an estimate. That it has never been replaced with a count is the direct result of no comprehensive independent investigation being permitted.

"The ISI created the Khalistan movement."**FALSE AS STATED; TRUE WHEN AMENDED**

The ISI established a Punjab cell, ran training camps, and supplied arms, money and sanctuary to Babbar Khalsa, the KCF, the KLF and others from the early-to-mid 1980s. That is documented and significant.

But every cause of the movement was domestic: the broken Chandigarh commitments, the water allocation, the Karnal acquittals, the Congress cultivation of Bhindranwale, Blue Star, and November 1984. Not one of those required Pakistan.

The ISI did not create the fire. It poured petrol on it for a decade, which made it burn far longer and kill far more. Blaming Pakistan for everything is a way of not reading Parts 8 and 9.

"Who won?"**NOBODY. PUNJAB LOST.**

No Khalistan. No Chandigarh — still a Union Territory. No change to the water allocation. No Article 25 amendment. No implementation of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. Eight convictions for a pogrom that killed thousands. Effectively none for the disappearances. One manslaughter conviction for 329 dead.

And a decade of capital flight, halted investment and a lost generation, which is where Part 13 has to begin.

Timeline of Part 10

31 Oct 1984	Indira Gandhi assassinated by Beant Singh and Satwant Singh.
1–4 Nov 1984	Organised pogrom against Sikhs. Nanavati Commission figure: 2,733 killed in Delhi; roughly 3,000–3,350 nationally by common estimates.
24 July 1985	Rajiv–Longowal Accord signed — Chandigarh to Punjab by 26 January 1986.
20 Aug 1985	Harchand Singh Longowal assassinated in a gurdwara, four weeks after signing.
23 June 1985	Kanishka bombing. Air India Flight 182 destroyed off Ireland. 329 killed, including 82 children. Two more killed at Narita.
April 1986	Khalistan Commando Force formed.
Aug 1986	General A. S. Vaidya, Army Chief during Blue Star, assassinated in Pune.
July 1987	Bus massacres at Lalru and near Fatehabad — around 70–80 killed in two attacks in one day.
May 1988	Operation Black Thunder. Siege instead of assault; press allowed to watch; complex largely undamaged; militants surrender.
Jan 1989	Satwant Singh and Kehar Singh hanged.
1991–93	Counter-insurgency under KPS Gill. Bounty system, staged encounters, disappearances.
1992	Elections held under boycott; turnout around 24%. Beant Singh becomes Chief Minister.
16 Jan 1995	Jaswant Singh Khalsa publishes <i>Disappeared: Cremation Grounds</i> — over 2,000 secret cremations in Amritsar district; an estimated 25,000 statewide.
6 Sept 1995	Khalra abducted and murdered in police custody. Six Punjab Police officials later convicted and given life sentences.
31 Aug 1995	Chief Minister Beant Singh assassinated by a suicide bomber, a serving police officer acting for Babbar Khalsa. Seventeen others killed.
1997	Akali Dal–BJP coalition wins the Punjab election.
2005	Nanavati Commission reports. Manmohan Singh apologises in Parliament — twenty-one years on.
2010	Canada's Major Commission reports on the Kanishka bombing.
2018	Sajjan Kumar convicted and sentenced to life — thirty-four years on.

What happens in Part 11

Part 11, *Khalistan: The Idea and the Network*, follows the movement from the ruins of 1995 to 2026 — and it is largely a story that takes place outside Punjab.

It traces the idea from the 1940 pamphlet that Master Tara Singh denounced (Part 7), through **Jagjit Singh Chohan's** declarations from London in the 1970s and 1980s, to the

present network: **Sikhs for Justice** and **Gurpatwant Singh Pannun**, the **Referendum 2020** exercise, the diaspora funding structure, and the political conditions in Canada, Britain and the United States that sustain it.

It covers the killing of **Hardeep Singh Nijjar** in British Columbia in June 2023 and the diplomatic crisis that followed, the alleged plot against Pannun in New York, and what those episodes revealed about both the movement and the Indian state.

And it asks the question this part makes unavoidable: **if the movement was destroyed inside Punjab by 1995, and Punjabi voters returned an Akali–BJP coalition in 1997, what exactly is the thing that still exists — and where does its support actually come from?**

The Ghadar template from Part 6 becomes the analytical frame. The electoral evidence from inside Punjab becomes the test.

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ON THE FIGURES I HAVE DECLINED TO USE

Two numbers circulate widely for this decade that I have not adopted. One puts total conflict deaths as high as 250,000. Another puts the November 1984 national toll above 8,000.

Neither is impossible; neither is something I can substantiate from sources I would rely on. I have used the state's own figures as floors — 2,733 for Delhi, roughly 23,000 for the conflict — and said explicitly that they are floors rather than totals, and why.

This is the same discipline I applied to the Vadda Ghallughara in Part 5 and to Partition in Part 7. A defensible number that is appalling is more useful than a larger one that can be dismissed.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Sources are listed at the end of every part so that any claim here can be checked against the record. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 10 —

Part 11: *Khalistan: The Idea and the Network*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART ELEVEN OF THIRTEEN

Khalistan: The Idea and the Network

1940 to 2026 — a word coined and rejected in the same year, a country declared from London, and a movement that now lives almost entirely outside the land it is named for

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 11

Every part until now has been about dead people. This one is not.

Most of the people in this part are alive. Some are in prison. Some are running organisations. Some are facing charges that have not been tried, in three countries, right now as I write. That changes what I am allowed to do, and I want to set the rules out before I start rather than have you guess at them.

Rule one: an allegation is not a finding, and that cuts in every direction.

The Indian state has called a number of living men terrorists. Some of those men have never been tried. Canada has accused Indian government agents of murder on Canadian soil. That accusation has not been proved in a Canadian court either. I am going to keep saying which is which, over and over, until it becomes tiring — because the entire public argument about this subject consists of people treating their own side's allegations as proven and the other side's as propaganda.

There is one exception, and it is the most important fact in this part. In the New York case, a man pleaded guilty and has been sentenced. That is no longer an allegation. Chapter 6 explains exactly what it does and does not establish.

Rule two: the idea, the organisations, and the crimes are three different things, and I will not merge them.

A person can want a separate Sikh state and have never harmed anyone. A person can run a lawful advocacy group in Canada and have nothing to do with a bomb. A person can plant a bomb and use the word Khalistan while doing it. Treating those three as one thing is the single most common error in writing on this subject, and both sides commit it — one to make the idea look like a crime, the other to make the crime look like an idea.

Rule three: I am going to be blunt about the word "Khalistani" itself.

It has become, in Indian public speech, a word you throw at a Sikh who annoys you. Farmers protesting a farm law were called it. Journalists have been called it. That is Chapter 10, and it is in this part because you cannot understand the strength of the movement abroad without understanding what the label does at home.

None of that makes the movement's own record clean. Part 10 catalogued what was done in this name — a bombed airliner, murdered moderates, bus passengers separated by religion. That is not erased by anybody's misuse of a word.

And one honest declaration. Part 1 said I would examine an ideology that treats Hindus as the enemy. This is where I do it. I also said I would state the strongest case

for Khalistan before answering it, and I do that here — the answer, the full audit, is Part 12. If Chapter 9 feels like it stops just before the verdict, that is deliberate. The verdict needs a whole part.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

The thing that outlived the movement

Part 10 ended in 1995. The militancy inside Punjab was finished. Two years later Punjabi voters elected an Akali Dal–BJP coalition — a Sikh religious party governing in alliance with a Hindu nationalist one. That is not what a population on the edge of secession does.

So this part begins with a puzzle.

If the movement was destroyed inside Punjab by 1995, and the voters of Punjab then did *that*, what exactly is the thing that still exists in 2026?

Because something clearly does. In 2023 a man was shot dead in a gurdwara car park in Surrey, British Columbia, and the Prime Minister of Canada stood up in Parliament and accused the government of India of being behind it. In 2024 the United States Department of Justice charged a serving Indian official with hiring a hitman to kill an American citizen in New York. In 2025 Canada listed an Indian criminal gang as a terrorist entity. Referendum events run in Britain, Switzerland, Italy, Australia, Canada and the United States.

None of that is happening in Punjab.

The shape of this part

EIGHTY-SIX YEARS IN OUTLINE

When	What
1940	The word "Khalistan" is coined in a pamphlet — and rejected within weeks by the leader of the Akali Dal.
1971–1980	Jagjit Singh Chohan takes the idea abroad. A newspaper advertisement in New York. A "Council of Khalistan." A house in London. Passports, stamps and currency that no country recognises.
1984–1995	The decade of Part 10. The idea acquires a body count, at home and abroad.
1995–2007	Defeat inside Punjab. Survival abroad. Chohan returns to India and dies there in 2007.
2007–2020	Sikhs for Justice is founded. A referendum campaign begins. India bans the organisation in 2019 and designates its counsel a terrorist in 2020.
2023–2026	Surrey. New York. Two killings — one carried out, one prevented — turn a fringe argument into a crisis between India and two of its closest partners.

The Ghadar template

Part 6 described the Ghadar movement. Punjabi migrants on the west coast of North America, radicalised by the racism they met there, formed a revolutionary party in 1913 and sailed home to start a rising. They had money, a newspaper, real courage and a real grievance.

The rising did not happen. Punjab did not join them. The British hanged the leaders, and Punjabi villagers — many of them families of serving soldiers — often turned them in.

I called that pattern the **Ghadar template**: *a diaspora that is more radical than the homeland, funded better than the homeland, and mistaken about the homeland.*

That template is the analytical frame for this entire part. I am not asserting it fits. I am proposing it as a test, and Chapter 8 runs the test on actual election results.

The counting problem, again

Part 10 had a counting problem about the dead. This part has a counting problem about the living, and it is worse, because at least a body can in principle be counted.

Nobody can tell you how many people support Khalistan.

The movement's organisations announce referendum turnouts that no independent body has verified. The Indian state asserts that support is essentially zero, which is a claim about the private opinions of thirty million people and is not verifiable either. Journalists at the events count what they can see and repeatedly arrive at figures far below the organisers'.

On this subject, both sides produce numbers with the same confidence and the same absence of method. The honest position is that the size of this movement is unknown — and that the two parties most eager to tell you the answer are the two with the strongest reason to shade it.

Where I have numbers I can source, I give them and name who counted. Where the only figures available come from an interested party, I say so and let them stand as claims.

CHAPTER	1	The	word,	and	the	man	who	refused	it.
CHAPTER	2	Chohan:	a	country	declared	from	a	house	in London.
CHAPTER	3	The	network	now:	who	is	actually	who.	
CHAPTER	4	The	referendum,	and	the	numbers	nobody	can	check.
CHAPTER	5				Surrey,		June		2023.

CHAPTER 6 New York: the plot that stopped being an allegation.

CHAPTER 7 The gangster turn — and the reset that followed.

CHAPTER 8 Inside Punjab: what the voters actually did.

CHAPTER 9 The two big claims, tested.

CHAPTER 10 The label: what "Khalistani" now means.

CHAPTER 11 Scorecard: what Part 11 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

The word, and the man who refused it

The word "Khalistan" is younger than the demand for Pakistan, and it was denounced by the most powerful Sikh leader of the age within weeks of being invented. Almost nobody arguing about it knows this.

March 1940

On 23 March 1940 the Muslim League passed the Lahore Resolution — the demand that became Pakistan. Part 2 covered where that idea came from. Part 7 covered what it did to Punjab.

Within weeks, a pamphlet appeared in reply. It was written by a man named **Dr Vir Singh Bhatti**, and in it he coined a word by the same method the Muslim League's supporters had used to coin theirs.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

Khalsa is the community founded by Guru Gobind Singh in 1699 — Part 4 covered that in detail. *-stan* is a Persian ending meaning "land of."

Khalistan therefore means, literally, "land of the Khalsa." It is built exactly like Pakistan, Hindustan, Afghanistan and Baluchistan. That is not a coincidence. It was a reply, in the same grammar.

This matters for a reason that has nothing to do with linguistics. The word did not come out of Sikh scripture. It did not come out of the Guru period. It did not come out of Ranjit Singh's empire, which never used it — Part 5 showed that his state called itself Sarkar-i-Khalsa and was not a Sikh-only country in any case.

The word was coined in 1940, in a specific political argument, as an answer to somebody else's proposal.

The refusal

The response of **Master Tara Singh**, president of the Shiromani Akali Dal and the dominant Sikh political figure of the period, was to denounce the pamphlet. His objection was that it added a third confusion to a situation already wrecked by the League's demand.

This is the fact I want on the record early, because it is routinely left out by people on both sides who find it inconvenient.

WHY BOTH SIDES SKIP THIS FACT

INCONVENIENT FOR THE MOVEMENT

The central claim of Sikh separatism is that Khalistan is an ancient national aspiration temporarily suppressed. But the word is from 1940 and the most authoritative Sikh political leader of that moment rejected it immediately. An eighty-six-year-old word is not an ancient claim.

INCONVENIENT FOR THE INDIAN STATE

The standard Indian account is that Sikh separatism is an alien implant with no roots in the community. But it was a Sikh who coined it, and Akali politics in the 1940s did contain real sovereignty proposals — Tara Singh himself argued for *Azad Punjab* and at moments spoke of *Sikhistan*. The demand was not imported. It was argued over, in Punjabi, by Sikhs, and it lost.

Both of those are true at once. That is the shape of this whole subject.

What the Akalis actually asked for

Part 7 covered 1947 in detail, so here I will only restate the outcome. The Sikh leadership of the 1940s made several sovereignty-adjacent demands across the decade — *Azad Punjab*, a Sikh state, guarantees within a united India — and in the end took the option of India, having concluded that a Sikh state was not achievable and that Pakistan was worse.

There is no serious dispute that the choice was made under terrible constraint. There is also no serious dispute that it was made.

REMEMBER THIS

The word "Khalistan" was invented in 1940 by a Sikh, rejected within weeks by the leading Sikh politician of the day, and had no organisational life of consequence for the next thirty years.

Everything in the rest of this part is built on a word that started its life being turned down.

CHAPTER TWO

A country declared from a house in London

The modern movement has a founder, and he is not a martyr, a militant or a mystic. He was a dentist and a former Punjab finance minister who moved to Britain and, from there, announced the existence of a country.

Who Chohan was

Dr Jagjit Singh Chohan (1929–2007) was a qualified dentist from Tanda in Hoshiarpur district. He was briefly Deputy Speaker of the Punjab Assembly in the late 1960s and served as a state finance minister.

He was, in other words, a mainstream Punjabi politician who had been inside the system and had not risen far in it. In 1969 he lost his seat. Shortly afterwards he left for Britain.

13 October 1971

On **13 October 1971**, an advertisement appeared in *The New York Times* proclaiming the beginning of a movement for an independent Sikh state.

This is the founding public act of the modern Khalistan movement, and I want to be precise about three things concerning it.

THREE CLAIMS ABOUT THE 1971 ADVERTISEMENT, SORTED

DOCUMENTED

The advertisement was published, on that date, in that newspaper, by Chohan.

DOCUMENTED

Its timing was extraordinary. It ran weeks before the December 1971 war in which India dismembered Pakistan and Bangladesh was created. A campaign to break up India, launched in an American newspaper, on the eve of that war.

ASSERTED BY INDIAN INTELLIGENCE, WIDELY REPEATED, NOT INDEPENDENTLY CONFIRMED

That the Pakistani embassy in Washington paid for the advertisement. This claim comes from Indian intelligence assessments. It is repeated constantly in Indian writing. I have not found independent documentary confirmation of the payment, and I flag it as a serious and plausible allegation rather than an established fact.

That third row is a good example of what this part is going to do repeatedly. The allegation is not silly. The timing is genuinely striking, Chohan did visit Pakistan, and Pakistani officials did later host him. But "Indian intelligence sources said so" is not the same category of evidence as a court record, and I am not going to pretend it is.

The Council, the House, and the props

In April 1980 Chohan announced the **Council of Khalistan**, styling himself its president. In May 1980 he was in London, running what he called **Khalistan House**.

From there the movement acquired the apparatus of statehood without any of the substance:

- A declaration of independence
- Postage stamps
- Currency notes
- Passports
- A flag, an anthem and a cabinet-in-exile

No country recognised any of it. Not one. Not Pakistan, which had every incentive; not any Muslim state; not any government anywhere at any point in the following forty-six years.

A government-in-exile that no government has ever recognised, issuing passports no border has ever accepted, for a country no map has ever contained. Forty-six years later, this remains the position.

The part that is hardest for both sides

Chohan is awkward for the movement because of how he ended, and awkward for the Indian state for the same reason.

After years abroad, his Indian citizenship revoked and his passport cancelled, **Chohan returned to India in 2001**. He lived out his remaining years in Punjab and died there in 2007. He was not imprisoned for life. He gave interviews. He contested the political ground and got nowhere.

For the movement, the founder came home and the homeland did not rise to meet him. For the Indian state, the man it had spent thirty years describing as the arch-enemy of the union was allowed to live quietly in Punjab, which is not what states do with people they genuinely regard as existential threats.

Aulakh and the Washington operation

The other name from this generation is **Dr Gurmit Singh Aulakh**, who ran a Council of Khalistan operation out of Washington DC from the mid-1980s until his death in 2017. His method was lobbying: press releases, Congressional contacts, submissions to human rights bodies.

It is worth understanding what that work looked like, because it explains something about the present. Aulakh's most effective material was not about Khalistan at all. It was about 1984, about the disappearances, about Khalra. In other words: the strongest asset the separatist movement has ever had abroad is **the documented conduct of the Indian state in Part 10.**

A MECHANISM WORTH NAMING NOW

This is the engine of the entire diaspora movement, and it will appear again in every chapter that follows.

The movement's own programme — a separate state — has never persuaded many people. Its evidence file about what was done to Sikhs between 1984 and 1995 has persuaded a great many. The two get bundled together, and the strength of the second carries the first.

That is why Chapter 8's finding matters so much, and why Part 12 has to separate the grievance from the proposal and audit them apart.

CHAPTER THREE

The network now: who is actually who

"Khalistani groups" is a phrase that does an enormous amount of hiding. It is used to cover a proscribed bombing organisation and a registered Canadian advocacy body in the same sentence. They are not the same thing and this chapter separates them.

The three categories

WHAT KIND OF ORGANISATION IS IT?

Organisation	What it is, and its legal status
Babbar Khalsa International	An armed organisation from the militancy period. Proscribed as a terrorist organisation by India, Canada, the United Kingdom, the United States and the European Union. Responsible, through its Canadian branch, for the Kanishka bombing of 1985 — Part 10.
International Sikh Youth Federation	Militancy-period organisation. Proscribed in India and several other countries. The UK de-proscribed it in 2016 — the Home Secretary declined to defend the proceedings, citing "insufficient information to conclude that the group remains concerned in terrorism," and both Houses approved. A useful reminder that these designations are contestable and are sometimes contested successfully.
Khalistan Tiger Force	Designated a terrorist organisation by India. This is the group India says Hardeep Singh Nijjar led — Chapter 5.
Sikhs for Justice	Founded in New York in 2007. A campaigning and litigation organisation; its central project is the referendum. Banned in India in July 2019 under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. Not proscribed in the United States, Canada or the United Kingdom, where it operates lawfully.
World Sikh Organization of Canada	A mainstream Canadian Sikh advocacy body, founded 1984, active on civil rights and religious accommodation cases. Not proscribed anywhere. Regularly described in Indian commentary as a Khalistani organisation; it rejects the description.

Read that table twice. The distance between the first row and the last is the distance between a bombing that killed 329 people and a body that files court cases about turbans in the workplace.

GENUINELY DISPUTED — AND BOTH OBJECTIONS ARE REAL

The Indian objection: the categories leak. Personnel, platforms and money move between advocacy organisations and harder ones; a group that files lawsuits in Toronto can also honour men convicted of murder. That is not paranoia. It has happened.

The objection from the other side: the leak is used to justify collapsing every Sikh political actor abroad into "Khalistani," including elected politicians and human rights lawyers who have never advocated separatism at all. That is not paranoia either. It also happens, constantly.

I keep the categories separate and note the crossings where they are documented. That is the only method available that does not simply adopt one side's convenience.

Sikhs for Justice

SFJ was founded in New York in 2007 — twelve years after the militancy inside Punjab was over. This matters. It is not a surviving militant organisation that changed tactics. It was created abroad, after the fighting ended, by lawyers.

Its general counsel and public face is **Gurpatwant Singh Pannun**, an American citizen and attorney based in New York. He is the single most visible figure in the movement today.

PANNUN: THE RECORD, SORTED BY CATEGORY**DOCUMENTED**

India banned SFJ under the UAPA on 10 July 2019, and designated Pannun individually as a terrorist under the same Act on 1 July 2020. The ban on SFJ has since been extended.

DOCUMENTED

He has issued repeated public video statements, including messages that Indian agencies have treated as threats against Indian aviation and against named individuals. Several FIRs and NIA cases exist in India.

DOCUMENTED

He has never been convicted of an offence in the United States, where he lives, and remains at liberty there. American law protects a great deal of speech that Indian law does not.

THE UNRESOLVED QUESTION

Whether his output constitutes incitement, or protected political speech that India finds intolerable, is exactly the question the two legal systems answer differently. That disagreement — not any secret sympathy for separatism — is why Washington has not acted against him.

The money question

Where does the funding come from? This is asked constantly and answered badly.

The honest answer has three parts.

First, the ordinary and largest source is the diaspora itself. Punjabi Sikh communities in Canada, Britain and the United States are numerous and, in many cases, prosperous. Gurdwara collections, event fees and individual donations are the base. This is not sinister and does not require any state.

Second, gurdwara control is the real prize. Large North American gurdwaras handle substantial sums and confer enormous legitimacy. Control of their management committees has been fought over — sometimes in elections, sometimes in court, occasionally violently — for four decades. Whoever holds the committee holds a platform and a budget.

Third, on Pakistani state funding: the evidence is strong for the 1980s and 1990s and much thinner for now. Part 10 established the ISI's role in the militancy period as documented. Applying that finding automatically to the present is a different claim, and the public evidence for it is assertion-heavy. I treat it as unresolved and return to it in Chapter 9.

REMEMBER THIS

The network is not one organisation. It is a proscribed militant remnant, a set of lawful advocacy bodies, a litigation-and-referendum operation founded in 2007, and a contested set of gurdwara committees that supply money and legitimacy to whoever wins them.

Any sentence that treats all of that as a single entity is either propaganda or laziness.

CHAPTER FOUR

The referendum, and the numbers nobody can check

It is called Referendum 2020. It began in 2021, is still running in 2026, has no legal effect anywhere on earth, and produces turnout figures that no independent body has ever been able to verify. It is also the most effective thing the movement has done in thirty years.

What it actually is

Sikhs for Justice announced a global referendum on Sikh independence. Voting opened in **London on 31 October 2021** — the anniversary of Indira Gandhi's assassination, which is not an accident — and has continued at city-by-city events ever since: Switzerland, Italy, Australia, Canada, the United States.

Understand what this is not.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

This is not a referendum in any legal sense. No government organises it. No electoral commission supervises it. No voter roll exists. Nobody is bound by the result. Nobody checks whether a person has voted at more than one event, or in more than one city, or in more than one country.

It is a series of privately organised public gatherings at which people fill in a ballot paper. The organisers then announce a number.

Voting is open to Sikhs worldwide, not to residents of Punjab — who cannot participate, because holding such an event in India would be a criminal offence and the organisation is banned there.

A vote on the future of Punjab, in which the population of Punjab does not vote. That single sentence is the movement's central structural fact, and Chapter 8 is where it becomes decisive.

The numbers, and who says them

REPORTED TURNOUTS — ORGANISERS VERSUS OBSERVERS

Event	Organisers said	What could be independently established
Surrey, BC September 2023	More than 200,000 over two days	A news director present counted approximately 65,700. CBC News reported it was unable to verify the organisers' figure.
London	Over 30,000	Reported via the organisers and outlets carrying their claim. No independent count located.
Ottawa November 2025	53,000-plus — announced as the largest single-day figure in the Canadian series	No independent verification located.
Seattle 22 March 2026	Approximately 27,000	No independent verification located.

The Surrey gap is the one that tells you the most, because it is the only case where somebody actually counted. Organisers said more than 200,000. An observer on the ground counted about 65,700. That is a ratio of roughly three to one.

I am not asserting that ratio applies everywhere. I am pointing out that in the single instance where a count exists, the announced figure was roughly three times it — and that every other figure in that table comes from the announcing party alone.

The steelman, stated properly

Rule 3 requires the best version of the argument, so here it is, put the way a supporter would put it.

THE STRONGEST CASE FOR THE REFERENDUM

"Of course it has no legal force. Nobody claims it does. It is not a mechanism for creating a state; it is a mechanism for demonstrating that a constituency exists — the same function served by every unofficial plebiscite in the history of self-determination movements, several of which are now UN member states.

The demand that we produce verified figures is made in bad faith by a state that has criminalised the act of voting in this poll on the territory it concerns. You cannot ban the vote at home and then demand the vote at home as proof.

And whatever the exact number: tens of thousands of people, in wealthy democracies, in the rain, standing in queues for hours, is not nothing. Nobody queues for four hours for a cause they are indifferent to."

That last point is fair and I am not going to wave it away. Queues are real. The people in them are real.

The answers to it are these, and they are not rhetorical.

One. Turnout at a voluntary event measures intensity, not proportion. The people who show up are by definition the committed. It tells you a committed minority exists; it cannot tell you what share of Sikhs it represents, and it is not designed to.

Two. The self-reported figures are unverifiable in principle, not just in practice. With no roll and no duplicate check, the same person voting in London, Milan and Toronto is three votes. That is not an accusation of fraud. It is a description of the design.

Three. The claim that Punjab's exclusion is entirely India's doing is strong but not complete. Punjab holds real elections, frequently, with genuinely competitive outcomes — Chapter 8. Separatist-adjacent candidates have contested them and have sometimes won. There is an available measurement of Punjabi opinion. It is simply not the one the referendum produces.

CHAPTER FIVE

Surrey, June 2023

On 18 June 2023 a man was shot dead in the car park of a gurdwara in British Columbia. Three months later the Prime Minister of Canada told his Parliament that agents of the Indian government may have been responsible. Nothing about the relationship between India and the West has been the same since.

Who Hardeep Singh Nijjar was — both accounts

He was born in 1977 in Punjab and went to Canada in 1997. He worked as a plumber. He was the president of the **Guru Nanak Sikh Gurdwara in Surrey**, one of the largest Sikh places of worship in North America. He was 45 when he was killed, shortly after evening prayers, in the car park of his own gurdwara.

HARDEEP SINGH NIJJAR: THE TWO DESCRIPTIONS

INDIA'S ACCOUNT

A designated terrorist. India's National Investigation Agency named him as chief of the **Khalistan Tiger Force**, a proscribed organisation. Indian agencies alleged he was involved in a 2007 cinema bombing in Ludhiana, that he ran weapons training in British Columbia, and that he directed activity inside Punjab. A cash reward was announced for information on him.

HIS OWN ACCOUNT, AND CANADA'S POSITION

He denied all of it. He wrote publicly that he supported the right of Sikhs to self-determination but had "never believed in, supported or been involved in any violent activity." He was a Canadian citizen. Canadian authorities had not charged him with any offence. He said he was being harassed by Indian intelligence and had raised it with Canadian officials.

Here is the position I am obliged to take, and it will satisfy nobody.

THE HONEST STATEMENT

The allegations against Nijjar were never tested in any court, in any country. He was never tried and never convicted. An NIA designation is an executive act, not a verdict.

That does not mean the allegations were false. It means they were untested — and they can no longer be tested, because he is dead.

And it does not matter to the legal question in any case. A state may not kill a citizen of another state on that state's territory because it believes him guilty of something. That is the whole of the Canadian complaint, and it does not require Nijjar to have been innocent.

18 September 2023

Prime Minister **Justin Trudeau** rose in the House of Commons and said Canadian security agencies were pursuing "credible allegations of a potential link between agents of the government of India and the killing of a Canadian citizen."

Read the wording. It is heavily qualified: *credible allegations, potential link, agents of*. That is the language of an investigation, not of a finding.

India rejected the allegation as absurd and motivated. Diplomatic expulsions followed in both directions. India suspended visa services for Canadians for a period, and required Canada to withdraw **41 diplomats** from India.

What has happened since, in order

THE SURREY CASE: CURRENT STATUS AS AT MID-2026	
ESTABLISHED	Nijjar was shot dead on 18 June 2023 in Surrey, British Columbia.
ESTABLISHED	In May 2024 the RCMP arrested four Indian nationals — Karan Brar, Kamalpreet Singh, Karanpreet Singh and Amandeep Singh — and charged them with first-degree murder and conspiracy.
ESTABLISHED	Bail was granted to the accused in January 2025. The case proceeded to the British Columbia Supreme Court by direct indictment, a step that bypasses a preliminary inquiry.
ALLEGED, NOT PROVED	That the government of India directed the killing. Canada has asserted this at the highest level. As at mid-2026 no court has ruled on it.
DENIED	India has consistently and categorically denied any involvement, and has never resiled from that denial — including during the diplomatic reset of 2025–26.

I want to be exact about one more thing, because it is where most commentary goes wrong. **Charging four men with the murder is not the same as proving state direction.** Establishing who pulled the trigger and establishing who ordered it are separate evidentiary problems. The first is before a Canadian court. The second, as at the time of writing, is not.

CHAPTER SIX

New York: the plot that stopped being an allegation

Everything else in this part is contested. This is not. In a New York courtroom in 2026, a man admitted under oath that he had been hired to arrange the murder of an American citizen on American soil, and that the person who hired him worked for the government of India. He has been sentenced.

What the indictment said

In November 2023 the United States Department of Justice unsealed an indictment against **Nikhil Gupta**, an Indian national. The allegation: that he had been recruited in May 2023 by an Indian government employee to arrange the killing of a Sikh separatist leader in New York — a US citizen, unnamed in the document but universally understood, and later confirmed, to be Gurpatwant Singh Pannun.

The plot failed for a reason that is almost farcical. The "hitman" Gupta hired was an undercover American law enforcement officer. A payment of **\$15,000** was made as an advance. The entire arrangement was being recorded by the people he thought he was employing.

The name

In October 2024 a superseding indictment named the Indian official previously identified only as "CC-1." He was **Vikash Yadav** — a former assistant commandant in the Central Reserve Police Force, described in the indictment as employed by India's **Cabinet Secretariat**, the part of the Indian government that contains the Research and Analysis Wing, India's external intelligence service.

The FBI issued a warrant. India stated that Yadav was no longer a government employee. He was separately arrested by Delhi Police in an unrelated extortion and kidnapping case and was granted bail in April 2025. He has not been extradited.

13 February 2026

Gupta pleaded guilty in Manhattan federal court to three counts: **murder-for-hire, conspiracy to commit murder-for-hire, and conspiracy to commit money laundering.**

On **29 May 2026**, he was sentenced by US District Judge Victor Marrero to **24 years** in prison.

WHY THIS IS THE HINGE OF THE WHOLE PART

A guilty plea is not a press briefing, an intelligence assessment or a leak. It is a formal admission, made under oath, accepted by a federal judge, and followed by a 24-year sentence.

The plot against Pannun is therefore no longer a claim made by one government about another. It is a matter of judicial record in the United States.

What it establishes, and what it does not**READING THE NEW YORK CASE PRECISELY****NOW JUDICIALLY ESTABLISHED**

A conspiracy to murder Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, an American citizen, in New York, existed. Nikhil Gupta was part of it, has admitted it, and is serving 24 years.

CHARGED BY THE UNITED STATES, UNCONTESTED IN COURT

That the man who directed Gupta was Vikash Yadav, then employed by the Cabinet Secretariat. Yadav has not appeared to answer the charge, so it has not been tested adversarially.

NOT ESTABLISHED

How far up the Indian government knowledge or authorisation went. The indictment does not answer this and no court has. Anyone who tells you it has been proved either way is going beyond the record.

INDIA'S POSITION

India denies any state involvement in a plot to kill Pannun, and has characterised the matter as the unauthorised act of an individual. It set up a high-level inquiry committee in response to the American information.

The consequence for every other argument in this part

This is the reason Chapter 6 sits where it does.

Before February 2026, India's blanket position — that all such accusations are fabrications by hostile actors and separatist lobbies — was internally coherent. You could believe it without believing anything unlikely.

After a guilty plea and a 24-year sentence in a US federal court, that blanket position is no longer available. Something happened. A conspiracy to kill a man in New York existed, and the person the United States says organised it was employed by the Indian government at the time.

That does not prove Surrey. Different country, different case, different evidence, no verdict. But it destroys the argument that such a thing is unthinkable — which was, until 2026, the

main thing standing between the Canadian allegation and belief.

The New York case did not prove the Canadian one. It did something narrower and more damaging: it removed the presumption of impossibility.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The gangster turn — and the reset that followed

In October 2024 the Canadian police made an allegation that went considerably further than one killing. Then, within a year, both governments decided they had more to gain from trade than from the argument. Both of those facts belong in this chapter, and neither cancels the other.

14 October 2024

The RCMP took the unusual step of going public mid-investigation. Commissioner **Michael Duheme** said investigators had linked agents of the Indian government to a pattern of serious criminal activity in Canada — homicides, extortion and coercion directed at members of the South Asian diaspora.

The alleged method was the part that mattered: not intelligence officers acting directly, but **the use of organised crime networks as intermediaries**. The network named was the gang associated with **Lawrence Bishnoi**, an Indian gangster who has run his operation from inside Indian prisons.

Canada expelled six Indian diplomats, including High Commissioner **Sanjay Kumar Verma**, after India declined a request to waive their immunity. India expelled six Canadian diplomats in reply and called the allegations preposterous.

Then the designation

On **29 September 2025**, Canada listed the **Lawrence Bishnoi gang as a terrorist entity** — an Indian criminal organisation, formally designated as terrorists by a G7 government.

A subsequent RCMP report went further, describing the group as "acting on behalf of" the Indian government.

GENUINELY DISPUTED

The Canadian position: a foreign state used a criminal gang as a proxy to intimidate, extort and kill people on Canadian soil. That is a sovereignty violation of a very serious order.

The Indian position: the allegations are unsubstantiated, no evidence has been produced publicly, and Canada is responding to domestic political pressure from a constituency that includes people India regards as terrorists.

What can be said: the Bishnoi gang is real, violent, transnational and operating in Canada — nobody disputes that. The claim that it operates *on behalf of the Indian state* is a police assertion that has not been tested in court. It is a serious assertion from a serious institution. It is not a verdict.

The reset — and what it tells you about all of this

Then something happened that surprised almost everyone.

Justin Trudeau left office. **Mark Carney** became Prime Minister of Canada in 2025. In June 2025, at the G7, Carney and Narendra Modi agreed to rebuild relations. High Commissioners were restored. In **February 2026 Carney visited India** on a four-day official visit, with trade and security cooperation at the centre of it.

The Nijjar allegation was not withdrawn. India's denial was not withdrawn. Neither government resolved anything. They simply decided the dispute was costing more than it was worth.

REMEMBER THIS

Between 2023 and 2026 Canada accused India of murder on Canadian soil, expelled its High Commissioner, designated an Indian criminal network as terrorists, and then signed trade agreements with the same government — with the accusation still standing and still denied.

For anyone in the movement who believed that Western outrage would translate into Western pressure, this is the most important fact in this part. It did not. It translated into a trade delegation.

That is the Ghadar template again, and in its cruellest form. In 1914 the diaspora believed the world would respond to Punjabi grievance and it did not. In 2026 the diaspora watched a G7 government make an accusation of extraterritorial murder and then travel to New Delhi to talk about market access.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Inside Punjab: what the voters actually did

Punjab holds real elections. They are competitive, governments lose them, and the results are not what either side of this argument would like. This chapter is the test, and it does not deliver a clean answer to anybody.

Why elections are the best instrument available

We cannot survey thirty million people on secession. But Punjab votes, often, and its elections are genuinely uncertain — three different parties have formed governments there in the last fifteen years. Voters throw out incumbents. Independents win. The results are not managed.

Elections are a blunt instrument for measuring a view on independence, because nobody is on the ballot offering it. But they are the only large-scale, repeated, independently counted measurement of Punjabi opinion that exists. Everything else in this argument is an assertion.

The record

PUNJAB AT THE BALLOT BOX, 1997–2026

When	Result
1997	Akali Dal–BJP coalition wins the assembly. Two years after the militancy ends, Punjab elects a Sikh religious party in alliance with a Hindu nationalist one.
2022 assembly	AAP sweeps Punjab — a party with no panthic programme whatsoever, campaigning on schools, clinics, electricity and corruption. The Akali Dal, the traditional vehicle of Sikh politics, is reduced to three seats .
June 2022	Simranjit Singh Mann , a lifelong hardline panthic politician, wins the Sangrur by-election — the sitting Chief Minister's own vacated seat — four months after the sweep. By 5,822 votes: 253,154 to 247,332. A real win, and a narrow one, on very low by-election turnout.
2024 Lok Sabha	Congress 7, AAP 3, Akali Dal 1, Independents 2 . BJP zero. The two independents are Amritpal Singh (Khadoor Sahib, margin 197,120 — the largest in Punjab) and Sarabjit Singh Khalsa (Faridkot, margin 70,053), son of one of Indira Gandhi's assassins.
2026 civic polls	AAP retains its base, winning 958 of 1,977 wards. The Akali Dal fails to recover.

The strongest case each side draws from this

THE 2024 RESULT, READ TWO WAYS — BOTH READINGS ARE SERIOUS

THE SEPARATIST READING

A jailed preacher held under the National Security Act won a Lok Sabha seat by the largest margin in the state, and the son of Indira Gandhi's assassin won another. Neither had a party, money or a machine. Punjabis knew exactly what they were voting for and did it anyway.

That is not apathy. That is a constituency, and it is growing precisely because the Akali Dal collapsed and left nobody else speaking for it.

THE UNIONIST READING

Two seats out of thirteen. The other eleven went to Congress and AAP — parties whose manifestos contain nothing resembling separatism. Two years earlier the same electorate had handed AAP a landslide on drains, schools and electricity bills.

A protest vote against three discredited mainstream parties, in two seats, is not a mandate to leave India. If it were, the same voters would not have spent the previous election on municipal services.

Both of those are honest readings of the same numbers. Here is what I think the evidence actually supports, stated carefully.

WHAT THE ELECTORAL RECORD SUPPORTS

- 1. A real panthic constituency exists.** It is concentrated in the Majha border districts, it is capable of winning parliamentary seats without a party organisation, and it is not going away. Anyone claiming support for hardline Sikh politics inside Punjab is zero is refuted by two 2024 results.
- 2. It is a minority, and not close to a majority.** Eleven of thirteen seats, and a preceding assembly landslide for a party running on governance, say so.
- 3. Its growth is a symptom of collapse, not conversion.** The Akali Dal destroyed its own credibility — the 2015 sacrilege incidents and police firing, the alliance choices, the family control. The panthic space did not expand. Its occupant died and something moved into the vacancy.
- 4. Voting for Amritpal Singh is not the same as voting for secession,** and there is no way to separate the two from a ballot. This is a genuine limit on what this evidence can show, and I am not going to overclaim past it.

The survey evidence, with its limits stated

Two data points exist. Both need caveats, and I am giving the caveats rather than just the numbers.

Pew Research Center, *Religion in India* (published 2021). Among Sikh respondents: **95% said they were very proud to be Indian**, and **70% agreed that a person who disrespects India cannot be a Sikh**. Only 14% said Sikhs face a lot of discrimination in India.

CORRECTION — HOW THIS SURVEY IS MISUSED

This finding is quoted constantly in Indian commentary as proof that Sikhs reject Khalistan. It does not say that, because it did not ask that.

National pride and constitutional preference are different questions. A person can be proud to be Indian and still believe Punjab was cheated on water, Chandigarh and the SYL canal — Part 8's entire file. The survey was also fielded between late 2019 and early 2020, **before the farmers' protest**, which changed the political temperature in Punjab considerably.

What it does establish, robustly, on a sample of 1,782 Sikhs: at that moment, Sikh national identification with India was high — not marginal, not grudging, and not consistent with a population on the verge of leaving.

The BBC surveys of April 1984. At the absolute peak of the crisis — two months before Operation Blue Star — separate surveys reported that **88% of Sikhs in Punjab and 82% of Sikhs in Britain were against the idea of Khalistan**.

If that is accurate, it is the single most important number in this part, and it is worth sitting with. At the moment of maximum grievance, maximum mobilisation and maximum militant presence, roughly nine in ten Sikhs in Punjab did not want the thing.

The movement's weakest moment has always been the same one: the place it is named after has never voted for it, including when it was on fire.

CHAPTER NINE

The two big claims, tested

Two sentences do most of the work in this argument. One says Khalistan is a Pakistani intelligence project. The other says it is the suppressed will of the Sikh nation. Both are stated here at full strength, and then tested.

Claim one: "Khalistan is a Pakistani project"

THE CLAIM AT FULL STRENGTH

"The 1971 advertisement was paid for by Pakistan's embassy. Chohan operated with Pakistani facilitation. The ISI ran training camps, supplied weapons and money to Babbar Khalsa, the KCF and the KLF, and provided sanctuary across the border throughout the militancy — this is documented and India has said so for forty years.

The demand serves Pakistan's strategic interest precisely: it would detach India's border state, its granary, and the recruiting ground of a large share of its army. No Pakistani government has ever supported an equivalent movement among its own Sikhs, or among Punjabi Muslims, because the object was never Sikh freedom. Rawalpindi has been open about Kashmir. Khalistan is the same instrument aimed at a different limb."

Testing it.

Part 10 examined this and produced a verdict I am keeping: *false as stated, true when amended*. The ISI's role in the militancy period is documented and was substantial. But every cause of the movement was domestic — Chandigarh, the water allocation, the Anandpur Sahib Resolution, the Congress cultivation of Bhindranwale, Blue Star, November 1984. Not one of those required Pakistan.

For the present period, three further things must be said.

One. The word was coined by a Sikh in 1940 in *opposition* to the Muslim League's demand. Whatever the movement later became, it did not begin as a Pakistani instrument. It began as a reply to one.

Two. The evidence for current Pakistani state funding of the diaspora network is thin in the public record. Assertion is plentiful; documentation is not. The bulk of the money is plainly diaspora money — gurdwara collections and individual donations in Canada, Britain and the United States. That requires no foreign intelligence service at all.

Three, and this is the point that does the real damage: if the movement were principally a foreign operation, the Indian state's own conduct would not matter to its strength. It manifestly does. The recruiting material that works is not Pakistani. It is Indian — 1984, the disappearances, Khalra, and now the New York indictment. Chapter 6 was a bigger gift to the movement than anything Pakistan has managed in twenty years.

REMEMBER THIS

Pakistan armed this movement. Pakistan did not cause it, does not currently fund most of it, and cannot sustain it.

What sustains it is a grievance file that the Indian state wrote itself and has never closed.

Claim two: "Khalistan is the will of the Sikh nation"**THE CLAIM AT FULL STRENGTH**

"Sikhs were promised autonomy and given a truncated state without its capital, without its rivers and without its Punjabi-speaking areas — Part 8. When they protested peacefully through the Akali morchas, they were jailed. When they passed a resolution through constitutional means, it was declared secessionist.

Then the state stormed their holiest shrine on a martyrdom anniversary, organised the killing of thousands of them in its capital city, disappeared thousands more, and convicted almost nobody for any of it.

A people that is told it cannot obtain justice inside a state is entitled to conclude that it should not be inside that state. The referendum queues, the 2024 result, and the fact that a foreign government has now accused India of murdering Sikhs abroad are all evidence that the conclusion is spreading, not fading."

Testing it.

The grievance half of that argument is not weak. It is, in the main, *documented* — by this work across Parts 8, 9 and 10, and largely by the Indian state's own commissions and courts. I am not going to soften it and Part 12 will not soften it either.

The inference is where it fails, and it fails on the movement's own chosen ground.

One. The claim is about the will of a people. Punjab has voted repeatedly, freely and unpredictably, and has never returned a separatist mandate — not in 1997, not in 2022, not in 2024, not in 2026. A movement claiming to speak for a nation cannot indefinitely explain away every election that nation holds.

Two. The referendum measures the committed, not the proportion, and its own numbers cannot be checked. Chapter 4.

Three. Roughly nine in ten Sikhs in Punjab were against Khalistan at the peak of the crisis in 1984, on the available survey evidence. If the claim was not true then, when the grievance was rawest, the burden on anyone asserting it is true now is very heavy.

Four, and this is the hardest one. The people who acted in this name between 1984 and 1995 killed a great many Sikhs — police, journalists, politicians, clergy, and villagers who

would not pay. They shot Harchand Singh Longowal in a gurdwara for signing an accord that gave Punjab Chandigarh. A movement's claim to embody a people sits badly beside its record of killing that people's own leaders for negotiating.

REMEMBER THIS

The grievance is real and largely proven. The mandate is not.

These are separable, and the entire argument turns on refusing to separate them. Part 12 separates them and audits the proposal on its own terms — water, land, capital, borders and exit routes — with the grievance fully granted.

CHAPTER TEN

The label: what "Khalistani" now means

A word that described a political demand now functions, in Indian public speech, as a way to end an argument with a Sikh. This chapter is here because the label has become one of the movement's most reliable recruiting assets, and it is not the movement that supplies it.

What the word does now

Between 2020 and 2021, farmers — a large proportion of them Sikh Punjabis — camped on the roads into Delhi in protest against three farm laws. The laws were eventually withdrawn.

During that protest, and for a long time afterwards, a great many of those farmers were publicly described as Khalistanis: on television, by political figures, and at enormous volume online. So have journalists, comedians, students, activists, and Sikhs who criticised government policy on entirely unrelated matters.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

The word has changed jobs. It used to describe someone who wanted a separate country. It is now frequently used to mean *a Sikh who is arguing with me*.

When a word can be applied to a farmer objecting to crop pricing, it has stopped carrying information about separatism.

The other half, stated honestly

Rule 5 applies here as everywhere, so: the label is not conjured out of nothing.

There were Khalistan flags at some protest sites. Sikhs for Justice openly attempted to attach itself to the farmers' movement and offered money in its name. Separatist organisations abroad did try to claim the protest as their own. The farm unions rejected this, repeatedly and publicly — but the attempt was real, and people who point to it are not inventing it.

What follows is that a genuine phenomenon existed at the margin, and it was then used to characterise the whole. That is a specific and identifiable error, and it is the one this chapter is about.

Why this is a strategic disaster for the Indian state

Here is the mechanism, and it is worth stating plainly because it is not usually stated at all.

The core proposition of Sikh separatism — the thing it has to establish before anything else follows — is: **Sikhs cannot be fully and safely Indian.**

Every time a Sikh who has no interest in separatism is publicly called a Khalistani for holding an ordinary political opinion, that proposition acquires a small piece of evidence. Not from a pamphlet. From lived experience, on national television.

The separatist movement has spent fifty years trying to persuade Sikhs that India will not accept them as Indians. The most effective demonstration of that claim in the last decade was not produced by the movement. It was produced by its opponents, for free, at scale.

This is not an argument that the movement is therefore right. Chapter 9 already found its central claim unsupported by every measurement available. It is an argument about causation: a state that wants fewer separatists has a direct interest in not telling loyal citizens that they are separatists.

WHY THIS FACT BELONGS IN THIS PART AND NOT ANOTHER

Part 11 is about a movement that survives almost entirely outside Punjab. Chapter 8 showed it cannot win an election inside Punjab. So the obvious question is what keeps it alive at all.

The answer is two things, and both are Indian: an unclosed grievance file from 1984–1995, and a live, continuously renewed supply of evidence that Sikh identity is treated as suspect. The movement does not have to generate either. It only has to point.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Scorecard: what Part 11 proves

"Khalistan is an ancient Sikh national demand."

FALSE

The word was coined in a pamphlet in March 1940 by Dr Vir Singh Bhatti, in reply to the Muslim League's Lahore Resolution of the same month. Master Tara Singh, president of the Akali Dal, denounced it within weeks.

Sikh sovereignty *arguments* in the 1940s were real — Azad Punjab, Sikhistan. But the specific demand, under this name, is 86 years old and was rejected by Sikh leadership at birth.

"The movement was created by Pakistan."

FALSE AS STATED; PARTLY TRUE WHEN AMENDED

The 1971 *New York Times* advertisement was allegedly paid for by Pakistan's Washington embassy — an Indian intelligence claim, widely repeated, not independently documented. ISI arming and training of militant groups in the 1980s and 1990s is documented and was substantial.

But the word was coined by a Sikh *against* the Muslim League; the causes were entirely domestic; the present-day funding base is overwhelmingly diaspora money; and the recruiting material that actually works is Indian conduct, not Pakistani propaganda.

"Khalistan has a government-in-exile."

FALSE IN EVERY SENSE THAT MATTERS

Chohan declared one from London in 1980, complete with passports, stamps, currency and a cabinet. In forty-six years **not one government on earth has recognised any of it** — including Pakistan, which had every incentive.

Chohan himself returned to India in 2001 and died there in 2007.

"The referendum proves mass support."

UNVERIFIABLE BY DESIGN

No voter roll, no duplicate check, no independent supervision, no legal effect, and the population of Punjab cannot participate.

In the one case where an independent count exists — Surrey, September 2023 — organisers announced more than 200,000 and an observer counted about 65,700. **CBC News reported it could not verify the organisers' figure.** Every other number in the series comes from the announcing party alone.

What the queues do establish: a committed minority exists, abroad, in numbers that are not trivial. What they cannot establish is a proportion.

"India murdered Hardeep Singh Nijjar in Canada."**ALLEGED AT THE HIGHEST LEVEL; NOT PROVED IN COURT**

Trudeau's September 2023 statement was carefully worded — "credible allegations of a potential link." Four Indian nationals were charged with the murder in May 2024 and granted bail in January 2025; the case went to the BC Supreme Court by direct indictment. As at mid-2026, no court has ruled on state direction.

India has denied involvement throughout, including during the 2025–26 diplomatic reset. Charging four men with the killing is not the same as establishing who ordered it.

"Allegations of Indian assassination plots abroad are fabrications."**NO LONGER AVAILABLE AS A POSITION**

On 13 February 2026 Nikhil Gupta pleaded guilty in Manhattan federal court to murder-for-hire, conspiracy to commit murder-for-hire and conspiracy to commit money laundering, in a plot to kill Gurpatwant Singh Pannun in New York. On 29 May 2026 he was sentenced to **24 years**.

The US superseding indictment of October 2024 named the official who directed him as **Vikash Yadav**, then employed by India's Cabinet Secretariat. Yadav has not been extradited and the charge against him remains untested.

This does not prove the Canadian case. It removes the presumption that such a thing could not happen — which was the main defence the Canadian allegation had to overcome.

"Punjab wants Khalistan."**NOT SUPPORTED BY ANY AVAILABLE MEASUREMENT**

1997: Akali-BJP coalition, two years after the militancy ended. 2022: AAP landslide on schools, clinics and electricity; the Akali Dal reduced to three seats. 2024: Congress 7, AAP 3, Akali Dal 1, independents 2 of 13. 2026 civic polls: AAP retains its base.

Survey evidence points the same way — 95% of Sikh respondents "very proud to be Indian" (Pew, published 2021, fielded 2019–20); and at the peak of the crisis in April 1984, BBC surveys reported 88% of Sikhs in Punjab against Khalistan.

"There is no support for hardline Sikh politics inside Punjab."**ALSO FALSE — AND THIS IS THE OTHER HALF**

In 2024 **Amritpal Singh won Khadoor Sahib by 197,120 votes** — the largest margin in Punjab — while detained under the National Security Act in a jail in Assam, with no party and no machine. **Sarabjit Singh Khalsa won Faridkot by 70,053**. In June 2022 Simranjit Singh Mann won the Sangrur by-election.

A real panthic constituency exists, concentrated in the Majha border belt. It is a minority. It grew because the Akali Dal destroyed itself and left the space empty — a vacancy filled, not a population converted.

"Calling people Khalistanis is harmless."**FALSE, AND STRATEGICALLY EXPENSIVE**

Farmers protesting crop laws, journalists, comedians and students have been labelled with it. The separatist case requires one proposition above all — that Sikhs cannot be fully and safely Indian. Every misapplication of the label supplies public evidence for exactly that.

The honest other half: SFJ did try to attach itself to the farmers' protest, and some Khalistan flags did appear. The farm unions rejected it publicly. A marginal phenomenon was then used to characterise a movement of hundreds of thousands.

"So what is the thing that still exists?"**A DIASPORA MOVEMENT LIVING ON AN INDIAN GRIEVANCE FILE**

Not an insurgency — that ended in 1995. Not an electoral force in Punjab — Chapter 8. Not a recognised state project — nobody has ever recognised it.

What exists is a network of organisations abroad, funded mainly by diaspora money and gurdwara committees, whose most persuasive material is not its own programme but the documented conduct of the Indian state between 1984 and 1995 — now supplemented by a federal conviction in New York.

It cannot win Punjab. It does not need to in order to persist. And the 2026 Canadian reset showed what its ceiling abroad looks like: an accusation of extraterritorial murder, followed by a trade visit.

Timeline of Part 11

March	1940Dr Vir Singh Bhatti coins "Khalistan" in a pamphlet, replying to the Muslim League's Lahore Resolution.												
	Master			Tara		Singh			denounces			it.	
13 Oct	1971	Jagjit Singh Chohan's advertisement in <i>The New York Times</i> proclaims a movement for an independent Sikh state, weeks before the India–Pakistan war.											
12 Apr	1980	Chohan announces the Council of Khalistan; from May, operates "Khalistan House" in London. Passports, stamps and currency follow. No state ever recognises them.											
1984–1995	The decade of Part 10. Kanishka, 329 dead. November 1984. The disappearances. The movement destroyed inside Punjab.												
1997	Akali Dal–BJP coalition wins Punjab — two years after the militancy ends.												
2001	Chohan returns to India. He dies there in 2007.												
2007	Sikhs for Justice founded in New York — twelve years after the fighting ended.												
10 July	2019	India bans SFJ under the UAPA.											
1 July	2020	India designates Gurpatwant Singh Pannun a terrorist under the UAPA.											

2020–21	Farmers' protest. Large numbers of Sikh protesters publicly labelled Khalistanis. The laws are withdrawn.
31 Oct 2021	Khalistan Referendum voting opens in London , on the anniversary of Indira Gandhi's assassination.
2022	AAP sweeps Punjab ; Akali Dal reduced to three seats. In June, Simranjit Singh Mann wins the Sangrur by-election by 5,822 votes.
April 2023	The Bloom Review , an independent review for the UK government, warns of "subversive, aggressive and sectarian" pro-Khalistan activity in Britain.
18 June 2023	Hardeep Singh Nijjar shot dead in the car park of the Guru Nanak Sikh Gurdwara, Surrey, British Columbia.
18 Sept 2023	Trudeau tells Parliament of "credible allegations of a potential link" between Indian government agents and the killing. India rejects it; 41 Canadian diplomats withdrawn from India.
Sept 2023	Surrey referendum event. Organisers claim 200,000+; an observer counts about 65,700; CBC unable to verify .
Nov 2023	US DOJ unseals the Nikhil Gupta indictment — a murder-for-hire plot against Pannun in New York; \$15,000 advance paid to an undercover officer.
May 2024	RCMP charges four Indian nationals with Nijjar's murder.
June 2024	Amritpal Singh wins Khadoor Sahib by 197,120 votes while jailed under the NSA; Sarabjit Singh Khalsa wins Faridkot by 70,053 . Congress 7, AAP 3, SAD 1, BJP 0.
14 Oct 2024	RCMP alleges Indian agents used organised crime networks for homicide, extortion and coercion in Canada. Six Indian diplomats expelled, including the High Commissioner; India expels six Canadians.
Oct 2024	US superseding indictment names Vikash Yadav , then of India's Cabinet Secretariat, as the official who directed Gupta.
Jan 2025	The four Nijjar accused are granted bail; the case proceeds to the BC Supreme Court by direct indictment.
June 2025	Modi and Carney agree to rebuild relations at the G7. High Commissioners restored.
29 Sept 2025	Canada lists the Lawrence Bishnoi gang as a terrorist entity . A later RCMP report describes it as "acting on behalf of" the Indian government.
13 Feb 2026	Nikhil Gupta pleads guilty in Manhattan federal court to three counts.
27 Feb 2026	Carney begins a four-day official visit to India . The Nijjar allegation stands; so does the denial.
22 Mar 2026	Referendum event in Seattle; organisers report approximately 27,000 votes.
Apr 2026	Amritpal Singh's NSA detention expires; he is immediately re-arrested in the Ajnala police station attack case and returned to Dibrugarh jail.
29 May 2026	Gupta sentenced to 24 years by Judge Victor Marrero.

What happens in Part 12

Part 12, *The Feasibility Audit*, does the thing this part has deliberately not done. It grants the grievance in full — every finding of Parts 8, 9 and 10, conceded without argument — and then asks a different question entirely.

Would it work?

Not "is it deserved." Not "is it just." Those are the questions everyone argues about and they are not the questions a state is built on. Part 12 runs the proposal the way I would run a business plan across a desk:

- **Water.** The hardest question there is. Punjab's rivers rise outside Punjab. Headworks upstream sit in territory a separate Punjab would not control. Part 8 established the dependency; Part 12 prices it.
- **Land and borders.** A landlocked state with no port, one hostile frontier and one former-parent frontier. What is the exit route for a grain economy?
- **Capital and revenue.** What is the tax base, what is the currency, who lends to it, and on what terms?
- **Demography.** Who would actually be inside such a state, and what happens to everyone who is not Sikh — roughly two in five of Punjab's present population?
- **The precedent.** Part 5 audited the one Punjabi sovereign state that has actually existed. It lasted forty years and destroyed itself in ten. That record is admissible evidence and Part 12 admits it.

Emotion is not admissible in that chapter. Neither is sentiment on the other side. It is the chapter I have been building toward since Part 1, and it is where this work stops describing the argument and starts answering it.

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 11

Court records and official documents

- **United States v. Nikhil Gupta**, US District Court for the Southern District of New York — indictment unsealed November 2023; superseding indictment naming Vikash Yadav, October 2024; guilty plea 13 February 2026; sentencing before Judge Victor Marrero, 29 May 2026.
- **Government of Canada, Global Affairs** — statement of Minister Mélanie Joly announcing the expulsion of Indian diplomats, 14 October 2024.
- **Public Safety Canada** — listing of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang as a terrorist entity, 29 September 2025; and the Currently Listed Entities register generally, for the status of Babbar Khalsa International and the ISYF.
- **Royal Canadian Mounted Police** — public statements of Commissioner Michael Duheme, 14 October 2024, and subsequent reporting on the Bishnoi group.
- **Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India** — UAPA notification banning Sikhs for Justice, 10 July 2019, and subsequent extensions; UAPA designation of Gurpatwant Singh Pannun as an individual terrorist, 1 July 2020.
- **Hansard, House of Commons of Canada** — statement of Prime Minister Justin Trudeau, 18 September 2023.
- **Colin Bloom**, *Does Government "do God"? An independent review into how government engages with faith*, UK Government, April 2023 — the "Sikh extremism" section.
- **UK Home Office** — *The Terrorism Act 2000 (Proscribed Organisations) (Amendment) Order 2016*, SI 2016/391, de-proscribing the International Sikh Youth Federation; laid 22 February 2016, with the accompanying Hansard debates in both Houses.
- **Election Commission of India** — Punjab results, 2022 Vidhan Sabha and 2024 Lok Sabha, for all margins and seat totals cited.

Survey data

- **Pew Research Center**, *Religion in India: Tolerance and Segregation*, 29 June 2021. Fielded late 2019 to early 2020; 29,999 respondents including 1,782 Sikhs. The 95% "very proud to be Indian" and 70% "cannot be a Sikh" figures come from here, with the caveats given in Chapter 8.
- **Lokniti-CSDS** Punjab post-poll studies, 2022 and 2024.
- **BBC surveys of April 1984** on Sikh attitudes to Khalistan in Punjab and Britain — as reported subsequently; I have not been able to inspect the original instrument, and flag the figure as widely cited rather than personally verified.

Journalism

- **Kim Bolan** (*Vancouver Sun*) — four decades of reporting on Sikh militancy in British Columbia, gurdwara politics and the Air India case. The indispensable source on the Canadian end.
- **CBC News** — reporting on the Surrey referendum turnout and its verification problems; on the Nijjar charges, court appearances and bail.
- **The Globe and Mail** — profile of Hardeep Singh Nijjar; reporting on the diplomatic expulsions and on the Bishnoi designation.
- **Global News (Canada)** — reporting on the RCMP allegations and the terrorist listing.
- **The Tribune (Chandigarh)**, **ThePrint**, **Deccan Herald** — Punjab electoral coverage, the Amritpal Singh detention and NSA extensions, and Indian coverage of the Gupta and Yadav proceedings.
- **Al Jazeera**, **BBC**, **Reuters** — the Gupta guilty plea and sentencing; profiles of Pannun and Yadav.

Scholarship and background

- **Gurharpal Singh**, *Ethnic Conflict in India: A Case-Study of Punjab* — on the structural politics of the demand.
- **Darshan Singh Tatla**, *The Sikh Diaspora: The Search for Statehood* — the standard scholarly account of exactly the subject of this part.

- **Cynthia Keppley Mahmood**, *Fighting for Faith and Nation* — interviews with militants, valuable for how participants describe themselves.
- **Harjot Oberoi**, *The Construction of Religious Boundaries* — for the longer argument about Sikh identity formation underlying all of this.
- Wikipedia entries on *Jagjit Singh Chohan*, *Gurmit Singh Aulakh*, *Khalistan Referendum*, *Hardeep Singh Nijjar* and *Tara Singh (activist)*, used for dates and cross-checking only, and verified against the primary sources above wherever a claim in this part depends on them.

ON THE SOURCING OF A PART ABOUT LIVING PEOPLE

Three categories appear throughout this part and I have tried to mark every one of them.

Court record — the New York conviction. This is the strongest evidence in the part and the only thing in it that has survived an adversarial process.

Police or government assertion — the RCMP's Bishnoi finding, India's NIA designations, the Pakistani funding of the 1971 advertisement. Serious, from serious institutions, and untested.

Interested-party claim — every referendum turnout figure, and every assertion that support is zero. Reported as claims, attributed, and not adopted.

Where I have collapsed those categories anywhere, I have made an error, and I would like to be told about it.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. This part deals with matters currently before courts in three countries, and with people who are alive. Where the record moves, this part will be corrected. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 11 —

Part 12: *The Feasibility Audit*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART TWELVE OF THIRTEEN

The Feasibility Audit

Not "is it deserved" — *would it work?* The proposal tested the way a business plan is tested: water, land, capital, revenue, supply lines, exit routes, and the one Punjabi state that has actually existed

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 12

Eleven parts of this work have described an argument. This one answers a question inside it, and I want to be honest about what that costs.

I am granting the grievance in full, in advance, without argument.

Everything Parts 8, 9 and 10 established stands. Chandigarh was promised and never delivered. The water allocation was decided against Punjab by a process Punjab never agreed to. The Anandpur Sahib Resolution was a constitutional document treated as a secessionist one. The Akal Takht was stormed on a martyrdom anniversary. Thousands of Sikhs were killed in an organised pogrom in the national capital and eight people were convicted for it. Thousands more disappeared, and the man who documented it was murdered by policemen who were later convicted of his murder.

None of that is in dispute in this part. I am not going to re-argue it, soften it, or balance it. It is granted.

And then I am going to ask a completely different question, which is: would the proposed remedy work?

Those are not the same question and the confusion between them is, I think, the single greatest source of bad reasoning on this subject. A wrong can be entirely real and the remedy proposed for it can still fail. A man can be robbed and still not be able to run a bank.

So the rules for this part are different from every part before it.

Emotion is not admissible. Not mine, not the movement's, not the Indian state's. When I audit water availability I am not going to mention 1984, because 1984 does not put water in a river.

Where an assumption could go either way, I take the one that helps the proposal. I audit the smallest and most achievable version of Khalistan, not the largest. I assume a peaceful, negotiated separation rather than a war, which is enormously favourable and almost certainly unrealistic. I assume international recognition. If the proposal fails even under those assumptions, it fails.

And I have to say the last thing plainly. I am Punjabi, I am writing in Punjab, and some of the people who will read this chapter and dislike it are people I know. I would rather publish a conclusion that costs me something than pretend I ran the numbers and they came out differently.

Chapter 10 is the verdict. Chapter 9 is the strongest case against my own verdict, written as well as I can write it. If you only read two chapters, read those two, in that

order.

— *L.S.*

INTRODUCTION

The question nobody asks

In fifty-five years of argument about Khalistan, I have not been able to find a published feasibility study. Not one. No draft constitution, no budget, no water plan, no trade route analysis, no defence estimate. The most argued-about proposal in modern Punjabi politics has never been costed by anybody, in public, on either side.

That absence is where this part begins, and it is itself a finding.

Two questions that are constantly confused

THE TWO QUESTIONS

QUESTION ONE — THE MORAL QUESTION

Were Sikhs wronged, and badly enough to justify wanting out?

This is the question everybody argues about. It is answered across Parts 8, 9 and 10 of this work, largely in the affirmative, largely on the Indian state's own documents. **It is granted here without further argument.**

QUESTION TWO — THE ENGINEERING QUESTION

Would the proposed state function?

This is the question almost nobody argues about, because it is boring, technical, and produces answers that nobody on either side wants. It is the only question this part asks.

A supporter of Khalistan will say the second question is a trick — that you do not ask a prisoner to file a business plan before letting him out of an unjust cell. That objection has real force and I answer it properly in Chapter 9.

But the short answer is this. Nobody is proposing to open a cell. They are proposing to build a country, for thirty million people, on a specific piece of ground with specific rivers and specific borders, and those people will have to live in it. The grievance justifies the anger. It does not build the state.

The method

This is the method I use professionally when someone brings me a business plan. It is deliberately unglamorous.

- **What exactly is being proposed?** Define the entity precisely. Vagueness is where most bad plans hide.

- **What are the inputs, and who controls them?** Any input controlled by someone else is a dependency, and every dependency is a point of failure.
- **What is the revenue, what is the cost, and what is the gap?**
- **What are the supply lines and the exit routes?** Nothing works without them.
- **Who is inside the entity, and do they agree?**
- **Has anything like this been tried, and what happened?**

Six questions. Chapters 1 to 8 answer them.

REMEMBER THIS BEFORE YOU START

An audit is not a judgement about whether people deserve something. It is a statement about whether a specific plan, on specific ground, with specific resources, would produce the outcome its authors intend.

The audit can find that a plan fails and that everything the plan's authors say about their treatment is true. Those findings do not contradict each other. Most of this part lives in that space.

What I am granting, listed

So there is no ambiguity, here is the concession list. Every item is a finding from an earlier part of this work and is treated in Part 12 as established fact requiring no further proof.

GRANTED IN ADVANCE, WITHOUT ARGUMENT

From	Granted
Part 7	Punjab paid a share of Partition's cost out of all proportion to its size, and the border was drawn in five weeks by a man who never visited it.
Part 8	Chandigarh was promised to Punjab and never transferred. The river water allocation was made by executive decision, not adjudication. The Anandpur Sahib Resolution was a constitutional demand treated as sedition.
Part 9	Bhindranwale was cultivated by the Congress for electoral advantage before he became uncontrollable. Operation Blue Star's methods were a choice, and Operation Black Thunder in 1988 proves it.
Part 10	November 1984 was an organised pogrom, not a riot. Thousands disappeared in Punjab in the following decade. Jaswant Singh Khaira was murdered by police officers who were convicted of it. Almost nobody has been punished for any of it.
Part 11	A conspiracy to murder an American citizen in New York existed, a man has been convicted and sentenced for it, and the United States says the official who directed it worked for the Indian government.

That is a heavy list. I am not minimising it by putting it at the front. I am putting it at the front so that nobody can claim the audit's conclusion depends on denying any of it.

If the audit that follows still fails, it fails on water, land, money and borders — not on whether Punjab was wronged. Punjab was wronged. That is the starting assumption, not the question.

CHAPTER 1 What exactly are we auditing?

CHAPTER 2 Water: the chapter that ends the argument.

CHAPTER 3 Landlocked: the two roads out.

CHAPTER 4 The books: what Punjab earns and what it owes.

CHAPTER 5 The grain trap: who buys the harvest.

CHAPTER 6 Who is inside: the demographic problem nobody will name.

CHAPTER 7 Who holds the border.

CHAPTER 8 The precedent: the only Punjabi state that ever existed.

CHAPTER 9 The case against this chapter, at full strength.

CHAPTER 10 The verdict.

CHAPTER 11 Scorecard: what Part 12 proves.

CHAPTER ONE

What exactly are we auditing?

Before you can test a proposal you have to know what it is. Part 1 showed that four different places share the name Punjab. A separate state built on each of them is a completely different object, with different rivers, different borders and a different population. So the first job is to pick one — and I pick the one that helps the proposal most.

The three candidate territories

WHICH PUNJAB?

Version	What it contains	Audit position
A. Present Indian Punjab	Roughly 50,362 km ² . Around 3 crore people. Sikhs 57.69%, Hindus 38.49% at the 2011 Census. Three rivers: Sutlej, Beas, Ravi.	This is what I audit. It is the territory the referendum campaign refers to, and it is the version with the fewest obstacles.
B. Greater Punjab	A adds Chandigarh, Punjabi-speaking parts of Haryana and Himachal, and in some versions more.	Requires territory to be taken from two other Indian states that would object. Every problem in Version A, plus a border war with Haryana over the same water.
C. Historical Punjab	Both Punjabs, Indian and Pakistani. Lahore, Faisalabad, Multan, Rawalpindi.	Requires Pakistan to surrender its largest and most powerful province. In this version Sikhs would be a very small minority of the population — around one in fifty. The maximal claim is self-defeating and I do not audit it.

Version C deserves one further sentence because it is quietly fatal, and because supporters and opponents both avoid it. Pakistani Punjab holds well over a hundred million people and effectively no Sikhs. A state combining both Punjabs would be a Muslim-majority country in which Sikhs were a tiny minority. It would not be Khalistan in any sense its supporters intend.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

The bigger the map you draw, the fewer Sikhs are inside it. The version with the highest Sikh share is the small one — present Indian Punjab, at about 58%.

So the audit uses the small version. That is the most favourable assumption available, and I am giving it to the proposal for free.

The other assumptions I am giving away

ASSUMPTIONS GRANTED TO THE PROPOSAL, ALL FAVOURABLE

Peaceful separation

I assume India agrees, negotiates and withdraws without fighting. This is close to unimaginable, and every actual secession attempt in South Asian history has involved a war. Granting it removes the largest single cost from the proposal's side of the ledger.

International recognition

I assume the new state is recognised and admitted to international institutions. Part 11 showed that in forty-six years not one government has recognised the existing claim, so this is generous.

An orderly handover of assets

I assume roads, power plants, canals and public buildings inside Punjab pass to the new state intact and without dispute.

No population movement

I assume nobody flees, nobody is expelled, and the demographic position on day one is the demographic position today.

Competent government

I assume the new state is administered at least as well as Punjab is administered now.

Every one of those is unrealistic in the direction that helps. If the audit fails with all five granted, the failure is structural — it is about the ground, the water and the arithmetic, not about politics or bad luck.

CHAPTER TWO

Water: the chapter that ends the argument

Punjab means five rivers. Here is the fact that decides this entire part: not one of the three rivers Punjab now has begins in Punjab, and neither of the two dams that control them stands in Punjab. A separate Punjab would own the fields and not the tap.

Where the water actually comes from

Part 1 explained the rivers. Part 8 explained the allocation fight. This chapter is about something narrower and more brutal: **physical control**.

THE THREE RIVERS OF INDIAN PUNJAB — ORIGIN AND CONTROL

River	Where it rises	Where the controlling storage sits
Sutlej	Near Lake Rakshastal, in Tibet . Enters India at the Shipki La pass, in Himachal Pradesh.	Bhakra Dam — Bilaspur district, Himachal Pradesh . Nangal headworks about 14 km downstream.
Beas	Beas Kund, in Himachal Pradesh .	Pong Dam — Kangra district, Himachal Pradesh .
Ravi	Himachal Pradesh , then through Jammu and Kashmir.	Ranjit Sagar storage, on the northern boundary; Madhopur headworks.

Read the third column again. **Bhakra is in Himachal Pradesh. Pong is in Himachal Pradesh.**

These are not minor structures. They are the reason Punjab has water in the dry months at all. They store the monsoon and the snowmelt and release it across the year. Without regulated release, the rivers are seasonal — heavy in summer flood, thin the rest of the time. That was Punjab's condition for most of its history and it is why Part 1 called the five rivers "the machine that made Punjab, and the trap inside it."

A separate Punjab would be a downstream state. Its water would arrive through territory belonging to the country it had just left, released at times chosen by that country, from dams that country owns.

The demonstration that removes all doubt

Here is where the audit stops being theoretical.

In **April 2025**, following the Pahalgam attack, India placed the **Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance**. India's position, restated repeatedly through 2026, is that the treaty will remain in

abeyance until Pakistan credibly ends support for cross-border terrorism, and that it cannot function in its present form. Pakistan's position is that the treaty remains fully operational and that abeyance is not a thing the treaty provides for.

The legal proceedings went against India. In 2026 the court of arbitration held that the treaty does not permit unilateral abeyance and reaffirmed its own jurisdiction; a further award concerned limits on India's water-control ability. **India rejected the awards and called the court illegally constituted.**

I am not adjudicating that dispute here. I am extracting one finding from it, and it is the most important finding in this part.

WHAT THE INDUS WATERS TREATY EPISODE PROVES FOR THIS AUDIT

Pakistan is a nuclear-armed state of 240 million people. It had a 65-year treaty, negotiated and guaranteed by the World Bank, with a dispute-resolution mechanism and a sitting court of arbitration.

None of that was sufficient. When India decided to use its upstream position as leverage, it did so, and when the court ruled against it, it rejected the ruling.

Now ask the audit question. A new Punjabi state would have: no treaty, no guarantor, no army, no nuclear deterrent, one-eighth of Pakistan's population, and a first-day dependency on dams inside Indian territory.

If Pakistan cannot enforce a water agreement against India, on what mechanism would a two-year-old landlocked republic of thirty million do it?

This is not a prediction that India would cut the water off. It is a statement about who would hold the decision. In an audit, that is the whole point: *a critical input controlled entirely by another party is not a risk to be managed, it is a dependency that defines the enterprise.*

The fallback is already failing

A supporter might answer: forget the rivers, Punjab runs on tubewells anyway. That is substantially true and it is the worst possible answer.

PUNJAB GROUNDWATER — CENTRAL GROUND WATER BOARD ASSESSMENT, 2025

Measure	Value
Assessment blocks classed over-exploited	111 of 153 — about 72.6%
Stage of groundwater extraction	156.36% — the highest of any Indian state
Annual extraction	26.27 billion cubic metres
Direction of travel	Improving slightly — extraction was 164% in 2023, over-exploited blocks were 117

A stage of extraction of 156% means Punjab takes out roughly half again as much water each year as nature puts back. That is not agriculture. That is a withdrawal from a savings account with no deposits.

The slight improvement since 2023 is real and I record it honestly — it is what expanded canal irrigation does. But note what that improvement depends on: **canal water, which comes from the dams in Himachal**. The fallback improves only when the dependency deepens.

The steelman on water, and the answer

THE STRONGEST CASE FOR THE PROPOSAL ON WATER

"Every country on earth has upstream neighbours. Egypt's Nile rises in Ethiopia. The Netherlands depends on the Rhine. Bangladesh depends on India for the Ganges and has a treaty. Downstream status is normal, not fatal.

Moreover, Punjab is not only downstream. The Sutlej, Beas and Ravi flow onward into Pakistani Punjab, which means a Punjabi state would have its own upstream leverage over a country of 240 million. That is not nothing. It is a card, and it would be played.

And international water law exists precisely for this. A new state would inherit rights under customary law and could seek treaty guarantees as a condition of recognition."

The answers, in order.

One. The comparison to Egypt and Bangladesh cuts the wrong way. Both are examples of downstream states in permanent, unresolved anxiety about upstream construction, and neither has ever managed to compel an upstream neighbour to do anything. They are illustrations of the problem, not solutions to it.

Two. Leverage over Pakistan is not leverage over India. The upstream card is played against the wrong player. A state can be simultaneously a bully to its south and helpless to its north — and that describes exactly the position on offer.

Three, and this is decisive. The appeal to international law was tested in 2025 and 2026 and failed in front of us. A court of arbitration ruled, and the upstream state rejected the ruling and continued. That is the single most recent, most relevant and most damaging precedent available, and it happened on these exact rivers.

REMEMBER THIS

Water is the whole audit. A state whose rivers rise abroad, whose storage dams stand in another country's territory, and whose groundwater is being extracted at 156% of recharge, does not have a water problem it can negotiate its way out of. It has a structural dependency on the state it proposes to leave.

Everything in the next six chapters is additional. This chapter alone is sufficient.

CHAPTER THREE

Landlocked: the two roads out

Punjab has no coast. It never has. For a farming economy that must move tens of millions of tonnes of grain, that means everything depends on the road to a port — and there are exactly two, one through the country you have just left and one through the country that armed your insurgency.

The geography, stated flatly

Present Indian Punjab is a landlocked block of about 50,362 square kilometres. Its neighbours are Jammu and Kashmir to the north, Himachal Pradesh to the north-east, Haryana to the south-east, Rajasthan to the south-west, and Pakistan to the west.

Four of those five are India. The fifth is Pakistan.

THE EXIT ROUTES, BOTH OF THEM

Route one — south-east through India to Gujarat

The natural port for northern India is **Mundra**, with **Kandla** beside it. Roughly **1,250 km** from Punjab, and every kilometre of it across Indian territory. Kandla's own official description names Punjab as part of its gateway hinterland.

Route two — west through Pakistan to Karachi

Geographically far shorter. The land crossing is **Attari-Wagah**, India's only permitted land trade route with Pakistan. **Trade through it has been suspended since 2019** — India imposed 200% duty in February 2019 and a full embargo in August 2019, and it has stayed shut for seven years.

So the audit finding on supply lines is short. **A landlocked Punjab's access to the sea would run either through the state it seceded from, or through the state that spent a decade supplying weapons to its insurgency — and the second route has been closed for seven years already, while both parties were still notionally at peace.**

Why this is worse than it sounds

Landlocked is not automatically fatal. What matters is the quality of the neighbours.

LANDLOCKED AND RICH, LANDLOCKED AND POOR**SWITZERLAND, AUSTRIA, LUXEMBOURG**

Landlocked and wealthy. All three sit inside or beside a single European market with customs union, free transit rights, integrated rail, and neighbours who have not fought each other in eighty years. Transit is a legal right they can enforce, not a favour they must request.

NEPAL, BOLIVIA, AFGHANISTAN, SOUTH SUDAN

Landlocked and poor. All four are dependent on a single dominant neighbour for access to sea. All four have had that access interrupted for political reasons. Nepal's 2015 border blockade with India is the closest available parallel to what a new Punjab would face.

The variable is not the sea. It is whether your neighbour wants you to succeed.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Secession is, by definition, the act of making your largest neighbour worse off against its will.

Every landlocked success story depends on neighbours who are indifferent or friendly. A state created by taking territory, water and a border from a much larger neighbour begins its life in the exact configuration that produces the Nepal outcome rather than the Switzerland outcome.

This is not a claim that India would be vindictive. It is a claim about incentives, and incentives are what an audit measures.

The border itself

One further item belongs here rather than in Chapter 7. Punjab's western frontier with Pakistan is an international border of roughly 550 kilometres — the figure commonly cited for the Punjab sector, though different sources measure the line differently.

Today that border is held by the Indian Army and the Border Security Force, at Indian expense. On day one of independence it becomes a border a new state must hold at its own expense, on the far side of which is the country whose intelligence service, on the documented record of Part 10, armed the insurgency that killed thousands of Punjabis.

CHAPTER FOUR

The books: what Punjab earns and what it owes

This is the least emotional chapter in the whole work. It is a state's balance sheet, taken from its own budget documents, and it says that Punjab today does not cover its own running costs.

The headline numbers

All figures are from the Punjab Budget for 2026-27, presented on 8 March 2026, as analysed by PRS Legislative Research, and from the Punjab Economic Survey 2025-26.

PUNJAB'S FINANCES, 2025-26 AND 2026-27

Measure	Value
GSDP, 2026-27 (current prices)	Rs 9,80,635 crore
GSDP growth, 2025-26 (constant prices)	6.1% — against India's 7.4%
Agriculture growth, 2025-26	−2.5%
Sector shares, 2025-26	Agriculture 23% · Manufacturing 29% · Services 48%
Per capita income, 2025-26	Rs 2,30,523 — against India's Rs 2,19,575
Revenue deficit, 2026-27 (estimated)	2.2% of GSDP (Rs 21,955 crore)
Fiscal deficit, 2026-27 (target)	4.1% of GSDP (Rs 39,971 crore)
Outstanding liabilities, end 2026-27	45.1% of GSDP — among the highest of any Indian state

Three of those lines matter more than the rest, and I want to take them one at a time in plain words.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

A revenue deficit of 2.2% means Punjab borrows to pay for its day-to-day running — salaries, pensions, subsidies, interest. Not for building things. For existing. A state with a revenue deficit is spending more than it earns before a single new road is laid.

Debt at 45.1% of GSDP means Punjab owes close to half of everything it produces in a year. Interest on that debt is one of the largest single items it pays.

Growth of 6.1% against India's 7.4% means Punjab is falling behind the country it is part of — slowly, but every year.

The line that ends the chapter

Now the item that an audit exists to find. Punjab's revenue receipts for 2026-27 are estimated at **Rs 1,26,190 crore**. Of that:

WHERE PUNJAB'S REVENUE COMES FROM, 2026-27

Rs 86,537 crore — 69%

Raised by Punjab itself. Own tax revenue Rs 70,851 crore; non-tax revenue Rs 15,687 crore.

Rs 39,653 crore — 31%

From the centre. Share in central taxes Rs 30,464 crore; grants from the centre Rs 9,189 crore.

Roughly thirty-one paise in every rupee Punjab spends arrives from Delhi.

On the first day of independence, that thirty-one paise stops. Not gradually — on the day. Simultaneously, a series of costs that Delhi currently carries arrive on Punjab's books: defence, foreign affairs, the currency, the central share of major schemes, and debt servicing on whatever share of India's liabilities is negotiated across.

So the arithmetic of day one is: **revenue falls by about a third, and expenditure rises**. Starting from a position that already runs a revenue deficit and carries debt at 45% of output.

The subsidy that cannot be cut and cannot be kept

One item deserves separate treatment because it sits exactly where the economics and the water meet.

PUNJAB'S POWER SUBSIDY

Item	Value
Total power subsidy, around	Rs 20,500 crore a year
— of which, free power to agriculture	about Rs 10,000 crore
— domestic consumers	Rs 7,614 crore
— industry	Rs 2,893 crore
Agricultural tubewells on free power	around 14 lakh
Farm power subsidy, 1997-98	Rs 604.57 crore — roughly a seventeen-fold rise since
Cumulative spend on free farm power since rollout	about Rs 1.34 lakh crore

Fourteen lakh tubewells running on free electricity is precisely the mechanism producing the 156% extraction rate in Chapter 2. The subsidy and the water crisis are the same policy seen

from two directions.

A new state would inherit a subsidy it cannot afford, which funds the destruction of the resource it cannot replace, and which no government can withdraw and survive an election. That is not a budget line. It is a trap with a bow on it.

The steelman on the economy, and the answer

THE STRONGEST CASE FOR THE PROPOSAL ON MONEY

"You are reading the ledger upside down. Punjab's per capita income is *above* the Indian average — Rs 2,30,523 against Rs 2,19,575. Punjab was India's richest state for decades and its decline is the direct result of central policy: a cropping pattern imposed for national food security, an industrial policy that favoured coastal states, and the systematic under-investment Part 8 documented.

The 31% central transfer is not charity. It is Punjab's own tax money coming back, minus what Delhi keeps. Punjab has been a net contributor to the national exchequer for most of its history. Remove the extraction and you remove the need for the transfer.

And every new state starts with a fiscal shock. Bangladesh in 1971 was called a basket case and is now a manufacturing exporter with a higher growth rate than Pakistan."

The answers.

One. The per capita comparison is correct and is the proposal's best number. But Punjab's lead over the Indian average is now small and shrinking — a few percent, on slower growth. The trend line crosses. That is a fact about the last two decades and it is Part 13's subject.

Two. The claim that the transfer is Punjab's own money returning is partly true and does not survive contact with the day-one problem. Even if every rupee of it is Punjab's by right, the mechanism that collects and returns it would cease to exist. A new state would have to build a revenue administration capable of collecting what the Government of India currently collects, immediately, during a secession.

Three. Bangladesh is a serious analogy and I answer it properly in Chapter 9, where it belongs. The short version: Bangladesh had a port.

CHAPTER FIVE

The grain trap: who buys the harvest

Punjab's agriculture is not a market. It is a purchasing arrangement with a single customer, at a price that customer sets, for a crop chosen to suit that customer's needs. The customer is the Government of India, and on the first day of independence it stops being obliged to buy anything.

The size of the arrangement

In the 2025-26 wheat season, India procured 256.31 lakh tonnes of wheat at Minimum Support Price. **Punjab supplied 103.89 lakh tonnes of it** — roughly two fifths of the national total, from a state with about 2% of India's population and 1.5% of its land.

In the 2026 season Punjab was reported as set to procure about 132 lakh tonnes against a target of 122 lakh tonnes. The Minimum Support Price for wheat in 2025-26 was Rs 2,585 per quintal. The national MSP outflow for wheat that season was around Rs 62,156 crore across 21.03 lakh farmers.

Paddy runs on the same machinery, with the same buyer, at a separately announced MSP.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

A Punjabi farmer does not sell wheat to whoever offers the best price. He takes it to a government-regulated mandi where a government agency buys it at a price the Government of India announced in advance, and moves it into a national food reserve.

The whole system — the cropping choice, the tubewell, the free electricity, the debt — is built around the certainty of that purchase.

What happens on day one

THE PROCUREMENT DEPENDENCY, AUDITED

Who currently buys

The Government of India, through the Food Corporation of India and state agencies, at a price it announces, into a national buffer stock it maintains for its own food security.

Why it buys

To feed India's public distribution system. **Not to support Punjab.** Punjab's prosperity is a by-product of India's food security policy, not its purpose.

What changes on separation

The buyer becomes a foreign government with no obligation, no political interest in Punjabi farm incomes, and an active interest in diversifying its grain sourcing away from a state that has just left.

Who else could buy

The world market — reachable only through the ports of Chapter 3, at world prices rather than MSP, in competition with Australia, Russia, Ukraine, the United States and Argentina, none of which is landlocked 1,250 km from a port.

I want to be careful here, because this is a place where it is easy to overclaim. I am **not** saying Punjabi wheat is bad or that nobody would buy it. I am making a narrower and firmer point about cost structure.

Punjab's farm economy has been built, over sixty years, around a guaranteed administered price. The tubewell, the free power, the input costs, the land prices and the farm debt are all calibrated to it. An economy calibrated to a guaranteed price does not adapt instantly to a variable world price, and it certainly does not do so while also absorbing a 31% revenue collapse and building a water treaty from nothing.

REMEMBER THIS

Punjab's greatest economic asset — a guaranteed buyer for everything it grows — is owned by the state it proposes to leave, and exists for that state's reasons.

This is the same structure as the water. In both cases the thing that makes Punjab work is controlled from outside Punjab. That is not a coincidence. It is what sixty years of integration produces, and it is the reason integration is so hard to reverse.

CHAPTER SIX

Who is inside: the demographic problem nobody will name

Khalistan means land of the Khalsa. At the 2011 Census, about 38 in every 100 people in Punjab were Hindu. This chapter is about that sentence, and about the fact that in fifty-five years of argument nobody has published an answer to it.

The numbers

PUNJAB BY RELIGION, 2011 CENSUS

Community	Share of Punjab's population
Sikh	57.69%
Hindu	38.49%
Muslim, Christian and others	the remainder, under 4%

And the state is not uniform. The picture by region matters more than the state total.

REGIONAL COMPOSITION — 2011 CENSUS

Malwa

The largest region and the Sikh heartland. Districts such as Bathinda, Mansa, Moga, Faridkot and Muktsar are Sikh-majority.

Doaba

The only one of Punjab's three regions with a Hindu majority overall. Nawanshahr is 60.72% Hindu and 37.42% Sikh. Kapurthala is the Doaba exception, at 59.46% Sikh.

Majha

Predominantly Sikh — but **Gurdaspur district is 47.35% Hindu against 44.44% Sikh.** Majha is also the belt where Part 11 found the panthic vote concentrated.

The question, asked directly

A state whose name and constitutional premise are religious would contain, on day one, over eleven million people who do not belong to that religion, concentrated in a whole region and a majority of at least one border district.

So: **what is the proposed status of Punjab's Hindus in Khalistan?**

I have looked. There is no published answer. There is no draft constitution, no citizenship provision, no minority rights guarantee, no proposed franchise. Part 11 established that the

movement has produced passports, stamps, currency and a flag over forty-six years. It has not produced a clause on who counts as a citizen.

WHY THIS ABSENCE IS THE FINDING

In an audit, a missing document is evidence. When a plan for a religiously defined state has produced a flag but not a citizenship provision, the omission is not an oversight of drafting. It is the hardest question in the plan, left blank.

And Punjab has an answer on the record already, from the only period when anyone tried to implement this idea by force. Part 10 documented it: buses stopped, passengers separated by religion, Hindus shot. That is not what the movement's advocates today propose, and I am not suggesting it is. But it is the only empirical evidence that exists about how this specific question gets answered on this specific ground.

The other half of the demography

The problem runs in the opposite direction too, and it is the one supporters find hardest.

Large Sikh populations live outside Punjab — in Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and elsewhere across India. Part 10's central atrocity, the pogrom of November 1984, did not happen in Punjab. It happened in Delhi.

A Sikh state carved out of Punjab does nothing for those communities. It would, on any realistic reading, make their position considerably worse: they would become a minority identified with a hostile neighbouring state, in a country that had just lost territory to it.

The proposal offers protection to Sikhs by drawing a line — and the Sikhs who most needed protection in the worst episode of this entire history would find themselves on the wrong side of it.

That is not a rhetorical point. It is the arithmetic. A state that cannot protect the specific people whose killing is its central grievance has a design fault at the level of purpose.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Who holds the border

Punjab currently has one of the best-defended frontiers in the world and pays nothing for it. A separate Punjab would have to build an army from zero, on a border with a nuclear-armed state, using soldiers it would first have to ask to change sides.

The cost that appears from nowhere

Defence, foreign affairs and currency are the three functions a state cannot outsource and cannot avoid. Punjab currently performs none of them. They are carried by the Union of India and do not appear anywhere in the Punjab budget analysed in Chapter 4.

WHAT A NEW STATE MUST BUILD, FROM NOTHING

A land army

To hold roughly 550 km of international border with Pakistan, plus new frontiers with four Indian states that were internal boundaries the day before.

An air force and air defence

Punjab is flat, shallow in depth, and its major cities sit close to the border. Amritsar is about 30 km from it. There is no strategic depth to trade for time.

A central bank and a currency

Which must be accepted, defended and given reserves — for a state with no port, no export surplus in foreign exchange, and a fresh sovereign credit history of zero years.

A foreign service, and recognition

Chapter 1 granted recognition as an assumption. Part 11 established that in forty-six years no state has ever granted it.

None of these can be phased in. A state is either defending its border on day one or it is not.

The soldiers

Here is where an honest audit has to record a genuinely disputed number.

GENUINELY DISPUTED — SIKH REPRESENTATION IN THE INDIAN ARMY

The Government of India **does not publish the religious composition of the armed forces**, as a matter of stated policy. Every figure in circulation is therefore an estimate.

Figures commonly cited range from **about 2%** at the low end to **about 8%** at the high end, against a Sikh share of India's population of roughly 1.7%. During the Second World War the proportion was far higher — around 20% of a very differently recruited army.

I am not going to pick one. What both ends of the range agree on is the direction: **Sikhs are represented in the Indian Army at above their population share, and in some accounts far above it.** The Sikh Regiment is among the most decorated formations in the force.

Now apply that to the audit.

The professional military manpower a new Punjabi state would need is currently employed by the Indian Army, has served in it in some cases for generations, and in many families across several. A secession would require a very large number of those men to change allegiance — not as a matter of sentiment but as a matter of staffing a defence force.

Part 6 examined exactly this question at Ghadar in 1914-15, when a diaspora revolutionary movement assumed Punjabi soldiers would come over. They did not; many families of serving soldiers turned the revolutionaries in. Part 10 recorded what happened after Blue Star, when some units did mutiny: the mutinies were localised, were suppressed, and did not spread.

Twice in a century, a Punjabi movement has assumed the loyalty of Punjabi soldiers and been wrong. That is not proof it would be wrong a third time. It is the only evidence there is, and it points one way.

The steelman on defence, and the answer

THE STRONGEST CASE FOR THE PROPOSAL ON DEFENCE

"Small states with hostile large neighbours exist and survive. Israel was created in 1948 surrounded by states that invaded it immediately, with a population of about 800,000, and it survived. Punjab would have thirty million people, a martial tradition second to none in South Asia, and a diaspora with real money in three wealthy countries.

And who exactly is India going to fight it with? A very large part of India's own military tradition is Punjabi. That is not a weakness of the proposal. It is the proposal's greatest asset."

The answer is in two parts, and the second is the one that matters.

First, the Israel comparison omits the decisive variables: a coastline, external great-power support, a population arriving with nowhere else to go, and no dependency on the adversary for water or food purchase. Punjab has the reverse of all four.

Second, and this is the sharper point: the argument that Punjabi soldiers are the backbone of the Indian Army is simultaneously the argument that Punjab is deeply integrated into the Indian state at its most sensitive level. You cannot invoke that integration as a source of strength for separation. It is the strongest single piece of evidence against the premise that Sikhs cannot be safely Indian — which is the proposition Part 11 identified as the movement's necessary foundation.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The precedent: the only Punjabi state that ever existed

There is exactly one case study available. Part 5 examined it in detail. A sovereign Punjabi state existed, it was strong, it was well run, it was rich — and it destroyed itself in the ten years after its founder died, before any foreign army defeated it.

What the record shows

Part 5 audited Ranjit Singh's empire honestly, including the parts that flatter it. It was militarily formidable. It was not a theocracy — it employed Muslims and Hindus, Europeans and Americans, at the highest levels. It governed a genuinely plural population with a lighter hand than most contemporaries. On its own terms it worked.

And then Ranjit Singh died in 1839, and within ten years the state was gone.

THE FAILURE MODE, FROM PART 5

No succession mechanism

The state had no rule for transferring power. What followed was a decade of court murders, poisonings and coups.

An army that became a political actor

The Khalsa army, superb in the field, became the arbiter of who ruled — and then the constituency that had to be appeased by whoever did.

A treasury that could not pay for the army it needed

The classic terminal condition of a militarised state without a growing revenue base.

Defeat came last, not first

The British finished it. The British did not cause it. By 1845 the state was already consuming itself.

Part 5 called this "the audit: what the Sikh Empire proves about Khalistan," and deferred the conclusion to here. This is the conclusion.

The finding

The single most common argument for Khalistan's viability is that a Punjabi sovereign state has existed before and can exist again. That argument is available, and it cuts the way its users do not intend.

REMEMBER THIS

The precedent exists, and it is a warning rather than a promise. The one Punjabi state that has actually existed had a brilliant founder, a formidable army, a productive economy and no external enemy strong enough to destroy it — and it failed on **constitutional design**: no succession rule, no limit on the army's political role, no mechanism for peaceful transfer of power.

Now note what the modern proposal has published on those same questions, in fifty-five years. Nothing. No constitution. No head of state. No franchise. No succession rule. No provision on the role of the armed forces in politics.

The historical Punjabi state failed at exactly the point where the proposed one is silent.

The proposed state's governing institution, unexamined

One more item, which is uncomfortable and belongs in an audit.

Any religiously defined Punjabi state implies a relationship between religious authority and civil government. Part 4 traced the doctrine of Miri-Piri — temporal and spiritual authority together — and noted the question it leaves open. Part 8 examined the Anandpur Sahib Resolution, which was a document about federal autonomy rather than theocracy.

But there is a live institution here: the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee, the elected body that manages the historic gurdwaras. Its elections have been irregular. Its control has been the subject of prolonged political capture. Part 11 showed the same pattern in North American gurdwara committees, where control of a management committee delivers both money and legitimacy.

An audit does not need to decide whether religious authority in a Sikh state is desirable. It needs to observe that the question of what body holds ultimate authority has not been answered, that the most likely candidate institution has a contested governance record, and that the historical precedent in Chapter 8 failed precisely on this class of question.

CHAPTER NINE

The case against this chapter, at full strength

Rule 3 of this work says every side gets its best case, not its worst. This chapter is the strongest argument against everything I have just written, put the way its cleverest defender would put it. I have tried to write it well enough that it hurts.

THE CASE AGAINST THE FEASIBILITY AUDIT

"Your entire method is rigged, and it is rigged in a way that is invisible to you because it flatters your professional training.

One. No new state has ever passed a feasibility audit. Run this exercise on the United States in 1776: thirteen quarrelling colonies, no navy, no treasury, no currency, facing the world's greatest military power. Run it on Israel in 1947: no defensible borders, no water, no army, five invading neighbours. Run it on Bangladesh in 1971: called a basket case in the American State Department. Run it on Singapore in 1965: expelled from Malaysia, two million people, no land, no water — *it imports its drinking water from the country that threw it out to this day.*

Every one of those states would have failed your audit. All of them exist. Your method has a perfect record of predicting that nothing new can happen, which is another way of saying it has no predictive power at all.

Two. You have audited the wrong counterfactual. You compare an independent Punjab against an idealised present. But the present is Part 13: a collapsing water table, a debt at 45% of output, agriculture shrinking at 2.5% a year, growth below the national average, and an entire generation leaving. You have measured secession against a status quo that is itself failing, and you did not audit the status quo.

Three. Dependency is a consequence of subjugation, not an argument for it. Every colonised territory in history was told it could not survive alone, by the power benefiting from its dependence, using data generated by that dependence. Punjab has no industry because industrial licensing went elsewhere. Punjab grows wheat and rice because it was told to, for India's food security, at the cost of its aquifer. Punjab's transfers come from Delhi because Delhi takes the revenue first. *You have described the mechanism of extraction and then cited it as proof that extraction must continue.*

Four. You granted the grievance and then made it irrelevant. If a state can storm your holiest shrine, organise the killing of thousands of your people in its capital, disappear thousands more, convict almost nobody, and then be told by its own historians that you must stay because your dams are in Himachal — then the lesson is that atrocity carries no cost as long as the victim is economically integrated. That is not an audit. It is a counsel of permanent submission, and it is exactly what every such audit has always been for."

My answers

That is the best case and parts of it land. I am going to answer all four, and concede where I should.

On point one — the new-state objection. Partly conceded, and it is the strongest of the four.

It is true that feasibility audits have a poor record against determined national movements. It is true that Singapore, Israel and Bangladesh all existed against the arithmetic.

But look closely at the examples, because they are not interchangeable.

THE FOUR PRECEDENTS, EXAMINED

Case	What made it work	Does Punjab have it?
Singapore	The finest deep-water port on the world's busiest shipping strait. Its entire existence is a transit point. It survived without water by having something the world needed to come to.	No. Punjab's problem is the exact inverse: it is 1,250 km from a port.
Israel	Coastline, sustained external great-power backing, and a population with literally nowhere else to go.	No on all three.
Bangladesh	A port, a distinct language spoken by nearly the whole population, a majority so overwhelming the demographic question did not arise, an army that defected in large numbers, and a neighbouring great power that invaded on its behalf.	No on port, no on the demographic question, no on the army, and the neighbouring great power is the adversary.
United States, 1776	An ocean between it and its adversary, a French alliance and fleet, and a continent of unexploited resources.	No. Punjab's adversary is upstream of its water and surrounds it on four sides.

So the concession is this: a feasibility audit cannot prove a state will fail, and I do not claim it can. What it can do is identify *which* constraints are binding. In every successful precedent offered, the binding constraint was solved by a specific asset — a port, an ocean, an alliance, a demographic supermajority. **Punjab has none of the four, and its binding constraint — upstream water controlled by the adversary — is not one any of the four faced.**

On point two — the wrong counterfactual. Substantially conceded.

This is a fair hit and I accept it. I have audited the proposal and not the status quo. The status quo is genuinely failing, and Part 13 audits it with the same instruments and no more mercy. If Part 13 finds that Punjab inside India is on a trajectory to ruin, that finding stands alongside this one and does not cancel it.

But two things can both be unworkable. "The current arrangement is failing" is an argument for changing the current arrangement. It is not, by itself, an argument that any particular alternative would work — and the alternative on offer makes the water position worse, not better.

On point three — dependency as the product of subjugation. Partly conceded, and then answered.

The historical claim is largely right. Punjab's cropping pattern was a national policy choice. The industrial thinness is partly a licensing legacy. Part 8 documented the water decisions. I am not disputing the mechanism.

But the audit answer is about physics, not history. **Bhakra is in Bilaspur and Pong is in Kangra because of where the Himalayan foothills are.** No colonial policy put them there. If every extractive decision Delhi ever made were reversed tomorrow, the Sutlej would still rise in Tibet and enter India through Himachal. That constraint is geological, it predates the Indian state, and it would outlast it.

On point four — that this is a counsel of submission. Rejected, and here is why.

The objection assumes that if secession fails the audit, the grievance has no remedy. That is the movement's own framing and it is false. It treats one proposed remedy as the only one.

Chapter 10 sets out what the audit actually implies, and it is not submission. It is that a grievance this well documented deserves a remedy that would work, and that the one on offer would leave Punjab poorer, thirstier and less safe than it is now — which is not a defence of Delhi. It is the reason to demand something better than a flag.

CHAPTER TEN

The verdict

The audit is finished. Here is what it found, stated once, without hedging, and then here is exactly what that finding does and does not license anyone to say.

The ledger

THE FEASIBILITY AUDIT — FINDINGS

Water **FAILS**

All three rivers rise outside Punjab. Both controlling dams — Bhakra and Pong — stand in Himachal Pradesh. Groundwater extraction is at 156.36% of recharge, the highest in India, with 111 of 153 blocks over-exploited. The 2025–26 Indus Waters Treaty episode demonstrates that upstream position is used as leverage and that arbitration does not restrain it. **This finding alone is sufficient.**

Supply lines and exit routes **FAILS**

Landlocked. Nearest port roughly 1,250 km away, entirely across Indian territory. The only alternative crossing, Attari–Wagah, has been closed to trade since 2019.

Public finances **FAILS**

Revenue deficit before separation. Debt at 45.1% of GSDP. **31% of revenue receipts come from the centre** and stop on day one, while defence, currency and foreign affairs costs begin.

The revenue base **FAILS**

Roughly two fifths of India's wheat procurement comes from Punjab, purchased by the Government of India at an administered price for its own food security. That buyer has no obligation to a foreign Punjab.

Demography and internal consent **FAILS**

38.49% Hindu at the 2011 Census, with a Hindu-majority region and a Hindu-plurality border district. **No published citizenship or minority provision exists.** Sikhs outside Punjab are made materially less safe.

Defence **FAILS**

A 550 km border with a nuclear-armed state, no strategic depth, an army to be built from zero, and a manpower assumption that has been tested twice in a century and failed twice.

Constitutional design **NOT ATTEMPTED**

No draft constitution, no head of state, no franchise, no succession rule, no provision on religious authority — in fifty-five years. The one historical Punjabi state failed on exactly these questions.

Per capita income **MARGINAL — the proposal's best number**

Rs 2,30,523 against India's Rs 2,19,575. A real advantage, small and narrowing, on growth below the national rate.

The verdict, stated once

On the most favourable assumptions available to it — the smallest territory, a peaceful separation, international recognition, an orderly handover and competent government — the proposal fails the audit on water, and fails independently on five further grounds.

I want to be precise about the strength of that claim, because precision is the only thing that makes it worth anything.

I am not saying Khalistan is impossible. Chapter 9 conceded that feasibility audits cannot prove impossibility and have a poor record trying.

I am saying something narrower and firmer: **the proposal has a binding constraint it cannot solve, and it has never attempted to solve it.** The binding constraint is that the water is controlled from outside. Everything a Punjabi state would need to survive — irrigation, drinking water, the crop, the export earnings, the tax base — passes through that single gate, and the gate is in Himachal Pradesh.

In fifty-five years of pamphlets, declarations, passports, flags, referendums and lobbying, nobody has published a page explaining how a separate Punjab gets water. That is the finding of this part.

What this does not mean

Rule 5 of this work says nobody is only a hero or only a villain, and it applies to conclusions as much as to people. So here is the disciplined statement of what the audit does not license.

READING THE VERDICT CORRECTLY

WHAT THE AUDIT DOES NOT SAY

It does not say Punjab was not wronged. Every finding of Parts 8, 9 and 10 stands and was granted in advance.

It does not say people who want Khalistan are stupid, foreign-funded, or traitors. Part 11 tested those claims and found them unsupported.

It does not say Punjab's present arrangement is working. Part 13 says the opposite.

It does not say the state's conduct in 1984 or the 1990s is excused, mitigated, or closed.

WHAT THE AUDIT DOES SAY

That the specific remedy proposed would leave Punjab with less water security, less market access, less revenue and less physical safety than it has now.

That the plan's authors have never addressed its binding constraint.

That a grievance this well documented deserves a remedy that survives contact with the ground it would be built on.

That the demand which would actually change Punjab's position is not a border. It is control of the water — and that is a demand you make from inside a federation, with courts and votes, not from outside one with nothing.

The sentence this part exists to make possible

Fifty-five years of argument have run on a bad trade. One side has said: *the grievance is a fabrication, so the demand is treason*. The other has said: *the grievance is real, so the demand must be right*.

Both sides need those two things welded together. This part is the chisel.

REMEMBER THIS

The grievance is upheld. The proposal fails.

Anyone who can hold both of those sentences at the same time understands this subject better than almost everybody currently shouting about it — including, on the evidence of Part 11, several governments.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Scorecard: what Part 12 proves

"An independent Punjab could control its own water."

FALSE — AND THIS IS THE DECIDING FINDING

The Sutlej rises near Lake Rakshastal in Tibet and enters India through Himachal Pradesh. The Beas rises in Himachal. The Ravi rises in Himachal and passes through Jammu and Kashmir. **Bhakra Dam is in Bilaspur district, Himachal Pradesh. Pong Dam is in Kangra district, Himachal Pradesh.**

Not one river, and not one controlling storage, would be inside the proposed state.

"Water disputes can be settled by treaty and arbitration."

TESTED IN 2025–26 AND FAILED

India placed the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance in April 2025 and has maintained that position through 2026. A court of arbitration held that unilateral abeyance is not permitted and reaffirmed its jurisdiction; India rejected the awards and called the court illegally constituted.

Pakistan — 240 million people, nuclear-armed, with a 65-year World Bank-guaranteed treaty — could not enforce it. The mechanism a new state of thirty million would rely on has just been demonstrated not to work on these exact rivers.

"Groundwater can substitute for river water."

ALREADY FAILING

Central Ground Water Board, 2025: **111 of 153 blocks over-exploited** (72.6%); stage of extraction **156.36%**, the highest of any Indian state; annual extraction 26.27 billion cubic metres.

Honest note: this is improving slightly — 164% and 117 blocks in 2023. The improvement comes from expanded canal irrigation, which deepens the dependency in the previous verdict rather than relieving it.

"Landlocked states can prosper — look at Switzerland."

TRUE, BUT NOT TRANSFERABLE

Switzerland, Austria and Luxembourg are landlocked inside a customs union with enforceable transit rights among neighbours who have not fought in eighty years. Nepal, Bolivia, Afghanistan and South Sudan are landlocked among neighbours who are not.

The variable is the neighbour's disposition. Secession is the act of making your largest neighbour worse off against its will. Punjab's nearest port is roughly **1,250 km away across Indian territory**; the alternative crossing at Attari–Wagah has been shut to trade since 2019.

"Punjab is rich enough to stand alone."**NOT ON ITS OWN BUDGET**

Punjab runs a **revenue deficit** — it borrows for day-to-day running. Outstanding liabilities are estimated at **45.1% of GSDP** at the end of 2026-27. Growth in 2025-26 was 6.1% against India's 7.4%, with agriculture at -2.5%.

Decisively: of Rs 1,26,190 crore in revenue receipts for 2026-27, **Rs 39,653 crore — 31% — comes from the centre**. That stops on day one, while defence, currency and foreign affairs costs begin.

The proposal's best number is real and belongs here: per capita income Rs 2,30,523 against India's Rs 2,19,575. A narrow and narrowing lead.

"Punjab's agriculture would sustain an independent state."**IT IS OWNED BY THE BUYER**

In 2025-26 Punjab supplied **103.89 lakh tonnes of the 256.31 lakh tonnes** of wheat procured nationally at MSP — roughly two fifths, from about 2% of India's population.

The purchaser is the Government of India, buying at an administered price for its own food security, not for Punjab's benefit. A cost structure calibrated to a guaranteed price does not transfer to a world price reachable only through a port 1,250 km away.

"Khalistan would be a Sikh state."**NOT ON THESE BORDERS**

2011 Census: Sikhs 57.69%, **Hindus 38.49%**. Doaba is Hindu-majority overall; Nawanshahr is 60.72% Hindu; Gurdaspur in Majha is 47.35% Hindu against 44.44% Sikh.

No draft constitution, citizenship provision or minority guarantee has ever been published — in fifty-five years, alongside a flag, an anthem, passports, stamps and currency. In an audit, the missing document is the finding.

And large Sikh populations live outside Punjab. The pogrom of November 1984 happened in Delhi. A border drawn around Punjab leaves those communities on the wrong side of it.

"A Punjabi state existed before and can exist again."**TRUE — AND THE PRECEDENT IS A WARNING**

Ranjit Singh's empire was formidable, plural and well governed. He died in 1839 and the state destroyed itself within a decade: no succession rule, an army that became the political arbiter, a treasury that could not sustain it. The British finished it; they did not cause it.

The historical Punjabi state failed on constitutional design. On those same questions the modern proposal has published nothing.

"No new state ever passes a feasibility audit."

PARTLY TRUE — THE STRONGEST OBJECTION TO THIS PART

Singapore, Israel, Bangladesh and the United States would all have failed such an audit. Conceded: this method cannot prove impossibility.

But each solved its binding constraint with a specific asset — Singapore a port on the world's busiest strait, Israel a coast and great-power backing, Bangladesh a port plus a linguistic supermajority plus an invading ally, America an ocean and a French fleet. **Punjab has none of the four, and its binding constraint is one none of them faced: the adversary owns the water.**

"So the grievance was never real."

NO. THIS PART GRANTED IT IN FULL, IN ADVANCE

Chandigarh promised and withheld. Water allocated by executive decision. The Anandpur Sahib Resolution treated as sedition. The Akal Takht stormed. An organised pogrom with eight convictions. Thousands disappeared. Khalra murdered by policemen convicted of murdering him. A conspiracy to kill an American citizen in New York, now a matter of federal record.

The grievance is upheld. The proposal fails. Both sentences are true and neither cancels the other.

Timeline: how the constraints were built

This part has no narrative of events. It has a structure — and the structure was assembled by a series of decisions, most of them taken without Punjab's consent, and most of them now irreversible.

1799–1849 **The Sikh Empire.** The only sovereign Punjabi state. Ranjit Singh dies 1839; the state consumes itself within a decade — Part 5, and Chapter 8 of this part.

1947 **Partition.** The river system is cut across an international border. Headworks end up on one side, canal commands on the other — Part 7.

1960 **Indus Waters Treaty.** India receives exclusive use of the three eastern rivers — Ravi, Beas, Sutlej. Punjab's water future is now fixed by a treaty Punjab was not party to.

1963 **Bhakra Dam commissioned,** on the Sutlej, in Bilaspur district, **Himachal Pradesh.**

1966 **Reorganisation.** Punjab is divided; Chandigarh becomes a Union Territory; the river waters are allocated by executive decision rather than adjudication — Part 8.

1974 **Pong Dam completed,** on the Beas, in Kangra district, **Himachal Pradesh.**

1970s–80s The Green Revolution locks in the wheat–paddy cycle, tubewell irrigation and the free-power subsidy. Prosperity now depends on a single administered buyer and a falling aquifer.

1981–82	The Sutlej-Yamuna Link agreement and the start of construction. The canal is never completed and becomes the longest-running water dispute in Indian federal politics.
1997–98	Farm power subsidy stands at Rs 604.57 crore. It will rise roughly seventeen-fold.
2019	Attari–Wagah trade closed. 200% duty in February; full embargo in August. Punjab's only western trade route shuts and stays shut.
April 2025	India places the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance after the Pahalgam attack, and maintains the position through 2026.
2025	Central Ground Water Board: 111 of 153 Punjab blocks over-exploited; extraction at 156.36% of recharge , the highest in India.
May 2026	The court of arbitration rules against unilateral abeyance and on limits to India's water control. India rejects the awards and calls the court illegally constituted. The Supreme Court, separately, tells Punjab and Haryana that the SYL dispute cannot be decided on law alone.
March 2026	Punjab Budget 2026-27: GSDP Rs 9,80,635 crore; debt 45.1% of GSDP; 31% of revenue from the centre.

What happens in Part 13

Chapter 9's second objection was the one I conceded most fully: *you audited the proposal and not the status quo*. Part 13 audits the status quo, with the same instruments and no more mercy.

It begins where Part 10 ended — with a decade of capital flight, halted investment and a lost generation — and runs to the present.

- **The Green Revolution's invoice, now due.** The aquifer at 156% extraction. The wheat–paddy cycle nobody can break. Stubble burning and what it actually costs.
- **Farm debt and farm suicides** — the numbers, the disputes about the numbers, and what the data will and will not support.
- **The drug crisis** — evidence against moral panic, and the difference between the two.
- **The emptying.** Punjab's outward migration, and the sharp reversal since 2024 as Canada tightened. Roughly 1.8 lakh students went to Canada from Punjab in 2023; India's share of Canadian student intake fell from 51.6% in 2023 to 33.6% in 2024 to 8.1% in 2025. An economy built on the assumption that the young leave has just had that assumption withdrawn.
- **Politics after 1995** — the Akali collapse, the AAP sweep, and the 2027 election.
- **The final ledger for the whole series.** Every major claim across thirteen parts, in one table, tagged.

Part 12 asked whether leaving would work. Part 13 asks the question that actually determines Punjab's future, which is what happens if nothing changes.

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 12

Public finance

- **PRS Legislative Research**, *Punjab Budget Analysis 2026-27* — the source for GSDP, deficits, outstanding liabilities, per capita income and the revenue composition. Budget presented by Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema on 8 March 2026. Also the 2025-26 analysis for comparison.
- **Punjab Economic Survey 2025-26** — sectoral shares and growth rates at constant prices.
- **Reserve Bank of India**, *State Finances: A Study of Budgets* — for the comparative debt-to-GSDP position across states.
- **The Tribune** — reporting on the power subsidy: the roughly Rs 20,500 crore total, the Rs 10,000 crore farm component, the Rs 604.57 crore 1997-98 baseline, and the cumulative Rs 1.34 lakh crore figure.

Water

- **Central Ground Water Board**, Dynamic Ground Water Resources assessment, 2025 — 111 of 153 blocks over-exploited; stage of extraction 156.36%; annual extraction 26.27 bcm. Compared against the 2023 assessment for the direction of travel.
- **Bhakra Beas Management Board** — for the location, capacity and operating arrangements of Bhakra and Pong.
- **Indus Waters Treaty, 1960** — the text, and the allocation of the eastern rivers.
- **NUS Institute of South Asian Studies**, *The Indus Waters Treaty: A Year After the Pahalgam Terror Attack* — the clearest available account of the abeyance dispute and the divergent Indian and Pakistani positions.
- Reporting on the Court of Arbitration's 2026 awards and India's rejection of them, and Indian government statements that the treaty will remain in abeyance.
- **Supreme Court of India** — proceedings in the Sutlej-Yamuna Link matter, including the 2026 direction to Punjab and Haryana to cooperate with the centre, and the observation that the dispute cannot be decided on law alone.

Agriculture and procurement

- **Department of Food and Public Distribution** and **Food Corporation of India** — wheat and paddy procurement figures, season by season, and Minimum Support Price notifications.
- Government of India procurement bulletins for Rabi Marketing Season 2025-26: 256.31 lakh tonnes procured nationally, Punjab's 103.89 lakh tonnes, MSP Rs 2,585 per quintal, Rs 62,156 crore outflow, 21.03 lakh farmers.
- **Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices (CACP)** — cost of cultivation data underlying the MSP.

Demography, trade and defence

- **Census of India 2011** — religion tables for Punjab, by state and district. Sikhs 57.69%, Hindus 38.49%; district figures for Nawanshahr, Kapurthala and Gurdaspur.
- **Land Ports Authority of India** and Ministry of Commerce notifications — the February 2019 duty increase and the August 2019 trade embargo affecting Attari.
- **Kandla and Mundra port authorities** — hinterland descriptions and distances.
- On Sikh representation in the armed forces: no official figure is published. The 2% and 8% ends of the range are both in wide circulation and neither is sourced to a government release. Flagged in Chapter 7 as genuinely disputed.

Comparative and historical

- **Part 5 of this work** — the audit of Ranjit Singh's empire and its collapse, on which Chapter 8 rests entirely.
- **Khushwant Singh**, *A History of the Sikhs*, volume I — the succession crisis and the army's political role after 1839.

- **UN-OHRRLS** — analytical work on the structural position of landlocked developing countries.
- **Ramachandra Guha**, *India After Gandhi* — for the reorganisation and the federal water architecture.

ON WHAT THIS AUDIT COULD NOT OBTAIN

Three things I looked for and did not find, and their absence shaped the conclusions.

A published feasibility study for Khalistan. None exists in the public domain from any organisation advocating it, in fifty-five years.

A draft constitution, or any citizenship provision. None found. Chapter 6 treats this as a finding rather than a gap in my searching, but if such a document exists I would like to be sent it and I will publish a correction.

An official figure for Sikh representation in the Indian armed forces. Not published, as a matter of stated policy. Chapter 7 gives the range rather than a number.

If any of the three exists and I have missed it, the relevant chapter is wrong and I would rather know.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

The method of this particular part comes directly from that training. A feasibility audit is what you run before you commit capital, and its only virtue is that it does not care what anybody wants to be true.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

He is working toward doctoral research, with Punjab — its history, its politics and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995 — as the intended field. These thirteen parts are the groundwork for it.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. This part rests on figures that are updated annually — budget estimates, groundwater assessments, procurement totals — and every one of them is dated in the text so that it can be checked and replaced. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 12 —
Part 13: *The Reckoning*

A 13-PART INVESTIGATION

Punjab: The Whole Truth

*Five thousand years of history, one honest look —
from the first farmers to the Khalistan question.*

PART THIRTEEN OF THIRTEEN

The Reckoning

1995 to 2026 — the invoice for the Green Revolution, an aquifer with a date on it, a generation that left and a door that just shut. And the final ledger for all thirteen parts.

LOVEPREET SINGH

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Written in plain English.

Every disputed number shows its range and its source.

Every side gets its strongest argument before it gets an answer.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before Part 13

This is the last part, and it exists because of an objection I could not answer.

In Part 12 I audited the case for Khalistan and found it failed. In Chapter 9 of that part I wrote out the strongest argument against my own conclusion, and one of its four points went through me cleanly:

"You have audited the wrong counterfactual. You compare an independent Punjab against an idealised present. But the present is a collapsing water table, debt at 45% of output, agriculture shrinking, growth below the national average, and an entire generation leaving. You measured secession against a status quo that is itself failing, and you did not audit the status quo."

I conceded it there and promised to do the work here. This is that work. Same instruments, same rules, no more mercy.

I want to be honest about what I expected and what I found. I began this part expecting to write that Punjab inside India is difficult but manageable. That is not what the numbers say. The Central Ground Water Board's own projection has a date on it, and the date is inside the working life of people currently farming.

So this part is not a comfortable ending for anybody, and I am not going to manufacture one. Part 12 found the exit does not work. Part 13 finds the room is running out of air. Those are both true and neither rescues the other.

Three other things about this part.

It contains genuinely good news, and I have given it the same prominence as the bad. Stubble fires are down by roughly nine tenths since 2021. Groundwater extraction is improving, slightly, for the first time in decades. Rule 5 works in both directions and I am not going to write a doom document by leaving out the recoveries.

Chapter 9 is where I am least confident in this entire work. It asks what would actually change Punjab's position, and it is the only place in thirteen parts where I move from describing evidence to suggesting action. I have flagged it as such and kept it short. Treat it as the weakest chapter here, because it is.

And Chapter 10 is the point of the whole thing. Every significant claim across thirteen parts, in one table, tagged. If you read nothing else in this work, read that, and then go and check me.

— L.S.

INTRODUCTION

The other audit

Part 10 ended in 1995 with a sentence I have been carrying for two parts: a decade of capital flight, halted investment and a lost generation. This part picks it up there and follows it to today.

What changed after the guns stopped

The standard account of Punjab after 1995 is that peace returned, elections resumed, and the state got on with being a normal Indian state. All of that is true and none of it is the story.

The story is that during the thirty years when everybody was arguing about 1984, three things happened underneath the argument, and all three are now arriving at once.

WHAT WAS HAPPENING WHILE NOBODY WAS LOOKING

The water ran out on a schedule

The Green Revolution's cropping pattern was drawing groundwater faster than it could be replaced, every year, for sixty years. The Central Ground Water Board now puts a date on the consequences. That is Chapter 1.

The economy stopped leading

Punjab was India's richest state. It ranked first on per capita income until around 2000. It is now roughly tenth among the major states, growing more slowly than the country. That is Chapter 6.

The young left, and it worked

Outward migration became the safety valve for an economy that could not employ its own graduates. Remittances came back. Everyone treated this as prosperity. Then, between 2024 and 2026, the door closed. That is Chapter 5.

The counting problem, one last time

Every part of this work has had a counting problem. Part 10's was casualties. Part 11's was membership. Part 12's was budget lines.

Part 13's is the hardest of the four, because here **the contested numbers are contested on purpose.**

Farmer suicide figures depend on who is legally a "farmer" and which state agency files the return. Drug prevalence figures depend on whether "substance use" includes tobacco. Stubble fire counts depend on what time of day a satellite passes overhead. Per capita income depends on whether you use current prices or constant prices — and Chapter 6 shows those two produce opposite answers to the question "is Punjab above or below the national average."

In this part, more than any other, whoever picks the definition picks the answer. So I give the definition every time, and where two honest definitions disagree, I give both and say which is which.

How this part ends the series

Chapters 1 to 7 are the audit of the present. Chapter 8 puts it side by side with Part 12's audit of the exit, using the same six tests, so the two can be read against each other. Chapter 9 asks what would actually change the picture. Chapter 10 is the final ledger for all thirteen parts. Chapter 11 is where I set out what I think I got wrong.

CHAPTER 1 The invoice: what the Green Revolution actually cost.

CHAPTER 2 2025: the year the water came the other way.

CHAPTER 3 The farm: an arithmetic nobody can escape.

CHAPTER 4 Drugs: what the evidence actually supports.

CHAPTER 5 The emptying — and the door that just shut.

CHAPTER 6 The economy that stopped leading.

CHAPTER 7 A state that ran out of parties.

CHAPTER 8 The status quo, audited.

CHAPTER 9 What would actually change it.

CHAPTER 10 The final ledger: thirteen parts, one table.

CHAPTER 11 What I got wrong, and how to check me.

CHAPTER ONE

The invoice: what the Green Revolution actually cost

Punjab was asked to feed India and it did. The arrangement worked so well that for thirty years nobody asked what it was being paid for with. The answer is water, and the Central Ground Water Board has now put a date on when it runs out.

The deal, stated plainly

From the mid-1960s, Punjab was given high-yield seed, subsidised fertiliser, a guaranteed price for wheat and rice, and eventually free electricity for tubewells. In return it grew the grain that ended Indian famine.

Part 12 covered the economics of that arrangement — the single buyer, the administered price, the 14 lakh free tubewells. This chapter covers the physical bill.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

Rice is not a Punjabi crop. It needs standing water, and Punjab is a semi-arid plain that does not have enough rain for it. Punjab grows rice by pumping water out of the ground.

For sixty years it has pumped out more than the rain and rivers put back. Every year. That gap is the invoice.

The numbers, and the date

PUNJAB GROUNDWATER — THE POSITION

Measure	Value
Blocks classed over-exploited (CGWB, 2025)	111 of 153 — about 72.6%
Stage of groundwater extraction	156.36% — highest of any Indian state
Annual extraction	26.27 billion cubic metres
Average rate of water-table fall	roughly 0.49 metres a year
Depth of extraction in much of central Punjab	already 150–200 metres
CGWB projection — first aquifer (to 100 m)	exhausted by 2029
CGWB projection — water table	below 300 m by 2039

The second projection matters more than the first, and it is not really about quantity.

Good-quality water in Punjab sits in the first aquifer, down to about 100 metres. Below 300 metres the water is heavily mineralised and contaminated — **not fit for irrigation and not**

fit for drinking.

The question is not whether Punjab runs out of water. It is that at some point in the next fifteen years, on the state's own regulator's projection, what comes out of the ground stops being usable — and there is no second aquifer underneath.

I want to mark the status of that projection honestly. It is a projection, made by extrapolating current extraction rates. Extraction rates can change, and Chapter 1's next section shows they have started to. A projection is not a prophecy. But it is the best estimate the responsible technical body has published, and nobody has produced a serious argument that it is too pessimistic.

The good news, given its full weight

Rule 5 of this work says nobody is only a hero or only a villain, and the same discipline applies to trends. So here is the recovery, stated at full strength rather than buried.

WHAT HAS IMPROVED, 2021–2025

Groundwater extraction is falling

From 164% of recharge in 2023 to **156.36% in 2025**. Over-exploited blocks down from 117 to 111. Water levels improved in **81 of Punjab's 153 blocks**. This is the first sustained improvement in decades and it is real.

Stubble fires have collapsed

Punjab recorded **5,114 fire counts in the 2025 paddy season** — a 53% fall on 2024, and roughly **90% below 2022**, when the figure was 49,922. Rs 3,120 crore of central money went into crop-residue machinery for Punjab and Haryana, with over 2.6 lakh machines distributed.

Short-duration varieties are spreading

Around 66% of surveyed farmers were growing short-duration parmal rice varieties by 2022 — less water, earlier harvest, less burning pressure.

The extraction improvement is genuine and it deserves to be said loudly, because Punjab is almost never credited with anything.

But note what is driving it. The improvement comes substantially from **expanded canal irrigation** — that is, from surface water rather than groundwater. And Part 12 established where the surface water is controlled from: Bhakra in Bilaspur district and Pong in Kangra district, both in Himachal Pradesh.

So the aquifer recovers to the exact extent that Punjab increases its dependence on storage it does not own. That is not an argument against doing it. It is the correct thing to do. It is simply the trade that is actually being made, and it should be visible.

The stubble numbers, and why I do not fully believe them

This is a case study in how to read a government statistic, and it belongs here because the improvement is being claimed as a policy triumph.

GENUINELY DISPUTED — HAS BURNING FALLEN, OR HAS COUNTING?

The official position: farm fire counts fell to 5,114 in 2025, from 49,922 in 2022 — roughly a 90% reduction, attributed to machinery, enforcement squads and awareness campaigns.

The problem: India's official monitoring satellites observe the ground between about **10.30 am and 1.30 pm**. Research using 15-minute SEVIRI sensor data found that **over 90% of large farm fires in Punjab in 2024 and 2025 occurred after 3 pm** — outside the observation window. In 2021, only 3% did.

The corroborating measure: burnt *area* has not fallen in step with fire *counts*. Around 19.17 lakh hectares were affected in 2024 — close to the 2023 figure. A study by iFOREST concluded the official system is missing the majority of incidents. Separate high-resolution work found sensors detecting seven of 169 fires in one sample.

What I conclude: some real reduction has almost certainly occurred — the machinery is real and the varieties are real. But a fall in *counts* of that size, alongside flat burnt *area* and a documented shift of burning to after the satellite passes, cannot be read as a 90% fall in burning. The honest statement is that the true reduction is unknown and smaller than claimed.

I include this at length because it is the single best illustration in this work of Rule 2. A number went down. A policy was credited. And the mechanism that produced the number changed at the same time, in a way that would produce the same result with no change in behaviour at all.

The health question, marked carefully

The Malwa belt has been called Punjab's cancer belt for two decades, and a train from Bathinda to Bikaner carries patients to a cancer hospital in Rajasthan often enough to be called the cancer train. About a third of that train's roughly 300 passengers are travelling for that hospital.

THE MALWA CANCER QUESTION, SORTED

DOCUMENTED

Cancer incidence in Malwa is elevated. Studies put it at around **136 cases per 100,000** against a national figure of about **80 per 100,000**. Muktsar, Mansa and Bathinda report among the highest numbers.

DOCUMENTED

Groundwater in parts of Malwa contains arsenic, lead and uranium. A 2004 study by the Centre for Science and Environment found high pesticide residue in the blood of farmers sampled in Bathinda and Ropar.

CONTESTED — CAUSATION IS NOT ESTABLISHED

Which factor is responsible, and in what proportion, is genuinely unsettled. Uranium in Malwa groundwater is at least partly geological rather than industrial, and critics reasonably ask why incidence rose in recent decades if the uranium was always there. Pesticide exposure, tobacco, screening rates and an ageing population are all live variables.

NOT SUPPORTED

Single-cause claims in either direction — "it is definitely the pesticides," or "there is no excess cancer at all." Neither survives the evidence.

The elevated incidence is real. The confident explanations are not. That distinction is the whole of what an honest reader can take from this file, and it is why I have not used the cancer figures as a headline anywhere in this work.

CHAPTER TWO

2025: the year the water came the other way

In August and September 2025 Punjab had its worst flood since 1988. Fifty-seven people died. Around 2,555 villages were affected. And the mechanism that made it worse is the same mechanism Part 12 identified as the state's fundamental dependency, running in the opposite direction.

What happened

THE 2025 PUNJAB FLOODS

Measure	Reported figure
Severity	Worst flooding in Punjab since 1988
Lives lost	57
Villages affected	around 2,555
People affected	roughly 4 lakh
Crop area damaged	about 1.75–2 lakh hectares
Worst-hit districts	Gurdaspur, Amritsar, Ferozepur, Fazilka

The immediate cause was meteorological: back-to-back heavy rainfall in August and early September turned a rainfall deficit into a surplus very quickly.

The aggravating cause is the one that matters for this work. The rain filled the upstream reservoirs, which then had to make controlled releases, and those releases moved down into a Punjab already saturated.

WHY THIS CHAPTER IS HERE AND NOT IN A FOOTNOTE

Part 12's central finding was that Punjab does not control its own water because the storage is in Himachal Pradesh. The obvious reading of that finding is about scarcity — someone else can turn the tap down.

2025 demonstrated the other half. Someone else also decides when the tap opens. A downstream state is downstream of the release decision in a flood exactly as it is in a drought.

This is not an accusation against anyone. Reservoir operators facing a full dam and continuing rain have very few choices, and holding water past capacity is the worst of them. It is a statement about structure: **Punjab is exposed at both ends of the range and controls neither.**

The finding that closes the argument between Parts 12 and 13

Put the two chapters together and the shape of Punjab's actual position appears.

THE SAME DEPENDENCY, TWO DIRECTIONS

TOO LITTLE

The aquifer is at 156% extraction, projected past usable depth by 2039. The only substitute is canal water. The canal water comes from Bhakra and Pong, in Himachal. Every year Punjab reduces groundwater stress, it increases dependence on storage it does not own.

TOO MUCH

In 2025 the same storage, facing extraordinary rainfall, released downstream into Punjab. Fifty-seven dead, 2,555 villages, two lakh hectares of crop. The worst flood in thirty-seven years, in a state whose farmers are simultaneously running out of water.

And this is going to recur. Whatever anyone believes about the causes, the pattern of very heavy rainfall arriving in compressed bursts is the pattern the region is being told to expect. A state with an emptying aquifer and an increasing flood exposure is not experiencing two problems. It is experiencing one problem — **loss of control over the timing of water** — expressed twice.

CHAPTER THREE

The farm: an arithmetic nobody can escape

A Punjabi farmer is caught between two facts. The only crops with a guaranteed buyer are the two destroying his water. And his holding has shrunk by nearly a third in five years. This chapter is that arithmetic, with the numbers that are solid separated from the numbers that are not.

The debt

PUNJAB FARM INDEBTEDNESS

Measure	Value
Outstanding farm loans, Punjab	around Rs 1,04,064 crore — highest among the northern states
Outstanding across Punjab, Haryana, HP and Chandigarh (31 Mar 2024)	over Rs 2.20 lakh crore
Interest — institutional lenders	about 7.35% to 7.72%
Interest — non-institutional lenders	17% to 21%
Average landholding, 2016-17	1.08 hectares
Average landholding, 2021-22	0.74 hectares — a fall of about 31% in five years

The landholding line is the one that does not get enough attention. A 31% fall in average holding size in five years is not a slow structural drift. It is a collapse in the viability of the unit of production, driven by inheritance division and by distress sale.

And the interest spread tells you the rest. When a household has exhausted institutional credit, it moves to the *arhtiya* and the private lender at 17% to 21%. A farm generating thin margins on an administered price cannot service that. This is the mechanism, and it is well documented.

The suicides, and the honest position on the data

This is a place where I am going to be more careful than most writing on the subject, because the numbers are used as weapons by everybody and the underlying data is weak.

GENUINELY DISPUTED — AND THE DISPUTE IS ABOUT DEFINITIONS, NOT MOTIVES

What is reasonably established: indebtedness is the dominant identified factor in Punjabi farmer suicides. The NCRB's 2015 reporting attributed about **51%** to high indebtedness, mostly institutional. A 2025 study put the figure higher, at **62.08%**.

Why the totals are unreliable: whether a death is recorded as a farmer suicide in India depends on who legally counts as a farmer — landowners are counted, landless agricultural labourers frequently are not, and women working family land often are not recorded as farmers at all. Reporting also depends on the state agency filing the return, and Punjab-specific university surveys have repeatedly found more cases than the official series.

What I will not do: quote a headline total. Figures in circulation vary by large multiples depending on the definition used and the years covered. I have not found a series I would stake a claim on.

What can be said: the direction is not in dispute, the link to debt is not in dispute, and the undercount runs in one direction — official figures are floors, not totals. That is the same discipline Part 10 applied to the disappearances, and for the same reason.

The trap, in one paragraph

Here is why "just grow something else" has failed for forty years, stated as an arithmetic problem rather than a moral one.

WHY DIVERSIFICATION DOES NOT HAPPEN

The guarantee only covers two crops

Wheat and paddy have an assured buyer at an announced price — Part 12, Chapter 5. Maize, pulses, oilseeds, fruit and vegetables do not, in any comparable way. Switching means trading a certainty for a market.

The debt makes risk unaffordable

A household servicing loans at 17–21% cannot absorb one bad season on an unfamiliar crop. The more indebted the farmer, the more rational it is to stay on the guaranteed crop — which is precisely the crop worsening the water position.

The infrastructure is built for grain

Mandis, procurement centres, storage, transport and the credit system itself are all configured for wheat and paddy. Horticulture needs cold chain, which is thin.

Free power hides the true cost

When electricity for pumping is free, the water-intensive crop does not carry its own water cost. The subsidy that protects farm incomes is the same subsidy that makes the destructive choice look economically sensible.

Every element of that trap was created by a policy that was, in its time, correct. India needed grain and Punjab produced it. Nobody set out to build this. It is what a successful policy looks like sixty years later when nobody redesigned it.

REMEMBER THIS

The Punjabi farmer is not behaving irrationally. Given a guaranteed price for two crops, free electricity to pump water, 17–21% interest on the marginal rupee, and a holding that has shrunk by a third in five years, growing paddy is the *rational* choice.

That is what makes it so difficult. You cannot fix this by persuading farmers. You can only fix it by changing what is rational — which means changing the guarantee and the subsidy, which are the two things no government can touch and survive.

CHAPTER FOUR

Drugs: what the evidence actually supports

You have heard that most of Punjab's young men are addicts. That claim is not supported by any evidence I can find. What the evidence does support is a serious, concentrated opioid problem with hundreds of thousands of dependent users — which is bad enough, and is being obscured by the exaggeration.

The claim in circulation

The widely repeated version says that some very large share of Punjabi youth — the figure most often quoted is around 70% — are drug addicts. It appears in films, in political speeches from every party, and constantly online.

I have not been able to find a survey that supports it. What I have found is that the number appears to have escaped from a small, non-representative study and then been repeated until it became a fact about Punjab that everybody knows.

What the actual surveys say

THE EVIDENCE BASE ON SUBSTANCE USE IN PUNJAB

Source	Finding
Punjab Opioid Dependence Survey (AIIMS-led)	Over 232,000 people opioid-dependent in Punjab, heroin the dominant drug. Figures of this order have been reported since around 2015.
Population survey, 2022	15.4% of residents reported substance use.
Government statement, 2024	Over 6.25 lakh minors aged 10–17 and 63.6 lakh adults using "various substances."
Punjab Police, first half of 2024	4,373 NDPS cases , over 6,000 arrests, 215 kg of heroin seized.

Those four rows are not measuring the same thing and it is essential to say so.

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

"Substance use" is a very wide category. Depending on the instrument it can include tobacco and alcohol. A figure of 63.6 lakh adults "using various substances" in a state of about 3 crore is not a statement about heroin.

"Opioid dependent" is a clinical category with diagnostic criteria. That is the 232,000 figure, and it is the one that describes the crisis people mean when they talk about Punjab's drug problem.

Confusing the two is how you get from a real emergency affecting a couple of hundred thousand families to a claim that most of the state is on heroin.

Why the exaggeration is not harmless

I could have left this chapter as a correction and moved on. I am not going to, because the inflation of this particular figure has three specific consequences and they all point the same way.

WHAT THE EXAGGERATED FIGURE DOES

It converts a health problem into a policing problem

If most of a population is criminal, enforcement is the only conceivable response. If a defined group of a couple of hundred thousand people has a treatable clinical dependency, treatment capacity is the response. The size of the claimed number selects the policy.

It is politically useful to every party in Punjab

Whoever is in opposition uses it against whoever is in government. It has been deployed by the Akali Dal, by the Congress and by AAP in turn, and none of them has an interest in the number being smaller.

It attaches to Punjabi identity, which is Part 11's mechanism running again

A claim that most young Punjabis are addicts is a claim about a people rather than a policy failure. Rule 4 of this work exists precisely to catch that move — "groups of people are never the explanation." A generalisation about Punjabi character explains nothing, because it cannot explain why the problem grew in specific districts in a specific period.

And there is a fourth consequence, which is the one that should worry anybody who actually cares about the users. **If the problem is believed to be universal, it is also believed to be hopeless.** Nobody funds treatment capacity for a lost cause. A precise number of 232,000 is a number you can build clinics for.

REMEMBER THIS

Punjab has a severe opioid crisis. The dependency figure — on the order of two hundred thousand people — is large, concentrated, and worth treating as an emergency.

It is not most of the young population, it never was, and the people who repeat that it is have made the problem harder to solve.

CHAPTER FIVE

The emptying — and the door that just shut

For twenty years Punjab exported its surplus young people and imported their money. Everyone called it prosperity. Between 2024 and 2026 the receiving countries changed the rules, and the arrangement Punjab's economy quietly depended on has stopped working.

The scale of what was happening

PUNJABI OUTWARD STUDENT MIGRATION AT ITS PEAK

Measure	Value
Indian students who went to Canada, 2023	about 3.19 lakh
— of whom, from Punjab	about 1.8 lakh
Punjab's share of India's population	roughly 2%
Punjab's share of the Indian student diaspora	about 12.5%
Spent by Punjabi students in Canada in a single year	around \$3.7 billion

Read the last row twice. In one year, Punjabi families sent abroad, in tuition and living costs to a single country, a sum in the region of three and a half billion dollars.

That money left Punjab. What came back was remittances — and India's remittance inflows reached a record **\$110.47 billion in 2025-26**, the first time the figure has crossed a hundred billion, with Punjab among the states most dependent on that flow.

The reversal

THE DOOR CLOSING, 2023–2026

India's share of Canada's incoming student population

51.6% in 2023 → 33.6% in 2024 → 8.1% in 2025.

Indian students going abroad, all destinations

9,08,364 in 2023 → 7,70,127 in 2024 → **6,26,606 in 2025.**

Punjab specifically

Roughly a **50% reduction** in students migrating to Canada after Class XII in 2024.

The mechanism

Canada doubled the Guaranteed Investment Certificate requirement from about \$10,000 to over \$22,000, alongside tighter study-permit and post-study work rules. The all-in cost of the route reportedly moved from around Rs 15 lakh to around Rs 32 lakh.

The visible collapse

The IELTS coaching industry in Ludhiana, Jalandhar and Chandigarh — once running over 6,000 test-takers a month before 2024 — is contracting, with agencies closing or redirecting to Australia, New Zealand, the UK, Germany and the Gulf.

Some of this is redirection rather than disappearance — the agencies are switching destinations, not shutting entirely. I do not claim migration has stopped. But a fall from 51.6% to 8.1% of a single destination's intake in two years is not a redirection. It is the closing of the specific channel Punjab had built its aspirations around.

Why this is the most under-discussed fact in Punjab

WHY THIS MATTERS

Chapter 6 shows Punjab's unemployment rate running consistently above the national average — around **7.3%** against a national figure near 4.8%.

That number has been survivable for two decades for a reason nobody put in a policy document: **a large share of the young people who would otherwise have appeared in it left the country.** Emigration was the employment policy. Remittances were the welfare system.

Both were working. Neither was chosen. And the country on the other end has now changed its mind.

So Punjab now faces a question it has not had to answer since the 1980s: **what does it do with its own young people?**

The state has an economy that does not generate enough graduate employment, an agriculture sector that cannot absorb more labour on shrinking holdings, an industrial base that has been relocating for two decades, and — as of 2024 — a substantially narrowed exit.

Part 11 asked what keeps a separatist movement alive in a state that will not vote for it. Part 12 asked whether the exit it proposes would work. This chapter is about a different exit, the one hundreds of thousands of families were actually using, and it is the one that just narrowed.

A generation that had somewhere to go is becoming a generation that does not. Whatever happens in Punjab over the next decade, that is the fact underneath it.

CHAPTER SIX

The economy that stopped leading

Punjab was the richest state in India. It is now somewhere around tenth. This chapter is about how that happened, and about a statistic that gives two opposite answers depending on which honest method you use.

The slide

PUNJAB'S POSITION ON PER CAPITA INCOME, OVER TIME	
1981	First among Indian states.
Until around 2000	Still at the top of the rankings.
2001	Fourth.
2021-22	Around tenth among the major states.

Nothing dramatic caused that. No single disaster. It is what happens when a state grows more slowly than the country for twenty-five consecutive years.

The statistic that answers itself twice

Now the case study in reading numbers, and it is a good one because both figures are correct.

IS PUNJAB ABOVE OR BELOW THE NATIONAL AVERAGE?	
AT CURRENT PRICES — PUNJAB IS ABOVE	
Punjab's per capita income in 2025-26 is estimated at Rs 2,30,523 , against India's Rs 2,19,575 . Punjab is about 5% ahead.	
This is the figure in the state budget documents and it is the one Punjab's government quotes.	
AT CONSTANT PRICES — PUNJAB IS BELOW	
Measured at constant 2011-12 prices, Punjab's per capita income has been reported at about Rs 1,15,882 against a national Rs 1,16,067 — marginally behind.	
This is the figure critics quote, and it is the one that strips out inflation to show real growth.	

IN THE SIMPLEST WORDS

Current prices tell you what a rupee buys today. Constant prices tell you how much more you actually produce than you did in 2011.

Punjab is slightly ahead on the first measure and has just fallen behind on the second. Both are true. The second is the one that predicts where the first is going, and it has already crossed.

The honest summary: Punjab's lead over the Indian average has effectively vanished, and 2025-26 growth of 6.1% against India's 7.4% means the gap continues to move the wrong way.

Where the industry went

Punjab's industrial thinning is often blamed on militancy, and Part 10 documented the capital flight of that decade honestly. But the larger movement happened afterwards, in peacetime, for reasons that had nothing to do with terrorism.

WHY MANUFACTURING LEFT**Tax holidays next door**

Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Jammu and Kashmir offered long income-tax and excise exemptions and cheaper power. Punjab did not match them.

What moved

Ludhiana hosiery and auto components; Mandi Gobindgarh steel; a substantial number of pharmaceutical firms to Himachal. Relocation of small and medium firms has continued for roughly fifteen to twenty years.

Power costs

Industrial power in Punjab has been expensive relative to competitors, in part because the free agricultural power in Chapter 3 has to be paid for from somewhere.

The result

Punjab's unemployment rate has run **consistently above the national average** — reported at around 7.3% against a national 4.8%, and at 6.1% in 2022-23 when the national figure was lower.

Note the connection between the last two rows and Chapter 3. The free power that keeps the tubewells running is cross-subsidised, and part of what pays for it is a higher industrial tariff. **The policy protecting farm incomes is one of the policies pushing out the factories that would employ farm children.**

That is not an argument for abolishing the subsidy tomorrow. Chapter 9 explains why that is politically impossible and probably socially catastrophic in the short run. It is an argument for seeing that the pieces are connected, which is the thing that thirteen parts of this work have been for.

CHAPTER SEVEN

A state that ran out of parties

The Shiromani Akali Dal carried Sikh political demands for a century — the morchas, the Punjabi Suba, the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. In 2022 it won three seats out of 117. Nothing in Punjab's recent politics makes sense until you understand that a hundred-year-old institution vacated the field.

Thirty years of alternation

PUNJAB'S GOVERNMENTS SINCE THE MILITANCY ENDED	
1997	Akali Dal–BJP coalition. Two years after the insurgency ended — Part 10's most under-quoted fact.
2002	Congress.
2007 and 2012	Akali Dal–BJP. The first Punjab government in decades to win consecutive terms.
2017	Congress.
2022	AAP, 92 of 117 seats. The Akali Dal reduced to three . A party with no panthic programme at all sweeps Punjab on schools, clinics, electricity and corruption.

Punjab throws out incumbents. That is worth stating plainly, because it is the answer to anyone claiming Punjab's elections do not reflect Punjabi opinion. Every government since 1997 that sought a third consecutive mandate has been removed, and in 2022 the removal was total.

The collapse, and what filled it

The Akali Dal's fall has specific causes and they are not mysterious: the 2015 sacrilege incidents and the police firing that followed, prolonged family control of the party, the alliance decisions, and the eventual break with the BJP in September 2020 over the farm laws — which left it without its urban Hindu partner and without a farm constituency that trusted it.

Part 11 established what happened next, and this is the join between the two parts.

THE JOIN BETWEEN PART 11 AND PART 13

Part 11 found a real panthic constituency inside Punjab, concentrated in the Majha border belt, capable of winning parliamentary seats without a party or a machine. In 2024 it returned **Amritpal Singh from Khadoor Sahib by 197,120 votes** — the largest margin in the state, won from a jail cell in Assam — and **Sarabjit Singh Khalsa from Faridkot by 70,053**.

Part 11's conclusion was that this constituency grew because **the Akali Dal destroyed itself and left the space empty**. A vacancy filled, not a population converted.

Chapter 7 of this part is the other half of that finding. The vacancy is not a Khalistan story. It is the story of an institution that stopped functioning, in a political system where the alternatives — Congress, AAP, BJP — have no panthic programme and do not want one.

Where it stands now

PUNJAB'S POLITICAL POSITION, 2024–2026

Contest	Result
2024 Lok Sabha	Congress 7 · AAP 3 · Akali Dal 1 · Independents 2 · BJP 0
2026 civic polls	AAP 958 of 1,977 wards · Congress 397 · Akali Dal 192 · BJP 172
2027 assembly	The Bhagwant Mann government's term ends in February 2027. Four-cornered contest expected; AAP entering from a position of organisational strength and facing anti-incumbency.

Two structural observations, neither of which favours any party.

First, Punjab now has competitive multi-party politics with no party that speaks for the panthic constituency. That constituency has therefore been voting for independents. Independents cannot govern, cannot legislate a programme, and cannot be held accountable at the next election in the way a party can.

Second, none of the four parties has a published answer to Chapter 1. Not one of them has a water plan on the scale the CGWB projection implies. The 2027 election will be fought, on present evidence, on welfare transfers, corruption and law and order — while the aquifer runs to a schedule none of the manifestos mentions.

Punjab's politics is competitive, free and functioning, and it is not currently contesting the thing that will determine Punjab's future. That is not a failure of democracy. It is a failure of the argument being put to it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The status quo, audited

Part 12 ran six tests on the proposal to leave. This chapter runs the same six tests on the arrangement Punjab is in. Reading them side by side is the point of writing both.

The same six questions

THE STATUS QUO — FINDINGS ON THE SAME TESTS AS PART 12

Water **FAILS**

Extraction at 156.36% of recharge. 111 of 153 blocks over-exploited. CGWB projects the first aquifer exhausted by 2029 and the table below usable depth by 2039. Substitution by canal water works, and deepens dependence on storage in Himachal Pradesh. The 2025 floods showed the same dependency running the other way. **Improving slightly, from a position that is not survivable at present rates.**

Supply lines and exit routes **PASSES**

Still landlocked, still 1,250 km from a port — but with unrestricted transit across Indian territory as a matter of constitutional right rather than negotiation. This is the clearest single advantage of the status quo and it is decisive.

Public finances **FAILS**

Revenue deficit. Debt at 45.1% of GSDP, among the highest of any state. Growth at 6.1% against India's 7.4%. A Rs 20,500 crore power subsidy that cannot be withdrawn. Unemployment persistently above the national rate.

The revenue base **MARGINAL**

The MSP purchase is secure, large and reliable — Punjab supplied 103.89 of 256.31 lakh tonnes of national wheat procurement in 2025-26. But the crop it guarantees is the crop emptying the aquifer. **The revenue base is safe and is consuming the resource base.**

Demography and internal consent **PASSES**

Punjab votes, frequently, competitively and unpredictably. Governments are removed. Independents win. Nobody's citizenship is in question. Whatever else is wrong, consent is measured and counted.

Defence **PASSES**

The 550 km international border is held at no cost to the Punjab budget.

The two audits, side by side

READING PART 12 AND PART 13 TOGETHER

LEAVING — PART 12

Fails on water, supply lines, public finances, revenue base, demography and defence. Six of six, on assumptions deliberately stacked in its favour, with a binding constraint — upstream water — that has never been addressed in fifty-five years.

Not survivable.

STAYING — PART 13

Passes on supply lines, consent and defence. Fails on water and public finances. Marginal on the revenue base, which is secure precisely because it consumes the thing that is failing.

Survivable, and on the present trajectory, failing.

That is Punjab's actual position, and I want to state what it does and does not amount to.

WHAT THIS COMPARISON IS NOT

It is **not** a finding that India is good and Khalistan is bad. Three of the six status-quo passes are structural facts about being part of a large country — transit, defence, a functioning franchise — and none of them is a credit to any particular government's conduct toward Punjab. Parts 8, 9 and 10 recorded that conduct in full.

It is **not** a finding that Punjab's grievances are answered. They are not. The Chandigarh file is still open. The water allocation is still disputed. The SYL matter was still before the Supreme Court in 2026, with the court telling both states the dispute cannot be settled on law alone. Eight convictions still stand for a pogrom that killed thousands.

It **is** a finding about where the danger actually lies. The thing most likely to break Punjab in the next fifteen years is not a constitutional question. It is a hydrological one, and neither the movement nor any of the four political parties is currently contesting it.

The sentence this chapter exists for

Fifty-five years of Punjabi political argument have been conducted almost entirely about the first question — whether Punjab should be inside India — while the answer to the second question, whether there will be usable water in Punjab, was being decided by tubewells nobody was counting.

The argument Punjab has been having is not the argument that will determine what happens to Punjab. That is the finding of this entire work, and it took thirteen parts to be able to say it with evidence.

CHAPTER NINE

What would actually change it

This is the only chapter in thirteen parts where I move from what the evidence shows to what I think should follow, and I want that clearly marked. It is short, it is the weakest chapter in this work, and you should treat it as an argument rather than a finding.

A WARNING ABOUT THIS CHAPTER

Everything before this point in thirteen parts has been an attempt to establish what happened and what is true. This chapter is different in kind. It contains judgements about policy, on which competent people disagree in good faith, and on which I have no special standing.

I include it because ending a work like this on a diagnosis with no discussion of remedies would be its own kind of dishonesty. But it is not evidence, and I do not want it read as though it were.

Four things the evidence points toward

One. The water has to be priced, or at least measured.

Free electricity for 14 lakh tubewells is the mechanism producing 156% extraction. As long as pumping is free at the margin, no farmer has a reason to pump less, and Chapter 3 showed that the rational individual choice is the destructive collective one.

I am not going to pretend this is easy or that I would vote for it. Removing the subsidy outright would devastate small farmers already carrying debt at 17–21%, and no Punjab government could do it and survive an election — which is precisely why none has. But schemes that pay farmers for the power they *do not* use, and metering that measures without immediately charging, have been tried elsewhere in India and are at least a starting point. The honest position is that this is the highest-leverage change available and the least politically achievable, and that everything else is smaller.

Two. The guarantee has to cover something other than wheat and paddy.

Every diversification campaign for forty years has failed for the reason in Chapter 3: a household servicing debt cannot trade a certainty for a market. Diversification is not a persuasion problem. Until the assured purchase extends to maize, pulses, oilseeds or horticulture at a scale that makes switching safe, the wheat–paddy cycle will continue, because it is rational.

This is a decision for the Government of India rather than for Punjab, which is itself worth noticing.

Three. The 1984 file should be closed, and the argument for closing it is not sentimental.

Part 11 found that the diaspora movement's most effective material is not its own programme, which persuades almost nobody, but the documented conduct of the Indian state between 1984 and 1995. Part 11 also found that the misuse of the word "Khalistani" against ordinary Punjabis supplies live evidence for the movement's core proposition.

So the case for completing the 1984 prosecutions, and for treating Sikh political dissent as ordinary political dissent, is not that it would be gracious. **It is that these are the two things keeping a movement alive that cannot win an election in Punjab.** A state that wants fewer separatists has a direct, calculable interest in both.

Four. The demand that would actually change Punjab's position is about water, not borders.

Part 12's finding was that a separate Punjab would have less water security than Punjab has now, because the storage is in Himachal Pradesh either way and secession removes every legal mechanism for arguing about it.

The inverse of that finding is the constructive one. Punjab's water position is contestable *inside* the federation — in the Supreme Court, in the finance commissions, in the Bhakra Beas Management Board, at the ballot box, in a national politics where Punjab has thirteen parliamentary seats and a great deal of moral standing it does not currently spend on this.

REMEMBER THIS

Fifty-five years of Punjabi political energy have gone into a demand that would make the water position worse.

The same energy directed at the water itself — allocation, pricing, storage, the SYL file, the terms of the Bhakra Beas arrangements — is aimed at the constraint that actually binds. That is not a compromise position. On the evidence of Parts 8, 12 and 13, it is the only one with anything to win.

What I am not saying

I am not saying any of this will happen, or that Punjab's politics is currently capable of it. Chapter 7 found that none of the four parties has a water plan and that the 2027 election is unlikely to be fought on one.

Nor am I saying these four items are sufficient. They are the four the evidence in this work points to most directly. Somebody with a better grasp of agricultural economics, or water engineering, or Indian federal finance, would produce a better list, and I would rather read theirs than defend mine.

CHAPTER TEN

The final ledger: thirteen parts, one table

This is what the whole work was for. Every major claim tested across thirteen parts, in one place, tagged. Each row is a summary of a verdict reached in the part named — the reasoning and the sources are there, not here.

How to read the tags

THE SIX TAGS	
TRUE	Supported by good evidence; no serious dispute among people who have examined the record.
MOSTLY TRUE	Substantially correct, with a qualification that matters.
HALF TRUE	Contains a real fact and a false inference, usually in the same sentence.
MISLEADING	Every component may be accurate; the impression created is not.
FALSE	Does not survive contact with the record.
STILL DEBATED	Competent specialists disagree in good faith, and I am not able to settle it.

The ledger

EVERY MAJOR CLAIM IN THIS WORK, TAGGED

Part	The claim, as usually stated — and what the evidence showed	Verdict
1	"Punjab" has always meant one place. Four different territories share the name — the historical region, the Indian state, the Pakistani province, and the Punjabi-speaking area. Almost every argument about Punjab equivocates between them.	FALSE
1	Punjab's geography is incidental to its politics. Water, land, who counts as Punjabi, and who has the right to rule are the four permanent questions, and the first two are set into the ground.	FALSE
1	The origins of the earliest Punjabis are settled. Harappa, the Rigveda and the Aryan question each carry real evidence and real limits on what that evidence can show.	STILL DEBATED
2	Punjab's contribution to civilisation is military. Panini's grammar and Taxila were produced here. The greatest thing Punjab made was not a sword.	FALSE
2	Alexander conquered Punjab. He fought one major battle here, turned back at the Beas, and left within months. The empire that followed was Chandragupta's, not his.	MISLEADING
3	Punjab became Muslim by the sword alone. Conquest, Sufi preaching, social mobility and long settlement all operated. The outcome decided the 1947 boundary.	HALF TRUE
3	Punjab produced nothing under Muslim rule. Baba Farid and the invention of written Punjabi belong to exactly this period.	FALSE
4	Sikhism began as a military faith. Nanak raised no army. The institutions came first; the arming followed the executions of 1606 and 1675.	FALSE
4	Guru Tegh Bahadur was executed defending Hindus. Supported by the tradition's own sources and not seriously disputed.	TRUE
4	Miri-Piri settles the relationship between religious and temporal authority. The doctrine establishes that both exist; it does not resolve who governs whom — the question Part 12 found still unanswered.	STILL DEBATED
5	The Sikh Empire was a Sikh theocracy. Ranjit Singh's state employed Muslims, Hindus,	

Europeans and Americans at the highest levels and governed a plural population. **FALSE**

5	The British destroyed the Sikh Empire. They finished it. It was already consuming itself — no succession rule, an army that became the political arbiter, a treasury that could not sustain it.	HALF	TRUE
5	A Punjabi state existed before, so it can exist again. The precedent is real and is a warning: it failed on constitutional design, exactly where the modern proposal is silent.	MISLEADING	
6	Punjabis are a martial race. A colonial recruitment category, invented after 1857 for administrative convenience, and then believed by the people it was invented about.	FALSE	
6	Punjab was loyal to the British. Punjab did not rise in 1857 and supplied the army — and produced the Kukas, Ghadar, the Komagata Maru, the Akali morchas and Bhagat Singh. Both halves are true.	HALF	TRUE
6	Jallianwala Bagh was an aberration by one officer. The victors' own inquiry records the reasoning. The canal colonies and the martial-race system were the context, not the exception.	FALSE	
6	A diaspora movement can raise Punjab. Ghadar had money, courage and a real grievance. Punjab did not join. This is the template Part 11 tested again.	FALSE	
7	Partition could have spared Punjab. Once a religious criterion was accepted, Punjab's demography made division arithmetically unavoidable.	FALSE	
7	The border was drawn carelessly. Five weeks, no site visits, and the award published two days after independence.	TRUE	
7	One community started the killing. The sequencing cannot be established from the record and the question does not have an answer.	STILL	DEBATED
7	Punjab paid a normal share of Partition's cost. It paid a share out of all proportion to its size, and lost its water headworks within eight months.	FALSE	
8	Chandigarh was promised to Punjab. Promised, repeatedly, including by written accord — and never transferred.	TRUE	

8	Punjab's river waters were allocated by proper adjudication. Allocated by executive decision, not by a tribunal Punjab accepted. The SYL matter remained before the Supreme Court in 2026.	FALSE
8	The Anandpur Sahib Resolution was a secessionist document. It was a demand for federal autonomy. It was treated as sedition, and that treatment is a large part of what followed.	FALSE
8	The Green Revolution was an unqualified gift to Punjab. It ended Indian famine and it issued an invoice, payable in groundwater, that Part 13 quantifies.	HALF TRUE
9	Bhindranwale was a creation of the Congress. The cultivation is documented; the extent of subsequent control is inferred rather than proved. Part 9 separates the two carefully.	MOSTLY TRUE
9	Operation Blue Star's methods were the only ones available. Refuted by the Indian state itself: Operation Black Thunder, 1988 — same complex, siege instead of assault, press present, building intact, militants surrendered.	FALSE
9	Bhindranwale demanded Khalistan. What he said, and pointedly refused to say, is on the record and is more equivocal than either side finds convenient.	STILL DEBATED
10	November 1984 was a riot. Voter lists used to identify Sikh homes, mobs transported, identical methods across separated localities, police non-intervention, the army not deployed for around three days. The word is pogrom.	FALSE
10	Justice was done for 1984. Of 126 trial court cases the Nanavati Commission analysed: 8 convictions, 118 acquittals. Around ten commissions in four decades. Sajjan Kumar convicted in 2018 — thirty-four years on.	FALSE
10	The militants were fighting for Sikh rights. A very large share of those they killed were Sikhs. They shot Longowal in a gurdwara four weeks after he signed the accord giving Punjab Chandigarh. They bombed an airliner and killed 329 people, 82 of them children.	FALSE
10	The disappearances are separatist propaganda. Khalra documented over 2,000 secret cremations in Amritsar district from municipal records, and was abducted and murdered — six police officials convicted and given life sentences.	FALSE
10	The ISI created the Khalistan movement. The ISI armed, trained and funded it. Every cause was	

	domestic: Chandigarh, water, the Congress cultivation, Blue Star, November 1984.	HALF	TRUE
11	Khalistan is an ancient Sikh national demand. The word was coined in a pamphlet in March 1940 by Dr Vir Singh Bhatti and denounced within weeks by Master Tara Singh.	FALSE	
11	Khalistan has a government-in-exile. Declared from London in 1980, with passports, stamps and currency. In forty-six years no state on earth has recognised any of it — including Pakistan.	FALSE	
11	The referendum proves mass support. No roll, no duplicate check, no supervision, and Punjab cannot vote. Where an independent count exists — Surrey, 2023 — organisers said 200,000+, an observer counted about 65,700, and CBC could not verify.	MISLEADING	
11	Allegations of Indian assassination plots abroad are fabrications. Nikhil Gupta pleaded guilty in a Manhattan federal court on 13 February 2026 and was sentenced to 24 years on 29 May 2026.	FALSE	
11	India directed the killing of Hardeep Singh Nijjar. Alleged at the highest level by Canada, denied throughout by India, four men charged, no court ruling on state direction as at mid-2026.	STILL	DEBATED
11	Punjab wants Khalistan. 1997 Akali-BJP; 2022 AAP landslide; 2024 eleven of thirteen seats to Congress and AAP; 2026 civic polls to AAP. Pew: 95% of Sikh respondents "very proud to be Indian."	FALSE	
11	There is no support for hardline Sikh politics inside Punjab. Amritpal Singh won Khadoor Sahib by 197,120 votes from a jail cell; Sarabjit Singh Khalsa won Faridkot by 70,053. A real minority constituency, grown from the Akali collapse.	FALSE	
12	An independent Punjab could control its own water. Not one of the three rivers rises in Punjab. Bhakra is in Bilaspur, Himachal Pradesh. Pong is in Kangra, Himachal Pradesh.	FALSE	
12	Water disputes can be settled by treaty and arbitration. India placed the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance in April 2025, rejected the 2026 arbitral awards, and called the court illegally constituted. Pakistan could not enforce it.	FALSE	

12	Punjab is rich enough to stand alone. Revenue deficit before separation; debt 45.1% of GSDP; 31% of revenue receipts from the centre , ending on day one, while defence, currency and foreign affairs costs begin.	FALSE
12	Khalistan would be a Sikh state. 38.49% Hindu at the 2011 Census, a Hindu-majority region, a Hindu-plurality border district — and no citizenship or minority provision published in fifty-five years.	MISLEADING
12	No new state ever passes a feasibility audit. True of Singapore, Israel, Bangladesh and 1776 — each of which solved its binding constraint with a port, a coast, an ally or a supermajority. Punjab has none, and its constraint is upstream water.	HALF TRUE
13	Punjab's water problem can be managed. Extraction at 156.36% of recharge, 111 of 153 blocks over-exploited, CGWB projecting the first aquifer exhausted by 2029 and the table below usable depth by 2039.	FALSE
13	Stubble burning has fallen by 90%. Fire <i>counts</i> fell to 5,114 in 2025 from 49,922 in 2022. But over 90% of large fires now occur after 3 pm, outside the satellite window, and burnt <i>area</i> has not fallen in step.	MISLEADING
13	Most young Punjabis are drug addicts. The opioid-dependent population is on the order of 232,000 — a severe, concentrated, treatable crisis. The universal claim has no survey behind it and makes the real problem harder to solve.	FALSE
13	Malwa's cancer rates are caused by pesticides. Elevated incidence is documented — around 136 per 100,000 against a national 80. Causation is genuinely unresolved between pesticides, heavy metals, geology, screening and age structure.	STILL DEBATED
13	Punjab is still India's richest state. First until around 2000; roughly tenth among major states by 2021-22. Above the national average at current prices, marginally below at constant prices, growing at 6.1% against India's 7.4%.	FALSE
13	Punjab's problem is that Punjabis leave. Emigration was the employment policy and remittances the welfare system, and both were working. India's share of Canadian student intake fell from 51.6% in 2023 to 8.1% in 2025. The problem now is that they cannot.	MISLEADING
13	The central question for Punjab is constitutional. The argument Punjab has been having for fifty-	

five years is not the argument that will determine what happens to Punjab.

FALSE

The four sentences that carry the whole work

IF YOU REMEMBER NOTHING ELSE

One. The grievance is real and largely proven — by the Indian state's own commissions, courts and convictions. Parts 8, 9 and 10.

Two. The remedy on offer would not work — and fails on the one constraint it has never addressed in fifty-five years. Part 12.

Three. The movement survives on Indian conduct, not its own programme — an unclosed file from 1984–95, and a label applied to Sikhs who are not separatists. Part 11.

Four. None of that is what will decide Punjab's future. The water is, and nobody is contesting an election about it. Part 13.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

What I got wrong, and how to check me

Part 1 promised that I would show you the range, include what damages my own case, and refuse to write propaganda in either direction. This chapter is where I account for how well I kept that, and where I tell you the weakest points so you can attack them properly.

Where this work is weakest

THE SOFT JOINTS, LISTED HONESTLY

Chapter 9 of this part

The only chapter in thirteen where I recommend rather than establish. I have no special standing on agricultural economics or federal finance and I have flagged it in the text. Attack it first; it will give way most easily.

The BBC 1984 survey figure

Part 11 used a widely cited finding that 88% of Sikhs in Punjab opposed Khalistan at the peak of the crisis. I have not been able to inspect the original instrument. It is marked in Part 11 as cited rather than verified, and if it is wrong, one of Part 11's strongest paragraphs weakens.

Sikh representation in the armed forces

Part 12 needed this and could not get it. The government does not publish religious composition. I gave a range of roughly 2% to 8%, which is uselessly wide, and built no argument that depends on the number.

Farmer suicide totals

Chapter 3 declined to quote a headline figure because I could not find a series I would defend. Readers who want a number will find this unsatisfying. It is the honest position and it is also a gap.

Parts 1 to 3

The ancient and medieval chapters rest more heavily on secondary scholarship than the modern ones, and I do not read Persian, Sanskrit or Braj. Where those parts summarise a scholarly consensus, I am reporting rather than assessing.

Everything in Part 11 with a court date on it

Live litigation in three countries. The Nijjar prosecution has no verdict. Vikash Yadav has not been extradited. Any of it can move, and when it does, Part 11 is out of date rather than wrong.

What I changed my mind about

Three things, and I record them because Part 1 said I started this to find out rather than to prove.

I expected the ISI to be more central than it is. I began Part 10 assuming Pakistan's role would explain a great deal about the militancy, because that is the account I grew up hearing. The documentary record supports arming, training and sanctuary — and it does not support causation. Every cause was domestic. That finding changed how I wrote Parts 10 and 11 both.

I expected the status quo to be more comfortable than it is. I have said this in the author's note and I will repeat it here. I intended Part 13 to be a chapter about difficulties. The CGWB projection turned it into something else, and the argument between Part 12 and Part 13 is not the one I thought I would be writing.

And I did not expect Part 11's central finding. I assumed the diaspora movement was sustained by nostalgia and foreign money. The evidence says it is sustained by an Indian grievance file that has never been closed, and by a word used against Sikhs who want nothing to do with it. The most effective recruiter for Sikh separatism is not in Lahore or Surrey.

How to check me

Sources are listed at the end of every part. That is not decoration. Here is the practical method.

IF YOU WANT TO TEST A CLAIM IN THIS WORK

Start with the primary documents

The Nanavati Commission report. The Major Commission report on the Kanishka bombing. The 2011 Census religion tables. The PRS budget analyses. The CGWB assessments. The court records in *United States v. Nikhil Gupta*. Almost every contested claim in this work traces back to a document you can obtain.

Check the dates on the volatile figures

Budget estimates, groundwater assessments, procurement totals, election results and live court cases all move. Every one is dated in the text so that you can replace it with a newer one and see whether the argument survives. If an argument does not survive a data update, it was a bad argument.

Attack the inferences, not the facts

Most of the facts here are on the public record and are not really in dispute. The interesting disagreements are about what follows from them — and that is where I am most likely to be wrong.

Write to me

Corrections are welcome and taken seriously. Several claims in this work are marked as cited-but-unverified precisely so that somebody who can verify them will.

The last thing

Part 1 opened by saying that everybody in Punjab has an opinion about Punjab and almost nobody arguing has read anything — and that I included myself in that.

Thirteen parts later I want to be careful about what I claim to have earned. I have read a great deal more than I had. I have found that most of the confident things I was told growing up were wrong in one direction or the other, and that the correction almost never lands where either side would like.

The Indian state did things in Punjab it has never accounted for, and its own commissions and courts say so. The movement that claimed to answer that did things it has never accounted for either, and killed a great many Punjabis while claiming to speak for them. And underneath both arguments, quietly, for sixty years, the water has been going.

If this work is useful for anything, I would like it to be this: that it becomes slightly harder, for anyone who has read it, to say a simple thing about Punjab.

Simple language is not simple thinking.

It is what is left after the thinking is finished.

REFERENCE

Sources and further reading — Part 13

Water and environment

- **Central Ground Water Board**, Dynamic Ground Water Resources of Punjab, 2025 assessment — 111 of 153 blocks over-exploited; stage of extraction 156.36%; extraction 26.27 bcm; improvement in 81 blocks. Compared with the 2023 assessment (164%, 117 blocks).
- **CGWB projections** on aquifer depletion — first aquifer to 100 m exhausted by 2029, water table below 300 m by 2039, and the quality threshold below 300 m. Reported via *The Wire Science* and *Mongabay India*; treated in the text as a projection rather than a forecast.
- **Punjab Pollution Control Board** and **Press Information Bureau** — paddy-season farm fire counts: 5,114 in 2025; 49,922 in 2022; 36,663 in 2023. Crop residue management funding of Rs 3,120.16 crore to Punjab and Haryana, 2018-19 to 2025-26.
- **iFOREST** (International Forum for Environment, Sustainability and Technology) — study finding that India's satellite monitoring misses the majority of stubble fires; and the SEVIRI-based research showing over 90% of large fires in 2024–25 occurred after 3 pm against 3% in 2021. This is the basis for the Chapter 1 correction.
- **CEEW** (Council on Energy, Environment and Water) — crop residue management, short-duration varieties, and how satellite fire detection works.
- **2025 Punjab floods** — Government of Punjab relief bulletins; *Mongabay India*, "Lives, homes and crops lost as Punjab faces the worst flood in decades"; India Water Portal FAQ, September 2025; *Down To Earth*, "Despair after deluge."

Agriculture, debt and health

- **NABARD** — outstanding agricultural credit; Punjab farm loans of about Rs 1,04,064 crore; average landholding falling from 1.08 ha (2016-17) to 0.74 ha (2021-22); institutional and non-institutional interest rates.
- **National Crime Records Bureau**, Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India — used with the definitional caveats set out in Chapter 3, and not used for headline totals.
- **Punjab Agricultural University** and **Punjabi University, Patiala** — the census-style farmer suicide surveys that have repeatedly found more cases than the official series.
- **Journal of Agricultural Development and Policy** (2025) and related studies on indebtedness as a factor in Punjabi farmer suicides.
- **Centre for Science and Environment** (2004) — pesticide residue in blood samples from Bathinda and Ropar districts.
- Malwa cancer incidence studies and reporting on the Bathinda–Bikaner service, including *The Diplomat*, "Punjab's 'Cancer Train' Runs on Hope" (2024). Causation is treated as unresolved throughout.

Substance use

- **Punjab Opioid Dependence Survey** — the AIIMS-led estimate of opioid-dependent population in Punjab, and the associated peer-reviewed publication on the two complementary survey methods used.
- *Discover Public Health* (Springer, 2025), "A narrative review of trends and challenges of substance use in Punjab: a 10-year analysis of data from 2015 to 2024."
- **Punjab Police** NDPS enforcement data, 2024.
- Government of Punjab statements, November 2024, on minors and adults reporting substance use — used in Chapter 4 specifically to illustrate the definitional problem, not as a measure of opioid dependence.

Economy, migration and politics

- **PRS Legislative Research**, *Punjab Budget Analysis 2026-27*; **Punjab Economic Survey 2025-26**.
- **NITI Aayog**, *Macro and Fiscal Landscape of the State of Punjab* (2025) — the ranking slide and the structural analysis.
- **Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister**, *Relative Economic Performance of Indian States: 1960-61 onwards* — for Punjab's position over time.

- **Periodic Labour Force Survey** — Punjab unemployment relative to the national rate.
- **Bureau of Immigration** and **Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada** — Indian students going abroad (9,08,364 in 2023; 7,70,127 in 2024; 6,26,606 in 2025) and India's share of Canadian intake (51.6% → 33.6% → 8.1%).
- **Reserve Bank of India** — remittance inflows, including the record \$110.47 billion in 2025-26.
- **Election Commission of India** — Punjab assembly and Lok Sabha results; **State Election Commission, Punjab** — the 2026 civic poll ward totals.
- **The Tribune, ThePrint, Down To Earth, The India Forum** and **Business Standard** — reporting relied on throughout, and cited in the text where a specific figure comes from a single outlet.

ON THE NUMBERS I DECLINED TO USE IN THIS PART

A headline farmer suicide total. Figures in circulation vary by large multiples depending on whether landless labourers and women are counted. I have used the indebtedness proportion, which is better established, and said why.

The "70% of Punjabi youth" drug claim. No survey supports it. Chapter 4 explains what it displaces.

A single per capita income figure. Chapter 6 gives both, because current and constant prices give opposite answers and both are honest.

This is the same discipline applied to the 250,000 conflict-death figure in Part 10 and to the referendum turnouts in Part 11. A defensible number is worth more than a dramatic one.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the author

Lovepreet Singh is a researcher and writer working toward doctoral research. He writes long-form work on Indian history, society, religion, public policy and technology — from the record, in plain language, with competing views left standing.

Background

He is the founder of **Lovelace**, an independent design and engineering studio building websites, brand systems, 3D and WebGL experiences and digital products, and is **Founder and Managing Director of Five Rivers Inc.**

He has studied at **Panjab University** and **Chandigarh University**, and is in the second year of an **MBA in Business Strategy and Analysis**. He is a **Certified Ethical Hacker** and a self-taught developer working in the MERN stack.

His interests run across history, epistemology, belief and public life — and the common thread, in the security work as much as the research, is a preference for testing a claim to destruction rather than defending it.

The Living Archive

Punjab: The Whole Truth is the first major work of The Living Archive, a long-form research project examining subjects that are argued about constantly and read about rarely. The method is fixed across everything published there: plain language, named sources, disputed figures shown as ranges, and every opposing argument stated at full strength before it is answered.

What comes next

These thirteen parts were written as groundwork. The intended field for doctoral research is Punjab — its history, its politics, and the contested decades between 1966 and 1995. Part 13 has changed the emphasis somewhat: the water file now looks at least as urgent as the constitutional one, and considerably less studied.

Corrections and correspondence are welcome, and taken seriously.

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If you find an error of fact in this work, please write. Chapter 11 of this part lists the places where I think it is weakest, so that anyone who wants to test it knows where to start. A corrected edition is better than a confident one.

— End of Part 13 —

End of *Punjab: The Whole Truth*

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